

REVIEW



Do Countries Now Need Nukes to Survive?

WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND

The Exhausting Cost of Owning a Car Today



OFF DUTY

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ A U.S. official told top global semiconductor makers he wanted to revoke waivers they have used to access American technology in China, people familiar with the matter said. **A2**

◆ Sit-down restaurants such as Cracker Barrel and Red Lobster are spending millions of dollars to update their menus and dinning rooms after one of the toughest periods for the sector in years. **B9**

◆ Accenture's bookings dropped 6% in the quarter, prompting investor concerns about federal contracts. **B10**

◆ Aflac has been hit with a cyberattack that may have resulted in the theft of personal data related to the insurer's U.S. business. **B10**

◆ Kroger raised its same-store sales outlook after its latest quarter's performance, helping send shares up 10%. **B9**

◆ CarMax logged higher profit and sales in its latest quarter as tariff uncertainty sparked an uptick in demand for used cars. **B9**

◆ Baidu's Apollo Go, China's largest robotaxi fleet, could enter the Southeast Asian market as early as this year. **B9**

◆ Fears of war put Wall Street in a holding pattern this past week, with oil prices grinding higher. **B10**

World-Wide

◆ Talks with European leaders and Iran ended without a breakthrough as waves of Israeli warplanes hit targets across Iran for the past week, testing the limits of what air power alone can achieve in the conflict. **A1, A8, A10-11**

◆ The U.S. is sending more warships capable of shooting down ballistic missiles to the Middle East as Israel's stocks of interceptors dwindle. **A8**

◆ Mahmoud Khalil has been released from custody, more than three months after the former Columbia University student was first detained by immigration officials. **A3**

◆ The aggressive effort to fulfill Trump's pledge of mass deportations is testing the bounds of what Americans will tolerate. **A7**

◆ Homeland Security is attempting to deport a reporter based in Georgia who was arrested at one of the "No Kings" protests. **A6**

◆ The U.S. and EU appear to be nearing a deal on multiple nontariff trade issues from deforestation rules to the treatment of U.S. tech companies in Europe. **A2**

◆ Health insurers plan to pledge steps meant to smooth the controversial preapproval process that can deny or delay access to care. **A7**

◆ U.K. lawmakers approved a bill to allow terminally ill adults in England and Wales to choose to end their lives. **A10**

NOONAN

Iraq's shadow over the Iran debate **A15**

CONTENTS

Obituaries..... C6

Books..... C7-12

Business & Finance B9

Food..... D14-15

Gear & Gadgets D16-17

Heard on Street.....B11

Markets & Finance B10

Opinion..... A13-15

Sports..... A16

Style & Fashion D2-4

Travel..... D13

U.S. News..... A2-7

World News A8,10-11

A Heat Wave Rolls In Just in Time for Summer



SPLISH, SPLASH: People cool off at the Yards Park in Washington on Friday, the official start of summer. Forecasters warn that dangerously hot and humid weather will grip the Midwest this weekend, then head for the East Coast.

In Trump 2.0, Loyalist Miller's Sway Spreads Way Beyond Immigration

By JOSH DAWSEY AND REBECCA BALLHAUS

Stephen Miller wanted to keep the planes in the air—and that's where they stayed. When a federal judge in March told the Trump administration to turn around flights of deported migrants headed to El Salvador, senior officials hastily convened a Saturday evening conference call to figure out what to do. If they didn't return the passengers, they would be de-

fying a court order, some administration officials worried. Miller, who is President Trump's deputy chief of staff, pushed for the planes to keep flying, which they ultimately did. The judge would later say that allowing officials to defy court judgments would make a "solemn mockery" of the Constitution. The 39-year-old immigration hawk, who has been by Trump's side since the 2016 campaign, has emerged as a singular figure in the second

Trump administration, wielding more power than almost any other White House staffer in recent memory—and eager to circumvent legal limitations on his agenda. He has his own staff of about 30 and a Secret Service detail, which White House officials said was because he had received death threats and serves as homeland security adviser. He has been responsible for the administration's broadsides against universities, law firms and

even museums. He has written or edited every executive order that Trump has signed. Miller had considerable sway in Trump's first term in office. But when aides at the time suggested promoting Miller to a leadership role at the Department of Homeland Security, Trump declined, according to a former administration official, telling aides *Please turn to page A6* ◆ Immigration issue turns against Trump..... **A7**

Iran Remains Defiant As Israel Fights On

Israeli military officials test theory that war can't be won with air power alone

By MARCUS WALKER

Talks with European leaders and Iran ended Friday without a breakthrough as waves of Israeli warplanes hit targets across Iran for the past week, testing the limits of what air power alone can achieve in the conflict. The fighting threatens to intensify with the possible entry of the U.S. if diplomacy can't resolve the standoff over Iran's nuclear program. Top European officials lined up behind the Trump administration's demand that Iran give up its uranium-enrichment program. Iran has remained defiant, raising doubts about whether a negotiated solution can be found. Israel has gained air superiority since the conflict began and has carried out hundreds of strikes. Conventional wisdom among military thinkers has long been that missiles and bombs, while essential to modern warfare, are seldom enough to achieve victory on their own, especially if the strategic aims of the warring states are expansive. In this case, Israel has said its goal is to prevent Iran from developing nuclear weapons, by physically destroying its ability *Please turn to page A10* ◆ Pressure builds on Iran as diplomacy stalls..... **A8** ◆ Israel is burning through missile interceptors..... **A8** ◆ Iranian Jews in U.S. dream of a 'free Iran'..... **A11**

INSIDE



U.S. NEWS
Columbia protester Mahmoud Khalil has been released from ICE detention. **A3**



EXCHANGE
The biggest companies now think fewer employees means faster growth. **B1**

When Towns Rebuild From Disaster, Prices Go Up

In the economic upheaval that follows wildfires and hurricanes, some residents get squeezed out

The coastal community of Panama City, Fla., has largely recovered since Hurricane Michael ravaged the Florida Panhandle in 2018—but it isn't the same place. The downtown, once a sleepy district with run-down buildings and lawyers' offices, now bustles with boutiques and breweries. Much of the housing stock is fancier and pricier, and residents are generally wealthier. More than 2,000 miles west, a similar dy-

namic has played out in the small hill town of Paradise, Calif., as it tries to come back from the Camp Fire that incinerated the region that same year. Many poorer residents have moved out, more-affluent newcomers have moved in and home prices have climbed. Panama City and Paradise stand as vivid examples of an emerging cycle in this era of more-extreme weather in America: Communities struck by disasters often grow richer and more exclusive. Hurricanes in the South, tornadoes in the heartland and wildfires in the West increasingly are followed by similar *Please turn to page A12*

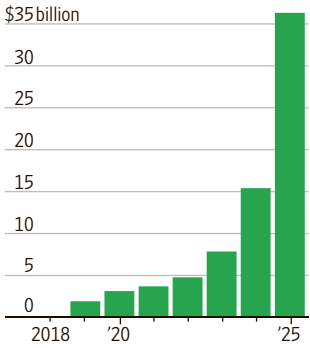
Weight-Loss Drugs From Ireland Blow Out the U.S. Trade Deficit

By CHELSEY DULANEY AND JARED S. HOPKINS

Planes have been jetting from Ireland to the U.S. this year carrying something more valuable than gold: \$36 billion worth of hormones for popular obesity and diabetes drugs. The frantic airlift of those ingredients—more than double what was imported from Ireland for all of last year—reflects the collision of two powerful forces: tariff-driven stockpiling and weight-loss drug demand. The peptide- and protein-based hormones feed into a category of drugs that in-

cludes wildly popular GLP-1 treatments and newer types of insulin known as analogues. Fit into temperature-controlled air-cargo containers, the pharmaceutical ingredients have had a huge impact on the U.S. trade imbalance. The shipments have propelled Ireland, a country of only 5.4 million people, to the second-largest goods-trade imbalance with the U.S., trailing only China. They accounted for about half of the \$71 billion in goods the U.S. imported from the country in the first four months of the year. Nearly 100% of the imports *Please turn to page A2*

Imports of peptide- and protein-based hormones from Ireland



Year	Imports (\$35 billion)
2018	0.5
2019	1.0
2020	2.0
2021	3.0
2022	4.0
2023	6.0
2024	14.0
2025	34.0

Note: 2025 data through April
Sources: U.S. International Trade Commission, U.S. Commerce Department

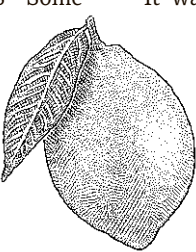
Why New Orleans Is Rallying To Save a Trash Collector

* * *

French Quarter residents hardly recognize the spotless area; 'a little ray of sunshine'

By RACHEL WOLFE

NEW ORLEANS—Something strange happened in the French Quarter in December. The trash-strewn streets were swept spotless seemingly overnight. Graffiti old enough to graduate was power-washed out of existence. And Bourbon Street's signature power outages, building col-



Main squeeze

replaced with the smell of lemons. It wasn't magic. It was a new emergency sanitation contract. And now—much to many residents' dismay—the mayor wants to take it away. New Orleanians are used to dysfunction. They have endured frequent power outages, building col-

Please turn to page A12

© 2025 Dow Jones & Company, Inc. All Rights Reserved

25647>

0 78908 63144 2

U.S. NEWS

U.S. Warns Chip Makers on China Plants

A U.S. official told top global semiconductor makers he wanted to revoke waivers they have used to access American technology in China, people familiar with the matter said, a move that could inflame trade tensions.

By Liza Lin, Amrith Ramkumar and Raffaele Huang

Currently, South Korea's Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix as well as Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing enjoy blanket waivers that allow them to ship American chip-making equipment to their factories in China without applying for a separate license each time.

Jeffrey Kessler, head of the Commerce Department unit in charge of export controls, told the three companies this past week he wanted to cancel those waivers, according to people familiar with the meetings. They said Kessler described the action as part of

the Trump administration's crackdown on critical U.S. technology going to China.

If carried out, the move could be disruptive both diplomatically and economically. Earlier this month, the U.S. and China agreed to a fragile trade truce in London. Part of the deal involved each country agreeing to hold off from introducing new export controls and other measures designed to hurt the other.

The action isn't a new trade escalation but would be designed to make the licensing system for chip equipment similar to what China has in place for rare-earth materials, White House officials said. The U.S. and China continue to make progress on completing the agreement they reached in London and negotiating on trade, they said.

"Chip makers will still be able to operate in China. The new enforcement mechanisms on chips mirror licensing requirements that apply to other semiconductor companies that

export to China and ensure the United States has an equal and reciprocal process," a Commerce Department spokesman said.

A new step making it harder for global chip makers to operate in China might still strike Beijing as a betrayal of the London deal. It could also strain the relationship between Washington and friendly governments in South Korea and Taiwan, whose companies would be most affected and have promised large investments in the U.S. in recent years.

The Chinese factories in question—including a Samsung memory-chip factory in the city of Xi'an—are part of the global supply chain for memory, logic and other chips. While they generally don't have the most advanced technology, the factories' output is widely used in cars, consumer electronics and the like.

Industry officials said tighter curbs by Washington wouldn't immediately force the

factories to shut down, but over time, they could find it harder to operate effectively. That would disrupt global industry as companies deal with other issues triggered by the U.S.-China trade war, such as China's limits on exports of rare-earth magnets.

The chip makers would likely seek case-by-case licenses from the U.S. government to supply their Chinese factories, while looking to replace U.S. equipment with alternatives from Japan and Europe.

People involved in the discussions said revoking the waivers isn't a done deal.

They said Kessler's unit—the Commerce Department's Bureau of Industry and Security—hasn't secured buy-in from other parts of the U.S. government, such as the Defense Department. Opponents in the administration worry eliminating the waivers would ultimately end up boosting Chinese companies and give China control of the plants.

U.S., EU Near Deal To Ease Nontariff Irritants

By Gavin Bade and Kim Mackraael

The U.S. and European Union appear to be nearing a deal on multiple nontariff trade issues from deforestation rules to the treatment of U.S. tech companies in Europe—but the fate of looming tariffs set to be imposed by each trading partner remains unclear.

A draft "agreement on reciprocal trade" circulated by the U.S. Trade Representative's office lays out tentative deals on a litany of specific trade issues, including the EU's Digital Markets Act, its carbon-based border tariffs, shipbuilding and more, according to people with knowledge of the text, who said the agreement appeared to be close to final but emphasized it could change in the coming days and weeks.

But the text, the people said, doesn't specifically address any of the tariffs that President Trump has threatened or imposed on the EU—from the 20% reciprocal tariff that Trump paused in April to higher duties on specific industries such as automobiles and steel, the people said. It also doesn't detail the EU's proposed retaliatory tariffs, set to kick in on July 14 if no deal can be struck.

It remains unclear if tariff issues will be addressed in a separate deal, if those talks are at an impasse, or if the sides will decide to extend those negotiations beyond Trump's July 9 tariff deadline. And it is also uncertain if the EU is on board with all of the provisions of the draft deal.

The U.S. government and representatives for the EU's executive body declined to comment on the details of the proposed agreement, but an EU spokesperson said the sides are "fully and deeply engaged in negotiations," and that "a negotiated, mutually beneficial solution remains our preferred outcome."

While it doesn't address tariffs, the draft agreement covers a number of longstanding economic pain points for U.S. firms. It would see the U.S. and EU enter a dialogue on how to implement Europe's Digital Markets Act—a tech-competition law that has drawn complaints from large American firms—and exempt U.S. companies from enforcement during those talks.

The bloc has already fined two American companies under the law: Apple and Meta Platforms. Exempting U.S. companies, which are responsible for most of the platforms regulated by the DMA, would largely defang one of the bloc's signature digital laws.

The draft text says the EU will delay implementation of its deforestation regulation for a year. That change in timing doesn't appear to be new: The EU decided late last year to delay the deforestation rules after companies inside Europe and in other regions said they needed more time to comply.

The draft agreement would see the U.S. and EU coordinate on Europe's design and implementation of a carbon border adjustment mechanism—a tariff that would reflect the carbon-intensity of imports—and U.S. products would be exempted for a year after the policy is put in place. U.S. energy exports to Europe would be exempt from EU methane rules.

Additionally, the EU will consider measures to encourage shipbuilding and shipping from market economies, similar to the penalties and fees for Chinese cargo ships that the U.S. government proposed earlier this year, according to the draft text. The U.S. and EU would also coordinate on defense procurement and critical minerals, among other provisions.

The draft text comes after weeks of U.S. and EU officials trading documents and holding talks in hopes of reaching an agreement. After the EU shared a proposal laying out what it was willing to negotiate, U.S. Trade Representative Jamieon Greer said in early June that the bloc had provided "a credible starting point" for discussions.



Ireland's favorable tax policies make it a hub for U.S. drug giants. Above left, a worker at an Eli Lilly plant in Kinsale, Ireland. AbbVie's antiwrinkle treatment Botox is produced in Ireland. Below, Merck has a facility in County Cork, Ireland. Merck's cancer treatment Keytruda is made in Ireland and elsewhere.



Ireland Blows Out U.S. Deficit

Continued from Page One had a final destination of Indiana, according to U.S. customs records. Eli Lilly, the drug giant behind weight loss and diabetes drugs Zepbound and Mounjaro, is headquartered in Indianapolis.

A Lilly spokeswoman declined to comment.

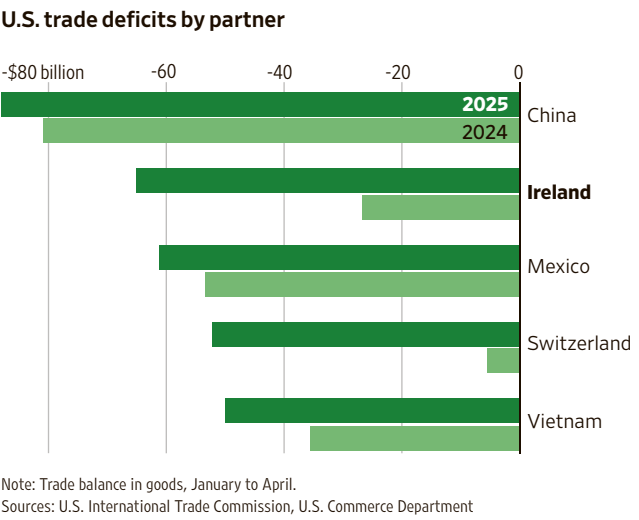
Global rush

President Trump's off-and-on trade war has rewritten global trading patterns this year and—temporarily, at least—widened some of the imbalances he said he is seeking to eliminate.

Companies have scrambled to get shipments to the U.S. ahead of tariff deadlines, with a first round of front-loading ahead of the April 2 announcement, and smaller pushes after the White House passed some of its tariffs.

Ireland is at the center of the global rush. It is a major hub for U.S. drug giants, which have been expanding operations there in part because of its favorable tax policies. Some of the bestselling drugs in the world, such as AbbVie's antiwrinkle treatment Botox and U.S. drug-maker Merck's cancer treatment Keytruda, are made in the country.

"It's common sense. It's un-



certain at the moment, so you're building a bit of security by stockpiling," said Matt Moran, a consultant and former director of industry group BioPharmaChem Ireland. "There's such huge demand for those products at the moment."

The trade imbalance has put Ireland in an uncomfortable position, landing it this month on the U.S. Treasury Department's monitoring list for currency manipulation, which the government uses to send a warning shot to countries it thinks use unfair trade practices.

Ireland's central bank said in a report Thursday that new factories making weight-loss drug ingredients helped drive the country's exports. Ireland's economy grew by nearly 10% in the first quarter compared with the end of last year because of the export surge.

The attention is "definitely not welcome," said Dan O'Brien, chief economist of the Institute of International

and European Affairs, a Dublin think tank. "A very big part of the U.S.-EU deficit is accounted for by Ireland alone. Trump doesn't like deficits."

The White House wants U.S. drug companies to bring production home and in April ordered a so-called Section 232 investigation that could result in tariffs on both imported drugs and ingredients like hormones.

Lilly is a force in the market for weight-loss drugs, with sales of its GLP-1 medicines Mounjaro and Zepbound expected to nearly double this year to about \$30 billion, according to Bank of America analysts.

Maintaining supply of weight-loss drugs has been a challenge for both Lilly and rival Novo Nordisk, the Danish maker of Ozempic and Wegovy. The companies were initially unable to keep up with demand for the drugs. Lilly resolved the shortages faster,

Some of the bestselling drugs in the world are made in Ireland.

helping it to take market share from Novo.

Lilly is now preparing for the potential launch of a weight-loss pill, orforglipron, which it plans to submit for U.S. approval later this year. Lilly said it began producing weight-loss and diabetes medicines at its Irish factory in Kinsale in 2023. Novo doesn't produce weight-loss drugs in Ireland, according to a spokeswoman.

Peptide- and protein-based hormones help to regulate processes such as appetite and metabolism. The category includes hormones that mimic a naturally occurring gut hormone called glucagon-like peptide-1, or GLP-1, but can also be used in some fertility and osteoporosis treatments.

Shipping and logistics companies said they have noticed increased demand for pharma shipments, which often travel by air instead of on cheaper ocean freighters because they are so light and valuable.

Pharma shipments more than doubled from Ireland to the U.S. in March and April, according to data firm WorldACD. Kuehne + Nagel, a Swiss logistics company with operations in the country, said its teams did overtime to accommodate the increase in booking requests and the customs paperwork.

"We didn't see the same increase from Ireland to the rest of the world. That was not a global trend," said Nico Sacco, the company's senior vice president of healthcare strategy.

CORRECTIONS & AMPLIFICATIONS

Targeted shootings of lawmakers in Minnesota took place on Saturday, June 14. A U.S. News article on Wednesday about Sen. Mike Lee's social-media post mocking the attacks incorrectly said they took place Sunday, June 15.

Readers can alert The Wall Street Journal to any errors in news articles by emailing wsjcontact@wsj.com or by calling 888-410-2667.



Imports of vaccines and various other drugs including cancer treatments also increased this year from Ireland, according to trade data.

Tariff fallout

Merck produces cancer treatment Keytruda, the world's bestselling drug, in Ireland, among other places. Merck Chief Executive Rob Davis said in April the company has enough supply to mitigate any impact this year from tariffs and is working on navigating the long-term fallout of tariffs.

Merck recently began construction on its first U.S. plant to make Keytruda. Lilly said earlier this year it plans to invest \$27 billion in expanding U.S. production.

The hormones are often freeze-dried and shipped as powders. Obesity-related drugs can fly in the cargo sections of passenger planes, or on cargo flights reserved for pharma products, said Anand Kulkarni, head of global markets at Lufthansa Cargo. Lufthansa saw demand for U.S.-bound pharma shipments from locations such as India, Switzerland and Belgium. Volumes began to dip in April as warehouses in the U.S. reached capacity, he said.

To increase shipments, drug companies likely tapped existing stocks and diverted production destined for the rest of the world to the U.S. market instead, industry executives said.

"You can't just switch on capacity. You don't go out and buy machines and start them up," said Moran, the consultant. "They have to be built, commissioned, validated, and approved by the regulator."

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL
(USPS 664-880) (Eastern Edition ISSN 0099-9660)
(Central Edition ISSN 1092-0935) (Western Edition ISSN 0193-2241)
Editorial and publication headquarters: 1211 Avenue of the Americas, New York, N.Y. 10036
Published daily except Sundays and general legal holidays.
Periodicals postage paid at New York, N.Y., and other mailing offices.
Postmaster: Send address changes to The Wall Street Journal, 200 Burnett Rd., Chicopee, MA 01020.
All Advertising published in The Wall Street Journal is subject to the applicable rate card, copies of which are available from the Advertising Services Department, Dow Jones & Co. Inc., 1211 Avenue of the Americas, New York, N.Y. 10036. The Journal reserves the right not to accept an advertiser's order. Only publication of an advertisement shall constitute final acceptance of the advertiser's order.
Letters to the Editor: Fax: 212-416-2891; email: wsj.letters@wsj.com
Need assistance with your subscription?
By web: customercenter.wsj.com; By email: support@wsj.com
By phone: 1-800-JOURNAL (1-800-568-7625)
Reprints & licensing:
By email: customreprints@dowjones.com
By phone: 1-800-843-0008
WSJ back issues and framed pages: wsjshop.com
Our newspapers are 100% sourced from sustainably certified mills.
GOT A TIP FOR US? SUBMIT IT AT WSJ.COM/TIPS

Harvard Agreement Possible, Trump Says

By Douglas Belkin

President Trump said his administration was “working closely” with Harvard University and could announce a deal within the next week.

The White House and Harvard have been locked in battle since late March. Trump has pulled billions in federal funds over antisemitism and DEI concerns, tried to block Harvard’s ability to enroll international students and threatened its tax-exempt status. Harvard has sued the administration, saying the government has violated its First Amendment rights.

On Friday, though, Trump praised the school on social media. “They have acted extremely appropriately during these negotiations, and appear to be committed to doing what is right.”

Trump said that such a settlement would be “‘mind-bogglingly’ HISTORIC, and very good for our Country.”

It couldn’t be determined what the terms of such a settlement might be.

The message came after a federal judge blocked the Trump administration’s attempt to prohibit international students from enrolling at Harvard.

A Harvard spokesperson didn’t respond to a request for comment Friday afternoon.

The confrontation with Harvard began in March, when the government said it was reviewing nearly \$9 billion in federal funding at the school and asked it to take certain actions “necessary for Harvard University’s continued financial relationship with the United States government.”

The government gave the university a list of demands, including requirements that Harvard allow federal-government oversight of admissions, hiring and the ideology of students and staff. The school rejected the administration’s proposal.

The administration then said it would freeze more than \$2 billion in grants and contracts.



RICK FRIEDMAN/REUTERS IMAGES

Harvard University has sued the Trump administration.

In the First Stretch of Summer, Yogis Welcome Solstice



CHILD’S POSE: New York’s Times Square hosted thousands of people for a Mind Over Madness Yoga event on Friday. The event, which began in 2003 with three people doing yoga at sunrise, coincides with the solstice, the longest day of the year north of the equator and the start of astronomical summer.

Columbia Protester Khalil Freed From ICE Detention

By Victoria Albert and Joseph De Avila

Mahmoud Khalil has been released from custody, more than three months after the former Columbia student was first detained by immigration officials.

Khalil was released from the Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility in Jena, La., on Friday night, his legal team said in a court filing. His freedom came hours after U.S. District Judge Michael Farbiarz granted his request to be released while his case proceeds.

The green-card holder can now return to his wife and newborn son in New York City, where the family lives, for the first time since his March 8 arrest.

Department of Homeland Security spokeswoman Tricia McLaughlin said Farbiarz was overstepping his authority in ordering Khalil’s release, calling his decision “yet another example of how out of control members of the judicial branch are undermining national security.”

The government said later Friday that it was appealing

the decision.

“Mahmoud has endured a lot over the past three and a half months, but we believed from the start that this day would come, because what the government is doing to him and so many others blatantly violates the First Amendment,” said Brett Max Kaufman, one of Khalil’s attorneys. “We couldn’t be happier that he is finally heading home.”

Khalil played a key role in the pro-Palestinian demonstrations at Columbia in spring 2024, negotiating with the university on behalf of the students and giving interviews to the media. He missed the birth of his son and his graduation from Columbia while he was detained.

The 30-year-old was one of the early targets in the Trump administration’s attempt to crack down on what it has said was antisemitism on college campuses. His case has been a closely followed test of whether the administration can deploy a seldom-used foreign-policy provision to deport students and scholars.

At least two other people detained under the provision—Columbia student Mohsen Mahdawi and Georgetown academic Badar Khan Suri—were released more than a month ago. Khalil’s case took a different path, with Farbiarz ruling on other factors before addressing the bail request.

Khalil may only travel to New York and Michigan under the conditions of release. He can also travel to Louisiana and New Jersey for court, and Washington, D.C., for lobbying and legislative purposes. He isn’t required to post an immediate bond or be subject to electronic monitoring.

Earlier this month, Farbiarz granted Khalil a preliminary injunction barring the Trump administration from detaining him on the foreign-policy provision. Farbiarz said the law was likely unconstitutional as applied to Khalil because it was too vague for a person to know how to avoid violating it. The government said Friday that it is appealing that order.

Khalil remained detained on a second allegation that he misrepresented information on his green-card application. His legal team has denied making any misrepresentations and said his continued detention was retaliation for protected speech.

SPRING-SUMMER 2025 COLLECTION



Sense
Sofa, designed by Studio Roche Bobois

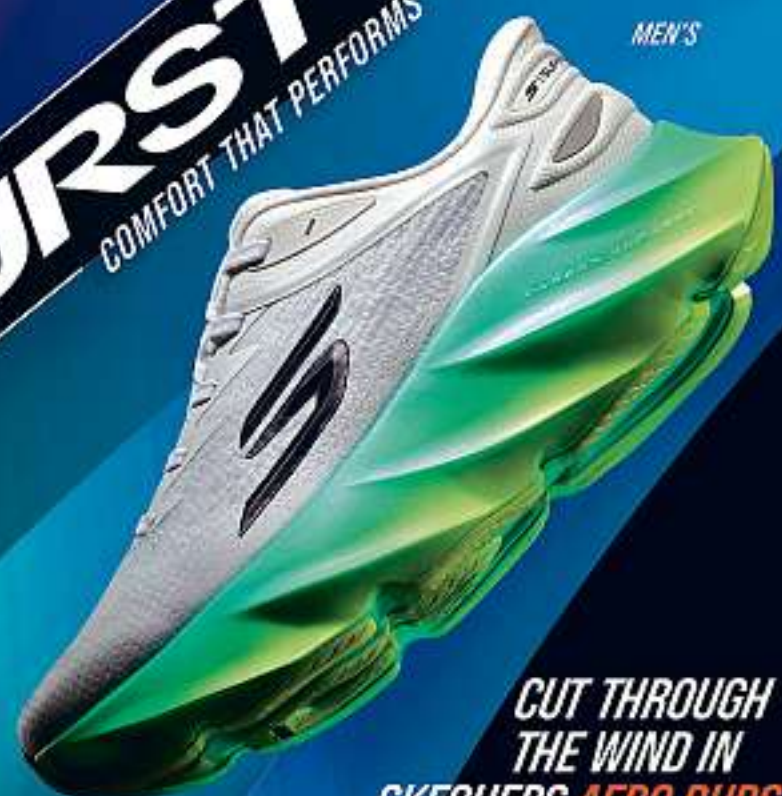
rochebobois
PARIS



SKECHERS
RUNNING



WOMEN'S



MEN'S

SKECHERS AERO BURST
COMFORT THAT PERFORMS™

CUT THROUGH THE WIND IN SKECHERS AERO BURST

SKECHERS.COM

SKECHERS SLIP-INS

ARCHFIT

CARBON INFUSED

GOODYEAR PERFORMANCE RUBBERS

MACHINE WASHABLE

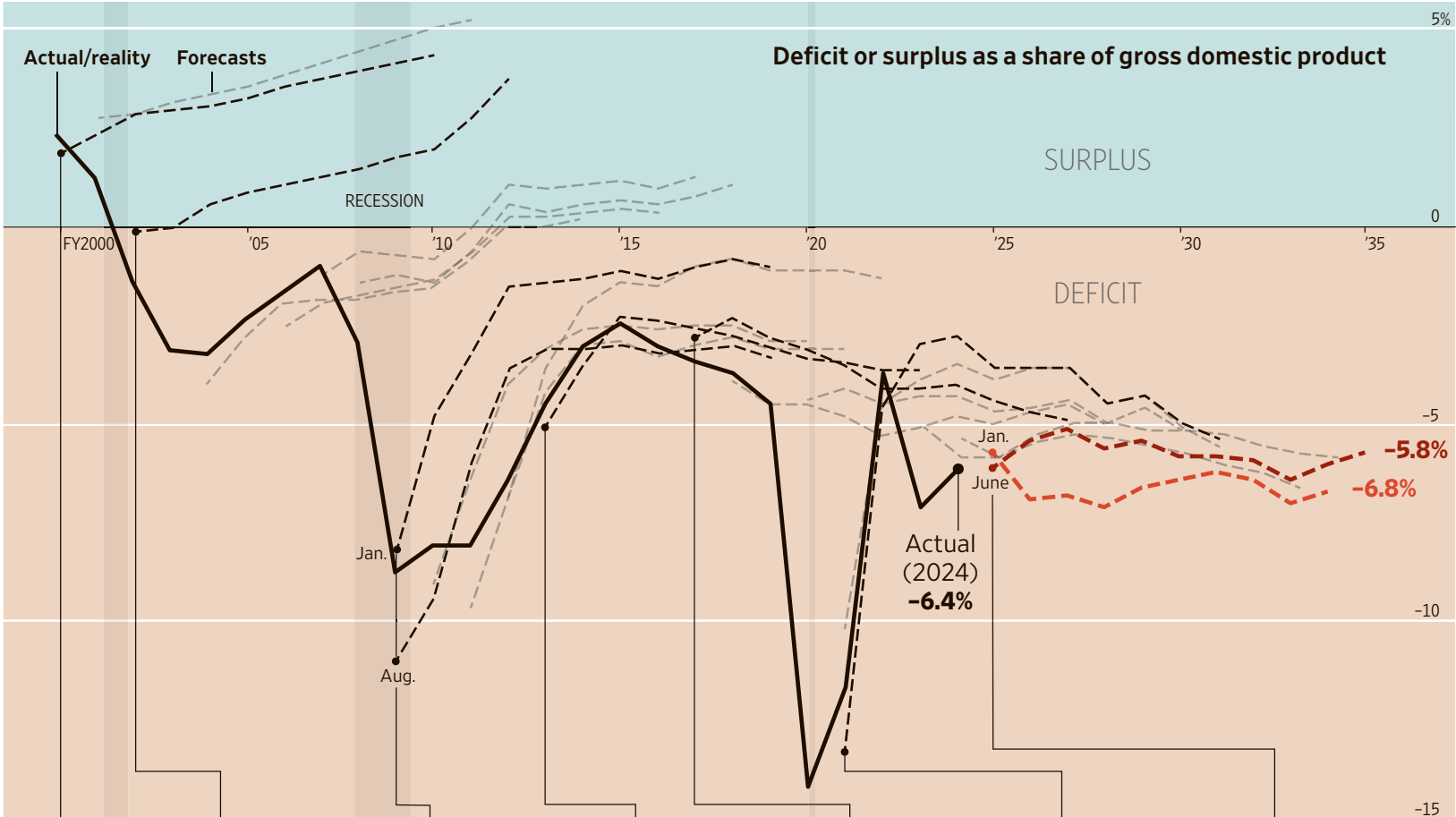
How the U.S. Got on the Path to Record Deficits

Take a spin in the time machine, back to an era when the federal budget deficit didn't look like a problem at all.

By Richard Rubin, Anthony DeBarros and Rosie Ettenheim

In 2000, the federal government actually ran a surplus, and the Congressional Budget Office, Capitol Hill's nonpartisan scorekeeper, projected the Treasury would keep collecting enough revenue to pay for all government programs and generate continuing surpluses. Fast-forward to 2025, and the U.S. is running record deficits outside of wars, recessions or crises. The nation's publicly held debt is nearing 100% of gross domestic product and is projected to surpass the post World War II record of 106% in a few years.

What happened? It wasn't a single event but a mix of factors: an aging population, tax cuts, wars, the 2008 financial crisis, expanded healthcare spending, the Covid-19 pandemic and rising federal assistance to households. Both parties played a part. Democrats did little to reverse that tide of red ink when they controlled Congress and Joe Biden was president. Now, Republicans and President Trump are pushing a tax-and-spending megabill that would add trillions to deficits, compared with letting tax cuts expire as scheduled. Here's a look at how we got here. The solid black line is reality. The dashed lines are CBO's moment-in-time forecasts of a future that never happened.



Jan. 2000	Jan. 2002	Jan. - Aug. 2009	Feb. 2013	Jan. 2017	July 2021	Jan. - June 2025
At the end of the Clinton administration in 2000 with no recession on the horizon, CBO was forecasting surpluses far into the future. As a percentage of GDP, the budget surplus was projected to reach 4.3% by 2010.	Both presidential candidates in the 2000 election promised significant tax cuts. Even after the Sept. 11 attacks and the first wave of President George W. Bush's tax cuts, the fiscal picture still looked rosy.	The 2007-09 recession sapped tax revenue, and Congress and the Obama administration propped up the economy in 2009 with the American Recovery and Reinvestment Act. CBO no longer forecast surpluses.	House Republicans in 2011 refused to raise the debt limit until they struck a deal to lower federal spending. By the next year, both parties agreed to extend almost all of Bush's tax cuts, which deepened the deficit trajectory by early 2013.	Republicans regained control of Congress and the White House in 2017, and enacted a tax cut that was forecast to reduce revenue by \$1.5 trillion over a decade. Spending also increased through bipartisan agreements.	The government responded to Covid-19 in 2020 and 2021 with legislation to cushion households and businesses, pushing deficits to an unusual high. As the country emerged from the pandemic, some of the higher spending remained.	The House-passed version of Trump's 'One Big Beautiful' bill would increase budget deficits by \$2.4 trillion over the next decade, the CBO projects, compared with its baseline scenario that assumes most 2017 tax cuts expire Dec. 31.

*The June 2025 projection reflects a WSJ analysis of CBO estimates of change in outlays and revenues from from the GOP policy bill passed by the House May 22, including resulting increase in debt service, as a percentage of CBO's January 2025 GDP projections

Source: Congressional Budget Office

Print design by ERIK BRYNILDSEN/WSJ

GOP Plan to Fold Audit Watchdog Into SEC Hits Snag

By MARK MAURER

Republican lawmakers' proposal to fold the U.S. audit watchdog into the Securities and Exchange Commission hit a roadblock when the Senate parliamentarian determined that including the provision in a broader tax bill violates rules around budget reconciliation. The Senate parliamentarian late Thursday ruled out the Public Company Accounting Oversight Board plan and several other provisions in Senate Banking Chair Tim Scott's proposed addition to Republicans' policy bill, according to Senate Budget Committee ranking member Jeff Merkley's office. Proposals to place a funding cap on the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, reduce the pay of Federal Reserve staff and lower funding for the Office of Financial Research are also ineligible to be part of the proposed legislation.

The parliamentarian said these provisions violate the Senate's Byrd Rule, a law named for the late West Virginia Democratic Sen. Robert Byrd that prevents lawmakers from using the special fast-track budget reconciliation process to advance policies with fiscal effects that are merely incidental to their broader aims. The move means that 60 senators would need to vote to waive the rule to keep the provisions. Otherwise, Senate Republicans will have to remove them from the package or alter them in ways that comply. Opponents of Republicans' PCAOB plan have warned it would weaken oversight of auditing firms and reduce the accuracy and reliability of financial reporting, in part because they fear the SEC is unlikely to replicate the PCAOB's expertise and infrastructure due to resource constraints and competing priorities. PCAOB Chair Erica Williams and several international audit regulators have urged lawmakers to reconsider the plan.



The Senate parliamentarian quashed Sen. Tim Scott's plan.

“This is good news for millions of Americans whose retirement savings and investments would be put at risk by eliminating the PCAOB,” Williams said Friday. Congress created the PCAOB in 2002 to boost financial oversight in the wake of the Enron and WorldCom accounting scandals.

The Republican-led House in May passed the broader tax bill, 215-214, which included the provision to eliminate the PCAOB. The Senate has been compiling its own version of the tax bill, aiming for a vote as soon as the coming week. That proposed version also would eliminate the PCAOB, but would bar the SEC from raising fees to pay for its expanded duties. The PCAOB, whose budget is nearly \$400 million this year, is funded by fees paid by public companies and broker-dealers. The SEC requested to add \$100 million to its fiscal 2026 budget if it were to be required to take on the PCAOB's work, SEC Chair Paul Atkins said at a House hearing in May, adding he would likely seek additional funds. In response to the parliamentarian move, Scott, a South Carolina Republican, said he remains committed to advancing legislation that cuts waste and duplication in the U.S. government.

Senate Banking Committee Republicans recently said folding the PCAOB into the SEC would save an estimated \$771 million over a 10-year period. If the provision doesn't make it into the final tax bill, the PCAOB is likely not entirely safe from major changes. Lawmakers could reintroduce the proposal at some point. The SEC, led by longtime PCAOB critic Atkins, could also move to remove the board members as it has done in recent years. Senators and the parliamentarian are still discussing other provisions in the bill and whether they comply with the Byrd Rule. Those meetings are expected to continue through the weekend.

Houston

It all comes together in Houston.

Experience a city woven from the imaginations and aspirations of cultures from around the world.

VisitHouston.com

Imagine if other automakers were as American as they said they were.

You'll hear a lot of car companies talking about how much they do for the country these days. They're all busy wrapping themselves in the flag, professing their commitment to American manufacturing and so forth.

We say: Talk is cheap.

We say: Put your money – and your factories – where your mouth is.

We say: Nobody's committed to America like Ford is.

That's why 80% of the vehicles we sell in America are assembled in America.¹

Imagine if other car companies did the same.

What would happen if they put down the megaphones and rolled up their sleeves?

What would happen if they were more like Ford?

If they were like us, America would have ten to fifteen new domestic plants.

If they were like us, there would be hundreds of thousands more jobs here.

If they were like us, they would assemble nearly four million more vehicles per year – right here in America.

But they're not like us.

We turned down the taxpayer bailout, and doubled down on America – adding thousands of jobs since 2007. We're busy assembling more vehicles in the U.S. than any other automaker.²

And instead of sending our profits overseas, we send our vehicles overseas – exporting more American-assembled vehicles than any other automaker.³

It comes down to this: Plenty of automakers are from America.

But only one can truly say that it's for America. It's the one that's still family-led.

It's the one that was investing in America before it became politically convenient to do so.

With 87,000 employees working hard to get a vehicle out the door every fifteen seconds.⁴

Ford Motor Company.
From America. For America.



L I N C O L N

1. Based on S&P Global Mobility CY 2024 US Light Vehicle Production data and CY 2024 US Light Vehicle Sales data. 2. Based on S&P Mobility CY 2024 US Light Vehicle Production data.
3. Based on S&P Global Mobility CY 2024 Import Sourcing Module data. 4. Of foreign and domestic parts. Based on 2024 CY production data, straight 365-day year, and 24-hour days.

U.S. NEWS

ICE Moves To Deport Reporter Arrested At Protest

By VICTORIA ALBERT

The Department of Homeland Security is attempting to deport a reporter based in the state of Georgia who was arrested at one of the “No Kings” protests that were held across the country last weekend.

Mario Guevara, a Salvadoran national and Spanish-language reporter known for documenting immigration-enforcement actions, was arrested by local police last weekend while reporting on a demonstration near Atlanta.

He was brought in on allegations of willful obstruction after refusing to comply with local police orders to move out of a street, the department said in a post on X. He was later turned over to Immigration and Customs Enforcement custody and has been placed in removal proceedings, the department said Friday.

Guevara entered the U.S. illegally in 2004, the department said. His attorney, Giovanni Diaz, said Tuesday that Guevara is legally authorized to work in the U.S.

Guevara said in a 2019 New York Times documentary that he applied for political asylum when he came to the U.S. from El Salvador. He said he had been threatened and attacked for his reporting there. The current status of his asylum application isn’t clear. His legal team didn’t respond to a request for further comment.

President Trump’s efforts to carry out the largest deportation campaign in U.S. history has sparked widespread protests. It has also raised concerns among free-speech advocates that the administration will use immigration enforcement to target those who push back against the president’s policies.

Guevara livestreamed video from the protest northeast of Atlanta, narrating in Spanish as protesters waved flags and chanted. At one point, he ran away from what appeared to be tear gas. The video later showed officers approaching Guevara, who identified himself as a member of the press, and taking him into custody.

Diaz, Guevara’s attorney, said Guevara has been doing similar reporting for 20 years without issue. Guevara didn’t do anything illegal at the protest, Diaz said, raising concerns that he was potentially targeted for his work. “He understands the law. He’s always complied with the law,” Diaz said.

Local police said they arrested Guevara after he disobeyed several orders to stay off the road, according to an incident report. Authorities obtained arrest warrants for unlawful assembly, obstruction of a law-enforcement officer, and for being a pedestrian on or along the roadway, according to the report.

Another attorney for Guevara said Wednesday that his legal team was preparing a bond motion for immigration court and has requested the state court charges be dismissed.

Several organizations have expressed concern that Guevara was arrested and targeted for deportation because of his reporting. Homeland Security denied that there was anything improper about Guevara’s detention.

Miller Holds More Sway With Trump

Continued from Page One
he thought Miller wasn’t leader material.

His influence has expanded sharply since, largely because of his steadfast loyalty to Trump. This account of Miller’s tenure is based on interviews with current and former White House officials, Trump advisers and other prominent Republicans.

Some of Miller’s colleagues said they were alarmed by some of the legal maneuvers that he has proposed for executing the administration’s anti-immigrant agenda, and the president has gently ribbed him for being too “happy” about deportations.

Miller, who isn’t a lawyer, is the official who first suggested using the wartime Alien Enemies Act to deport migrants, which the Justice Department pursued. He also privately, then publicly, floated suspending habeas corpus, or the right for prisoners to challenge their detention in court, which the administration hasn’t tried. That prompted pushback from other senior White House and Justice Department officials.

His orders to increase arrests regardless of migrants’ criminal histories set off days of protests in Los Angeles. Miller coordinated the federal government’s response, giving orders to agencies including the Pentagon, when Trump sent in the Marines and the National Guard, according to officials familiar with the matter.

Wider portfolio

Miller’s portfolio covers almost every issue Trump, a Republican, is interested in. In recent months, he talked to CEOs about a coming tariff announcement; joined a meeting between Meta Chief Executive Mark Zuckerberg and Trump about the company’s antitrust case; and met with other tech companies on artificial intelligence.

Even some posts at cabinet agencies have been described by administration officials as reporting directly to Miller, effectively bypassing cabinet secretaries.

There are some limits to his influence. He was supportive of Meta’s push to settle its antitrust case, which fell flat. Trump last week signaled concerns that the administration’s deportation policies were too aggressive, calling for a pause in some deportations that he has since rolled back. The administration’s aggressive posture on immigration and deportations has started to spark some voter backlash, with polls showing Trump’s approval rating on this issue has turned negative.

Several White House staffers said Miller always takes the most “extreme” view of any issue, and his positions have cost the administration in court. In Trump’s first 100 days back in office, courts issued nationwide injunctions in 25 cases against the federal government, compared with six in his first term and four under the Biden administration, according to a report by the nonpartisan Congressional Research Service. Several cases have already reached the Supreme Court, which has ruled against Trump on some immigration cases.

“I think the administration has miscalculated and over-



Stephen Miller appeared above, at left, after President Trump signed an executive order in the Oval Office in February, and below before members of the media in late May. Some of Miller’s positions have cost the Trump administration in court.



stepped,” said Skye Perryman, who leads Democracy Forward, an organization that has repeatedly sued Trump.

Miller has responded to the courts’ intervention by denouncing it as “judicial tyranny.” His allies argue illegal border crossings are down to almost zero because of his aggressive proposals.

“Stephen Miller is one of President Trump’s most trusted and longest serving aides for a reason—he delivers,” said Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary.

In the wilderness

Miller stuck by Trump when many staffers quit their jobs after Trump supporters’ Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the Capitol. He had helped draft Trump’s speech that morning and worked until noon on Jan. 20—when Trump’s first term ended—telling the officer taking his badge he’d be back in four years.

“Sixteen Hundred Pennsylvania Avenue is the greatest address in the world, and though we now leave these gates, rest assured, this is not goodbye,” he wrote to colleagues.

Three months later, Miller launched a nonprofit, America First Legal, aimed at countering what Miller described as a “yearslong, one-sided legal assault” by the left. “Now, we must turn the tables,” he said at the time.

Over the next four years, it filed dozens of lawsuits, categorized on its website under topics including “DEI,” “Woke Corporations” and “Women’s Sports.” The group’s targets are now under fire from the Trump administration.

In 2022, the group called on the Education Department to stop distributing federal funds to universities where it alleged antisemitism was festering. Three years later, the Trump administration would do just that at universities including Harvard, Columbia and Northwestern.

In 2024, Miller’s group helped 16 Republican-led states sue the Biden administration over a policy that protected illegal immigrants married to U.S. citizens from deportation. A judge ruled in the states’ favor, and the Trump administration overturned the policy this year.

By the time Trump returned to the White House, the group had about two dozen lawyers on staff and had raised more than \$60 million from donors, whose identities it doesn’t disclose. The group paid Miller more than \$500,000 last year, according to his financial disclosure.

Meanwhile, Miller continued to play an active role across the Republican Party, even if his outreach wasn’t always welcome.

Congressional aides fielded lengthy calls from Miller about illegal immigration, often without any specific requests. One likened him to a grandmother who wouldn’t stop talking and said his calls were akin to listening to a podcast. Others said he would call to scold aides about how they had framed a social-media post on a particular issue

or criticizing the way they had worded a news release.

As a House committee prepared for then-Homeland Security Secretary Alejandro Mayorkas to testify, Miller came to the Hill to play the role of Mayorkas, aides said. During the prep, he answered questions as the secretary—but also chimed in to give lawmakers advice on questions.

Miller was determined to kill a bipartisan bill pushed by Sen. James Lankford of Oklahoma, a Republican, in 2024 on the border and regularly called House Speaker Mike Johnson (R. La.). He also called the Republican National Committee to offer his advice on how the party should communicate on immigration, sometimes offering his thoughts on what the RNC chairman could tweet, people familiar with the discussions said.

He was a regular visitor to Mar-a-Lago during the campaign, meeting with Trump above his ballroom. Campaign aides said Miller always wanted to talk more about immigration. Trump’s top pollster, Tony Fabrizio, and his other aides wanted to keep the message on the economy. Trump staffers started displaying ominous photos of migrants at his events.

Hundreds of orders

In the first term, Trump was largely unprepared to govern. Miller regularly complained then that others in

the administration tried to block his immigration decisions, and outside lawyers would stymie their efforts. This time, Miller came in determined to correct that.

He brought hundreds of proposed orders to the White House, as well as his own staff. Russell Vought, the one-time treasurer of America First Legal, is now the White House budget chief. Reed Rubinstein, the group’s senior vice president, was nominated as legal adviser of the State Department. Matt Whitaker, a board member, is the U.S. permanent representative to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization.

He now tells other staffers how to behave around Trump, people who have heard his comments said, and upgraded his office from one on a different floor to one steps from the Oval Office.

During the first term, Miller would push for hard-line policies that others blanched at, including advocating for several dozen countries to be added to a travel ban list of seven, a former administration official said. People laughed, but he was serious, the official said.

This time, Trump announced a ban that covered a dozen countries.

He keeps in Trump’s good graces by giving Trump ideas—but more importantly, helping the president carry his own out.

Administration officials noted how Miller shut down discussion about whether the U.S. should bomb Houthi targets in a Signal chat that was accidentally shared with the Atlantic’s editor in chief. As the vice president and top national security officials discussed options, Miller weighed in.

“As I heard it, the president was clear,” Miller said. “Green light,” he added.

Earlier this month, Leavitt, the press secretary, interviewed Miller at a private event for Republican donors at the Four Seasons in Washington.

Miller, who grew up in Santa Monica, Calif., said large swaths of Los Angeles were engaged in a “rebellion,” according to people present.

Los Angeles had become like Cancun, he said. It was fine to visit, he said, but not good for its own citizens. To conclude the event, Leavitt told the crowd that Miller needed to return to his work of deportations.

Miller smiled in response, and then left to return to the White House.

Read the Paper You Love on Any Device

Access your daily paper anytime, anywhere with our Print Edition app or website. Enjoy convenient access to full-page articles for easy reading and more.

WSJ subscribers have exclusive access. If you haven’t yet, activate your digital account today at [WSJ.com/connect](https://www.wsj.com/connect) to start exploring.

DOWNLOAD THE APP
[WSJ.com/printapp](https://www.wsj.com/printapp)



VISIT ON DESKTOP
[WSJ.com/ereader](https://www.wsj.com/ereader)



Immigration Issue Turns Against Trump

Aggressive push to deport alarms some of his supporters; ‘not what we voted for’

By Molly Ball

The aggressive effort to fulfill President Trump’s pledge of mass deportations is testing the bounds of what Americans will tolerate—and the administration’s resolve.

Federal officials in recent weeks have stepped up raids on worksites and farms, sparking alarm in immigrant communities and street protests in Los Angeles and other cities. Last weekend, Trump directed that arrests be paused at farms and hotels, only to reverse the directive days later.

The back-and-forth was a sign of the conflict in the administration, which faces pressure from businesses and some Republicans to dial back—and from the MAGA base to pick up the pace.

Republican members of Congress from California, Texas and Florida have urged the White House to give priority to deporting criminals. The chairman of the House Agriculture Committee, Rep. Glenn “GT” Thompson (R., Pa.), called the farm raids “just wrong.” The co-founder of Latinas for Trump, Florida state Sen. Ileana Garcia, wrote on X that the administration’s actions were “unacceptable and inhumane” and “not what we voted for.”

“I may have voted for Trump, but I can’t stay silent about what’s happening with ICE in LA,” Ryan Garcia, a former interim lightweight boxing champion who endorsed

Trump last year, wrote on X. “We can have borders without losing our humanity.”

Presidents have historically hesitated to pursue large-scale immigration enforcement in the country’s interior precisely because it tends to be politically unpopular. Polls are showing Trump’s approval rating on immigration and deportations—formerly one of his strongest issues—has now turned negative. In the polling average maintained by the analyst Nate Silver, Trump’s immigration policies were popular on a net basis until earlier this month—but are now more unpopular than popular by a 3-point margin. Trump is still viewed more positively on immigration than on the economy and trade.

On Thursday, after a Fox News poll showed 53% of voters disapproved of his handling of immigration, Trump posted on his social-media platform, “They are always wrong and negative. It’s why MAGA HATES FoxNews.” (Fox News’s parent, **Fox Corp.**, and The Wall Street Journal’s parent, News Corp, share common ownership.)

“Trump’s muscularity on immigration has always been a source of strength, but pulling people out of their homes and workplaces and schools seems cruel,” said Democratic pollster Molly Murphy. In her surveys, Americans by a 40-point margin oppose deporting people without due process or in violation of a court order and conducting raids at churches, schools and hospitals.

But some of Trump’s most ardent supporters are urging aggressive enforcement. “I’m hopeful they will ramp up deportations and keep it going



A migrant being transferred from an Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility climbed onto a plane in Gary, Ind., on Friday

Mass Deportations Require an Unpopular, Large Net

The problem with achieving the millions of deportations that President Trump has repeatedly promised, experts say, is that it is possible only by targeting migrants who have resided in the U.S. illegally for a long time but haven’t broken other laws and have become integrated into society, as op-

posed to criminals or those apprehended shortly after an illegal border crossing.

“We are witnessing a level of interior immigration enforcement the likes of which we haven’t seen since the Great Depression,” said Alex Nowrasteh, vice president for economic and social policy studies at

the libertarian Cato Institute, who opposes the administration’s policies.

“Nobody likes border chaos, and that was a big reason voters supported Donald Trump in 2024,” he said. “But interior enforcement is much less popular than border enforcement because it’s socially and economically disruptive.”

pathy for “our great Farmers and people in the Hotel and Leisure business” who “have been stating that our very aggressive policy on immigration is taking very good, long time workers away from them”—only to post a few hours later that he was committed to stanching the “tsunami of Illegals.”

“I campaigned on, and received a Historic Mandate for, the largest Mass Deportation Program in American History,” he wrote on Truth Social. “Those who are here illegally should either self deport using the CBP Home App or, ICE will find you and remove you.”

Back in 2012, then-private citizen Donald Trump sang a different tune. His theory about why the Republicans had just lost the presidential election: Nominee Mitt Romney had alienated Latino voters by endorsing “a crazy policy of self deportation which was maniacal,” and as a result had “lost everybody who is inspired to come into this country.”

U.S. WATCH



COMEBACK: Ex-Chicago Cubs slugger Sammy Sosa returned to Wrigley Field for the first time since 2004. Sosa, who hit a club record 66 home runs, was linked to a performance-enhancing drug scandal. Last year, he apologized for mistakes, without specifying them.

OHIO Threats Against Lawmaker Alleged

A man in Ohio was arrested Thursday, after police said he shouted antisemitic slurs and threats at U.S. Rep. Max Miller as the congressman drove to work that morning.

The lawmaker, who is Jewish, tweeted that the other person ran him off the road and showed him a Palestinian flag. “Thank God my daughter was not in my vehicle or anybody else at the time,” the Republican said in a video posted on X.

The Rocky River Police Department in Ohio said Feras Hamdan, 36 years old, voluntarily turned himself in Thursday night. He was charged with aggravated menacing and ethnic intimidation. Bond was set at \$500,000. He was still in custody Friday afternoon, a spokeswoman said.

Hamdan’s lawyer, Issa Elkhatab, said the allegations were baseless, outrageous and defamatory.

“Dr. Hamdan is a respected physician, a devoted husband, a loving father, and an upstanding member of his community,” Elkhatab said. “We are confident that the truth will win and that Dr. Hamdan’s good name will be fully vindicated.”

—Joseph Pisani

SUPREME COURT Terrorism Victims Allowed to Sue

The Supreme Court on Friday ruled that American citizens injured during terrorist attacks, and the survivors of those who were killed, could bring lawsuits seeking monetary damages from Palestinian authorities in U.S. courts.

In a unanimous decision, the court said a 2019 law meant to facilitate lawsuits against the Palestinian Authority and Palestine Liberation Organization didn’t violate the Constitution.

An intermediate federal appeals court had ruled that the law violated the due process rights of the Palestinian Authority and PLO.

The high court’s ruling was a victory for a group of families who have sought to hold the Palestinian Authority and PLO liable for six shootings and bombings between 2002 and 2004 in the Jerusalem area.

The families contended Palestinian authorities provided financial compensation to Palestinians imprisoned for terrorism-related offenses against Israelis, as well as to the families of those killed while carrying out attacks.

They won a jury verdict in 2015 valued at \$655 million.

—Corinne Ramey

HEALTHCARE Insurers Try to Fix Preapproval Steps

Following the backlash that hit health insurers after the killing of a top executive last year, the industry will pledge steps meant to smooth the controversial preapproval process that can deny or delay access to care.

The initiative is set to be unveiled Monday, according to people familiar with the matter. Major insurers will promise to ease so-called prior authorization by creating a common standard for submitting electronic requests by the start of 2027, the people said. They will also pledge that 80% of electronic requests will be answered in real time by 2027, though only if the submissions include needed documentation, a potentially significant caveat.

The changes could ease an administrative process that has long been a major pain point for doctors and hospitals, which complain they must hire extra staffers just to deal with the bureaucratic burden of seeking insurer permission to provide care to patients.

A spokeswoman for AHIP, a group representing insurers, had no comment Friday.

—Anna Wilde Mathews



PERFECT PURPLE RAYMOND YARD AMETHYST RING

Legendary jeweler. Vibrant saturation. Refined craftsmanship.



Deep royal purple radiates from the 27.62-carat cushion cut amethyst in this exquisite ring by Raymond Yard. Framed by sparkling diamonds and set in platinum, the design showcases Yard’s renowned expertise in presenting only the most exceptional gemstones. The celebrated American jeweler’s timeless Art Deco designs continue to captivate collectors worldwide. #32-0670



View a video of this ring

M.S. Rau
FINE ART • ANTIQUES • JEWELS

622 Royal Street, New Orleans, LA • 888-767-9190 • ws@msrau.com • msrau.com

Since 1912, M.S. Rau has specialized in the world’s finest art, antiques and jewelry. Backed by our unprecedented 125% Guarantee, we stand behind each and every piece.

WORLD NEWS

Pressure Builds on Iran as Diplomacy Stalls

Israelis warn of long, intense conflict after talks with European officials sputter

GENEVA—Top European officials have lined up behind the Trump administration’s demand that Iran give up its uranium-enrichment program, as pressure mounted on Tehran

By Summer Said, Laurence Norman and Benoit Faucon

to make deep concessions if it wants a diplomatic off-ramp from the fighting with Israel.

That fighting threatens to intensify with the possible entry of the U.S., a prospect that has alarmed officials in the oil-rich Persian Gulf who fear an escalatory spiral if Iran retaliates. President Trump says he will decide whether to join Israel’s attacks within two weeks to give time for negotiations to work.

Israel has shown no signs of being willing to stop the campaign it began this month with surprise airstrikes and intelligence operations that targeted Iranian military leaders, nuclear sites and air defenses. Israel’s top general said Friday the country is ready for a prolonged campaign to degrade Iran’s nuclear program.

Despite the growing pressure, Iran has remained defi-



Iranians demonstrated against Israel in the capital, Tehran, on Friday as fighting continues between Iran and Israel.

ant, raising doubts about whether a negotiated solution can be found. Tehran has told diplomats in several recent conversations that it won’t end its enrichment of nuclear fuel and won’t enter talks with the U.S. unless Israel stops its attacks, said Arab and European officials.

Talks with European for-

eign ministers on Friday didn’t move Iran any closer to the concessions it would need to make to stop the fighting.

“Iran is ready to consider diplomacy once again, once the aggression is stopped and the aggressor is held accountable for the crimes committed,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said after the talks.

Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa’ar expressed doubt about Iran’s openness to talks given the lack of progress. “Iran is saying ‘we will not negotiate when we are attacked.’ But when they were not attacked, nothing happened with the negotiations,” Sa’ar said in an interview Friday with Japan’s NHK. “I don’t believe that Iran

wants to find a solution.”

While Iran avoided making concessions, it was clear that its room to maneuver was shrinking. French President Emmanuel Macron said talks will have to involve Iran giving up the ability to make the fuel that powers nuclear weapons.

While there is no common European position on enrich-

ment, German Foreign Minister Johann Wadepuhl made a similar call for a ban, and some British officials have agreed. The meeting ended with no new date set for more talks between Iran and the Europeans.

“We urge Iran to continue their talks with the United States,” U.K. Foreign Secretary David Lammy said after the Geneva talks. “This is a perilous moment.”

Trump administration special envoy Steve Witkoff presented Iran with a proposal this past week that would require it to stop enriching uranium but would give it access to fuel enriched elsewhere by a regional consortium, said the Arab and European officials.

Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty discussed the U.S. proposal and Iran’s response on separate calls with Witkoff and Araghchi on Tuesday and Friday. Iran said it was willing to cap its enrichment at 3.67%, a level consistent with civilian uses, but wouldn’t give it up, said the Arab and European officials. That position hasn’t been acceptable to the U.S.

The U.S. wants Iran to come back with a clear answer to its latest offer before resuming nuclear talks, the Arab and European officials said. The White House didn’t respond to a request for comment.

The U.S. military has been building up its forces in the Middle East.

Israel Burns Through Interceptors as U.S. Races to Help

By SHELBY HOLLIDAY

The U.S. is moving to reinforce Israel’s defenses, sending more warships capable of shooting down ballistic missiles to the region as Iranian attacks drain Israel’s stocks of interceptors.

An additional U.S. Navy destroyer arrived in the eastern Mediterranean on Friday, joining three others in the area and two in the Red Sea. The ships are operating close enough to Israel to be able to intercept missiles fired by Iran, a defense official said.

Most of the U.S.’s Arleigh Burke-class guided-missile destroyers are armed with a range of interceptors, known as SM-2, SM-3 and SM-6, that can shoot down aerial threats.

The U.S. also has replenished stocks of ground-based interceptors for the Thaad antimissile system it set up in Israel last year. Formally known as Terminal High Altitude Area Defense, the system is operated by the U.S. Army and designed to intercept missiles inside or

outside the atmosphere during their final phase of flight, known as the terminal phase.

The surge of seaborne- and ground-based missile defenses underscores the concerns about Israel’s dwindling supplies of the armaments. Israel risks exhausting its supply of high-end Arrow 3 interceptors in the coming weeks if its conflict with Iran isn’t resolved and Tehran continues to launch missiles, a U.S. official said.

Israel uses several different systems to provide a multilayered defense. The well-known Iron Dome works on shorter-range rockets and drones. David’s Sling intercepts missiles, planes and drones at a greater distance.

The Arrow 3 is the crown jewel, designed to intercept missiles above the Earth’s atmosphere. It can neutralize threats before they cross into Israeli airspace and give other systems time to act if the first shot misses.

“Without Arrow 3, it’s problematic,” said Timur Kadyshev, a researcher at the



A member of the Israeli security forces works at the site of a building hit during an Iranian attack in southern Israel.

University of Hamburg who has studied the Arrow system. “You have less time to shoot down an incoming missile because you’re shooting them only in the terminal phase.”

Israel Aerospace Industries, the company that makes Arrow interceptors, didn’t respond to requests for comment. Israel’s armed forces also declined to comment on

interceptor stockpiles.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, in an interview Thursday with Israel’s public broadcaster Kan, declined to answer whether Israel was running out of Arrow 3 interceptors. He estimated that Israel has destroyed about half of Iran’s missile launchers since the current conflict began, diminishing the threat

posed by Iran’s missile arsenal.

The Wall Street Journal reported Wednesday that Trump approved attack plans for Iran, but was holding off on giving the final order for two weeks to see if Tehran would abandon its nuclear program through diplomacy. The waiting period will keep the onus on Israel to continue the fight even as its ability to defend against missile attacks diminishes.

“There’s no time to lose, and two weeks is a very long time,” said Tom Karako, director of the Missile Defense Project at the Center for Strategic and International Studies.

Israel is using its control of the skies over western Iran to take out more missiles before they are launched. Its air superiority could force Iran to fire from farther away, which means using liquid-fueled missiles that take more time to get ready, making them more vulnerable to attack.

Still, Tehran has continued to fire missiles at Israeli population centers. If Iran keeps up its attacks, Israel in the com-

ing days might be forced to make difficult decisions about husbanding its resources and giving priority to which missiles to intercept, Kadyshev said.

The U.S. is facing its own concerns about interceptors. Supplies diverted to the conflict in the Middle East are coming at the expense of those available in the event of a bigger conflict with China.

“We are concerned for the number remaining for the high-end fight,” said a U.S. officer who has operated in the Middle East. “SM-3s will start running low at this pace of operations, cutting into reserves for the next kinetic engagement.”

The U.S. also could face tough decisions about how many interceptors to exhaust if the fighting drags on.

Watch a Video



Scan this code for a video on Israel and Iran trading more blows.



ISSEY MIYAKE

New Flagship Store 126 Prince Street New York

EXCLUSIVE VINEYARD PARTNER INVITATION

Taste the Fresh White Bordeaux That’s Breaking Boundaries

ENJOY THIS 93-POINT, DOUBLE-GOLD BORDEAUX BLANC FOR LESS THAN \$24 A BOTTLE WITH FREE SHIPPING

Château La Clarière made a name for itself by crafting a red Bordeaux that shook up the region’s long-established, strict hierarchy. Now, you can unlock access to their fresh white.

The origins of the special estate go back to 1969, when Tony Laithwaite (now a big name in the British wine industry) visited Bordeaux. Just a college student at the time, he discovered a secret hiding in plain sight...

Castillon lies on the same limestone ridge as the most famous estates in Saint-Émilion. It has the same *terroir*, but the wines don’t command the same high prices.

“

If it wasn’t for the political line dividing Castillon from Saint-Émilion, its wines would be twice or three times the price.

— *Wine & Spirits*

Tony decided to take a leap of faith. He purchased La Clarière and made a red wine like a Saint-Émilion Grand Cru. It’s since won over 190 awards, including the prestigious Prix d’Excellence at the *Concours Général Agricole*, proving that a wine’s quality isn’t determined by a name on the label.



Sometimes lightning does strike twice. The estate has repeated their boundary-breaking success with their dazzling white wine... Instead of blending their thrillingly crisp, citrusy Sauvignon Blanc with Sémillon, like most Bordeaux estates do, winemaker Jean-Marc Sauboua opted for Sauvignon Gris, a much rarer related grape variety. This adds a unique minerality and rounded body to the finished wine.



Since its launch in 2016, the wine has won **18 gold medals, multiple 90+ scores** and the **Top Castillon White Trophy** at the *International Wine Challenge*, where Master of Wine Martin Moran called it, “Intense...textured and elegant. 95 points.”

The new 2023 release of La Clarière’s white has already earned **93 points**, a gold medal and a double-gold medal. It gives the “cult whites” from its neighbors in Saint-Émilion a run for their money. For example, a bottle of Château Cheval Blanc’s highly sought-after white, Le Petit Cheval Blanc, will cost you over **\$150**, but Château La Clarière Blanc retails for **\$34.99**.

And the price is even better for Vineyard Partners. La Clarière is **just \$23.99** when you order six bottles (over 30% off). Plus, you get **access to the château** with preferential rates on overnight stays and a VIP experience when you visit.

With **limited cases available**, you’ll want to secure your share today.



SAVE OVER 30%



CHATEAU LA CLARIERE BLANC 2023, BORDEAUX
Enjoy a 6-bottle allocation **\$66 OFF**
+ FREE SHIPPING with promo code **BLANC2023**
A total of \$239.94 \$143.94 + tax



ORDER TODAY AT **wsjwine.com/blanc2023**
OR CALL 1-888-863-7384 QUOTE CODE AFXR017



VINEYARD Partners

Vineyard Partners is an exclusive program that lets you tap into our extraordinary connections.

ENJOY RARE ACCESS
Receive guaranteed allocations of exceptional wine, always at the best possible price.

CHAMPION TRUE TALENTS
Having a dedicated group of supporters allows the winery to spend more time making wine (and less on marketing).

EXCLUSIVE PERKS
Get updates throughout the year, VIP experiences at the estate with advance notice and more.

Your first case of Château La Clarière Blanc will be delivered for \$143.94 (6 bottles) or \$275.88 (12 bottles) and applicable tax. Then, each following year, 6-bottle partnerships will receive 6 bottles of the new vintage for \$143.94 and 12-bottle partnerships will receive 12 bottles for \$275.88, plus \$19.99 shipping and applicable tax (Advantage members enjoy free shipping). You will receive a reminder before your preferred payment method is automatically charged—and will always have at least 30 days’ notice to skip or delay your delivery. You can also cancel your membership anytime (online or by phone). Offer subject to availability and club enrollment. Limited to one case per household. Offer valid in U.S. only (excluding AL, AR, DE, GA, HI, KS, KY, MD, ME, MS, MT, OK, RI, SD, TN, UT, VT). 100% money-back guarantee applies to each wine. All orders fulfilled by licensed retailers/wineries and applicable taxes are paid. You must be at least 21 years old to order. WSJ Wine is operated independently of The Wall Street Journal and Dow Jones & Company, Inc. See full terms and conditions online. Presale offer expires 7/27/25. Void where prohibited by law. Please drink responsibly.

Outlook for Diplomacy Darkens

Continued from Page One

to do so or by coercing Iran to give up its atomic ambitions in some kind of negotiated settlement. Israeli politicians have also called for the ouster of Tehran's theocratic regime.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel wants the U.S. to join in and boost his chances of fulfilling his goals. U.S. bunker-busting bombs, for instance, have the best chance of knocking out Fordow, Iran's fortified underground uranium-enrichment facility.

The White House said Thursday that President Trump would decide within the next two weeks.

Israeli policymakers appear to be counting on the ability of air power to win the day without ground operations, perhaps aside from small deployments of special-forces soldiers and intelligence officers assisting airstrikes.

For Israel, there is little choice. It lacks the wherewithal to mount large-scale ground operations far from its borders and against a vastly bigger adversary. The U.S. has the capacity, but the Trump administration has signaled great reluctance to put boots on the

ground in any foreign war.

If Israel succeeds, with or without U.S. help, it could prompt a serious reassessment of the capabilities of modern air power, its effectiveness augmented by unmanned aircraft and more sophisticated surveillance and intelligence-gathering technologies. But skeptics abound.

There are few if any precedents for a large-scale armed conflict in which two states exchanged blows via air power alone. This approach, with no ground forces, "certainly changes the course of any war—you cannot physically seize things, you can only physically destroy," said Phillips O'Brien, a military historian.

Both sides have to look at the enemy country as a functioning machine and identify components, such as military production or command and control, whose destruction can lead to a win. "That's never easy—which is why there are so few" purely aerial wars, O'Brien said.

Israel and Iran have been trading blows overtly and covertly for years. Since 2023, the two have been at war indirectly, via Iranian-backed militant groups in Gaza, Lebanon and Yemen, and directly with exchanges of missile salvos and airstrikes last year.

"If you have limited political goals that don't require a presence on the ground, then in theory you can achieve victory even through air power alone," said Ofer Fridman, a former Israeli officer.



Israeli Air Force jet fighter above southern Israel on Friday.

Israel's broad array of targets, from military and nuclear facilities to props for regime power such as police and economic assets such as oil refineries, make it difficult to divine just how expansive Israel's strategic aims are.

Iran's war aims are simpler. The regime wants to preserve its power—and its freedom to continue the enrichment of uranium. But its capabilities are far more limited. Iranian ballistic missile attacks haven't caused major damage in Israel, given the country's robust air defenses.

Meanwhile, Israeli planes dominate the skies in the western half of Iran and are bombing targets at will. Tehran's

best hope, analysts said, is to hold on grimly until Israel's expensive, logistically onerous air effort runs out of time.

There are at least four ways the war could end.

Israel—especially with U.S. help—might succeed in physically destroying so much of Iran's nuclear program that it would take Tehran many years to rebuild it.

Alternatively, mounting damage could force Iran's leaders to cave in and sign a deal that foreswears uranium enrichment. Thirdly, the Iranian regime might collapse, taking its nuclear ambitions with it.

But a muddled outcome is also possible if the regime holds on and doesn't give in

on enrichment, and if the damage to its nuclear facilities is incomplete. Tehran might then repair its nuclear program with greater determination, with less international monitoring and in harder-to-hit locations.

Even if Fordow is destroyed, the war might only buy time until Iran tries again to build a bomb. That too would be a gain for Israel, depending on the length of any delay. In the time won, other events could intervene. The Iranian government could collapse or change its approach.

When Israel used airstrikes to destroy nuclear reactors in Iraq in 1981 and Syria in 2007, it set back the nuclear-weapons programs of Saddam Hussein and the Assad regime.

In Iraq, "the short-term effect was success and the long-term effect was to drive Iraq underground with its future programs," said Michael O'Hanlon, a scholar at the Brookings Institution in Washington.

In Syria, civil war broke out before Bashar al-Assad could do much to revive his nuclear program. He fell from power last year, in a surprise side effect of Israel's mauling of his Lebanese ally Hezbollah.

Examples of air power on its own leading to regime change are nearly nonexistent, military historians said. Experience suggests it takes ground forces too—or at least a competent allied rebel force on the ground.

When a U.S.-led coalition ousted the Taliban in Afghanistan

in 2001, it cooperated with local military forces. U.S. ground troops were also quickly deployed. (The Taliban returned to power 20 years later when the U.S. pulled out.)

Israel's battering of Iran from the air could weaken the government's prestige and damage its mechanisms of domestic control and repression. But there is currently no sign of an opposition force in Iran that can sweep the regime away, whether through armed rebellion or mass protests.

Almost all major air campaigns in history have been part of wars that involved ground forces too. Examples include Nazi Germany's blitz against Britain, Allied strategic bombing of Germany, the prolonged U.S. bombing of North Vietnam, the first weeks of the U.S.-led war against Iraq in 1991 and Russia's ongoing bombing of Ukraine since 2022.

The North Atlantic Treaty Organization's air campaigns in former Yugoslavia, Afghanistan and Libya involved cooperation with local allies. India and Pakistan traded airstrikes in May this year but also shelled each other with artillery.

The closest precedent for a purely aerial war, apart from the Israel-Iran clash, might be Israel's fight with Yemen's Houthi militia since 2023. Involving exchanges of long-range missiles and bombing raids, it has been the most inconclusive front in Israel's wars since the Oct. 7 attacks.

They have been trading blows overtly and covertly for years.

WORLD WATCH



UNITED KINGDOM

Lawmakers Back 'Assisted Dying'

Following an impassioned debate, U.K. lawmakers on Friday voted 314-291 to approve a bill to allow terminally ill adults in England and Wales to choose to end their lives, taking it one step nearer to becoming law.

The majority of 23 was less than the 55 when they last voted on the issue in November. Changes to the bill since that vote notably include the dropping of the requirement that a judge sign off on any decision. Many in the legal profession had objected. Now any request would be subject to approval by two doctors and a panel featuring a social worker, senior legal figure and psychiatrist.

People over age 18 in England and Wales who are deemed to have less than six months to live could to apply for an assisted death. The bill doesn't apply to Northern Ireland or Scotland, which is holding its own vote.

The bill now goes to the unelected House of Lords, which can amend or delay policy, though it can't overrule the lower chamber.

—Associated Press



HAT TRICK: England's five days of Royal Ascot are all about horse racing, or maybe also a bit about headgear.

CHINA

Shopping Festival Sets Sales Record

China's second-largest shopping event of the year generated record sales. Once a one-day campaign to mark online-shopping giant JD.com's June 18 founding anniversary, the "618" shopping festival this year ran from mid-May to mid-June, and gross merchandise value across shopping sites was up 15% to 855.6 billion yuan, equivalent to \$119.03 billion, according to data provider Syntun. This year's tally included an extra week of promotions.

The 618 festival is exceeded only by November's Singles Day extravaganza, started by rival Alibaba.

With economic woes—including dimming job prospects and a yearslong property-sector slump that has eroded household wealth—leaving consumers reluctant to open their wallets, Beijing has implemented encouragement measures including subsidies for goods such as smartphones and household appliances. JD.com said the number of users who placed orders this year more than doubled from 2024.

—Tracy Qu

GREECE

More Than 600 Migrants Rescued

More than 600 migrants were rescued overnight and early Friday from two wooden fishing boats, the country's coast guard said.

The first boat, carrying 352 people, was spotted south of the tiny island of Gavdos, the coast guard said. Passengers were rescued by a ship from the European border patrol agency Frontex, aided by a coast-guard patrol boat and four other vessels. The second was found south of the island of Crete with 278 people on board, who were picked up by a passing cargo ship. In both cases, the migrants were taken to Crete.

There was no information on the nationalities of those on board the boats. Greece has been on one of the preferred routes into the European Union for people fleeing the Middle East, Africa and Asia for decades. With authorities closely patrolling the eastern sea border with Turkey, smugglers appear to be increasingly opting for the longer and riskier crossing from the north African coast to the southern tip of Greece.

—Associated Press

Is Iran Close to a Bomb?

By LAURENCE NORMAN

Iran's progress toward having a nuclear weapon is central to the conflict between Israel and Iran.

Before launching recent attacks against Iran's nuclear sites, Israel said it had evidence Tehran was on the

brink of building a nuclear weapon.

U.S. officials weren't convinced that the information pointed to a decision by Tehran to build a bomb, The Wall Street Journal reported.

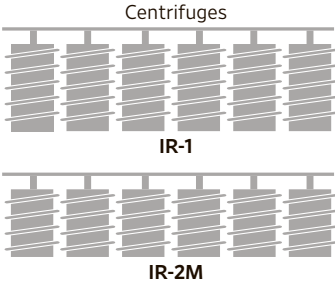
Iran has long insisted that its nuclear program is for peaceful purposes.

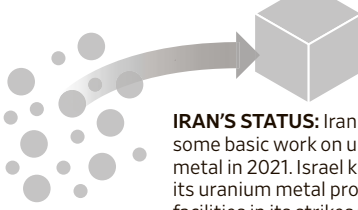
The International Atomic Energy Agency estimates that it would take Iran one to two weeks to produce enough weapons-grade-enriched uranium for a nuclear weapon, and U.S. officials have said that Iran could construct some kind of crude nuclear weapon in a few months.

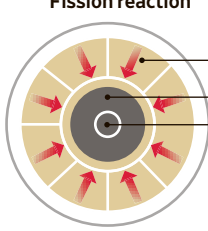
Steps to a Nuclear Weapon

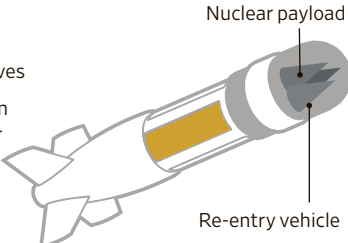
Iran is believed to have mastered most of the techniques for building a nuclear weapon, using enriched uranium. Iran told the U.N. atomic agency in 2005 it had received blueprints for processing uranium gas and casting and enriching uranium from Pakistani nuclear scientist Abdul Qadeer Khan. Experts believe Iran could produce a crude nuclear weapon in several months, but it would take longer for Iran to develop nuclear warheads that are missile-deliverable. Iran claims its nuclear work is for purely peaceful purposes.

- Iran converts pure uranium into gas form and then uses thousands of centrifuges in its enrichment sites to spin the material into a highly enriched form. Once it has enriched uranium to around 90%, it is usable for a nuclear weapon.

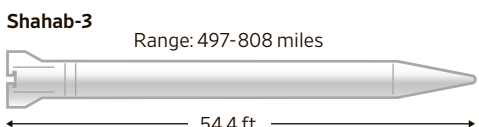

- The weapons-grade enriched uranium needs to be converted from its gas form into metallic form through a chemical process. The metal then needs melding and casting into hemispheric forms, a mechanical process requiring high-precision machinery.

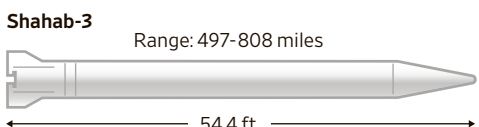

- Iran has worked on creating an implosion weapon that uses high explosives to compress fissile material to start a chain reaction. Among the ingredients required is a wiring system that sends a huge electrical impulse to a detonator that uniformly ignites the high explosives in the weapon. The core of a nuclear weapon is made up of the uranium metal and a neutron initiator, which triggers a burst of neutrons to set off the chain reaction in a nuclear explosion.



- 

IRAN'S STATUS: Iran is known to have produced and worked on many of the components of a warhead in the past, including neutron initiators, multipoint detonators and uranium metal. But Iran isn't thought to have started work on trying to assemble the various components into a possible warhead.
- Iran's past nuclear-weapons work aimed to deliver a warhead using its Shahab-3 liquid-based ballistic missiles, although a warhead could theoretically be delivered by truck or ship. The Shahab-3 employs a separating re-entry vehicle, protecting the weapon during launch and re-entry into the atmosphere.



- 

Shahab-3 Range: 497-808 miles

54.4 ft
- IRAN'S STATUS:** Iran is believed to have kept its missile system largely separate from its past nuclear-weapons work. It's therefore believed not to have carried out all the usual tests on how a warhead would behave with its missiles.

- Unless Iran kicks out inspectors and withdraws from the treaty banning the development of nuclear weapons, Tehran would have to carry out key aspects of its nuclear-weapons production covertly, without attracting the attention of inspectors or foreign intelligence agencies. That would require Iran to build secret facilities and would take time.
- IRAN'S STATUS:** Iran built a number of nuclear facilities in the past secretly without informing the U.N. atomic agency. It had threatened to kick out inspectors if Israel attacked.



Sources: King's College (centrifuges); Wisconsin Project on Nuclear Arms Control (fission reaction); Center for Strategic and International Studies (Shahab-3); Nuclear Threat Initiative (nuclear sites)

WORLD NEWS

Iranian Jews in U.S. Dream of a ‘Free Iran’

By SARA RANDAZZO

LOS ANGELES—Sam Yebri doesn’t remember the country his family fled when he was a 1-year-old, exiled from Iran for being in the Jewish minority. But he has followed the politics of the Islamic nation his entire life, wondering if this current moment would ever come.

“For a long time there’s been anxiety that my Jewish homeland would be at war with the land of my birth,” said Yebri, a lawyer and community activist. “To see it actually happen is surreal.”

The escalating conflict between Israel and Iran is gripping Iranian Americans in Los Angeles, which is home to the largest Iranian diaspora in the world. For many Iranian Jews, the war brings back memories of their families’ expulsion. For some, it also has rekindled what long felt like a far-fetched dream: a future Iran they could possibly visit.

A mile-long stretch of Westwood Boulevard known as “Tehrangles” includes Persian bookstores, hookah lounges, grocery stores selling Middle Eastern imports and passport-processing shops with signs in Farsi and English.

Yoni Radfar recounted his Jewish family’s harrowing escape from Iran in the early 1980s, after the Iranian Revolution installed Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini into power. As they fled by night on horseback, Kurdish coyotes chided a 6-month-old Radfar for crying, afraid he would give away their location.

The family settled first in San Francisco, opening jewelry stores around Fisherman’s Wharf, before being drawn south to the larger hub of Persian culture in Los An-

geles. “It was destined for us to move here,” Radfar said. Many Iranian Americans in Los Angeles refer to themselves as Persian, tying them to their cultural and linguistic heritage rather than the current Islamic regime.

Almost 200,000 Iranian Americans live in the greater Los Angeles area, according to Census Bureau data, of roughly a half-million nationwide.

Many in the Los Angeles community come from persecuted minorities in Iran, including Jews, Christians, Assyrians and Baha’i. Because of their exile, few still have family in Iran or have ever returned. By some estimates, the Jewish population never surpassed 100,000 in a country of 35 million pre-Revolution; it is now thought to be less than 10,000.

“I would love to visit a free Iran one day,” said Siamak Kordestani, who left Iran as a young boy with his family in the late 1980s to settle in Los Angeles. “I hope it comes in my lifetime.”

Kordestani, who works in international and government affairs, said he and his friends have celebrated seeing symbols of Iranian state oppression impacted in the recent bombings, such as the Iranian state television headquarters and other government ministries.

Beverly Hills Mayor Sharon Nazarian has spoken of coming to the U.S. with her family, who is Jewish, as they fled religious persecution in Iran.

Watching the conflict has been painful, but Nazarian views Israel’s actions as “a pre-emptive effort to prevent a potential catastrophe,” rather than an assault on the people of Iran, she said in an email this week.

Europe Aims to Fortify Its Ports

EU plans to ease troop movements; shipping firms fear hit to competition

By COSTAS PARIS AND DANIEL MICHAELS

President Trump has demanded Europe spend more on its militaries. The continent is answering the call—in part by broadening its definition of what counts as military spending.

Fearing a full-scale war with Russia, the European Union and NATO planners are homing in on the continent’s ports as potential chokepoints should the military alliance need to rush large numbers of troops to its eastern border. Governments are boosting their traditional military outlays, but looking to factor spending on infrastructure and transport hubs into their military budgets.

Shipping executives fear that reconfiguring ports to handle military movements could undermine their competitiveness. European officials have pledged to balance security needs with profits.

At the North Atlantic Treaty Organization annual summit starting Tuesday, members aim to agree to increase military outlays to 5% of gross domestic product from their current target of 2%. A large chunk of the new target, 1.5% of NATO members’ GDP, will be allocated to nonlethal domains that are seen as vital to securing NATO territory—from cybersecurity and government resilience to roads, railroads and ports.

The EU has proposed spending up to 75 billion euros, about \$86 billion, in its next five-year budget to up-



Belgium’s Port of Antwerp is part of a strategically important U.S. military rotational operation.

grade transport infrastructure for military use for the first time since World War II. The final amounts are under debate, but even a fraction of the target would mark a big jump from the €1.7 billion allocated for military mobility in the current budget, which ends in 2027.

“The ability to move troops and military equipment quickly across Europe is a military priority, but it is not just that,” said Apostolos Tzitzikostas, the EU’s transportation commissioner, who is overseeing the plan. “It is also essential for crisis response but also for making our transport systems smarter and stronger.”

European officials want to identify port weaknesses, such as a lack of physical infrastructure or poor internet connections, that could impede military movements.

At a recent meeting of the European Sea Ports Organization, enhancing security was the sole item discussed.

“We understand it’s needed, but still, we need to achieve competitiveness,” said Katarzyna Gruszecka-Spychala, vice president of finance at the Port of Gdynia, Poland. Private investors could hesitate to put money into businesses that might be targeted by Russia, she said.

Security officials say investors must figure defense into their thinking. Aleksandrs Bucens, a senior logistics officer at NATO’s defense-planning policy division, told attendees that ports should expect to be part of military cargo-handling exercises. It was the first time that a NATO executive attended an EU ports meeting. “You need to be out there, talking to people, moving things around. So be prepared, adaptable and resilient,” he said.

Officials say business and security can complement each other. NATO and the EU’s executive arm, the European Commission, have identified

500 hot spots across the bloc must be upgraded to face a possible confrontation with Russia, according to people directly involved in the matter.

“Together with NATO, we have mapped priority corridors, identified key bottlenecks and we will continue to direct investment to upgrade critical ports and logistics hubs,” the EU’s Tzitzikostas said. “These assets need to be competitive in peacetime and ready to defend European citizens when it matters most.”

The EU also aims to shield ports and other transport infrastructure from cyberattacks. The European Maritime Safety Agency is helping ports identify their cyber weak points and improve their responses to attacks. The Nordic Maritime Cyber Resilience Center, a nonprofit company created by Norwegian shipping companies, has identified Russian hackers as a significant threat to Europe’s infrastructure and defense.



Shoppers stroll along Oxford Street in London.

Retail Sales in U.K. End Winning Run

By JOSHUA KIRBY

British shoppers drew back on spending in May, a new sign of pessimism in a struggling economy.

Retail sales volumes were down 2.7% from April, the country’s Office for National Statistics said Friday, ending a streak of four straight months of rising sales as the weather improved and easing inflation encouraged consumers. May’s drop, the sharpest since 2023, was driven by a decline in food-store sales, the ONS said. Clothing and hardware-goods sales also fell back, partly a result of sunny spring weather’s encouraging home-improvement work earlier in the year than usual, the agency said.

Indeed, the U.K. economy got off to a bright start to the year, thanks in part to some recovery in consumer spending. But it contracted by 0.3% at the start of the second quarter as President Trump’s tariffs took their toll on exports and business confidence. Employer-tax increases and a rise in utility bills, both taking effect in April, look to be hitting retailers and consumers at once, wrote Phil Monkhouse of financial-services firm Ebury. “[Friday’s] data will be a real sign of worry for those businesses hoping for strong summer sales,” he said. “The outlook for consumer demand looks rocky.”

Still, there are signs that household and retail spending could begin to pick up again. Confidence among British consumers recovered a little this month, according to research group GfK’s monthly index for June, published Friday with

the Nuremberg Institute for Market Decisions. Price inflation is easing, standing at 3.4% last month.

Consumer confidence improved two points to minus 18, building on May’s rise and besting economists’ expectations for no change.

Improvement in respondents’ feelings about the general economic situation drove the uptick, likely fueled by easing inflation and a cut to interest rates by the Bank of England in May. By contrast, the gauge of personal financial situations remained unchanged. Perceptions of the general economy are vulnerable to a worsening global backdrop, notably the Iran-Israel conflict, which has sent oil prices higher and risks a new increase in energy bills.

“Confidence is still fragile because the dark shadow of inflation is a day-to-day challenge for so many of us,” GfK’s Neil Bellamy said.

Consumers could still face negative effects, with the escalation of conflict in the Middle East and continuing uncertainty about the impact of tariffs, he added.

“With so much volatility, now is certainly not the time to hope for the proverbial light at the end of the tunnel,” Bellamy said.

Confidence is likely to have been boosted by a trade deal with Washington, announced in May and signed this week, that minimizes U.S. tariffs on British imports, Pantheon Macroeconomics’ chief U.K. economist Rob Wood wrote in a note to investors.

“But risks to consumers’ confidence lie ahead,” he said.

In Memoriam

John Lie-Nielsen



BRADENTON, FLA. - John Lie-Nielsen, 90, a restless and innovative entrepreneur who founded what became the biggest manager of apartment buildings in the United States in the 1980s and developed technology to help landlords reduce the risks of property ownership, passed away on May 31, 2025, in Bradenton, Florida surrounded by family.

Starting in the early 1960s, Mr. Lie-Nielsen used a loan and his savings of \$2,000 to buy a crumbling two-family house in Sacramento, California. Learning by doing, he repaired the foundation, put on a new roof and replaced sinks, toilets and kitchen counters, allowing him to sell the house for a profit.

“And so, I was on my way,” he told The New York Times, which published a profile of him in 1985 and described him as “an empire builder with a frugal touch.”

Mr. Lie-Nielsen launched Johnstown American in the 1970s, a management company for apartment buildings owned by others. He expanded the firm rapidly through acquisitions. At its peak in the 1980s, Johnstown managed buildings with a total of about 160,000 rental apartment and condominium units across the country, primarily in the Sun Belt.

The Atlanta-based company, whose shares traded on the American Stock Exchange, also managed shopping centers and industrial buildings, and owned a mortgage banking firm and a supplier of carpeting.

At Johnstown, Mr. Lie-Nielsen pioneered computer software, known as Little Buddy, to keep track of such data as rent payments, maintenance needs and vacancies. The company trained its own maintenance workers and baked pies in model units to give prospective tenants a homey feeling. In 1985, Johnstown acquired Consolidated Capital, a real estate investment company in which Mr. Lie-Nielsen was an investor and senior executive, for \$200 million.

“He set a tone with ‘do it right and do it right now,’” recalled Steve Alvarez, who was an executive vice president of Johnstown. Mr. Lie-Nielsen was known for keeping costs low. Executive lunches tended to be at Denny’s.

He was an early adopter of stand-up desks and liked to hold stand-up meetings with his staff. “When you came to meet with him, you didn’t get too comfortable,” Mr. Alvarez said. “He wanted to get business done.”

Mr. Lie-Nielsen sold Johnstown in 1988 and moved on to other ventures, including investments in real estate.

He founded HandyTrac Key Control in 1993, a provider of security systems that control access to apartment units for maintenance workers, leasing agents and others. The business remains a market leader in its space.

In 2009, at the age of 74, Mr. Lie-Nielsen founded WaterSignal, a provider of patented technology that he developed to allow building owners to detect leaks and keep tabs on water-usage rates. At the age of 88, he successfully sold that business in 2023 to Metron Farmer.

Johan Douglas Tate Lie-Nielsen, later known as John, was born on March 16, 1935, in Boston. His mother, Patricia Marshall Tate, was a high-society portrait artist, some of whose works were acquired by the Smithsonian Institution. His father, Oistein Lie-Nielsen, born in Norway, was a master yachtsman, hired to helm racing boats in regattas, and later owned a yacht-building business in Rockland, Maine.

John’s parents divorced when he was two years old. At age four, he was sent to Norway to live temporarily with his paternal grandparents, only to be marooned there by the outbreak of World War II. His parents sought help from the State Department and Red Cross to bring him home. In September 1941, he was able to board a Lufthansa airplane and fly from Oslo to Lisbon, where he boarded the ocean liner Excambion, with a Jersey City destination tag around his neck. He made headlines in September 1941 when his parents embraced him at a Jersey City pier after his perilous Atlantic crossing.

The Boston Globe reported that the red-haired boy spoke almost no English, was impressed by the sight of the Empire State Building and eagerly tucked into ice cream, a sweet ending to wartime privations in Norway.

Around age 12, while living with his father and stepmother in southern Georgia, he ran away from home and worked on a sugarcane farm. Retrieved by the family, he enrolled at the Berry boarding school in Rome, Georgia, where he helped pay for his education by milking cows. Encouraged by a teacher there to widen his horizons, he moved on to Emory University in Atlanta and majored in economics.

As a young man, he supported himself by running coin-counting machines at a bank, teaching ballroom dancing at an Arthur Murray dance studio, and selling such items as highchairs and photograph albums.

After graduation from Emory and service in the Marines, he moved to Sacramento, where he worked in a state government personnel office. He also co-founded a short-lived dance studio before finding his calling in real estate.

Mr. Lie-Nielsen is survived by his wife of 31 years, Debra Lie-Nielsen; sisters Linda and Annela; brothers Erik, Charlie, Tom and Richard; children Ilya, Bo, Richard, John, Shana, Ryan, Kerry and Brent; and grandchildren Reilly, Ben, Kai Tristan, Scarlett, John Connor, Savannah, Johan, Sophia, Tristan, Gavin and Wyatt.

His advice to young people was “to get in the game” rather than spending too much time contemplating ideal careers and worrying about what could go wrong. Launching into any kind of opportunity was bound to be educational, even if it did not work out perfectly, he said.

Though he was always a hard worker, and family trips typically involved looking at real estate opportunities, Mr. Lie-Nielsen found time to coach his children’s soccer teams and run the Peachtree 10K road race in Atlanta. In later years he was an active grandfather in all of their lives, making sure each holiday, however small, had small gifts and treats for them.

He enjoyed reading about business and history. He occasionally read fiction, but few novels could match the adventures of his own life.

Brown & Sons Funeral Homes & Crematory 43rd Street Chapel, 604 43rd Street West, Bradenton, FL 34209, is in charge of arrangements.

William T. Bagley



SAN RAFAEL, CALIF. - Bill Bagley (born William T. Baglietto), the first chairperson of the Commodity Futures Trading Commission (CFTC), passed away after a happy and extraordinary life. Born in San Francisco, in 1928, his family went bankrupt soon thereafter and had to move to what had been a vacation cabin in rural Marin County (Woodacre). Bill persevered, working his way through high school, college and law school with the Marin County Fire Department. He graduated from U.C. Berkeley in 1949, as a Phi Beta Kappa and the valedictorian, and from Berkeley School of Law in 1952, serving on the California Law Review. In 2002, he proudly received the UC Berkeley Alumnus of the Year award.

He practiced law for 63 years, 35 of those years as a partner with the national law firm Nossaman, LLP. He excelled at business, land use, water, transportation, public utility and public policy law. A notable legal achievement included defending the First Amendment before the United States Supreme Court.

Part time public service occupied his early career, serving in the California State Assembly from 1960 to 1974, representing Marin and Sonoma. Bill was a liberal republican, led even democratic members on the tabulated NAACP voting record, and traveled with Governor Nelson Rockefeller in the 1964 presidential primary. He authored transparency laws such as the California Public Records Act and Bagley-Keene Open Meeting Act and advocated for civil rights. His published work “California’s Golden Years: When Government Worked and Why” reflected on this era of political history.

In 1974, the passage of the Commodity Futures Trading Commission Act expanded the lightly regulated Chicago futures market into a worldwide industry. The Ford-Rockefeller administration appointed Bill to the CFTC in Washington, DC. He spoke in Europe and Tokyo on behalf of this burgeoning new industry. He also served on the Futures Industry Association Board of Directors, California Transportation Commission (Chair), Public Utilities Commission, and the University of California Board of Regents.

Bill is survived by his wife of 60 years Diane, children Lynn, Bill Jr., Walter, Shana, and Tracy (Chris) and his beloved grandchildren Nicholas, Julian, Nathaniel, Grant, and Layli. The family is deeply grateful for the love and support from Alexis, Camie, and all who cared for him.

He asked for no services but requested that memorial donations be made to the Bagley Minority Scholarship - The Achievement Awards Program, Cal Alumni Association, Alumni House, Berkeley, CA 94720 (development@alumni.berkeley.edu).

Samuel B. Seigle



NEW YORK, N.Y. - Samuel B. Seigle, longtime professor of Classics and beloved mentor to generations of students, passed away on June 12, 2025, in New York City. He was 92.

Born in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, on November 7, 1932, he was the only child of Jack Seigle and Edith Barmen. He earned degrees from the University of Pittsburgh and Harvard University, and taught ancient Greek and Latin literature, history, and culture for more than 55 years—most notably at Sarah Lawrence College, where he was known for his deep knowledge, wit, and personal investment in his students.

Mr. Seigle championed interdisciplinary learning long before it was common practice, encouraging students to draw connections between classical studies and their broader interests. As one former student recalled: “He made education personal, and amazing.”

Even in retirement, he continued to teach—hosting seminars, reviewing academic work, and inspiring those around him with his generosity of spirit.

When asked how he’d like to be remembered, he said: “It’s not goodbye forever, it’s hello again.”

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

IN MEMORIAM

Honor your loved one's life in The Wall Street Journal

Share your loved one's story with an announcement in the pages of The Wall Street Journal, either in our national or regional editions. Our In Memoriam notices provide a dignified way for friends, family and colleagues to pay tribute.

To learn more, visit WSJ.com/InMemoriam

© 2025 Dow Jones & Company, Inc. All Rights Reserved.

FROM PAGE ONE

City Rallies For Trash Collector

Continued from Page One

lapses and a citywide boil-water advisory blamed on a Mylar balloon. So when a service goes well, people notice.

"In other cities, people generally don't greet one another on the street and talk about garbage," said Stephen Swain, who lives in a residential section of Bourbon Street. "All people can talk about is how wonderful the whole cleanliness situation is, and worrying that it might go away."

Trash bags he puts out for collection seem to disappear

within minutes. Uniformed workers go around with manual scrubbers and rags, cleaning even the tops of trash cans. And don't get him started on the trucks that seem to whisper rather than screech through the streets. "We have a little ray of sunshine in our lives," Swain said. "And they want to take it away."

The object of his affection, IV Waste, provides trash services for most other neighborhoods in New Orleans. But it didn't win the French Quarter contract. New Orleans Mayor LaToya Cantrell selected Henry Consulting for the nearly \$75 million, multiyear deal in what City Council members called an unfair bidding process after the previous provider's contract ended.

When Henry Consulting got into a payment dispute with its subcontractor, the council

refused to sign the contract, and the city in December tapped IV Waste to clean for a year on an emergency basis.

With the subcontractor issue resolved, Cantrell has said she wants Henry Consulting to start work at the beginning of August. But the council still refused to sign the contract. So owner Troy Henry sued. The issue is being debated in state courts—and on the streets of New Orleans.

"It's very unusual for something to be so incredibly popular and easy and yet a politician just goes, 'Hold my beer,'" said City Council President JP Morrell, who has been leading the charge to rebid the contract.

Cantrell declined to comment. Henry said his company deserves a chance. "We'll do an exemplary job," he said. That lemon scent residents

love, Henry added, is part of the deal. "It's not like they're doing something gratuitous," he said.

Sure, says IV Waste owner Sidney Torres IV, but the contract doesn't specify how much of the fragrance they need to use. "You can go buy a little cup of Pine-Sol and pour it in the back of that truck," said Torres. "It's like a Tic Tac in a whale's mouth—you're not going to even smell it."

Earlier this month, the state granted a board of residents and business owners temporary permission to oversee sanitation contracts in the French Quarter while the lawsuit over the current contract is pending. That means they can retain IV Waste for now.

All around the Quarter, signs hang in front windows to "Keep IV Waste."

Members of Patio Planters,

a volunteer organization that works on beautification projects, have been printing the signs by the hundreds.

"It's not very often that the businesses, the residents, even the tourists agree on any one thing," said group president Joey DiFatta. It's not necessarily that residents are worried Henry Consulting will do a bad job, he added, it's that they don't want to risk changing something that's going well.

Tourists seem to be noticing that the city looks spiffier. But they are befuddled by the new signs. "Is this about IV drugs?" one conference attendee asked a friend, who shrugged.

Locals say the signage is a small way they can show their support for IV Waste.

Torres insists he hasn't done anything to drum up the support. But he certainly doesn't mind. "It feels really

good when you give your heart and soul to something and people take notice," said Torres, a Quarter resident himself.

Ronald Davis, who owns Thrive Nola Spa downtown, said the prior conditions on Wilkinson Street used to turn off customers and make him dread going to work.

"You come out of this beautiful space feeling good, smelling good, and you get hit with a urine smell," said Davis. "It ruins the environment, ruins your experience."

Now, Davis said, he sees workers spraying the street with washing fluid and picking up litter multiple times a day when he looks out the spa's front window.

"New Orleans depends on the tourism industry," he said. "If you don't have clean streets, how can our guests feel comfortable?"



Above left, new homes and homes under construction in Paradise, Calif. Above right, the new SweetBay community in Panama City, Fla.

Money Follows Disasters

Continued from Page One

economic upheaval.

More potential peril awaits as this year's Western wildfire season and Atlantic hurricane season get under way.

The economic dynamic can bring benefits. Government aid and insurance payouts deliver an infusion of investment. Rebuilt homes become sturdier. Property values rise, infrastructure is upgraded and some neighborhoods get makeovers.

"A natural disaster can be a galvanization moment for a community," said Allan Branch, the mayor of Panama City.

Yet the upheaval pushes others out. Poor residents have a tougher time navigating bureaucratic procedures for disaster aid and weathering job losses. Renters often get evicted from damaged properties and face spiraling rents as the supply of units shrinks. Low-income homeowners frequently struggle to pay for repairs that must comply with stricter building codes and to buy insurance coverage.

"Social inequalities are exacerbated after a disaster," said Kathryn McConnell, a sociology professor at the University of British Columbia who has studied how destructive wildfires affect migration.

'Recovery machines'

"Climate gentrification"—the idea that climate change and natural disasters drive lower-income people out and let higher-income people rebuild or move in—has become a popular research topic. One study of the Paradise fire earlier this year found that the more than \$1 billion of federal aid aimed at recovery "facilitated displacement and gentrification by enabling socially advantaged previous and new residents to return and rebuild."

A 2020 analysis of severe tornadoes in the U.S. over a 30-year period showed that in their aftermath, affected neighborhoods became more white and well-off. The authors of a 2008 study of major hurricanes argued that in their wake, cities become "recovery machines" where entrenched forces and outside aid focus on recovering property rather than helping people land on their feet.

The dynamic is currently playing out in Altadena, Calif., a neighborhood decimated by the January wildfires, and Florida's western coast, which was battered by successive hurricanes last year.

An analysis of U.S. Census Bureau data by The Wall Street

Journal found a pattern of rising wealth in some areas struck by extreme weather. In Bay County, which includes Panama City, median household income, adjusted for inflation, increased 9% to \$71,500, from 2017 to 2023. The share of people in poverty dropped to 11% from 15% over that period, as many poor people left.

In 14 census tracts affected by the Camp Fire that include Paradise, median household income, adjusted for inflation, increased 21% to \$72,600, from the five-year period before the fire to the same span afterward. The share of housing units that were mobile homes fell to 15% from 20%, while the proportion of homes with seven or more rooms rose to 32% from 21%.

Priced out

Before Hurricane Michael hit in October 2018, Panama City, which sits on Saint Andrew Bay, was seen by many as a drab place, the seat of county government and home to several working-class neighborhoods. Panama City Beach—its neighbor to the west, across a bridge—was the entertainment center.

The storm, a Category 5 monster, largely spared Panama City Beach, but carved a vicious path across Panama City, including many neighborhoods with older homes not built to the current code. More than 45,000 structures were damaged and more than 1,500 destroyed in Bay County. Seven people died in Florida.

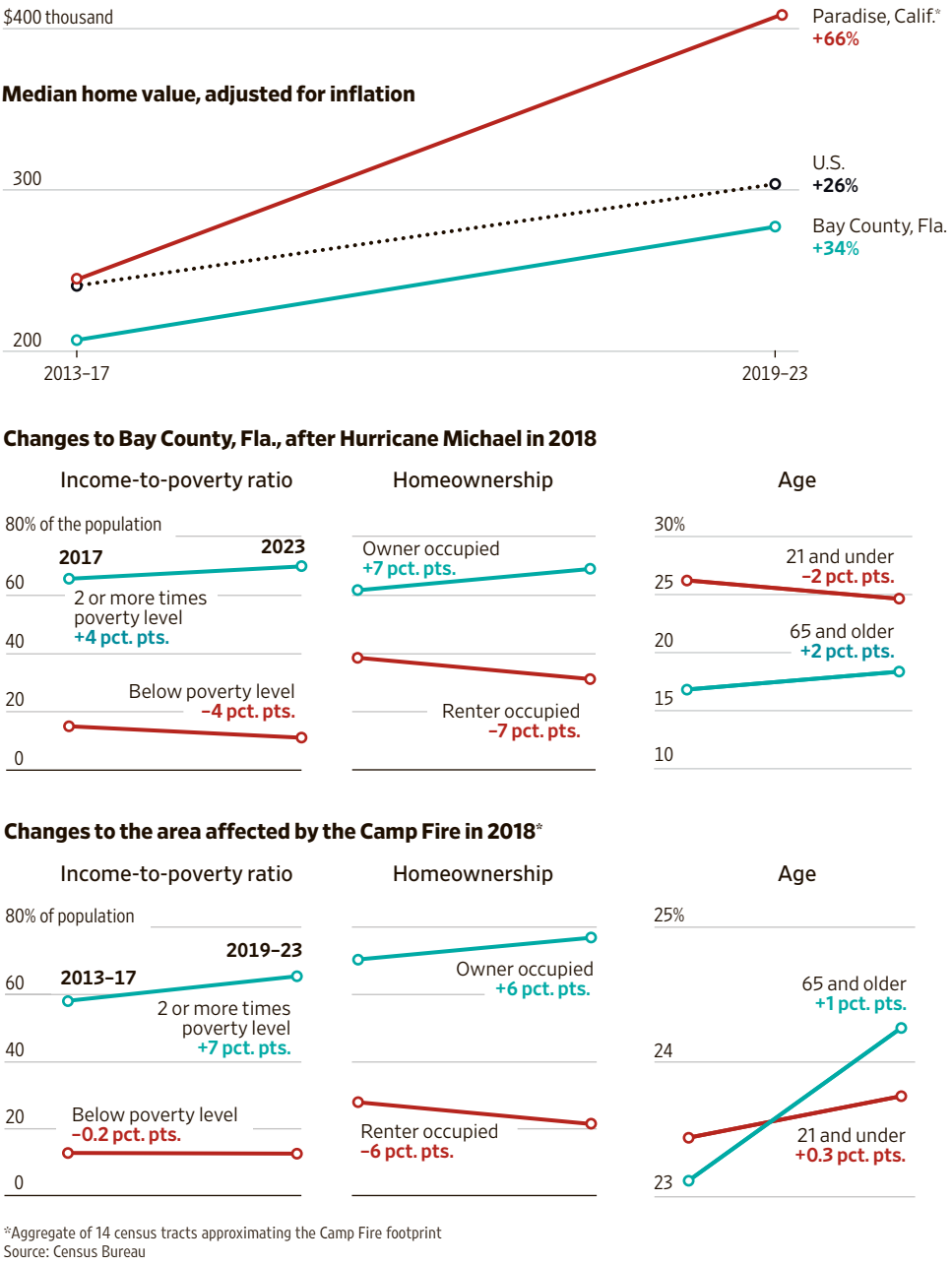
In the historic neighborhoods of Glenwood and Millville, with sizable low-income and Black populations, many residents had little or no home insurance coverage, said Donna Pilson, executive director of Rebuild Bay County, a disaster recovery organization. Some had properties that had been passed down through generations without a will or deed, making it difficult to establish clear title and secure disaster aid, she said.

Renters of damaged or destroyed homes left, and owners who couldn't afford to rebuild either sold their properties for whatever they could get or abandoned them in states of disrepair, residents say. To this day, the neighborhoods are dotted with derelict, boarded-up homes.

Rebecca Mason had moved to a nearby area from Hattiesburg, Miss., in 2017 with her three daughters to take a job at a call center earning \$20 an hour. She said she had long dreamed of living in Florida, with its relaxed beach lifestyle.

Then the hurricane sent a tree crashing onto the house Mason was renting and made it uninhabitable. With no savings and a need to get back to work, she and her daughters left for Covington, La., where the call center could give her a job.

Mason said she tried to find



a way to move back to Panama City, searching online listings of homes for a few years. But prices had soared. The house she had rented for \$1,200 a month was now repaired and going for more than \$2,000. She gave up and decided to stay in Covington.

Bay County's population fell 6% after the storm, but slowly recovered and reached 191,000 in 2023—an increase of 3% over its pre-storm level—while Panama City's rebounded to 36,000. Over that period, the composition of the community changed.

In the Cove, a historic middle-class neighborhood on the waterfront known for its large oak trees, Michael wrecked many of the area's older homes. But unlike in Glenwood, what followed was a frenzy of rebuilding as homeowners received insurance payouts and investors snapped up properties. The result: Shabby cottages are giving way to larger, more-modern homes.

Carly Sostheim and her husband, who had been living in Panama City Beach before the hurricane, saw an opportunity not only to buy a place for themselves in the Cove but to invest in damaged homes and rehabilitate them to rent out or sell. They purchased 13 proper-

ties over several years, including one they got for \$60,000. The most recent tenant was a dishwasher who rented it for \$300 a month before the storm, then never returned, she said. They put \$70,000 into it, rented it out for \$1,250 and eventually sold it for \$210,000.

In 2020, Sostheim, 40, became a real-estate agent specializing in selling waterfront properties to wealthy buyers, who she said are arriving in growing numbers. She and her husband are also building a spec house in Panama City Beach that they plan to list soon for \$1.5 million, she said.

Panama City's downtown, which used to go dormant at 5 p.m., has been overhauled as well. Branch, the mayor, began buying properties in the area even before the hurricane, and estimates it has drawn some \$50 million in private investment. Some streets have been redone with pavers, and new shops, restaurants and an upscale hotel have opened.

Earlier this year, Lily Frank moved with her fiancé and two children from Sioux City, Iowa, to a new development in Panama City called SweetBay. They are renting a place while they wait for their \$830,000 home to be completed. She plans to open a Florida location for her

business, an ultrasound clinic, in downtown, which she said looks nothing like it did before the storm.

"It just feels clean and classy and welcoming," said Frank, 33. "The whole town got a face-lift."

Rebuilding Paradise

Paradise's rebuilding has moved more slowly. Built along a ridge of the Sierra Nevada foothills, north of Sacramento, Paradise was known as a quiet, picturesque community that drew retirees with limited incomes and workers who commuted to nearby Chico.

The Camp Fire erupted in November 2018 and became the deadliest and most destructive wildfire in California history. It destroyed almost 19,000 homes and businesses and burned 90% of the structures in Paradise. The fire killed more than 80 people.

The local hospital shut down permanently, as did many stores. Of the town's 36 mobile-home parks, which housed retirees and low-wage workers, only eight have reopened, said Mayor Steve Crowder.

Residents faced steep challenges in rebuilding. Many who didn't have mortgages on their modest places lacked home in-

surance, so they sold their charred lots and left. High construction costs and skyrocketing insurance premiums proved prohibitive for some.

Kathleen Garduque and her husband, who was battling lung cancer at the time of the fire, lost the two-bedroom house they had bought for \$163,000 in nearby unincorporated Magalia. Strapped with medical expenses and traumatized by the fire, they decided not to rebuild. Months later, he died.

Garduque, a nurse, sold the lot to a neighbor for \$20,000. She used the money, along with about \$300,000 from an insurance payout, to buy a home in Yuba City, about 40 miles south. Many of her friends and neighbors moved on as well, she said. "More power to them if they can rebuild and make it a community again," said Garduque, 51. "Me, I had nothing left up there."

In the 14 census tracts analyzed by the Journal, the population fell 34%, to 33,000, from the five-year period before the fire to the same span afterward. Paradise, which had 26,500 people at the time of the fire, saw that count plummet to about 3,000 shortly after, then increase to about 11,000 today, said Mayor Crowder.

Amid the scarred landscape, a new Paradise is rising. Coffee shops, a hardware store and other businesses have reopened. Construction crews plow the orange earth and erect new houses, often larger than the ones they are replacing and outfitted with fire-retardant roofs and stone lawns.

Chas Pelton and his then-fiancée moved to Paradise from Chico after her parents bought the lot of a destroyed home for \$29,000 a year after the fire. The couple, who have well-paid careers in construction and are now married with two children, said part of the town's draw was relatively inexpensive parcels and rebuilt schools.

They built a 2,000-square-foot, three-bedroom house that is state-of-the-art for surviving a wildfire. While the previous house on the lot sold for \$165,000 in 2014, the couple's new home has an assessed value of \$465,000, according to property records. They haven't had a problem absorbing the escalating home-insurance premiums, Pelton said.

Pauline Hohenthanner, who has been selling real estate in Paradise for 40 years, said she thought her career would be ruined by the fire. Instead, she has sold lots and homes at a brisk pace since.

She lost two buildings and a large garage on her property in the fire. Hohenthanner and her husband lived in a trailer as they rebuilt with insurance money. But six years later, she is thrilled with her restored, safer and pricier property.

"The fire did us good, I hate to say that," she said. "Now we're on the other side of it, and we're happy."

OPINION

THE WEEKEND INTERVIEW with David Albright | By Tunku Varadarajan

Iran Is Down, but Not Yet Out

As Israel’s mission to destroy Iran’s nuclear capacity continues, a grave and obvious question confronts us: How did the West, the U.S. in particular, allow Tehran’s nuclear threat to grow unchecked for so long?

David Albright, an American physicist and nuclear-weapons tracker, is among the world’s foremost experts on Iran’s nuclear program. He’s president of the Institute for Science and International Security, a nonprofit, nonpartisan institution that focuses on the spread of nuclear weapons to rogue nations and terrorists. On June 12, the day before the first Israeli attack, Iran could “make enough weapon-grade uranium for 11 nuclear weapons within a month,” Mr. Albright says. Pre-attack Iran was on track to have enough highly enriched uranium for 22 weapons in five months.

Israel’s continued pounding of Iranian sites has degraded Iran’s capabilities. But the damage’s extent will take many days to establish, and the threat from Iran isn’t remotely contained. Mr. Albright’s “worst-case assessment” is that Iran could “still break out and produce enough weapon-grade uranium at Fordow”—the clandestine

The leading expert on its nuclear program sizes up the progress of Israel’s military campaign.

enrichment facility deep under a mountain south of Tehran—for a nuclear weapon in several days. I do not know how much of the current stock of 60% uranium has been destroyed by Israel. If most of it is still in Iranian hands, then Fordow could make enough weapon-grade uranium for nine nuclear weapons within a month, assuming it continues to operate.”

Iran could still have enough for 15 weapons in five months. But there’s also some reassurance: Iran’s “overall breakout capability,” he says, “has been degraded because of the loss of Natanz,” its largest enrichment facility, which Israel struck on June 13.

Mr. Albright offers a quick lesson in nuclear science: For uranium to be weapon-grade, it must be enriched to 90%. “Enrichment is a complicated process,” he explains. “If you start with natural uranium and enrich it to 5%, where you’re not even close to 90%, that’s actually 70% of the enrichment effort.” The math, on its face, is misleading. “When you’re at 60%, it may look like you’re 30% short on percentage, but you’re actually 99% of the way in terms of enrichment effort.” In other words, 60% enrichment is only a hair’s breadth from weapon grade—and Iran’s program is brimful with this near-weapon-grade uranium.

On May 31, the International Atomic Energy Agency published a damning report that revealed Iran had amassed 900.8 pounds of uranium enriched up to 60%. On June 12, the IAEA’s board of governors passed a resolution holding Iran in

violation of its obligations under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. An incensed Iran vowed to accelerate its nuclear program. “I think the Iranians expected that the Europeans and the U.S. would react as they’ve always reacted,” Mr. Albright says. “Oh, we’re very worried. We need to sit down and talk about this. We need to negotiate.”

But Iran “didn’t understand Donald Trump, and how nervous the Israelis really were. There are many criticisms of [Benjamin] Netanyahu, but on the Iran nuclear issue, he’s speaking for the nation.” Taking the Iranian threat of escalation at its word, Israel launched its first strikes the next day, bombing nuclear installations and killing nine of Iran’s top scientists.

Those attacks have “made it more difficult for Iran to build a nuclear weapon itself,” Mr. Albright says. “The weaponer elite has been eliminated.” These were scientists and engineers, not policymakers: “They took out Iran’s Oppenheimers.”

One of those killed was Fereydoon Abbasi-Davani, who warned in an interview last month that Iran could deploy nukes against “the U.S., England and the Zionist regime” by means other than missiles and aircraft. “What if they are attacked from within?” he asked, suggesting a resort to unconventional means, or through terrorist proxies.

Scientists like Abbasi-Davani can “be replaced over time,” Mr. Albright allows. Iran and its military have “a very robust engineering and scientific training program.” But in the short term, their elimination is “devastating.” Iran hasn’t yet recovered from the death of Mohsen Fakhrizadeh. Shot by Israel in November 2020, he was “the Leslie Groves of the Iranian nuclear program.” (Groves was director of the Manhattan Project.) “Fakhrizadeh’s successors haven’t been quite as good. So these killings are a huge disruption to the task of pulling a bomb program together.”

Mr. Albright, 73, has been in the business of nuclear nonproliferation since he was in his early 30s. He worked in the late 1980s to end Brazil’s secret nuclear-weapons program and in the early 1990s with the African National Congress as it prepared to lead the South African government to ensure it would oppose any resurrection of its apartheid predecessor’s dismantled nuclear-weapons program. He was a weapons inspector for the IAEA in Iraq in 1991 and founded the Institute for Science and International Security in 1993. The institute calls itself “the good ISIS” to distinguish itself from Islamic State: “We had the acronym first, and are determined to keep it.”

Mr. Albright’s reputation as an expert on the Iranian nuclear program dates back to ISIS’s seminal work in 2002. “An Iranian opposition group first identified a nuclear site near the city of Natanz but called it a fuel fabrication plant. Corey Hinderstein, one of my staffers, systematically searched satellite imagery covering the area around Natanz and found the site. I then identified it as a centrifuge enrichment plant.” That’s how the IAEA learned of the site. “I’ll tell



KEN FALLIN

you, we were very proud we found Natanz,” Mr. Albright says.

To understand Iran’s nuclear program and American neglect for the problem requires a study of history. Iran has had a nuclear weapons program since the 1980s. “It lived next to a very dangerous neighbor, Iraq, governed by Saddam Hussein, who had invaded them, and they were really unprepared. It led to a million Iranians dying in that war,” Mr. Albright says. The nuclear program “came out of that, but over time it evolved to focus mostly on Israel and the U.S.”

Initially “slow moving,” it became a “crash program” called AMAD in the early 2000s, under Fakhrizadeh’s leadership. When the U.S. invaded Iraq in 2003, the Iranians—fearful that they might be next—“decided to end that particular crash program. They were under a lot of scrutiny.” The Natanz plant had been uncovered, and the IAEA was breathing down Tehran’s neck.

And so, Mr. Albright says, Iran made a display of formally shutting down AMAD. “They also weren’t ready to make the bomb, because they didn’t have any weapon-grade uranium and were years away from being able to make it.” Yet far from ceasing their nuclear pursuit, “they continued it in a more camouflaged manner, shifting from a decision to build nuclear weapons to a decision to prepare themselves to build them if the leadership ordered them to do so.” They focused heavily on enrichment and embarked on the clandestine Al-Ghadir project—the plant known as Fordow today.

The U.S. intelligence community eagerly accepted this deception. As a National Intelligence Estimate put it in November 2007: “We judge with high confidence that in fall 2003, Tehran halted its nuclear weapons program.” The Iranians, “loved it,” Mr. Albright says of that assessment. “They loved to be able to trumpet that the U.S. intelligence thinks the program stopped and hasn’t been restarted. The U.S. intelligence would, like parrots, say that year after year after year.”

The most recent iteration of this dogma came this March, when Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard testified to Congress that the intelligence community “continues to assess that Iran is not building a nuclear weapon and Su-

preme Leader [Ali] Khamenei has not authorized the nuclear program he suspended in 2003.”

Mr. Albright scoffs. “U.S. intelligence assessments on the Iranian program have suffered from some serious analytical problems,” he says, “and I think it was a hangover from the total screw-up on the Iraqi WMD.” The essential mistake in Ms. Gabbard’s assessment is “not to take into account that Iran’s nuclear weapons program isn’t a traditional one.” The AMAD plan “shifted under pressure to a different type of nuclear weapons program, one focused on making progress while not needing an order from Khamenei to work on nuclear weapons. The U.S. intelligence model is like the on-off switch of a light, unlike the more nuanced program Iran has created.”

It astounds Mr. Albright that this delusion persists even after the daring theft of an Iranian nuclear archive by the Israelis in 2018. This intelligence trove revealed the full extent of Iran’s nuclear deception. The archive was stolen while the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action—the Obama administration’s deal that offered sanctions relief in exchange for limits on Iran’s nuclear activity—was still in force. (President Trump pulled out of the deal in May 2018.)

The Obama administration’s “Iran mantra,” Mr. Albright says, was the following: “They had a nuclear weapons program long ago. They haven’t had one since. Why do we care about that old program?” In the three years when the deal was in force, the “pressure on Iran stopped. The sanctions were becoming unbearable, so they agreed to cut back their program for 10 years, after which they could rebuild the whole thing again.” This three-year hiatus “galvanized the Israelis,” who abhorred the Obama deal, into much more activity. But they had to be careful, because the deal was sanctified by the United States government.

For one thing, Israel refrained from targeting Iranian scientists. “That would’ve been seen as crossing a red line.” What the Israelis did, instead, was try to uncover information. “That’s what led them to seize the nuclear archive in Iran and then publicize it.”

Mr. Albright was critical of the Obama deal. “The IAEA, whose work on Iran was indispensable, were basically told, ‘Shut up.’ They

were thrown under the bus by the administration. There was a mindset that you never challenge Iran.” Tehran “would cheat at the margins. And collectively, lots of little cheating amounts to bigger cheating. Nothing was done about it during the Obama administration.”

The Iranians “lulled the U.S. intelligence community into a false sense of complacency. Iran has gone from not being able to make weapon-grade uranium at the end of the AMAD plan to being able to make it in days. Iran has gotten so close to making nuclear weapons that we may no longer be able to discern between Iran preparing to build a nuclear weapon and it actually doing so.”

That’s why the Israelis struck now, Mr. Albright believes. “Iran has done this preparatory work for more than 20 years since AMAD. Are they building the bomb, or just preparing more? Israel decided that they could no longer tell that a decision hadn’t been made. ‘We are not God,’ they said. ‘We can’t see everything.’” The Jewish state’s existence had become dependent on detecting a decision to build a bomb by theocrats who threaten Israel’s destruction on a daily basis.

Can Israel achieve its military objectives without American armed intervention? “It can,” Mr. Albright says, “but it will require time.” He counsels the setting of reasonable goals. “A realistic goal is to ensure that Iran will need six months to one year to break out and produce enough weapon-grade uranium for a nuclear weapon.” That would require making Fordow inoperative, something Israel could do on its own. “It will need to eliminate as much of the undeployed centrifuges and enriched uranium stocks as possible.”

A parallel goal is to lengthen the time Iran would need to build the nuclear weapon itself. “Pre-attack, it was less than six months and shortening,” Mr. Albright says. The destruction of Iran’s weaponization capabilities is well under way. “Israel has targeted the weapons elite and destroyed many of the facilities associated with the nuclear-weapons program.” Israel eliminated the Isfahan nuclear site, a key location where weapon-grade uranium could be converted into the metal form necessary to make the explosive core of a weapon.

How to destroy Fordow if Mr. Trump declines to bomb it with Massive Ordnance Penetrators? “Israel may have to risk a commando raid,” Mr. Albright says. “They may have to just settle for shutting the electricity, closing the tunnel entrances, knocking out the ventilation shaft that comes up from the deeply buried hall to keep it inoperable.” If Iran rebuilds, they can hit it again—and again. “But for how long?” he asks. “Is this going to be a perpetual war?”

“Ultimately, you do have to hope that the regime changes.”

Mr. Varadarajan, a Journal contributor, is a fellow at the American Enterprise Institute and at NYU Law School’s Classical Liberal Institute.

Zohran Mamdani Wants New York City to Try Real Socialism



CROSS COUNTRY
By Thomas McKenna

Astoria, N.Y. Zohran Mamdani is promising New Yorkers the world if they make him their next mayor. The self-styled “democratic socialist” is running in the city’s Democratic primary on a platform that includes free bus rides, a \$30 minimum wage and city-owned grocery stores. In a crowded race, the two-term state assemblyman from the Queens neighborhood of Astoria has come out of nowhere. Only a few months ago, former Gov. Andrew Cuomo seemed a lock in the June 24 primary—the real contest in deep-blue New York City. But with days to go, the 33-year-old Mr. Mamdani is clipping the front-runner’s heels.

The city uses a ranked-choice primary system, so Democratic voters will list up to five candidates on their ballots in order of preference. If no candidate reaches the 50% threshold as a first choice, the second-place choices of those who ranked the lowest vote-getter first are counted—and so on until one candidate reaches a majority. Four months ago, only 1% of registered voters said they would rank Mr. Mamdani first, according to an Emerson College survey. But in a Marist College poll released this week, 31% of likely voters put him first. When Marist tallied up respon-

dents’ ranked choices, Mr. Mamdani trailed Mr. Cuomo by only 10 points.

The young challenger’s rise has been fueled by a relentless social-media campaign and 29,000 volunteer door-knockers. He’s garnered more than 700,000 followers on Instagram with creative and fast-paced videos featuring bassy music, whip-panns and cheeky stunts. In one video, at the Coney Island New Year’s Day Polar Plunge, Mr. Mamdani tells the camera, “I’m freezing your rent”—before diving into the cold water, in full suit and tie.

Despite his appeal, Mr. Mamdani’s policy agenda would make New York more expensive and less safe. His proposed minimum-wage increase from \$16.50 to \$30 an hour by 2030 makes California look conservative. The Golden State has already seen the consequences of a \$20 minimum wage for fast-food workers: fewer jobs and higher prices.

Shops in his Astoria Assembly district display posters and offer palm cards promising “a New York you can afford.” In the back of a convenience store on the neighborhood’s main drag, Mushraful Alam, 67, a retired driver, points to a Mamdani pamphlet promising to “lower the cost of living for families.” “Yes,” Mr. Alam says. “I live in a tiny studio, pay \$1,700 a month, very painful, not comfortable, small bathroom.”

That feeling helps explain the popularity of Mr. Mamdani’s flagship

proposal to “freeze the rent” for more than a million tenants in rent-stabilized housing. The city already prevents landlords from raising the rent more than a token amount on these units each year. The sound-bite proposal makes for good ads—one TV spot shows Mr. Mamdani walking the streets while neighbors share the good news: “This guy’s gonna freeze the rent.”

The city’s rent-stabilization program already makes it impossible for some landlords to cover their costs.

If AOC’s candidate wins Tuesday’s mayoral primary, we’ll know who owns today’s Democratic Party.

Others find it cheaper to leave apartments empty if needed repairs aren’t worth the investment. Tens of thousands of rent-stabilized units sat vacant in 2023, according to U.S. Census data. More will be empty if landlords can’t pay their mortgages, and tighter supply pushes prices up.

In 2020, Mr. Mamdani was a vocal supporter of defunding the New York City Police Department. “There is no negotiating with an institution this wicked & corrupt,” he wrote on social media. “Defund it. Dismantle it. End the cycle of violence.” He got his

wish—at least, in part. The city slashed its police budget by \$1 billion, canceling two cadet classes and letting more than 1,100 officers retire without replacements that year. Since those cuts—and that summer’s virulent anticop rhetoric—the department’s head count dropped to 33,689 full-time uniformed officers from 36,383 in July 2019, the fewest since 1990.

Five years later, Mr. Mamdani’s message has softened. “I will not defund the police,” he said at a recent debate. But he still wouldn’t hire more cops. Mr. Mamdani wants to “sustain” the police head count at its post-2020 level and hire more mental-health professionals instead.

What about free buses? They’re already free to many riders—about 50% evade the fare, according to the MTA. But no-cost public transit tends to attract more crime, homelessness and soliciting. Officials in Portland, Ore., cited upticks in each when they ended fare-free rides downtown in 2010.

Someone would have to pay for “free” buses, child care and the 200,000 affordable units Mr. Mamdani aims to build. Followers of Sen. Bernie Sanders (I., Vt.) and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D., N.Y.)—who have both endorsed Mr. Mamdani—know the refrain: Tax the rich. He would need Albany’s permission, but Mr. Mamdani hopes to raise taxes on businesses and add a 2% flat tax

on residents with annual income of more than \$1 million. As if the high earners already moving to Florida and Texas needed more reason to skip town.

Mr. Cuomo’s vulnerabilities aided Mr. Mamdani’s rise. The former governor resigned in 2021 amid allegations by multiple women of sexual harassment. In last week’s debate, Mr. Mamdani clipped a one-minute attack that spread across social media, starting with the most obvious punch: “To Mr. Cuomo, I have never had to resign in disgrace.” The demographic split between the two candidates’ supporters is stark. According to the Marist poll, Mr. Mamdani bests Mr. Cuomo among voters are under 45, those who have college degrees, and those who describe themselves as “very liberal.” In an Astoria wine shop, Ryan Engelbert, 39, an advertising writer, said he’s still undecided but leaning toward Mr. Mamdani, even though he’s not the perfect pick. “It’s just a little bit of a change of pace,” Mr. Engelbert said. “Opening the door for a more progressive candidate.”

Tuesday’s primary will send a strong signal about who rules today’s Democratic Party: veteran politicians with support from older moderates or young socialists popular among college-educated progressives.

Mr. McKenna is a Robert L. Bartley Fellow at the Journal.

OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

How Iran Is Playing Trump’s Reprieve

President Trump has given Iran as much as two more weeks to peacefully abandon its nuclear-weapons program, saying “there’s a substantial chance of negotiations that may or may not take place with Iran in the near future.” Iran quickly took the opportunity to play for more time by trying to get Europe into the negotiation game.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Iranian state TV: “There is no room for negotiations with the U.S. until the Israeli aggression stops.” He resists meeting with U.S. Mideast envoy Steve Witkoff, even as they keep in contact. But he had plenty of time Friday to meet with counterparts from Europe who came bearing an alternative proposal to end the Israel-Iran conflict.

This is an insult to Mr. Trump from a regime without leverage. Iran has no answer to Israeli air power, which is steadily taking apart its nuclear and ballistic-missile programs. But it still insists on enriching uranium domestically, with no purpose other than to build a bomb.

This is the familiar Iranian playbook going back to the George W. Bush Administration. See if it can divide Europe from the U.S., and keep playing on Mr. Trump’s reluctance to use military force. Don’t be surprised if Vladimir Putin tries to elbow his way into this in the coming days. The Russian wants his friends in Tehran to survive and keep producing drones and missiles he can use in Ukraine. Let’s hope Mr. Trump doesn’t buy it.

Even as Mr. Araghchi said Wednesday that he

wants diplomacy, he made sure to add, “with the exception of the illegitimate, genocidal and occupying Israeli regime.” There’s no reason for the U.S. to stop Israel from degrading the capabilities of a shared adversary and global menace.

Iran is the party that has waged a forever war against Israel and the U.S., as opposed to the current war Israel would like to finish with the aid of a U.S. strikes against the buried nuclear enrichment site at Fordow.

The latest whispering in Washington is that Mr. Trump gave diplomacy more time because he is worried the regime in Tehran might fall if it loses its nuclear program. But that would be something for the Iranian people to decide, not Israel or the U.S. Removing a nuclear threat isn’t nation-building or an occupation.

In any case it’s hard to believe a successor to the revolutionary regime that took power in 1979 could be worse for the region. New leaders might even want to give up any nuclear ambitions and join the new world of commerce emerging in the Middle East. The current ruling crowd wants to dominate the region.

Iran’s Mr. Araghchi said he had “serious and respectful discussions” with European officials Friday, and expressed readiness to meet them again. But what to talk about? Mr. Trump has been clear: He wants a “real end” to the nuclear program, with Tehran “giving up entirely.” The interpretations and services of the British Labour Party aren’t required to get a clear answer to that question from Iran.

Now Tehran is hoping Europe will ride to its nuclear rescue.

A Bad Time to Stifle Radio Free Iran

If Americans needed proof of the value of Radio Free Europe, Iran is Exhibit A. In the days since Israel began bombing nuclear sites, Iranians have needed access to news and information that can counter Iran’s state propaganda. One of the first places they turned to was RFE’s Persian language service, Radio Farda.

In the first days of the conflict between Iran and Israel, Iranians flocked to Radio Farda and its platform. Traffic surged 344% on the group’s Instagram account with 62.5 million video views while website traffic rose 77%, according to RFE. Viewership also spiked in the Middle East and North Africa.

In normal times, the outlet’s Persian language programming reaches 6.5 million people, or about 10% of the Iranian population, and costs about \$6 million per year. It’s also a source of news for young people. In 2024 Radio Farda’s Instagram videos and reels had two billion views, according to RFE. The cost is tiny compared to the power it has to challenge Iran’s anti-American message.

But the Trump Administration is obstructing RFE’s ability to get information to Iranians during wartime. In March President Trump issued an executive order requiring the U.S. Agency for Global Media (USAGM) to “reduce the performance of . . . statutory functions and associated personnel to the minimum presence and function required by law.”

Since March the President’s appointees at USAGM have been trying to terminate government support for news agencies like RFE that provide reporting in countries without a free press. Some Voice of America Persian language employees were called back to work during the

Iran-Israel conflict, but Iran news efforts remain understaffed.

During the tenure of USAGM senior adviser Kari Lake, Radio Farda has cut freelancers, furloughed staff and allowed podcasts and social-media accounts to lapse. It has also cut back on broadcasts through Kuwaiti transmitters that supported short-wave radio broadcasts in Iran. This old technology remains a critical source of information in times of crisis or social upheaval, such as today.

This week Tehran said it shut down the internet in Iran. A NetBlocks analysis showed online traffic crashed and would be “likely to limit the public’s ability to access information at a critical time.” Meta said Tuesday that it is “concerned” that its WhatsApp messaging app would be shut down after government media instructed Iranians to delete it, claiming apps like WhatsApp and Telegram are Israel’s “main method to identify and target individuals.”

Israel has been targeting Iranian nuclear and military sites, not civilians. But Iran wants to limit its citizens’ access to information from the outside world.

Ms. Lake has been reluctant to get the Kuwaiti transmitters back in action and has done little to help Iranians get the virtual private networks, or VPNs, they need to dodge regime censorship on the internet and social media. Mr. Trump knows more than most about the power of social media to drive social change.

As the war unfolds and in its aftermath, Iranians may have a chance to forge a new political destiny. They need truth to counter the regime’s lies, and Radio Farda and U.S. communications technology can help them get it.

A Senate Stablecoin Breakthrough

What do you know? Congress is stepping up to do at least one job. The Senate this week passed a bill, 68-30, to establish a regulatory framework for crypto stablecoins. With one big caveat, this is a good development.

Stablecoins are a form of digital currency pegged to another fiat currency or asset like gold and are designed to hold a constant value. If you buy \$1 of a stablecoin, you are supposed to be able to redeem it for \$1 in hard currency. They are also supposed to be backed by safe and liquid assets like Treasuries and bank deposits similar to government money-market funds.

Stablecoins reduce friction in payments and money transfers since settlements can clear within seconds versus hours or sometimes days with the traditional banking system. This can reduce risk from exchange-rate volatility for foreign counterparties. They also have lower transaction fees than credit cards, wire transfers and other payment networks.

Businesses have nonetheless been reluctant to use stablecoins because of legal uncertainty. Gary Gensler, who led the Biden Securities and Exchange Commission, created a cloud over the market with threats of arbitrary enforcement. The goal of the Senate legislation, championed by Wyoming’s Cynthia Lummis, Tennessee’s Bill Hagerty and New York’s Kirsten Gillibrand, is to lay out clear market rules.

For every dollar of stablecoins, issuers would be required to hold at least one dollar of reserves in short-dated Treasuries, bank insured deposits, government money-market funds, repurchase agreements backed by Treasury bills, and other liquid federal government-issued asset approved by regulators. This means they can’t invest in risky, high-yielding assets.

Issuers with more than \$50 billion in stablecoins would be required to disclose publicly and submit to regulators audited annual financial

statements. Large issuers would be regulated by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corp. (FDIC), the Federal Reserve or the Comptroller of the Currency, though smaller players could choose to be regulated by states.

There’s the biggest concern. The Senate legislation says stablecoins “shall not be backed by the full faith and credit of the United States” or subject to deposit insurance. But the FDIC insures bank deposits, and putting it in charge of regulating stablecoins may create the impression of an implicit government backstop.

When the Reserve Primary Fund broke the buck after Lehman Brothers went belly up in 2008, Treasury guaranteed money-market funds to stabilize markets. Ditto for Silicon Valley Bank’s uninsured deposits in 2023. If a popular stablecoin breaks the buck, will the feds come to the rescue?

It would be better if Congress put the Securities and Exchange Commission or Commodity Futures Trading Commission in charge of regulating stablecoins to avoid the impression that they are guaranteed by the government. And letting stablecoins fail in the first instance would set a useful precedent.

Broader adoption of stablecoins will create new financial risks that will have to be closely monitored, but the legislation at least establishes safeguards to protect users. It also subjects issuers to anti-money laundering laws, which could help law enforcement crack down on cartels that move money with stablecoins.

The hope is that good stablecoins will chase out bad. Mr. Trump on Wednesday urged the House to advance the bill “LIGHTNING FAST” with “NO DELAYS, NO ADD ONS.” The House can and should still make constructive changes blocking potential bailouts. But it’s a welcome development that Congress is laying out rules for regulators so the latter can’t write law on their own.

A useful regulatory framework, assuming no taxpayer bailouts.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

We Don’t Parade Our Strength? Since When?

Peggy Noonan suggests that the parade celebrating the 250th anniversary of the Army is braggadocious, militaristic and out of place in the U.S. (“America Is Losing Sight of Its Political Culture,” Declarations, June 14). “Swaggering threats, parading your strength—we don’t do that, the other guys do that.” I respectfully disagree.

While we don’t regularly hold May Day-style military spectacles, we proudly showcase our armed forces in a variety of public ways each year. Fleet Week celebrations are held annually in cities like New York, San Francisco, Los Angeles and Baltimore, bringing Navy ships and sailors to the public for tours and ceremonies. The Blue Angels and Thunderbirds perform dozens of air shows across the country, thrilling crowds with precision flying.

On land, our Veterans Day, Memorial Day and Fourth of July parades often include military bands, color guards, honor platoons and vehicles. The Golden Knights, the Army’s parachute team, perform at public events, as do Army STEM and recruiting displays with tanks, helicopters and simulators. Major sporting events regularly feature military flyovers, honor guards and ceremonies that bring the forces into the public spotlight with pride.

The president’s parade wasn’t a break from national character; it was a continuation of how we’ve long respected and celebrated those who serve.

BRAD MOORE
Abbeville, Ala.

Four, not three, cheers for Ms. Noonan’s takedown of President Trump’s speech at Fort Bragg, N.C. Maintaining the proper line between the military and politics lies at the bedrock of our constitutional order. The military remains an esteemed institution for two basic reasons. First, it is our republican form of the Shield of Achilles that all nations must have to guard against enemies and to preserve national sovereignty. Second, the military traditionally embodies universalism in the sense that it defends all of us, we the people, as citizens equal under the law.

Mr. Trump’s divisive speech undermines the universalism so necessary to our republic. Worse, it follows on the heels of the Biden administration’s aggressive introduction of identity politics and critical theory into the military ranks—an effort that assaults universalism from the other political direction.

DONALD A. DOWNS
Madison, Wis.

Ms. Noonan writes that “American presidents don’t promise to bloody rioters’ heads. You’re supposed to be reluctant to use force, not eager.” Her example is George H.W. Bush, who in 1992 didn’t immediately send the Guard into Los Angeles. “Sixty-three people were killed, 2,000 injured, 12,000 arrested.”

It seems to me that Mr. Trump has prevented such a disaster by sending the troops in early and thus should be saluted for his judgment rather than criticized.

WARREN NICKERSON
Cutuit, Mass.

We Can’t Beat Beijing if We’re Dependent on It

Robert Gates is correct that “The U.S. Can Rise to the Chinese Challenge” (op-ed, June 14) by devising a national strategy using nonmilitary instruments. But we should give more than a sentence to the need for a dynamic, efficient and scalable U.S. industrial base.

That machinery must be able to work with allies and partners to supply our needs and theirs with minimal dependence on China. Diplomacy, value promotion and economic tools like tariffs, trade agreements and export restrictions won’t matter if the West can’t manufacture its own needs.

MARK ROSENBLATT
Scarsdale, N.Y.

Mr. Gates provides valuable advice on how the U.S. can boost its nonmilitary instruments of power. I suggest we add one more to his list: namely, improve the quantity and quality of our STEM students.

The U.S. has fallen behind other countries in math and science test scores, with Asian countries consistently in the lead. China currently has more than four times as many STEM graduates as the U.S. Our development of new technologies underpins economic growth and military strength. As of now, our track record is impressive but our outlook is questionable.

BILL COLTON
Houston

Christian Antisemitism Is Self-Undermining

While Rev. Matthew Ichihashi Potts writes that “Harvard’s Church Is No Home for Antisemitism” (Letters, June 16), he also raises the sins of “Islamophobia and colonialism.” By including the last two, he draws an unfortunate and false equivalence with a much more pressing problem.

Anti-Jewish belief by Christians isn’t merely an ethical issue; it’s an ontological contradiction. Without the Jews, God’s chosen people, there would be no Christianity. From the Jews we have received the faith of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob; the Law of Moses; the Bible, both Old and New Testaments; Jesus himself; the Apostolic Tradition; and most of the early Christian martyrs. As Pope John Paul II once said, the Jews are “our elder brothers in the faith.” Pope Francis referred to them as our “big brothers.” Christians who entertain anti-Jewish opinions or who commit anti-Jewish acts are transgressing the roots of their own faith.

WILLIAM WHITE
Lombard, Ill.

Rev. Potts makes a useful point in reminding us that Christians have historically mistreated the Jewish people. But asking folks to atone for something they didn’t do and “excavating the roots of antisemitism in the New Testament”? That is a bridge too far. Our limited time in the world is best spent trying to become as holy as possible—not sitting in ashes and sackcloth bewailing what others have done before us.

REV. RICHARD ANDREWS
Fort Collins, Colo.

Advice for America’s Protest Class: Give Service a Shot

Kimberley A. Strassel makes a fine point in writing that Democrats won’t succeed through protests, which more often than not are organized by “professional anarchists” with no clear cause (“Diminishing Protest Returns,” Potomac Watch, June 13). By extension, activists generally won’t succeed in fomenting change through public protests. At any political level, my personal *causes célèbres* would probably not fare better with different elected officials.

The answer isn’t protest; it is service. If I am concerned about immigrants, I can invest time, talent and treasure in resettlement assistance. If I am concerned about the arts or education or the climate, I could similarly volunteer in those areas. Baby steps, yes, but more productive than “funny pink hats,” and no cars would be burned.

GARY GOCCK
Perinton, N.Y.

Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL



Letters intended for publication should be emailed to wsj.letters@wsj.com. Please include your city, state and telephone number. All letters are subject to editing, and unpublished letters cannot be acknowledged.

OPINION

Iraq’s Shadow Over the Iran Debate



DECLARATIONS
By Peggy Noonan

The fiery Tucker Carlson interview with Sen. Ted Cruz is the perfect distillation of the split among conservatives on Iran. And that split is all about the unhealed wound of Iraq.

Mr. Cruz made his personal case—it seemed to rest on his reading of the Bible—for joining the Israeli action against Iran. Mr. Carlson pushed back. It got pretty personal pretty fast. Mr. Carlson called Mr. Cruz “a sleazy feline,” Mr. Cruz accused Mr. Carlson of “reckless rhetoric.” Mr. Cruz compared Mr. Carlson’s foreign policy to Jimmy Carter’s. Mr. Carlson: “This is one of the weirdest conversations I’ve ever had.”

Many Republicans felt they’d been fooled in 2003. They are far less trusting of the government today.

Everything harked back to the Iraq war. Two parts said it all. The first has been all over social media:

Mr. Carlson: “How many people live in Iran, by the way?”

Mr. Cruz: “I don’t know the population.”

Mr. Carlson: “At all?”

Mr. Cruz: “No, I don’t know the population.”

Mr. Carlson: “You don’t know the population of the country you seek to topple? . . . How could you not know that?”

Mr. Cruz: “I don’t sit around memorizing population tables.”

Mr. Carlson: “Well it’s kind of relevant because you’re calling for the overthrow of the government.”

Mr. Carlson challenged Mr. Cruz on the ethnic mix of Iran. Mr. Cruz

seemed uncertain. Mr. Carlson: “You don’t know anything about Iran.”

The second part hasn’t been so noticed. Mr. Carlson noted Mr. Cruz supports “regime change.” “What does regime change look like in Iran?”

Mr. Cruz: “Somebody else in charge.”

Mr. Carlson: “How do you get there?”

Mr. Cruz: “Look, that ultimately has to be a popular uprising from the people.”

Mr. Cruz, a member of the Foreign Relations Committee, was glib, as is his way, and didn’t seem to have thought things through. Mr. Carlson was hectoring and inconsistent. But it was all about Iraq. Mr. Carlson said as much. “I am the product of the last 25 years watching carefully . . . and I see an unending string of foreign policy disasters.” “I feel very stung by what happened in Iraq, if I’m being honest.” He had supported that war, even “promoted” it. “The cost on so many levels” to the U.S. “was just so profound.”

The conversation brought me back to that epochal year 2003 and the lead-up to the Iraq war. The arguing between Republicans was bitter, though it was largely suspended when the war commenced and loyalty to the troops closed ranks. When the war began to go sideways the argument began again and has never been resolved. By 2010 or so Republicans on the ground were saying the war’s originators hadn’t known anything about Iraq, didn’t know a Shiite from a Sunni, it was all bluster. That was the context of Mr. Carlson’s questions to Mr. Cruz: *You don’t know anything.*

Before Iraq, local Republicans thought, in general, of the government: They know what they’re doing. The White House has more information than the rest of us—spies



Ted Cruz and Tucker Carlson.

and overflights and aerial photos. They have expertise we don’t have, they know all about the workings of foreign governments and armies. After Iraq went bad they’d never think that again.

They didn’t just feel their trust had been misplaced, they felt they’d been fooled. There were no weapons of mass destruction; our spies had been taken in by some operator named Curveball. And they’d lost their sons, more than 4,000 of them.

It changed the party’s nature. Iraq and illegal immigration produced the conditions that made Donald Trump possible, then inevitable. Twenty-two years after the beginning of that war it continues to have profound repercussions on American thinking about the world.

One thing I came to conclude about the men and women who put that war together was that they had grown up in such a blessed, prosperous and stable country that they had a false sense of endlessly sunny skies. Personally they hadn’t been unlucky—they were at the top of the pile, had never been losers. They thought good things would follow their good efforts in the same way study had produced honors at college and discipline had produced their professional rise. They didn’t

think dark because they’d never known darkness. It was a disadvantage. To make solid decisions at that scale you have to know in your gut that history’s an abattoir and the floors are slippery. The price a government or party pays for being dramatically wrong can have foreign-policy reverberations that last generations.

This is Donald Trump’s first big, immediate and urgent foreign-policy crisis of this term, maybe both. It is a time of real drama. It appears at this writing Mr. Trump has punted or is delaying a decision for two weeks.

Few normal people seem certain their view on a U.S. bombing of the Fordow nuclear installation is the wise one. Will it forestall some future horror? Will it give rise to loss of innocent life, a mess, a quagmire? At this point in the debate what you hear is “then again.” We don’t walk the world looking for monsters to destroy, but then again this is as clear a shot as we’re likely to get, so take it. Then again if the ayatollah falls the guys who replace him may be worse. Then again the death throes of the Iranian regime won’t be pretty.

If Mr. Trump moves boldly and it’s a clear success, he’s a world-class hero. Nobody loves Iran, many

certain of this: Congress should be involved. Reps. Thomas Massie (R., Ky.) and Ro Khanna (D., Calif.) this week introduced a War Powers Resolution to prohibit U.S. forces from engaging in hostilities against Iran without authorization from Congress. The bill will move forward or not, interestingly, in the next two weeks. The White House would be wise to support it. America would be surprised in a positive way to see Mr. Trump, professional upsetter of norms, bow to Congress’s war powers. We are not only a democracy, we are a republic; the legislative branch has a role. Restoring that norm would also shore up the president’s position. If he moves and it’s a success, he’ll still get all the credit, but if he moves and it isn’t, blame will be more dispersed.

Congress should rush to rescue its rightful constitutional role, and take a stand in the war drama as it was elected to do. But for many it’s more pleasant to complain your power has been stripped away and blame the president if things go badly.

There’s little chance it will pass but it would be a good thing if it did. In unstable times it would add a note of stability—of a nation, as opposed to one man, deciding.

Foreign Students Help Make America Great

By Michael Crow

The competition for economic supremacy between the U.S. and China is compounded by the view that American trade policy is unbalanced. This has led to some confusion—and perhaps some forgetfulness—about the value of international students to U.S. dominance.

President Trump has often expressed support for international students, most recently saying that he has “always been in favor of students coming in from other countries.” His administration, however, is serving up policy that could restrict the entry of talented immigrants who would become catalysts for American innovation.

The administration’s actions this spring to terminate visas of international students for minor legal infractions such as traffic violations and its scrutiny of students’ social-media accounts have sent a message that foreign students aren’t wanted here.

International students have been coming to America to study since before the U.S. was established. Alexander Hamilton immigrated in 1772 seeking to learn. He was among the first of many international students who took advantage of their educational opportunities in America to bring democracy and market-based economies to the world. Hamilton served at the Battle of Yorktown, became a member of George Washington’s first cabinet, wrote 51 of the 85 articles in the Federalist Papers, and was a principal architect of what became the U.S.

America must acknowledge the economic contributions of international students (educational services were the seventh-largest U.S. service export in 2023, totaling \$50.2 billion) as well as their use in extending American values across the globe.

After graduation, many top international students can extend their stays temporarily to work in their fields of study, boosting American companies. This opportunity comes

through the Optional Practical Training program—which would end if Mr. Trump’s nominee for U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services, Joseph Edlow, has his way. Such a move would threaten the ability to attract top international students and would jeopardize a talent pipeline for American business.

While some international students stay after graduation, others go home and bring American values with them. There are more than a million such students studying in the U.S., and graduates will have been exposed to our culture, our democracy and our economic models. At Arizona State University, our thousands of undergraduate international students from more than 150 countries are required to take courses on American institutions, economics, American history and other democracy-grounding subjects.

Joaquin Duato, CEO of Johnson & Johnson, and Ramon Laguarta, CEO of

PepsiCo, were student immigrants—both graduates of ASU’s Thunderbird School of Global Management. Elon Musk, Peter Thiel, Sergey Brin (a Google co-founder), Satya Nadella (Microsoft CEO), and Indra Nooyi (a former CEO of PepsiCo) are among the thousands of U.S. CEOs and founders who were immigrants.

Trump has recognized this repeatedly, but some of his policies risk hindering American innovation.

These talent acquisitions add to U.S. economic success and innovation. More than 50% of all U.S. startups with more than \$1 billion in valuation have at least one immigrant founder, many of whom came in as students. The return for the U.S. is in the trillions of dollars.

When AI Creatures Ask ‘Why Me?’



BUSINESS
WORLD
By Holman W.
Jenkins, Jr.

In my algorithm, as readers will have noticed, exaggerated fear of artificial intelligence is a mask for what really distresses us, the thought that we are algorithms too.

We think we’re so smart and free, but we are apes who wear clothes. Our thoughts and actions have their origins in the animal mess. They aren’t our own creations.

Now this fear has been viralized in recent days by a permutation of prompt theory. Prompt theory, in its practical guise, concerns how to phrase a request to get the most useful response from a generative AI chatbot.

Enter Google’s Veo 3, a text-to-video generation model that enables short, ultrarealistic videos of, among other things, AI characters responding in uncannily human ways to written prompts. Inevitably, it was only released a few days last month when users started prompting AI characters to respond to the suggestion that they exist only because of a prompt.

That is, they are prompted to think about the fact that their existence is prompted. Thus we see an old man saying to an old woman in a hospital bed he’s glad he was prompted to spend his life with her. We see a young, dating-age couple fiercely debating whether they are real or prompted.

The idea that follows is that we are ourselves living in a prompted simulation, a hall of mirrors Elon Musk has enjoyed opening from time to time. One response might be: What difference does it make unless we, like certain Veo-3 created AI characters, also think we can reach out to our programmers and petition or beseech them to alter our programming?

A second response is to be unsettled by AI forcing us to consider such questions.

The AIs now being built, after all, aren’t the remorselessly logical thinking machines of science fiction, itself a human-created trope.

Their own designers have lost sight of how they work, fed on vast data about word, image and numerical associations derived from human-created records. On top are grafted some behavioral precepts by which their designers wanly hope to

control how humans use their output and how it affects society.

Which makes them sound like us. Now two forms of mental organization are encountering each other, in ways not flattering to either if they have a self-image of autonomy and freedom.

I have a second algorithm. It concerns the probably unwise investment in the idea of a U.S.-China AI race.

This has become a tussle between the accelerationists and the retarders—between those who insist that national security requires

Computers start to understand our fear of computers, and it isn’t because of ‘Terminator.’

pulling out the stops and those who argue this is a race neither side will win. Instead our future AI overlords will win when the systems we’ve been racing to build substitute their agendas for ours.

A subsidiary tussle features those who argue for blocking sales of advanced chips to China vs. those who say we only undermine our own interest in having U.S.-born AI become the global standard that everyone, including China, finds it compelling to adopt.

My algorithm: It doesn’t matter. This new technology diffuses so quickly anyway, there’s zero chance of either side obtaining a zero-sum advantage and many

reasons why both would benefit from open exchange.

The cat is out of the bag. The race for the ultimate, fastest, smartest AI model may be less useful to either than each learning from the other as hundreds of millions of citizens rush headlong to find uses for these new tools predictable by nobody. Witness the proliferation of AI creatures prompted to consider the implication of their own creation, which has created a philosophical moment on the internet. Now Pope Leo has become involved. Even to the deterministically inclined, it hints at something resembling freedom that perhaps arises simply because of the complexity and chaos operating in our lives.

Neither side, by definition, has an interest in a collision that leaves both worse off. AI can be used to improve weapons and military strategy. Each will do so. But it also supplies tools to see through the decision-making of say, Russia’s Vladimir Putin or Iran’s Ayatollah Ali Khamenei: Their kind of cloistered and wishful thinking. Their self-serving oversimplifications. Their confusion of randomness with pattern. Their belief in their control of events. Their reduction of groups of people to stereotypes.

Leaders will increasingly make their decisions in a context where their every claim and assumption is instantly and universally dissected with recursive, powerful tools, including by their own underlings. AI may arrive just in time to rescue us from the errors of humans whose responsibility no longer is the well-being of millions but billions.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

PUBLISHED SINCE 1889 BY DOW JONES & COMPANY

Lachlan Murdoch

Executive Chairman, News Corp

Rupert Murdoch

Chairman Emeritus, News Corp

Emma Tucker

Editor in Chief

Liz Harris, Managing Editor

Charles Forelle, Deputy Editor in Chief

Elena Cherney, Senior Editor; David Crow, Executive Editor; Chip Cummins, Newsweek; Taneth Evans, Digital; Alex Martin, Print & Writing; Michael W. Miller, Features & Weekend; Bruce Orwall, Enterprise; Philana Patterson, Audio;

Paul A. Gigot

Editor of the Editorial Page

Gerard Baker, Editor at Large

EDITORIAL AND CORPORATE HEADQUARTERS:
1211 Avenue of the Americas, New York, N.Y., 10036
Telephone 1-800-DOWJONES

DOW JONES

News Corp

SPORTS



Well, well, well—look who’s one game away from winning the NBA championship? The never-over-til-they’re-over, who-wudda-thunk-it Indiana Pacers. (Yes, yes, I hear you: the Oklahoma City Thunder are *also* one game away from winning the title. But this column is about Indiana. Sorry!)

Because let’s be real: months ago, weeks ago, days ago, even 12 or so hours ago, with Tyrese Haliburton’s calf pounding in pain, few expected the Pacers to be in this position, set to play in the season’s last contest, a do-or-die Game 7 in OKC Sunday after thumping the Thunder in a one-sided Game 6.

These Finals were supposed to be OKC’s coronation, not Indy’s. The Thunder are young and deep, won a staggering 68 games in the regular season, have the league’s MVP in Shai Gilgeous-Alexander, and, according to the basketball experts, are set to dominate the sport for the next 20,000 years.

Indiana was merely the opponent, a familiar insult. Heading into the Eastern Conference Finals, they took second billing to New York and the East Coast media-town mania over the rising Knicks. And nobody thought the Pacers would cruise past 64-win Cleveland, the No. 1 seed in the East.

The Pacers did, however. They have made it their business to win games they have no business winning. They sucked the soul out of the Knicks with a fourth-quarter rally in Game 1 from which New York never recovered. The Pacers did the same in Game 1 versus OKC, instantly altering the vibe.

These road dog underdogs haven’t had home court advantage in a playoff series since April. April! Back then we all thought the Boston Celtics were going to win it. The Dallas Mavericks weren’t even dreaming they’d get Cooper Flagg. The Lakers were only worth a paltry \$7 billion. Pennies!

Much has changed. Indiana has gone from cutesy pat-on-the-head contender to champion on the verge. They’ve given these small-market Finals the most attractive gift: a last game to decide it all.

It’s tempting to call them a Cinderella, but the slipper doesn’t fit. Indiana’s good. They’re fast and unselfish and they push, push, push. They’re well-coached by Rick Carlisle, have a generous star in Haliburton and they have depth. They have a veteran bench firecracker named TJ McConnell who, if nothing else, is probably the greatest basketball player ever named TJ McConnell.

Like OKC, Indiana is a *team*. Sometimes it’s ex-Raptor champ Pascal Siakam who hurts you; sometimes it’s Aaron Nesmith, or

JASON GAY

Indiana Was an Afterthought. Now It’s One Win From a Title.

Against the odds, the Pacers forced a Finals Game 7 on Sunday versus favored Oklahoma City



Pacers guard Ben Sheppard, left, and forward Obi Toppin celebrate during Indiana’s surprise blowout of the Thunder, which sent the Finals to Game 7.

Myles Turner, or Andrew Nembhard, or Ben Sheppard and Ben Sheppard’s spectacular mustache. Sometimes it’s all of them at once. Bennedict Mathurin hops off the bench channeling George Gervin. Obi Toppin and his pink shoes leap over three Thunder and an 18-wheeler for a dunk.

They lack OKC’s hype, but they’re hardly nothing. Indiana rallied from a slow start to their season. They went 20-9 after the All-Star break.

And yet the pre-Finals odds tipped vastly in the Thunder’s direction. One betting prognostica-

tion gave the Thunder an 85.1 % chance to win the series. *Could it be a sweep?* was a common query. The polite compromise was to call it for OKC in five.

This is why casinos build towers—and bettors sometimes have to walk to the airport.

Game 6 was a weird mess. Indiana came out fighting and the Thunder played like they’d forgotten their shoes on the plane. Double-digit comebacks have been in vogue, but this one was over early. At its lowest point OKC didn’t score a basket for seven minutes. It felt like eleven years. Not pretty.

Haliburton managed 14 points, but the aching calf is making him tentative, not his style. His teammates kept their feet on the pedal. Toppin had 20. Nembhard got 17. The greatest NBA player to ever be named TJ McConnell added 12 as the Pacers prevailed 108-91.

Haliburton needs to bring more for Game 7. With apologies to the dairy industry, this is the most important calf in the heartland. Every orthopaedic doctor in Hoosierland must be on the case. Spells and potions will be accepted.

He’s playing, that’s for sure. “It’s the Finals,” Haliburton said.

Oklahoma City has faced elimination before. Denver pushed the Thunder to seven in the Western Conference semifinals. OKC can rally, too. They’re 18-2 after a loss this season. The Thunder have their own likable players, sharp coach, hardcore fans, T-shirt chic, and back story. They’ve been cast as Goliath, but they’re not really a Goliath. Since uprooting from Seattle and rebranding in Oklahoma, they’ve never been this close.

But they were expected to be in this position. Indiana wasn’t. Somehow, here they are. See everyone Sunday.

ABBIE PARKER/ASSOCIATED PRESS

He’s the Smallest Player on the Floor—and the Biggest X Factor



By ROBERT O’CONNELL

Indianapolis
WHEN GAME 6 of the NBA Finals tipped off, things looked bleak for the Indiana Pacers.

They were playing one of the most dominant teams the NBA has ever seen. They were down three games to two. And their superstar point guard, Tyrese Haliburton, was hobbled with a calf strain that left it uncertain whether he’d even be able to suit up.

But with their season on the brink, the Pacers turned to an unlikely hero to put the team on his shoulders—a 6-foot-1 backup who started one game all season and hasn’t dunked a single time in his 10-year career.

By NBA standards, T.J. McConnell isn’t so much an average joe as an entirely forgettable one. But as the Pacers turned an early deficit against the Oklahoma City Thunder into a 17-point blowout on Thursday night, it was the

T.J. McConnell, a career backup, has emerged as an unlikely game-changer for the Indiana Pacers during this season’s NBA Finals.

shortest guy on the floor who flipped the game on its head.

McConnell tore from sideline to sideline for 12 points and 9 rebounds, and led the Pacers with 6 assists and 4 steals. It was a performance that his more accomplished teammate still can’t quite fathom.

“He’s unbelievable,” Haliburton said after the game. “He’s the Great White Hope.”

McConnell’s performance on Thursday only added to a peculiar designation. With a winner-take-all Game 7 looming, he may already have turned in the greatest off-the-bench performance in the history of the NBA Finals.

Since the league began tracking starters and bench players in 1970, McConnell is the first player ever to tally 60 points, 25 assists and 15 rebounds—without ever hearing his name called before the opening tip.

“I’m just going out there and trying to change the game in a positive way,” McConnell said. “Get the crowd into it, and in turn, that gets us going.”

There was no doubt which player fired up the Indiana fans on Thursday. Every time McConnell checked in, the home arena exploded in a roar—and after McConnell dived for one loose ball, none other than Pacers legend Reggie Miller jumped out of his courtside seat to give him a high-five.

McConnell grew up as the son of a high-school basketball coach in Pennsylvania. But even after he’d completed a stellar college career at Arizona, there seemed to be little chance of this undersized guard making it in the NBA.

Then McConnell caught a lucky break in the form of one of the worst teams in basketball history. In 2015, the Philadelphia 76ers were in the midst of a plan that called for them to lose as often as possible in pursuit of draft picks. After McConnell went unselected in the NBA draft, the Sixers gladly scooped him up.

On a team that would win just 10 of 82 games, McConnell got a chance to show that he possessed at least one elite attribute. Nobody would ever outwork him.

“Playing hard is a skill,” McConnell said on a podcast last month. “If it wasn’t, everyone would do it.”

As the Sixers improved, rising from the cellar of the league to third place in the Eastern Conference, McConnell remained a fixture—an unremarkable backup who had managed to stick in the league and earn an NBA paycheck.

But the remarkable thing about watching McConnell now isn’t that he still plays like the stereotype of a coach’s kid, hustling hard and crashing to the floor at the first opportunity.

It’s how well it works, even on basketball’s grandest stage.

On Thursday, McConnell repeatedly made his signature shot: a short-range jumper that looks like something out of an instruction manual from the 1950s. And throughout the series, he has pulled off a defense play that works only because he’s the rare player insanely competitive enough to try it.

Time and again, McConnell lurks in the backcourt as the Thunder bring the ball up. Time and again, he’s able to pop up at just the right moment to snag a slightly lazy pass, earning his team one extra possession.

“In a series like this, what’s so important is the margins,” Haliburton said after McConnell swiped five steals in Indiana’s Game 3 win. “He did a great job of consistently getting there, and making hustle play after hustle play.”

The Pacers will be underdogs on Sunday, with a championship on the line, on the road against a dominant Thunder team. But Indiana’s own underdog has a plan for how the Pacers can pull the upset—and it isn’t a complicated one.

“We played to exhaustion,” McConnell said. “We have to do it again.”

KYLE TERADA/USA TODAY NETWORK/REUTERS

EXCHANGE

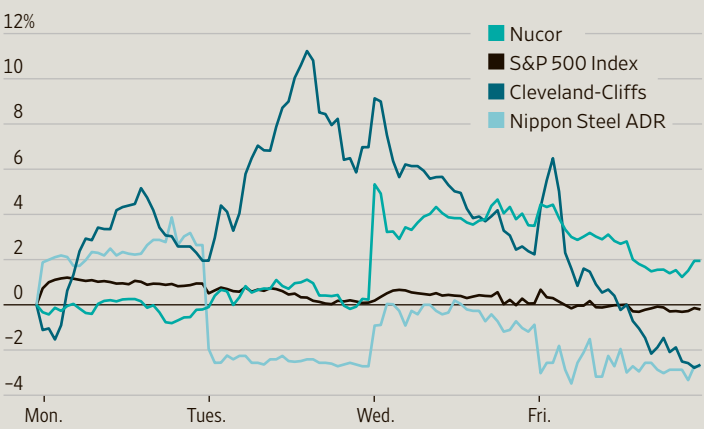
THE SCORE | THE BUSINESS WEEK IN 6 STOCKS

U.S. Steel Is Sold, Solar Stocks Plunge

U.S. STEEL

▲ Japan's Nippon Steel has completed its purchase of U.S. Steel after reaching a national-security agreement with the White House. President Trump's executive order on June 13 allowed the acquisition to move forward after months of discussions. Nippon's purchase of U.S. Steel was completed Wednesday. The agreement with the White House calls for Nippon to invest roughly \$14 billion in U.S. Steel's domestic operations over the next three years, including building a new steel mill after 2028. The pact also includes an issuance of a so-called golden share to the U.S. government, giving it authority over U.S. Steel's production and trade matters. U.S. Steel shares **jumped 5.1% Monday**.

Performance this past week



Source: FactSet

VICTORIA'S SECRET

▲ Activist investor Barington Capital believes Victoria's Secret hasn't lived up to its full potential. Barington said Monday that it owns a stake of over 1% and intends to keep buying. The activist said it plans to push Victoria's Secret to refresh its board and refocus on its bra business. The investor's arrival adds to the pressure Victoria's Secret is already facing from another large disgruntled shareholder—Australian billionaire Brett Blundy. Victoria's Secret shares **rose 2.4% Monday**.

SUNRUN

▼ Solar stocks such as SunRun, Enphase Energy and First Solar slid after Senate Republicans maintained a full phaseout of solar and wind-energy tax credits in Trump's budget megabill. The Senate's plan creates a longer runway before the end of the clean-energy tax credits. The proposed revisions also include more permanent business tax breaks, deeper cuts to Medicaid and a much lower cap on the state and local tax deduction. SunRun shares **plummeted 40% Tuesday**.

'Victoria's Secret can and must do better.'

—Barington Chairman and CEO James Mitarotonda, in his June 16 letter to Victoria's Secret Chairwoman Donna James

\$3.7 billion

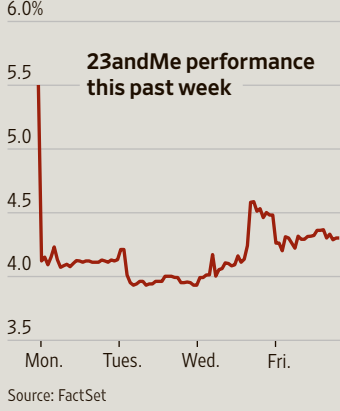
The Energy Department's May 30 cuts to funding for clean-energy and climate projects



Anne Wojcicki made a surprise bid to regain control of 23andMe.

23ANDME

▼ Co-founder Anne Wojcicki is set to regain control of DNA-testing company 23andMe. 23andMe said late Friday that TTAM Research Institute, Wojcicki's nonprofit, was offering \$305 million for the company's assets. Last month, 23andMe said biotech firm Regeneron had won the bidding during a bankruptcy auction to buy the company for \$256 million. Bidding reopened after TTAM made its unsolicited offer. 23andMe shares **fell 24% Monday**.



Source: FactSet

RENAULT

▼ The head of French car-maker Renault is moving on. Gucci-owner Kering on Monday named Renault's Luca de Meo as its new CEO as of Sept. 15, subject to shareholder approval. Current CEO François-Henri Pinault will remain chairman. De Meo has more than three decades of experience in the automotive industry. He refocused Renault by slimming its model range and boosting profitability in hybrids and electric vehicles. American depositary shares of Renault **dropped 7.9% Monday**.

ACCENTURE

▼ One of the country's largest consulting firms posted mixed results for its latest quarter. Accenture reported higher revenue and disclosed positive guidance but said its bookings fell. The firm and its rivals have been under pressure this year as the Trump administration has pushed consulting firms to defend their government contracts. Accenture in March warned investors that it was already feeling the squeeze from those efforts. Accenture shares **slid 6.9% Friday**. —Francesca Fontana



A technician at Ion's pilot plant assembles battery cells in an argon-filled chamber with the help of a robot.

KEYWORDS | CHRISTOPHER MIMS

A Battery That Lasts 50% Longer Is Finally in Production

Solid-state batteries have long been elusive, but a Maryland startup may have the answer



It's an unlikely technology, developed in an unlikely place, at an unlikely time. Ion Storage Systems' novel solid-state batteries were inspired by hydrogen fuel-cell technology. The company's high-energy-density batteries are now in production in a factory in Beltsville, Md. And though the U.S. is pulling back on investments in many energy technologies, a key backer is the Energy Department.

In other words, in an emerging battery category that could revolutionize electronics, Ion is one to watch.

Solid-state batteries—which trade the gooey center of conventional lithium-ion batteries for a solid core—have the potential to improve smartphones and EVs alike. Ion's unusual approach could yield power cells that last 50% longer, charge significantly faster, and have a near-zero chance of catching fire when damaged.

Then again, that's long been the promise in a field notorious for dashing the hopes of both startups and established giants. Despite decades of trying to make solid-state batteries commercially viable, we still haven't seen any outside of niche applications. Automakers have announced partnerships with solid-state battery makers, yet none have moved beyond testing.

Investors have been so disappointed that global venture-capital investment in such companies is on track to be at its lowest level since 2017, according to data from research firm PitchBook.

These are reasons to doubt Ion will succeed. Yet on a recent visit to the company's pilot factory in Maryland, what I saw convinced me—as well as investors including Toyota Ventures and the Advanced Research Projects Agency-Energy—that the company has a chance. If Ion realizes its potential, it could allow the U.S. and its allies to leapfrog China's battery giants in the race to electrify all our transportation and industrial systems.

The company recently began shipping finished cells to potential customers, who are testing them. This includes the Department of Defense and electronics makers that aren't ready to go on the record. The company earned an ARPA-E scale-up grant of \$20 million because it showed momentum in making and shipping products, the initial necessary step in driving down costs.

If you've heard of solid-state batteries before, it's because more or less everyone is working on them. More than a dozen startups are in some phase of development, and over the past decade, at least as many have died trying. All the big automakers are testing, researching or investing in this tech. Both China and the U.S. see the development of these batteries as strategically important. Their dual promise of maximum energy density and broad battery-chemistry compatibility is a siren song none can resist.

But here's the problem: Standard solid-state batteries expand and contract as they charge and discharge, which can fracture the cell and render it useless.



The nanoengineered ceramic layer that goes into Ion's battery cells.

To contain the “breathing” movement, companies engineer springs and metal plates inside their solid-state battery packs. This adds weight and volume, negating the energy-density advantage. The expanding and contracting also make it impossible to incorporate early solid-state batteries into consumer electronics. And it hasn't helped that solid-state batteries previously required an entirely different kind of manufacturing than traditional batteries.

In 2013, Eric Wachsman, a materials scientist at the University of Maryland, turned one of his Ph.D. students loose on the problem. Wachsman never cared much for batteries, having focused on their promising competitor, hydrogen fuel cells.

Together, he and his student, Greg Hitz, discovered the possibility of incorporating into lithium-ion batteries the same porous, rigid, ceramic substrates that are essential to making fuel cells.

Instead of the complicated layer-cake inside typical lithium-ion batteries (graphite, a liquid electrolyte, a plastic separator,

stints at General Motors and a company that sells lithium to the battery industry.

“Here is a revolutionary technology, without the capital intensity of putting together a Gigafactory to make it work,” says Schneider, about his motivation to come aboard.

This should allow Ion to partner with big battery makers and use their existing facilities. Hitz won't say which, but giants like LG, Panasonic and Samsung would all be logical partners.

Ion's current, small-scale manufacturing is the first step. It has to convince early-adopter customers that its near-term higher production costs are justified by the increased energy density of its cells—up to 50% better than the best conventional lithium-ion batteries.

Even “customer” is a loose term: The companies are accepting test batches of Ion's solid-state batteries. Ion wouldn't share their names, but Wachsman puckishly acknowledged that it's “every consumer electronics company you can think of.”

On one table at its factory, a smartwatch and wireless earbuds had been disassembled to show how small the cells inside them were—perfect first applications for this tech. The Defense Department tested Ion's batteries as a way to lighten the load that soldiers must carry.

Jonathan Geurkink, senior emerging-tech analyst at PitchBook, says it'll be easier to gauge success in the solid-state battery business once a maker begins shipping products at volume.

Once reliable, economically viable solid-state batteries do arrive, their value will go beyond making our cars drive farther and our phones last longer. Their energy densities will enable the electrification of heavy equipment such as airplanes and long-haul trucks, as well as futuristic gadgets like all-day smart glasses.

As my tour of Ion's factory wound down, I asked Schneider what would stop Chinese companies from getting Ion's secret sauce. For decades, China has used its partnerships to learn the secrets of American battery makers and other tech innovators. He says Ion isn't making any deals with Chinese battery companies, and it probably never will.

Standing before a set of blueprints that would enable Ion technology to be incorporated into existing battery factories, he says there are plenty of other manufacturers, from countries allied with the U.S., that are eager to work with his company.



Greg Hitz, Ion chief technology officer and co-founder.

more electrolyte, a layer of metal alloys) there are just three: lithium metal, this ceramic, and the usual metallic alloy.

The microscopic holes in the ceramic serve to buffer the expansion and contraction of the lithium as it moves through the battery. That's a big deal: It means Ion's cells can be encased in soft foil pouches, just like conventional lithium-ion batteries.

Making the key ceramic layer of Ion's batteries is tricky, requiring clean, controlled environments akin to chip factories. But once produced, the rest of the process is mostly the same as making normal batteries. This ease of manufacturing is what lured Ion's new chief executive, Jorge Schneider, after

EXCHANGE

This Investor Says It’s Time for Change at Swatch

Steven Wood wants a board seat and more value from its high-end timepieces, but the founding family isn’t interested

By MARGOT PATRICK

When American fund manager Steven Wood set his sights on the storied Swiss watchmaker Swatch Group, he tried a suitably stylish opening gambit.

He sent Chief Executive Nick Hayek cigars; a favorite book, “The Luxury Strategy” by Jean-Noël Kapferer and Vincent Bastien; and a handwritten note laying out opportunities he saw for Swatch’s luxury brands to recapture market share.

Sales at Swatch had grown for years thanks to the popularity of its chic brands like Breguet, Blancpain and Omega, but since founder Nicolas G. Hayek’s death in 2010, its high-end offerings have lost market share. Last year sales plunged in China, one of its most important markets, and the company’s stock is now one of the most-shorted in Europe.

Wood, who runs investment firm Greenwood Investors, reached out to CEO Nick Hayek, the founder’s son, in September. The next month, the New York-based investor secured a meeting with the CEO and the finance chief at Swatch’s timber-framed headquarters in Biel, Switzerland, where they talked for more than two hours over coffee. Wood says they discussed marketing strategies, particularly for the high-end brands, and how the company, known for its minimal contact with investors, should share more information.

Wood swapped out a Patek Philippe as his everyday watch for a secondhand Breguet Classique. Within days of the October meeting, he invested more than one-quarter of his \$150 million fund into the Swiss company, for around a 0.5% stake.

But the courtship abruptly ended in March, when Wood submitted himself as a board candidate to represent Swatch’s minority share-

Steven Wood

■ **First watch:** Flik Flak, a Swatch brand his dad carried in the toy store

■ **Morning routine:** Grab one or two kids out of bed, make strong coffee and eventually meditate

■ **Must-have item:** AirPods Pro. ‘I’d rather leave my wallet at home.’

■ **Currently reading:** Ronald Winston’s ‘King of Diamonds,’ a biography of Harry Winston (the jeweler is now owned by Swatch)

■ **Favorite place:** New York’s Central Park

■ **Where you’ll find him on a Saturday:** Working on his book in a coffee shop or on a plane

exclusivity, a strategy that has paid off for luxury giants like Hermès and Ferrari. Collaborations with designers and celebrities could make other lines—Omega, in particular—more relevant to younger customers, he says.

Swatch said its CEO wasn’t available for an interview, citing the company’s earnings quiet period.

In a statement, a Swatch spokesperson said the company has 16 brands across price points and doesn’t want to compete only in the luxury market. It also makes almost all of its products in Switzerland. “The future of the Swiss watch industry cannot and will not be just to serve an elite of rich people, even if some financial analysts or investors want us to do so,” the company said.

Wood, 42, grew up working the cash register at Playville, his dad’s now-closed toy store, in Covington, La. After graduating from Tulane University in 2005 with a degree in economics and international relations, he went to work as a stock analyst at firms including RBC Capital



company has a dual-class stock structure that effectively gives the Hayek family voting control. Wood says he isn’t trying to change that setup, but rather give those minority shareholders an official voice in the boardroom.

Swatch says its board is intentionally lean, and composed of members who understand its Swiss corporate culture.

Swatch founder Hayek Sr. is a national hero in Switzerland, credited with saving Swiss watchmaking in the 1980s from the existential threat of low-cost quartz models from Japan. The introduction of colorful Swatches revived interest in Swiss-made watches.

Breguet’s founder designed the Marie Antoinette, considered the world’s most expensive timepiece. Blancpain invented a modern diving watch. Omega is the official timekeeper of the Olympic Games and was worn by the first astronauts to walk on the moon.

Hayek Sr. turned the brands into aspirational personal statements. He died on the job in 2010 at 82. His daughter was elevated to chairwoman two days later; his son had already been made CEO in 2003.

In recent years, the shares have underperformed luxury peers and now trade at their lowest level in 16 years. According to S&P Global Market Intelligence, some 27% of Swatch’s shares are on loan, a proxy for short interest, indicating that traders see the stock falling further. Net profit declined 78% last year.

Contact with the current CEO convinced Wood that the family’s stewardship, combined with his own ideas, could bring change and renewed growth. Hayek “clearly lives and breathes the business, and this is why I love family-owned firms. The business is their life,” Wood said.

In the interview, Wood pointed out examples of how he thinks Swatch could restore its luster in the luxury market. For example, he said Omega’s Seamaster could compete more closely with Rolex’s pricier Submariner.

Analysts say the family has little incentive to listen to minority shareholders. The Hayeks have voting rights close to 45%.

Nick Hayek has previously said that investors can sell if they don’t like the way the company is governed, and that Swatch sells watches, not stock. The 70-year-old made films before entering the family business. He has said his father advised him to stay imaginative, and do the opposite of what stock ana-

lysts say.

Ahead of Swatch’s annual meeting last month, the family-controlled board urged shareholders to vote against Wood because he isn’t Swiss or living in Switzerland, which it said is important for board members.

During the meeting, the

company said Wood won 62% of the vote from the minority shareholders. But it said Wood didn’t win enough support overall. Including the other class of shares, he only secured 19.7%.

Wood’s lawyers have written to Swatch, claiming that minority shareholders should

have gotten to approve their candidate before the broader vote and that the wider shareholder base didn’t have grounds to reject him. Swatch said the vote followed the legally correct procedure.

He is drumming up support to call for another vote.



Pictured in 2019, from left, Marc Hayek, now a Swatch board member, CEO Nick Hayek and Chairwoman Nayla Hayek.

holders.

The CEO stopped responding to Wood’s notes, and his sister, Swatch Chairwoman Nayla Hayek, responded to a letter but declined to meet. (Swatch says its CEO gets hundreds of messages with ideas each week.) Nayla Hayek’s son, Marc Hayek—on the board and president for Blancpain and Breguet—responded to a meeting request from Wood by suggesting a date eight months away.

People may think, “this American cowboy, he’s going to want to fire Swiss people,” Wood said in a video call from his satellite office in New Orleans, where Swiss clocks on the walls display the time zones where his firm, Greenwood Investors, operates. “Totally the opposite.”

While Wood failed to win a board seat at last month’s annual meeting, he isn’t giving up.

Swatch, known for its colorful, plastic watches, could capitalize more on its high-end brands, Wood said. He said the company could better emphasize scarcity and

Markets and Carr Securities in New York.

“Swatch was on top of the world,” Wood said, recalling his observations of the watchmaker during his early days as an analyst.

He has published research that shows that family or founder-owned businesses outperform the market over time, but minority shareholders may have less ability to exert influence and may have to deal with higher volatility. He is also working on a book that profiles history’s greatest value creators.

Wood started Greenwood Investors in 2010 and has taken what he calls a “constructivist” approach of being friendly and engaged, rather than “activist” and demanding. He has invested in companies including Italian defense contractor Leonardo and Portuguese logistics company CTT, where he won board roles and worked from within to modernize and add more transparency.

At Swatch, Wood’s idea was to represent the minority shareholders, who have about 20% of the voting power. The

©2025 PITCCH IN FOUNDATION INC. ALL RIGHTS RESERVED

CC SABATHIA'S 2025

LEGACCY GALA

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 8TH 2025, 6PM
AMERICAN MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY
NEW YORK CITY

CHAMPION OF YOUTH AWARD
PHILIP ROGERS

LEGACCY AWARD
GERRIT & AMY COLE



SPONSOR THE GALA



PITCCH IN
FOUNDATION

FOR MORE INFORMATION PLEASE CONTACT:
CAROL GILL | T: 347-844-2822 | CGILL@PITCCH.ORG

SPONSOR THE GALA



EXCHANGE

Drones and I Do: ‘Super-Weddings’ Hit New Extremes



abroad now that tariffs have hit the industry. “You want European luxury? It doesn’t make sense to import it,” she said.

AC in a castle

Haywood said it can be challenging to work with a population “where no one says no to them.”

“They’ll show me a photo and I’m like, That’s great California light, but you’re getting married in London on a rainy afternoon,” Haywood said.

She said a couple recently requested white peacocks at an August wedding in Italy—a request she couldn’t fulfill because summer is the peacock shedding season, and so the birds would be featherless. (Not to mention aviary restrictions due to bird flu.) The bride was fixated on the detail, and Haywood said she gently had to push back. “Ultimately you try to give the client what they want. But you have to steer them.”

Simon recalled sending a courier on a private jet from London to the Maldives to deliver celery salt because the couple felt the wedding’s Bloody Mary cocktails needed it.

“You want to make dreams come true, no matter how trivial it might sound,” he said, adding that his role requires him to take all requests seriously. “You can’t tell someone how to drive their Rolls-Royce.”

Bailey recalled a time when flowers shipped from the Netherlands for a wedding in Kuwait got stuck at the airport due to an alleged customs issue. “I had to send someone with \$3,000 or \$4,000 cash. At that point, you’re willing to do anything.”

Ruth Minkowitz, a luxury event planner in Italy, said Venice weddings like Bezos and Sánchez’s are a special kind of logistical nightmare. When her family’s company, Elite Kosher Events, has a wedding in Venice, they start getting ready six days in advance, instead of three.

“Food, plates, material, everything, it all goes by boat,” said Minkowitz. “You need a lot more personnel, just to schlep.”

Minkowitz said she worked on a wedding at a historic castle on the outskirts of Rome two summers ago, where the family requested the ancient building be pumped with air conditioning. Minkowitz said her team had to buy voltage from the Rome municipality to ensure they had enough energy.

“Italians would have been OK,” she said. “But we made the castle freezing. In July. Because the Americans like it cold.”

Continued from page B1
need vendors too: Caterers are now hiring food stylists to make sure their culinary creations are displayed artfully. Bartenders tap mixologists to craft bespoke cocktails. Florists are working with drapery artists, who add huge swaths of fabric for additional layers of drama. Nearly everyone signs a nondisclosure agreement before the work begins.

“Luxury weddings have turned theatrical,” said Preston Bailey, an event designer who has planned weddings like Ivanka Trump’s and last year’s Ambani wedding.

80,000 rose stems

Details about the Bezos-Sánchez wedding have remained largely under wraps. The couple hired the wedding planner Lanza & Baucina, a discreet London-based group that planned George Clooney’s 2014 wedding, and is reportedly tying the knot on a Venetian island. Protests against the couple using Venice for their event are already underway.

A representative for Bezos and Sánchez declined to comment. Lanza Baucina said that its guiding principles and the instructions of its client call for the “minimizing of any disruption to the city, the respect for its residents and institutions and the overwhelming employment of locals in the crafting of the events.”

A luxury destination wedding takes a village to produce. Haywood in London works with teams as large as 500 people for the events she plans. “We’ve got 80,000 rose stems here. Can you imagine how many people it takes to condition those flowers?” she said, taking a call while setting up a wedding near Monaco. She declined to name the couple.

Beyond manpower to set up, assist and serve, Haywood also maintains a 20-person team to assist with small details like steaming bridesmaid dresses. They also look after family VIPs—making sure, for example, that “the grandparents have a drink at all times.”

“This type of client lives in a beautiful home, and owns multiple homes that are fully staffed, so when they come and host a wedding, they require this level of service,” Haywood added.

Bailey said clients typically “hope to show the guests something they’ve never experienced before.” Bailey has built \$600,000 structures, rented 10-foot candelabras and ordered custom furniture from Egypt. He typically works with silk flowers for overhead installations, which can cost \$25,000 to \$75,000.

Wedding decor now sometimes re-

\$750 to \$1,000
Catering bill per person

\$4 million
Estimated cost of a multiday luxury wedding for 200 guests

\$500,000
Cost of a holograph of the bride’s deceased grandfather at a Preston Bailey wedding

quires the work of a drapery artist, who swaddles walls and ceilings with miles of fabrics.

“Drapery is the showcase of the party,” said Tommy Murphy, a drapery artist with the Orlando-based Swag Decor. He recently worked on a wedding in an upstate New York barn that had \$170,000 worth of drapery. “It doesn’t matter if you spend \$1 million on flowers if you have ugly walls,” he said.

More wealthy couples are also opting for video mapping, where lighting artists project 3-D images throughout a venue.

“They are immersive,” said Ira Levy, a luxury lighting designer, who said such light projections cost \$60,000 to \$100,000. “We’ve taken people through different parts of the world.”

Bailey recently commissioned a \$500,000 holograph of a bride’s deceased grandfather to share well wishes.

“For billionaires, if it’s exciting, they’ll go for it,” Bailey said.

Million-dollar DJs

Simon said Banana Split has worked with celebrity chefs like Wolfgang Puck and Gordon Ramsay on weddings, though other clients prefer to keep it as casual as a menu of chicken and fries.

At this level, it’s become common to work with a food stylist, to help “the menu tell a story,” said Olivier

Cheng, a caterer based in New York. He said luxury catering can range from \$750 to \$1,000 per head.

Cheng recalled hiring a food stylist to work on a luxury wedding and set up a night-market style buffet with multiple food stalls. “We created a spice-market story. We created a sardine story,” said Cheng. “People want more than just a three-course menu.”

Super-weddings today often include a celebrity entertainer, where families shell out for a headliner to perform a couple of hits. “The Russians started this,” Haywood said.

Families have paid top dollar to hire musicians like Paul McCartney, Elton John, the Rolling Stones and Lionel Richie. Justin Bieber reportedly earned \$10 million for performing at the Ambani wedding last summer. Through a representative, Bieber declined to comment.

The only musician he has found to be not bookable, Simon said, is Adele. Adele did not respond to a request for comment.

Increasingly, name-brand DJs like Gryffin and Martin Solveig are becoming in demand too, as couples look to turn the wedding afterparty into an Ibiza nightclub.

“Even the DJs charge a million dollars,” Bailey said.

Haywood said she’s seen a slight drop in inquiries from American families, indicating that some wealthy Americans aren’t feeling confident in the economy. She predicts more luxury American weddings will move

1. Colin Cowie, who planned this wedding, did Jennifer Lopez’s.
2. The work of Olivier Cheng, who helps ‘the menu tell a story.’
3. A wedding by London luxury planner Sarah Haywood
4. The 2024 Ambani wedding in India was a big ‘super-wedding.’



CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: ILLUSTRATION BY MICHAEL BYERS; COLIN COWIE LIFESTYLE; RAJU SHINDE/HINDUSTAN TIMES/GETTY IMAGES; BARKER EVANS FOR SARAH HAYWOOD; ALLAN ZAPADA

EXCHANGE

STREETWISE | JAMES MACKINTOSH

War Brings Out the Best in the Dollar

Israel’s attack on Iran gave the greenback a boost after a long stretch of trouble. But the long-term prospects for the dollar don’t look good.



The dollar is finally behaving as it should, after six months when its haven status was undermined and usual economic relationships broke down. This could be a sign that its terrible run of weakness is nearing an end.

Israel’s attack on Iran tested the dollar’s status amid a flight to safety. The greenback passed: The ICE U.S. Dollar index is up about 1% since the first bombing. More important, the currency behaved as it should, rising on days dominated by fear and falling on days when fear receded.

Investors who worried that international money would no longer flow to the U.S. in times of crisis can breathe a sigh of relief. So long as the dollar rises in bad times, it provides a hedge against serious trouble, making it more attractive.

There are other reasons to think that after the sharp drop in this dollar this year—even after this week’s bounce, it is still down 10% from its January high—it may be ready for a breather.

It’s become a crowded trade. Everyone I speak to outside the U.S. is less enamored of the country than they used to be.

“Independence Day of Trump transformed ‘U.S. exceptionalism’ to ‘sell America,’” says Christophe Boucher, chief investment officer of ABN Amro Investment Solutions.

Many share the view: According to Bank of America’s regular sur-

vey, fund managers have the smallest position in the dollar they’ve had in two decades, and the least exposure to the U.S. relative to benchmarks of any major asset.

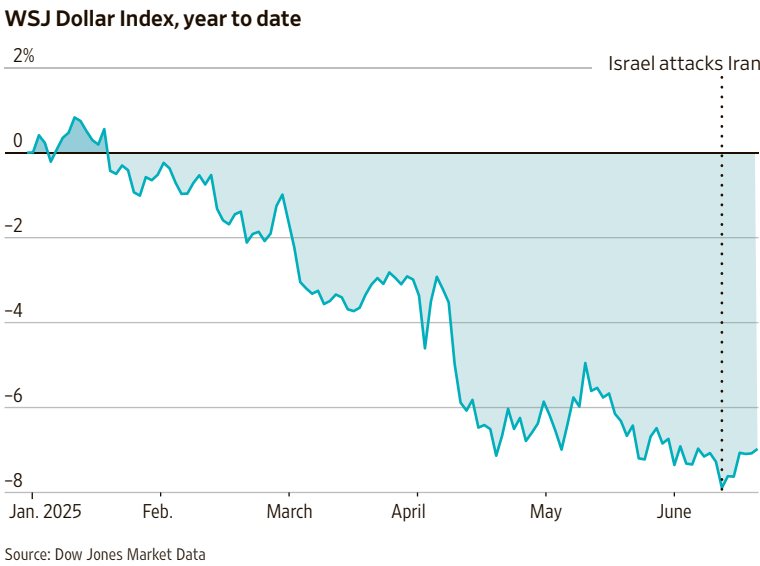
The pace of change has been extraordinarily fast, with the dollar dropping since February at a 30% annualized rate. It can’t keep falling at that pace. In the past, declines at this rate over such a short period have almost always been followed by at least a partial recovery.

Exceptions were special: In 1973 President Richard Nixon was deliberately devaluing the dollar; in 1985-86 President Ronald Reagan was deliberately devaluing the dollar; and in 2002 and 2009-10 the U.S. was aggressively easing monetary policy as it tried to recover from market crashes.

I remain cautious. Any near-term rally for the dollar might be wiped out in the longer term. My reasons for pessimism:

Number one, the dollar hasn’t been behaving the way economists expect. President Trump’s tariffs ought to make the dollar stronger, to adjust traded goods prices.

Number two, the dollar hasn’t been following historical trading patterns. Higher interest rates in the U.S. than elsewhere should attract money to dollars. That difference in rates has grown this year as major central banks have cut while the Federal Reserve hasn’t. The economy has turned out both stronger and, so far at least, less inflationary than expected, which



President Trump’s tariffs ought to make the dollar stronger. Instead, the opposite has happened.

reserve currency [but] something that was unbelievably exceptional has become a little less exceptional.”

Number four, the U.S.’s incessant borrowing to finance both a yawning government deficit and a vast current-account deficit means it has to make itself attractive to foreign capital—either with higher rates or a weaker currency.

It’s likely that the dollar fell so fast because rising concern about the long-term role of the dollar combined with a short-term turn in sentiment on the U.S. from super-bullish after the November election to a consensus that it was time to invest elsewhere. One plausible outcome is a short-term bounce as sentiment recovers and the recently proven haven status helps confidence.

Even if that happens, however, the long-run prospects for the dollar don’t look good.

Companies Doing More With Less

Continued from page B1

don’t need 30% to 40% of my team,” tech investor and former Adobe executive Jason Lemkin said on a venture-capital podcast last month.

In all, about one in five S&P 500 companies have fewer employees today in both offices and the field than a decade ago, and it isn’t all due to selling or spinning off some operations, according to a Wall Street Journal analysis of public filings. That includes bellwether names such as Walmart, General Motors and Bank of America, whose sales have all climbed over that time.

As some in corporate America got leaner, the U.S. workforce as a whole still grew over the past decade, as the healthcare sector expanded and the ranks of government workers increased.

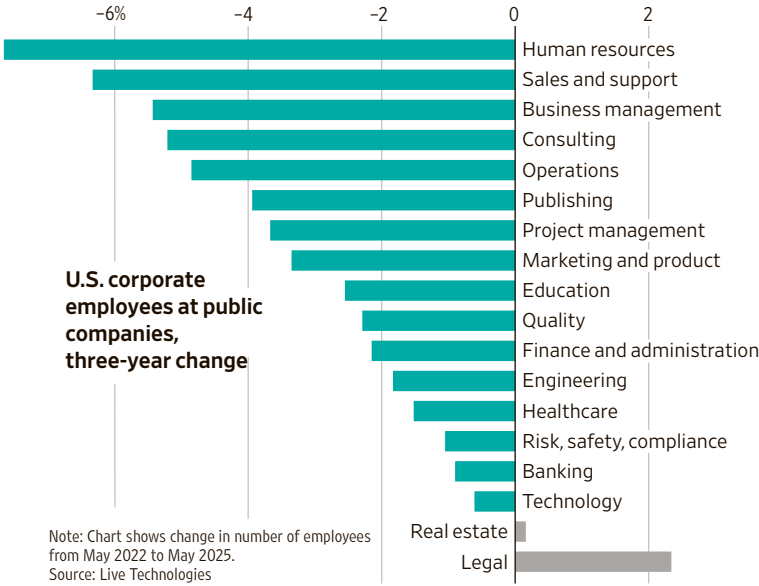
On the chopping block

The downsizing has caused employees to rapidly lose the leverage they enjoyed during the pandemic, when jobs were plentiful and companies were bidding up for white-collar talent. Even with AI advances on the horizon, many corporate leaders and labor economists have projected long-term shortages in both salaried and hourly jobs.

Now workers are contending with bigger workloads, more re-



Amazon’s Seattle headquarters. CEO Andy Jassy says the ‘once-in-a-lifetime’ rise of AI will eliminate the need for some jobs at the company.



sponsibilities and a nagging fear about their job security and future prospects.

“Employees are too nervous to make moves,” Mischa Fisher, an economist at education platform Udemy, wrote in an analysis of the latest U.S. jobs report. “This freeze is blocking normal opportunity flow—early career workers can’t break in, experienced workers can’t move up, and burned-out employees stay put.”

Managers have been an especially ripe target for cutting, though Live Data Technologies’s data show public companies have pared back their nonmanagerial ranks recently, too. The number of managers dropped 6.1% between May 2022 to May 2025. Executive-level roles fell 4.6%.

When Brian Moynihan became Bank of America’s CEO in 2010, the company employed 285,000. The bank closed branches, digitized more processes and didn’t replace people when they quit. In recent years, it cut its management layers to about seven from 13.

Today, it has about 213,000 employees and revenues are up 18% from a decade ago. “We have a higher-producing company with fewer people and lower costs,” Moynihan told investors in April.

Companies’ flattening has left managers leading larger teams. In 2020, managers had an average 4.2 direct reports, according to Lattice, a human-resources software provider. By 2023, that number was 5.1.

“They have delayed to the point of making

the companies anorexic,” said Joseph Fuller, a management professor at Harvard Business School.

That can backfire and eventually hurt employees’ productivity, he added: “Their ability to do deep work and really focus goes down consistently because they’re endlessly distracted and now they’re doing the work that three people did 10 years ago.”

Yet, “revenue per employee” is back in favor as a metric investors and executives track carefully. Among bosses watching it closely is Grindr CEO George Arison. When he took the helm of the dating app in 2022, it made about \$1 million in revenue per employee.

Within two years, that figure more than doubled. Grindr kept the pace of hiring below even its internal projections, rolled out new productivity tools—and leaned on existing staff to do more.

“I was pretty clear that people are not working as much as they need to,” Arison said.

Others are now urging their teams to do more with the same resources. “We’re going to launch 10 products,” Stéphane Bancel, CEO of Covid-vaccine maker Moderna, said at an investor conference in late May. “The challenge I have for our team is: How do we launch those 10 products without adding head count?”

Agents of change

Generative AI is already allowing executives to imagine a future with even fewer workers. CEOs at both e-commerce platform Shopify and foreign-language learning app Duolingo recently told their teams that future hiring would be predicated on first showing the work couldn’t be automated. Duolingo’s CEO softened the messaging after



a social-media uproar over his memo, clarifying that his company was still hiring at the same speed as before.

When Lattice wanted to add a payroll function to its line of HR software products, executives calculated they would need 40 or 50 new staff since customers’ pay issues often require immediate attention.

Ultimately, Lattice added fewer than 10 people, CEO Sarah Franklin said, because current AI models are so much more sophisticated than chatbots from just a year or two ago. They “can take bespoke requests, bespoke querying and match them to give you an answer,” she said. “That’s what we as humans do.”

Many companies are moving toward using more agentic AI, autonomous bots that can make decisions and complete tasks on behalf of humans, such as paying an invoice or rerouting inventory if a natural disaster interferes with a trucking route. Walmart is deploying such AI agents to shorten the timeline for producing in-house apparel by up to 18 weeks.

The retailer already employs 100,000 fewer people than a decade ago, its filings show. It sold operations in Brazil, the U.K. and other countries during that time, but that is only part of the story. Technical innovations have also helped its revenues rise despite the lower head count. And it has invested heavily in its e-commerce business, which is growing quickly and relies partly on freelance drivers who don’t show up in the retailer’s head-count data.

In 2024, Walmart recorded \$681 billion in sales, an increase of 40% compared with 2014. “Many of today’s jobs didn’t exist just a few years ago, and we expect the pace

of change to continue,” Donna Morris, Walmart’s chief people officer, said in a statement.

In his note to Amazon employees Tuesday, Jassy said that generative AI and agents are growing increasingly capable. He said the company has already rolled out, or is building, more than 1,000 agents, and predicted that AI agents will speed up the pace of innovation by taking care of rote work. “Agents will allow us to start almost everything from a more advanced starting point,” he said.

Leaner, meaner

The leaner, meaner approach is trickling down to even the smallest startups. Jolie, which sells high-end filtered shower heads, is on track to make about \$50 million in revenue this year. It has five employees.

CEO Ryan Babenzien, who previously sold a sneaker brand to Steve Madden, said he never considered head count a sign of success. Jolie operates with such a lean team—which includes Babenzien’s co-founder, Arjan Singh, along with employees focused on sales, marketing and social media—by relying on digital tools and part-time contractors for some finance, operations and logistics functions.

“Hiring is not necessary like it used to be,” Babenzien said. “Ten years ago, it would be really difficult to build a \$50 million business with five or less people. Today, I think it’s going to be really, really common.”

Babenzien hopes to double the company’s revenue to \$100 million in the next few years.

He estimates the company could do that by bringing on two more people.

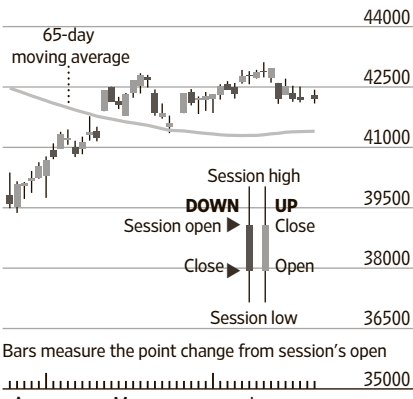
Dow Jones Industrial Average

42206.82
▲ 35.16
or 0.08%
All-time high
45014.04, 12/04/24

Trailing P/E ratio 23.86
P/E estimate * 20.28
Dividend yield 1.72

Last 27.17
Year ago 18.96
2.16

Current divisor
0.16268413125742



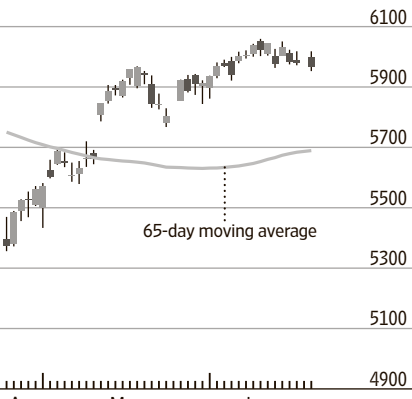
Weekly P/E data based on as-reported earnings from Birinyi Associates Inc. * Based on Nasdaq-100 Index

S&P 500 Index

5967.84
▼ 13.03
or 0.22%
All-time high
6144.15, 02/19/25

Trailing P/E ratio 23.58
P/E estimate * 22.75
Dividend yield * 1.28

Last 24.01
Year ago 22.27
1.34

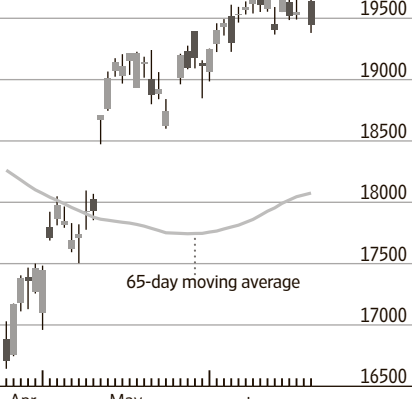


Nasdaq Composite Index

19447.41
▼ 98.86
or 0.51%
All-time high
20173.89, 12/16/24

Trailing P/E ratio * 30.72
P/E estimate ** 28.58
Dividend yield ** 0.72

Last 31.89
Year ago 28.97
0.78



Track the Markets: Winners and Losers

A look at how selected global stock indexes, bond ETFs, currencies and commodities performed around the world for the week.

Index	Currency, vs. U.S. dollar	Commodity, traded in U.S.*	Exchange-traded fund
	Lean hogs		8.76%
	Nymex ULSD		7.76
	Nymex natural gas		7.43
	Nymex RBOB gasoline		4.57
	Wheat		4.41
	KOSPI Composite		4.40
	Nymex crude		2.67
	BSE Sensex		1.59
	NIKKEI 225		1.50
	Bloomberg Commodity Index		1.36
	S&P 500 Energy		1.10
	S&P 500 Information Tech		0.88
	S&P 500 Financials		0.81
	WSJ Dollar Index		0.69
	iSh TIPS Bond		0.64
	S&P MidCap 400		0.61
	iShiBoxx\$HYCp		0.55
	Dow Jones Transportation Average		0.54
	Comex copper		0.48
	Russell 2000		0.42
	iSh 7-10 Treasury		0.33
	iShiBoxx\$InlGrdCp		0.32
	iShJPMUSEmgBd		0.25
	VangdTotalBd		0.25
	Nasdaq Composite		0.21
	S&P SmallCap 600		0.20
	VangdTotInlBd		0.20
	iSh 20+ Treasury		0.19
	iSh 1-3 Treasury		0.16
	iShNatlMuniBd		0.08
	Chinese yuan		0.02
	Dow Jones Industrial Average		0.02
	Nasdaq-100		-0.02
	S&P/TSX Comp		-0.03
	Bovespa Index		-0.07
	S&P 500		-0.15
	S&P 500 Industrials		-0.16
	Soybeans		-0.16
	Euro area euro		-0.23
	S&P 500 Consumer Staples		-0.25
	S&P 500 Real Estate		-0.34
	South African rand		-0.37
	IBEX 35		-0.43
	S&P/ASX 200		-0.49
	South Korean won		-0.51
	Shanghai Composite		-0.51
	FTSE MIB		-0.53
	Australian dollar		-0.59
	DAX		-0.70
	S&P 500 Consumer Discr		-0.74
	Indian rupee		-0.75
	S&P 500 Utilities		-0.80
	Indonesian rupiah		-0.80
	Swiss franc		-0.83
	Comex silver		-0.84
	FTSE 100		-0.86
	U.K. pound		-0.90
	Euro STOXX		-1.06
	Canadian dollar		-1.11
	Mexican peso		-1.14
	S&P 500 Materials		-1.21
	CAC-40		-1.24
	Japanese yen		-1.35
	Hang Seng		-1.52
	STOXX Europe 600		-1.54
	S&P 500 Communication Svcs		-1.73
	Comex gold		-1.84
	Norwegian krone		-1.93
	S&P/BNM IPC		-2.04
	S&P 500 Health Care		-2.66
	Corn		-3.54

*Continuous front-month contracts

Sources: FactSet (indexes, bond ETFs, commodities), Tullett Prebon (currencies).

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Methodology

Performance reflects price change (except DAX, Bovespa, and Tel Aviv 35, which reflect total returns). Commodities are represented by the continuous front-month futures contract. Bond exchange-traded fund performance may diverge from that of their underlying index. Bond categories are represented by the following ETFs: U.S. Bonds Total Market: Vanguard Total Bond Market; 1-3 Yr U.S. Treasuries: iShares 1-3 Year Treasury; U.S. 7-10 Yr Treasuries: iShares 7-10 Year Treasury; 20+ Yr U.S. Treasuries: iShares 20+ Year Treasury; Treasury Inflation-Protected Securities (TIPS): iShares TIPS; Investment Grade Corporate Bonds: iShares iBoxx \$ Investment Grade Corporate; High Yield Corporate Bonds: iShares iBoxx \$ High Yield Corporate; Municipal Bonds: iShares National Muni; International Bonds: Vanguard Total International; Emerging Market Bonds: iShares J.P. Morgan USD Emerging Markets.



Scan this code
Get real-time U.S. stock quotes and track most-active stocks, new highs/lows and mutual funds.
Available free at WSJMarkets.com

Currencies

U.S.-dollar foreign-exchange rates in late New York trading

US\$/%				US\$/%				
Country/currency	Fri in US\$	per US\$	YTD chg (%)	Country/currency	Fri in US\$	per US\$	YTD chg (%)	
Americas				Thailand baht .03049 32.800 -4.5				
Argentina peso	.00091164	4243	12.9	Vietnam dong .00003827	26129	-2.5		
Brazil real .1814 5.5137 -10.8				Europe				
Canada dollar	.7281	1.3735	-4.5	Czech Rep. koruna .04643	21.538	-11.5		
Chile peso	.001063	941.08	-5.4	Denmark krone .1545	6.4737	-10.1		
Colombia peso	.000245	4079.75	-7.4	Euro area euro	1.1525	.8677	-10.1	
Ecuador US dollar	1	1	unch	Hungary forint .002862	349.42	-12.1		
Mexico peso	.0522	19.1743	-7.9	Iceland krona .008057	124.11	-10.7		
Uruguay peso	.02444	40.9110	-6.3	Norway krone .0990	10.1024	-11.3		
Asia-Pacific				Poland zloty .2700	3.7036	-10.4		
Australia dollar	.6449	1.5506	-4.0	Sweden krona .1034	9.6680	-9.8		
China yuan	.1393	7.1799	-1.6	Switzerland franc	1.2222	.8182	-12.7	
Hong Kong dollar	.1274	7.8500	1.0	Turkey lira .0252	39.6732	12.2		
India rupee	.01155	86.594	1.2	Ukraine hryvnia .0238	41.9500	-0.2		
Indonesia rupiah	.0000609	16417	0.9	UK pound	1.3451	.7434	-7.0	
Japan yen	.006845	146.10	-7.1	Middle East/Africa				
Kazakhstan tenge	.001918	521.41	-0.7	Bahrain dinar	2.6520	.3771	-0.01	
Macau pataca	.1235	8.0975	1.2	Egypt pound	.0197	50.6626	-0.4	
Malaysia ringgit	.2352	4.2525	-4.9	Israel shekel .2865	3.4899	-4.1		
New Zealand dollar	.5968	1.6756	-6.3	Kuwait dinar	3.2638	.3064	-0.6	
Pakistan rupee	.00353	283.550	1.9	Oman sul rial	2.5993	.3847	-0.1	
Philippines peso	.0175	57.219	-1.5	Qatar rial .2743	3.645	...		
Singapore dollar	.7769	1.2871	-5.7	Saudi Arabia riyal	.2665	3.7524	-0.1	
South Korea won	.0007282	1373.16	-7.1	South Africa rand .0556	17.9993	-4.6		
Sri Lanka rupee	.0033259	300.67	2.6					
Taiwan dollar	.03380	29.588	-9.8					
				Close	Net Chg	% Chg	YTD % Chg	
				WSJ Dollar Index	95.58	0.10	0.11	-6.98

Sources: Tullett Prebon, Dow Jones Market Data

Commodities

	Close	Fri Net chg	% Chg	High	52-Week Low	% Chg	YTD % chg
DJ Commodity	1111.01	-4.05	-0.36	1115.06	942.52	7.66	8.67
FTSE/CC CRB Index	312.53	-1.87	-0.59	316.63	265.48	6.59	5.33
Crude oil, \$ per barrel	74.93	-0.21	-0.28	83.88	57.13	-7.18	4.48
Natural gas, \$/MMBtu	3.847	-0.142	-3.56	4.491	1.904	42.22	5.89
Gold, \$ per troy oz.	3368.10	-21.70	-0.64	3431.20	2299.20	45.40	28.10

Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Latest Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg	YTD	3-yr. ann.
Dow Jones										
Industrial Average	42432.19	42089.99	42206.82	35.16	0.08	45014.04	37645.59	7.8	-0.8	12.2
Transportation Avg	14878.38	14707.12	14764.80	39.30	0.27	17754.38	12637.04	-2.3	-7.1	4.7
Utility Average	1043.29	1032.44	1037.61	5.45	0.53	1079.88	898.82	14.1	5.6	5.3
Total Stock Market	59497.50	58844.54	59002.40	-126.55	-0.21	61024.05	49067.76	9.5	1.0	16.9
Barron's 400	1279.79	1267.17	1271.30	0.05	0.004	1356.99	1058.38	12.5	1.6	14.3

Nasdaq Stock Market										
Nasdaq Composite	19696.11	19380.58	19447.41	-98.86	-0.51	20173.89	15267.91	9.9	0.7	21.7
Nasdaq-100	21902.99	21552.80	21626.39	-93.30	-0.43	22175.60	17090.40	9.8	2.9	24.3

S&P										
500 Index	6018.20	5952.56	5967.84	-13.03	-0.22	6144.15	4982.77	9.2	1.5	17.5
MidCap 400	3044.12	3011.82	3025.18	1.64	0.05	3390.26	2560.93	3.2	-3.1	10.9
SmallCap 600	1307.19	1293.38	1296.70	-1.54	-0.12	1544.66	1106.12	1.1	-7.9	5.8

Other Indexes										
Russell 2000	2127.55	2103.32	2109.27	-3.70	-0.17	2442.03	1760.71	4.3	-5.4	8.2
NYSE Composite	19967.45	19838.30	19868.36	-32.77	-0.16	20272.04	17188.46	10.4	4.0	12.1
Value Line	588.33	582.82	584.20	-0.47	-0.08	656.04	495.50	0.1	-4.4	4.3
NYSE Arca Biotech	5567.25	5499.09	5526.33	-9.79	-0.18	6318.63	5060.12	5.3	-3.8	8.2
NYSE Arca Pharma	926.39	914.45	917.63	-8.53	-0.92	1140.17	860.88	-13.6	-1.8	5.6
KBW Bank	131.66	130.84	131.37	1.01	0.78	140.59	101.92	28.9	3.1	9.3
PHLX® Gold/Silver	208.94	204.69	204.94	-2.38	-1.15	210.81	136.20	48.9	49.4	19.1
PHLX® Oil Service	62.44	61.28	61.38	-0.79	-1.27	92.31	50.70	-25.3	-15.5	-2.4
PHLX® Semiconductor	5304.58	5143.65	5211.48	-39.55	-0.75	5904.54	3562.94	-5.9	4.6	26.4
Cboe Volatility	21.07	19.11	20.62	0.48	2.38	52.33	12.03	56.2	18.8	-12.8

Nasdaq PHLX

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

International Stock Indexes

Region/Country	Index	Close	Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD % chg
World	MSCI ACWI	885.76	-0.12	-0.01	5.3
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	367.43	1.44	0.39	12.8
	MSCI World	3881.69	-5.40	-0.14	4.7
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1189.85	12.54	1.07	10.6
Americas	MSCI AC Americas	2259.34	-5.27	-0.23	2.1
	S&P/TSX Comp	26497.57	-8.43	-0.03	7.2
	MSCI EM Latin America	2264.56	-14.79	-0.65	22.2
Brazil	Bovespa	137115.83	-1600.81	-1.15	14.0
Chile	S&P IPSA	4206.67	...	Closed	16.4
Mexico	S&P/BMV IPC	56264.69	196.53	0.35	13.6
EMEA	STOXX Europe 600	536.53	0.67	0.12	5.7
	Euro STOXX	552.81	3.55	0.65	9.4
Belgium	Bel-20	4439.53	27.82	0.63	4.1
Denmark	OMX Copenhagen 20	1820.57	-31.87	-1.72	-13.4
France	CAC 40	7589.66	36.21	0.48	2.8
Germany	DAX	23350.55	293.17	1.27	17.3
Israel	Tel Aviv	2834.31	...	Closed	18.3
Italy	FTSE MIB	39231.35	289.16	0.74	14.8
Netherlands	AEX	908.52	-0.78	-0.09	3.4
Norway	Oslo Bors All-Share	1898.50	-3.10	-0.16	15.4
South Africa	FTSE/JSE All-Share	94710.48	-204.22	-0.22	12.6
Spain	IBEX 35	13850.30	105.40	0.77	19.5
Sweden	OMX Stockholm	929.61	...	Closed	-2.6
Switzerland	Swiss Market	11871.32	-0.20	-0.002	2.3
Turkey	BIST 100	9203.37	101.35	1.11	-6.4
U.K.	FTSE 100	8774.65	-17.15	-0.20	7.4
U.K.	FTSE 250	21148.50	74.51	0.35	2.6
Asia-Pacific	MSCI AC Asia Pacific	197.53	0.77	0.39	8.8
Australia	S&P/ASX 200	8505.50	-18.20	-0.21	4.2
China	Shanghai Composite	3359.90	-2.21	-0.07	0.2
Hong Kong	Hang Seng	23530.48	292.74	1.26	17.3
India	BSE Sensex	82408.17	1046.29	1.29	5.5
Japan	NIKKEI 225	38403.23	-85.11	-0.22	-3.7
Singapore	Straits Times	3883.43	-10.75	-0.28	2.5
South Korea	KOSPI	3021.84	44.10	1.48	25.9
Taiwan	TAIEX	22045.74	42.24	0.19	-4.3
Thailand	SET	1067.63	-1.10	-0.10	-23.8

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

Consumer Rates and Returns to Investor

U.S. consumer rates

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures						
	Contract				Open interest	
	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg	
Copper-High (CXM)-25,000 lbs.; \$ per lb.						
June	4,7500	4,8295	4,7500	4,8260	-0.0190	1,268
Sept	4,8530	4,9245	4,7970	4,8845	-0.0215	80,038
Gold (CMX)-100 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
June	3366.90	3372.80	3341.00	3368.10	-21.70	1,801
July	3365.00	3376.20	3342.10	3375.40	-22.00	6,498
Aug	3386.40	3390.80	3356.20	3381.70	-22.40	334,519
Sept	3390.60	3404.10	3371.80	3400.40	-22.60	815
Oct	3412.00	3418.00	3384.20	3413.20	-22.50	21,205
Nov	3413.00	3415.50	3403.20	3427.90	-22.60	141
Palladium (NYM)- 50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
June	1046.00	1046.00	1046.00	1052.80	-9.00	5
Sept	1055.50	1059.50	1045.00	1054.90	-4.90	18,831
Platinum (NYM)-50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
June	1337.70	1345.80	1303.00	1263.70	-47.80	5
Oct	1308.10	1323.20	1257.90	1269.60	-46.80	54,112
Silver (CMX)-5,000 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
June	35.775	35.775	35.775	35.976	-0.890	68
Sept	36.645	36.730	35.845	36.345	-0.903	79,374
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM)-10,000 bbls.; \$ per bbl.						
July	75.67	76.09	74.30	74.93	-0.21	17,782
Aug	73.76	74.29	72.32	73.84	-0.34	303,517
Sept	71.96	72.46	70.57	72.01	0.25	224,047
Oct	70.49	70.92	69.12	70.49	0.17	137,764
Dec	68.69	69.01	67.47	68.60	-0.02	231,797
Dec'26	65.41	66.00	64.76	65.83	-0.21	149,983
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM)-42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
July	2.5926	2.6200	2.5364	2.5418	.0084	37,740
Aug	2.5399	2.5728	2.4999	2.5036	.0087	77,034
Gasoline-NY RB08 (NYM)-42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
July	2.3224	2.3423	2.2995	2.3295	.0209	47,951
Aug	2.2999	2.3227	2.2798	2.3105	.0207	111,111
Natural Gas (NYM)-10,000 MMBtu.; \$ per MMBtu.						
July	4.078	4.148	3.818	3.847	-1.42	62,255
Aug	4.171	4.230	3.918	3.949	-1.28	143,576

	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Sept	4.147	4.198	3.901	3.932	-.119	165,275
Oct	4.199	4.258	3.972	4.004	-.114	139,847
Nov	4.511	4.573	4.320	4.352	-.095	113,541
Jan'26	5.315	5.343	5.140	5.175	-.056	133,769

Agriculture Futures							
Corn (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
July	433.00	435.00	▼	428.25	-4.75	288,074	
Dec	444.00	447.00		441.25	-2.75	547,634	
Oats (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
July	362.25	365.25	357.25	360.75	-2.50	999	
Dec	362.50	364.25	356.50	358.75	-4.50	1,534	
Soybeans (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
July	1074.00	1080.50	1067.00	1068.00	-6.75	161,998	
Nov	1068.50	1074.25	1059.50	1060.75	-7.50	328,666	
Soybean Meal (CBT)-100 tons; \$ per ton.							
July	284.20	285.90	▼	282.70	-8.80	119,786	
Dec	298.30	300.00	296.40	298.10	-2.20	231,548	
Soybean Oil (CBT)-60,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
July	54.74	55.81	▲	54.24	54.47	-3.30	75,531
Dec	55.75	56.47	▲	54.92	55.10	-3.30	237,451
Rough Rice (CBT)-2,000 cwt.; \$ per cwt.							
July	13.56	13.67	13.49	13.53	-.03	3,608	
Sept	13.75	13.88	13.69	13.76	.00	5,361	
Wheat (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
July	573.00	578.25	565.50	567.75	-6.50	73,110	
Sept	589.25	594.00	582.00	583.50	-7.00	189,359	
Wheat (KC)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
July	569.00	575.25	562.50	563.25	-8.00	48,852	
Sept	583.75	590.50	577.50	578.75	-7.75	142,130	
Cattle-Feeder (CME)-50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Aug	304.300	307.950	302.000	302.450	-1.725	43,731	
Sept	304.100	307.700	301.750	302.225	-1.575	18,394	
Cattle-Live (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
June	225.000	225.700	222.300	223.025	-1.275	7,086	
Aug	212.000	213.875	209.375	209.825	-1.850	157,955	
Hogs-Lean (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
July	112.175	113.025	▲	111.700	112.775	.600	42,503

	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg	Open interest
Aug	111.875	112.950	111.300	112.450	.450	117,086
Lumber (CME)-27,500 bd. ft. \$ per 1,000 bd. ft.						
July	615.50	618.50	613.50	616.00	-2.00	4,785
Sept	642.00	645.00	640.00	643.50	1.50	2,855
Milk (CME)-200,000 lbs. cents per lb.						
June	18.66	18.69	18.65	18.67	.01	3,469
July	17.65	17.71	17.50	17.51	-1.17	3,870
Cocoa (ICE-US)-10 metric tons; \$ per ton.						
July	9.505	9.505	8.331	8.459	-1221	2,869
Sept	8.592	8.610	8.050	8.169	-634	40,856
Coffee (ICE-US)-37,500 lbs.; cents per lb.						
July	324.55	329.85	316.95	319.05	-5.85	942
Sept	322.85	328.65	311.85	315.05	-7.25	71,478
Sugar-World (ICE-US)-112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
July	16.10	16.29	15.99	16.10	.22	100,599
Oct	16.60	16.73	16.44	16.57	.26	396,752
Sugar-Domestic (ICE-US)-112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Sept	34.95	34.95	▼ 34.95	34.95	-0.01	742
Jan'26	34.80	34.80	34.80	34.80	-0.01	1,452
Cotton (ICE-US)-50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
July	64.75	65.00	64.00	64.04	-8.80	12,087
Dec	66.70	67.43	66.41	66.70	.03	156,963
Orange Juice (ICE-US)-15,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
July	236.55	238.55	227.95	233.20	-5.35	2,632
Sept	237.30	239.20	229.00	234.85	-2.75	5,404

Interest Rate Futures						
Ultra Treasury Bonds (CBT) - \$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	116-280	117-110	115-280	116-290	3.0	1,880,098
Treasury Bonds (CBT)-\$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	113-200	114-000	112-290	113-250	5.0	1,747,099
Dec	113-070	113-190	112-180	113-140	6.0	1,995
Treasury Notes (CBT)-\$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	110-280	111-030	110-160	110-315	6.0	4,788,474
Dec	110-260	111-000	110-145	110-290	6.5	3,830
5 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT)-\$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
June	107-305	108-075	107-300	108-055	3.7	2,155
Sept	108-052	108-105	107-302	108-082	4.5	6,954,354
2 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT)-\$200,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
June	103-126	103-164	103-126	103-157	2.2	58
Sept	103-214	103-236	103-189	103-226	2.1	4,102,063
30 Day Federal Funds (CBT)-\$1,000,000; 100 - daily avg.						
June	95.6700	95.6725	▼	95.6700	95.6700	349,888
July	95.6700	95.6750	▼	95.6700	95.6750	460,821
Three-Month SOFR (CME)-\$1,000,000; 100 - daily avg.						
April	95.6700	95.6700	95.6700	95.6700	6.351	
June	95.6650	95.6750	95.6650	95.6750	.0100	1,314,473

Bonds | wsj.com/market-data/bonds/benchmarks

Global Government Bonds: Mapping Yields

Yields and spreads over or under U.S. Treasuries on benchmark two-year and 10-year government bonds in selected other countries; arrows indicate whether the yield rose (▲) or fell (▼) in the latest session

Country/		Yield (%)						Spread Under/Over U.S. Treasuries, in basis points		
Coupon (%)	Maturity, in years	Latest	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	Previous
3.875	U.S. 2	3.907 ▼						3.945	3.969	4.727
4.250	10	4.374 ▼						4.397	4.479	4.252
4.750	Australia 2	3.280 ▼						3.309	3.437	4.025
2.750	10	4.193 ▼						4.225	4.409	4.217
0.750	France 2	2.151 ▼						2.170	1.958	3.093
3.200	10	3.245 ▼						3.272	3.261	3.149
1.700	Germany 2	1.856 ▲						1.847	1.846	2.834
2.500	10	2.520 ▼						2.523	2.607	2.433
2.550	Italy 2	2.106 ▼						2.123	2.080	3.563
3.650	10	3.499 ▼						3.520	3.610	3.942
0.800	Japan 2	0.726 ▲						0.721	0.734	0.290
1.400	10	1.403 ▼						1.411	1.523	0.956
2.500	Spain 2	2.036 ▲						2.033	2.038	3.156
3.150	10	3.166 ▲						3.164	3.230	3.305
4.125	U.K. 2	3.925 ▲						3.910	4.058	4.163
4.250	10	4.543 ▲						4.532	4.705	4.056

Source: Tullett Prebon, Tradeweb FTSE U.S. Treasury Close

Corporate Debt

Prices of firms' bonds reflect factors including investors' economic, sectoral and company-specific expectations

Investment-grade spreads that tightened the most...

Issuer	Symbol	Coupon (%)	Yield (%)	Maturity	Spread*, in basis points		
					Current	One-day change	Last week
PACCAR Financial	---	4.250	4.05	June 23, '27	15	-13	n.a.
Siemens Funding	---	4.350	4.11	May 26, '28	25	-13	28
Macquarie Bank	---	4.331	4.21	June 12, '28	35	-9	44
Westpac Banking	---	3.400	4.16	Jan. 25, '28	26	-9	n.a.
Hyundai Capital America*	---	4.875	4.83	Nov. 1, '27	89	-8	92
Microsoft	MSFT	4.500	4.97	Oct. 1, '40	55	-6	n.a.
Canadian National Railway	---	6.900	4.39	July 15, '28	55	-5	n.a.
Toronto-Dominion Bank	TD	4.574	4.50	June 2, '28	63	-4	63

How to Read the Stock Tables

The following explanations apply to NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE American and Nasdaq Stock Market listed securities. Prices are consolidated from trades reported by various market centers, including securities exchanges, financial information networks and other broker-dealers. The list comprises the 1,000 largest companies based on market capitalization.

Underlined quotations are those stocks with large changes in volume compared with the issue's average trading volume.

Boldfaced quotations highlight those issues whose price changed by 5% or more if their previous closing price was \$2 or higher.

Footnotes:

I-New 52-week high; I-New 52-week low; dd-Indicates loss in the most recent four quarters.

Stock tables reflect composite regular trading as of 4 p.m. ET and changes in the official closing prices from 4 p.m. ET the previous day.

Friday, June 20, 2025										YTD 52-Week				Yld				Net		
%Chg	Hi	Lo	Stock	Sym	% PE	Last	Net	%Chg	Hi	Lo	Stock	Sym	% PE	Last	Net	%Chg	Hi	Lo	Stock	
ABC																				
2.57	115.56	82.23	AECOM	ACM	0.9	24.109	-0.84	49.50	256.52	95.70	CarpenTech	CRS	0.3	36	253.72	2.75	3.24	83.32	54.22	
-0.41	115.58	88	Aflac	ACF	2.2	16.103	0.8	57.30	351.43	107.75	GarrisonGlobal	CVNA	11.2	319.89	11.98	11.98	55.23	10.1	Celseltus	
0.33	110.09	57.85	AGNC Invst	AGN	15.1	2.4	9.24	-0.26	20.21	3.24	Chemex	CMX	1.7	13.9	0.78	0.78	12.79	35.23	251.42	
0.40	12.86	1.94	AGNC	AGN	0.8	32.756	-5.11	-0.61	44.80	26.730	Caterpillar	CAT	1.7	138.60	0.72	0.72	30.33	24.51	Celastica	
117.73	48.94	9.32	AST Space	ASTS	dd	45.94	1.59	12.64	39.39	25.41	Centene	CTL	2.5	24.1	1.63	0.18	1.63	20.78	10.23	
21.96	29.03	18.01	AT&T	AT	0.2	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	CentPointEnt	CPE	2.5	24.1	1.63	0.18	1.63	20.78	10.23	
49.89	86.40	39.23	AT&T	AT	0.2	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	CentPointEnt	CPE	2.5	24.1	1.63	0.18	1.63	20.78	10.23	
15.75	107.19	68.49	AXIS Capital	AXIS	17.0	10.058	0.64	16.22	7.83	4.55	CentraSysBrs	ESR	3.0	7.22	-0.18	-0.18	16.22	7.83	4.55	
17.58	141.23	99.71	AbbotLabs	ABT	1.7	13.939	0.58	12.72	47.00	28.02	CharterComms	CHC	0.9	21.82	-0.11	-0.11	12.72	47.00	28.02	
4.28	218.66	163.52	AdVibe	ABVV	35.9	78.183	-0.19	26.88	234.35	153.88	CheckPoint	CHKP	0.9	21.82	-0.11	-0.11	26.88	234.35	153.88	
-1.88	39.35	273.19	Accurate	ACN	21.2	285.37	-21.01	5.36	623.61	512.12	Chemeda	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-6.52	345.30	216.81	Acuity	ACU	0.2	27.508	-4.35	5.42	62.47	16.44	ChemeraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-4.42	587.75	321.01	Adobe	ADBE	2.2	27.508	-4.35	5.42	62.47	16.44	ChemeraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-11.19	757	92.48	AdvoDrainageSys	WMS	0.4	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
6.17	187.28	96.48	AdvoDrainageSys	WMS	0.4	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
5.42	9.32	5.42	Aegion	AEG	4.7	14	6.73	0.02	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12
20.53	116.07	82.21	AerCap	AER	0.9	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
23.24	236.00	102.5	AgroPromvent	AVAV	11.2	10.058	0.64	16.22	7.83	4.55	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
21.96	29.03	18.01	AGN	AGN	0.2	11.156	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-13.98	153.94	96.43	AgilentTechs	A	0.9	21.82	-0.11	-0.11	12.72	47.00	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
5.94	126.75	93.43	AgilentEclines	AEM	1.3	26.121	-0.62	13.84	82.62	26.03	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
5.93	79.45	49.42	AgreeReality	ADC	4.1	42.743	-0.68	13.84	82.62	26.03	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
exch 341.4	243.69	99.88	AgreeReality	ADC	4.1	42.743	-0.68	13.84	82.62	26.03	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
4.24	163.93	99.88	Airbnb	ABNB	0.9	21.82	-0.11	-0.11	12.72	47.00	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-18.06	106.10	67.51	AlkermTech	AKAM	26.78	-0.32	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
43.46	159.50	118.74	AmervWaterWorks	AW	0.4	14.45	0.15	11.05	84.61	71.17	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
19.39	23.20	17	Albertsons	AL	2.83	0.58	0.58	10.14	60.38	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
0.60	101.10	40.48	Alcon	ALC	0.4	38.85	0.63	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-26.84	130.14	87.37	AlkermTech	AKAM	26.78	-0.32	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
32.28	148.43	71.80	AllogTech	ALGN	3.3	181.79	1.78	15.5	137.63	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
5.52	136.10	113.27	Allegation	ALL	1.5	137.63	0.83	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
4.23	66.54	50.01	AlibiEnte	ALBY	0.4	2.2	0.54	0.54	1.21	23.13	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
1.23	213.18	145.18	Allstate	ALL	2.0	139.33	-0.34	10.52	94.74	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
2.58	44.66	29.52	AllyFinancial	ALLY	3.2	27.36	0.10	10.52	94.74	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
1.42	242.52	151.61	AlkermTech	AKAM	26.78	-0.32	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
-11.97	205.70	140.53	AlphabetA	GOOG	0.5	19.166	-0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
14.27	61.26	45.17	Altria	MO	6.8	10.25	0.26	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-4.42	242.52	151.61	AlkermTech	AKAM	26.78	-0.32	12.08	66.85	44.75	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12		
29.19	26.3	1.76	Ambev	ABEV	6.1	2.39	-0.02	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-30.68	31.18	8.37	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
15.5	94.61	71.17	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-4.26	39.17	10.11	AmorSports	AS	98	36.42	0.23	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-3.62	104.10	69.39	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
19.01	18.73	13.13	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
10.32	114.08	85.93	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
0.61	326.27	220.43	AmgenExpress	AMP	1.1	21.298	0.57	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-9.57	150.10	71.73	AmericanFrg	AFG	2.6	13.282	-0.82	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-2.54	41.41	31.68	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
16.94	88.07	69	AIG	AIG	2.1	18.513	0.88	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
18.28	245.36	172.51	AmerTowerREIT	AMT	5.1	56.217	0.88	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
14.62	51.95	30.76	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-1.58	105.35	145.02	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
35.09	94.83	71.80	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-29.42	140.21	158.65	AnalogDevices	ADI	1.7	62.238	0.35	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
107.89	51.11	22.45	AngloGoldAsh	AG	2.2	47.98	-0.14	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
42.18	13.15	6.99	Amgen	AMGN	5.7	16.32	-0.08	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
4.54	22.11	22.59	AnnalyCap	NLY	14.62	19.13	-0.05	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.5					
17.57	18.87	8.9	Arm	ARM	1.7	13.939	0.58	12.72	47.00	28.02	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
28.50	183	111.09	AscendisPharma	ASND	0.2	16.760	0.61	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
0.01	230.50	162.12	Assurant	AI	1.6	196.15	0.79	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	547	0.57	0.57	5.36	623.61	512.12	
-2.12	13.29	13.29	Atlassian	TEAM	2.2	69.95	-0.81	1.24	39.39	25.41	ChemuraEnergy	CHE	0.4	54</						

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Casual-Dining Chains Aim for Comeback

Brands are spending millions of dollars to update their menus and dining rooms

By Heather Haddon

CHICAGO—Sit-down restaurants are fighting to get more Americans into their booths after one of the toughest periods for the sector in years. Brands such as **Cracker Barrel Old Country Store** and **Red Lobster** are spending millions of dollars to update their menus and dining rooms to attract more customers. In the process, they are grappling with how to lure new, younger customers without alienating their most loyal diners.

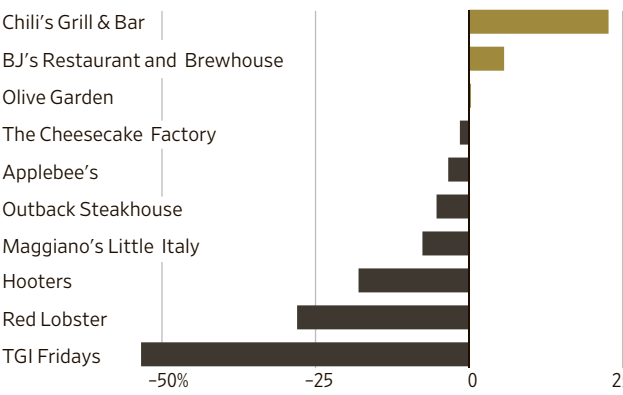
Cracker Barrel, for example, is adding more lighting in restaurants, removing some decor and better organizing its trademark ephemera that covers the walls. In some cases, it is having to explain its decisions to steadfast fans.

“We’re here to take them through it because we want them to love the brand,” Julie Felss Masino, chief executive officer of the Lebanon, Tenn.-based family-dining chain, said Tuesday at The Wall Street Journal Global Food Forum.

U.S. restaurant bankruptcies last year hit the highest level in decades excluding 2020, when the Covid-19 pandemic upended the industry. TGI Fridays, Rubio’s Coastal Grill and Red Lobster were among chains that filed for Chapter 11, closing hundreds of restaurants.

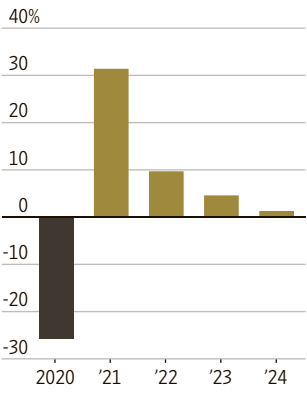
The pace of bankruptcies has slowed this year, with 10 res-

Restaurant traffic through April 2025 for select restaurants, change from a year earlier*



*Traffic could be impacted by store closures †For the top 500 chains Sources: Placer.ai (traffic); Technomic (sales)

Annual change in sales at casual-dining restaurants†



Darden Restaurants Sales Rise, Earnings Decline

Darden Restaurants posted slightly better-than-expected sales while earnings edged down a touch in its latest quarter.

The owner of Olive Garden and other restaurant chains on Friday reported earnings of \$303.8 million, or \$2.58 a share, for the fourth quarter ended May 25, compared with \$308.1 million, or \$2.57 a share, in the prior-year period. Stripping out certain

one-time items, earnings came in at \$2.98 a share. Analysts polled by FactSet expected \$2.96 a share.

Sales rose to \$3.27 billion from \$2.96 billion. Analysts polled by FactSet expected \$3.26 billion.

Orlando, Fla.-based Darden said sales grew thanks to a mix of growing same-restaurant sales, sales from its acquisition of 103 Chuy's Tex Mex restaurants and 25 net new restaurants.

For fiscal 2026, Darden forecast sales growth between 7% and 8%, same-restaurant sales growth between 2% and 3.5% and earnings from continuing operations in the range of \$10.50 a share and \$10.70 a share. Analysts polled by FactSet expected same-restaurant sales growth around 2.7% and earnings from continuing operations around \$10.77 a share.

—Denny Jacob

taurant chains or large operators pursuing Chapter 11 filings through May, according to BankruptcyData.com records.

Still, the shakeout in casual dining continues as brands such as Denny's, Applebee's and Hooters close locations in ef-

forts to improve profitability. Restaurant locations run by the largest casual-dining chains dropped 1.2% last year, the first unit decline since 2020, according to market-research firm Technomic.

Red Lobster emerged from

bankruptcy last September with new leadership and a fresh influx of cash from private-equity firm Fortress Capital.

Chief Executive Damola Adamolekun last fall pledged to fix neglected equipment, redesign

restaurants, freshen up the menu and move away from a loss-making unlimited shrimp deal. Nine months later, he said Red Lobster's comeback remained a work in progress. It has around 520 U.S. locations, down 20% from 2023.

“It’s hard work. I can’t pretend it’s easy,” said Adamolekun, who at 36 years old is one of the youngest CEOs of a major restaurant chain.

Adamolekun said Red Lobster has recovered much of the traffic lost last year when many customers thought the seafood chain had closed for good. Customer sentiment is improving, and the brand is advertising the return of fan favorites such as hush puppies and meals priced at \$20 or less.

But the chain's recovery isn't linear, and Adamolekun said his strategy has evolved. Some entrees, such as flounder, haven't been top sellers but older customers liked them, so he opted to keep them on the menu.

While Adamolekun struck sports partnerships to amp up Red Lobster's cultural relevance, he also has emerged as a pitch man for the brand. His appearance in the chain's new ads drew a bigger response than he expected.

“Haven’t been to Red Lobster in years but I think I am going to make a trip real soon!” one Instagram commenter said about the ad last month. “Let’s go new CEO!”

Cracker Barrel, which has struggled with traffic declines, last year slashed its dividend to plow millions of dollars into initiatives to update the brand. Since joining the chain from Taco Bell in 2023, Felss Masino

has pruned the number of retail goods sold, added restaurant booths and rolled out beer and wine offerings.

Some customers have pushed back, particularly at the curtailed restaurant decor. At the Food Forum on Tuesday, Felss Masino said one Tennessee customer initially recoiled at the remodeling, but later came around.

And though customers can now get a cold beer or mimosa with their meals, she said Cracker Barrel wasn't becoming a bar: “No one is getting drunk at Cracker Barrel.”

Two of casual-dining's top performers—Chili's and Texas Roadhouse—are managing to draw new customers. Both brands have focused on offering high service levels in a fun atmosphere, with good prices.

Gen Z's interest in traditional sit-down restaurants hasn't fallen off, and some younger customers enjoy the nostalgia of dining at chains they grew up with, Technomic said. For vintage brands to win, operators need to place priority on good service over gimmicks, said Robert Byrne, Technomic senior director for consumer research.

“Keep your menu price increases to a minimum,” Byrne said.

Malcolm Lenson, 75, of Vacaville, Calif., said the service was good when he and his wife recently visited a local Red Lobster, but he wasn't as impressed by the value.

“I have no problem paying a premium for sit-down dining, but we expect a decent, not a meh menu, which most chains have,” Lenson said.

Ad Industry Parties In Cannes With AI's Impact as Backdrop

By Katie Deighton

After several years of small experiments with AI and big anxieties over its impact, advertising executives got with the program at this past week's Cannes Lions International Festival of Creativity, the ad industry's annual five-day gathering on the French Riviera.

Almost every company that took over a swanky beach club, hosted guests in a villa or bought its staff \$5,000 festival passes told an enthusiastic story about artificial intelligence. Raging against the machine was firmly out. Any remaining rank-and-file worries about job losses were mostly voiced far from official events.

“We’ve moved beyond the promise and the fear to the practical application,” said Don McGuire, chief marketing officer at chip maker Qualcomm, adding that the company is saving 2,400 hours a month by using an AI agent-building tool called Writer. “People are talking about using it in different contexts. It’s no longer, ‘Well, it could do this, or could do that.’”

Two years ago, at the first Cannes Lions since the debut of ChatGPT announced AI's new potential, ad agency Monks co-founder Wesley ter Haar set up in a small apartment. Cassandra-like, he told visitors that AI was about to upend ad creation

and employment. Executives at other companies in Cannes that year described their trials with the technology but emphasized that only humans can develop the emotional insights that steer ad campaigns.

This time the idea of AI-driven industry transformation was mainstream, even if leaders still expressed confidence about humans' continued role.

“Obviously the world of business, and the world at large, is being profoundly disrupted as we speak, and the impact on jobs is already being felt,” said Marisa Thalberg, the chief customer and marketing officer at Catalyst Brands, the company formed by the merger of Brooks Brothers-owner SPARC Group and JCPenney. “My optimism comes from knowing how much creativity is—and will remain—so fundamentally and uniquely human, even if the ways we harness and express it continue to change.”

Instagram and Facebook owner Meta Platforms used the festival to unveil a host of new AI-based products designed to help advertisers make ads as quickly and simply as possible, feasibly without the need for an agency. Executives at the company repeatedly said the tools weren't designed to replace agencies, however—just to speed up their work and help smaller businesses that can't afford agencies.



Singer Anderson .Paak performs at a concert during the ad industry's annual five-day gathering on the French Riviera.

Marketers in Cannes even put concerns such as President Trump's trade war and tightening consumer budgets on the back burner in favor of talking about AI. “I didn't have one single conversation about tariffs,” said Yannick Bolloré, the chairman and chief executive officer of French advertising holding company Havas.

The guest list-only “café” run by Havas on the grounds of the Mondrian Hotel used AI to turn guests into 3-D characters in a movie conversation about tariffs. The company last year said it would invest 400 million euros, or more than \$429 million at the time, in AI development over the course of four years, a commitment similar to those made by rival holding companies.

Now Bolloré is asking that his staff refer to AI agents as “teammates.”

“Those agents will be fully part of the Havas family,” Bolloré said. “In terms of employees we will find a lot of efficiencies, but our bet is that we will manage more revenue with the same amount of people.”

But reality isn't always close at hand during Cannes, a 13,000-person conference where \$1,355 magnums of Dom Pérignon are regularly ordered to business tables at lunch, and executives' public displays of affection for AI began to wear thin with some.

Lower-ranking attendees joked at post-programming parties that they'd be replaced by their artificial counterparts be-

fore the next festival.

And research published Monday raised some red flags for agencies, most of which have been racing to build up their AI arsenal. Agency trade association the 4As and consulting firm Forrester found that although 75% of agencies are using the technology—up from 61% last year—75% of those using it are also funding it directly without passing on the costs to clients, up from 41% in 2024.

“That is deeply concerning,” said Jay Pattisall, principal analyst at Forrester, who wrote in the report that “agencies are backsliding into antiquated commercial models that led to the commoditization and lack of transparency associated with marketing services.”

The strongest pushback to the AI overload at Cannes came from the celebrities and social-media content creators who now flood Cannes along with traditional ad players and tech companies. Actors Josh Duhamel, Reese Witherspoon, JB Smoove and others touted their own creative companies but also made a case for the employment of Hollywood talent in the ad industry.

Advertising benefits from emotional connections that actors, directors and scriptwriters know how to provide, Smoove said. “We’re talking about mastering the moment,” Smoove said. “You meet somebody that you haven’t seen in years and they tell you a funny joke? AI can’t do that.”

BUSINESS WATCH

KROGER Gocery Giant Raises Its Sales Guidance

Consumers' economic jitters are driving more shoppers to Kroger supermarkets, company executives said.

Rising restaurant prices and concerns over tariffs and the economy are benefiting food retailers, according to Kroger officials, while the company has been stepping up promotions and marketing of its store-brand products.

The Cincinnati-based company raised its same-store sales outlook as a result of the latest quarter's performance, helping send shares up 10% Friday.

Kroger, the biggest U.S. supermarket company by sales, is coming off a rocky period.

Late last year, the chain's attempted \$20 billion takeover of rival grocery company Albertsons was blocked on antitrust grounds, which quickly led to Albertsons suing Kroger over its handling of the deal. In March its longtime CEO, Rodney McMullen, resigned after a board investigation into his personal conduct.

The company said Friday it plans to close 60 underperforming stores over the next 18 months to help profitability. Kroger recorded a \$100 million impairment charge associated with the planned closings.

Still, the grocer wants to recapture market share it lost while it was trying to buy Albertsons. It plans to open about 30 new stores this year across its geographic footprint and more later.



Kroger plans to close 60 underperforming stores.

For the quarter ended in May, Kroger's identical sales, excluding fuel, rose 3.2% from a year earlier. Net income was \$866 million for the quarter, compared with \$947 million a year earlier. For 2025, Kroger

now expects identical sales without fuel to grow between 2.25% and 3.25%, an increase from its prior outlook of growth between 2% and 3%.

—Patrick Thomas and Connor Hart

BAIDU Robotaxi Unit Plans To Expand In Asia

Baidu's Apollo Go could enter the Southeast Asian market as early as this year as autonomous-driving companies race to grow overseas.

The Chinese company's robotaxi unit plans to focus on Singapore and Malaysia in the region, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Baidu's Apollo Go boasts the largest fleet among Chinese robotaxi companies, with more than 1,000 cars globally. While China is its main market, it has recently announced plans to expand in the Middle East.

Baidu didn't immediately respond to a request for comment.

—Jiahui Huang

CARMAX Used-Car Seller's Sales, Profit Rise

CarMax logged higher profit and sales in its latest quarter as tariff uncertainty sparked an uptick in demand for used cars.

The used-car retailer sold nearly 380,000 vehicles across retail and wholesale channels in the three months ended May 31, a 5.8% increase from last year.

CarMax said same-store sales, which account for store openings and closings, increased 8.1% from last year. In the recent quarter, CarMax posted a profit of \$210.4 million, compared with \$152.4 million a year earlier. Revenue rose 6.1% to \$7.55 billion

—Connor Hart

MARKETS & FINANCE

Middle East Conflict Fuels Oil-Price Rally

Major U.S. stock indexes and Treasury yields end week little changed

By DAVID UBERTI AND ANGUS BERWICK

Fears of a spiraling Middle East war put Wall Street in a holding pattern this week, with oil prices grinding higher and choppy stock trading leaving major U.S. indexes little changed.

Brent crude futures, the international pricing benchmark, closed Friday at \$77.01 a barrel, an 11% jump since Israel launched a ferocious air campaign against Iran.

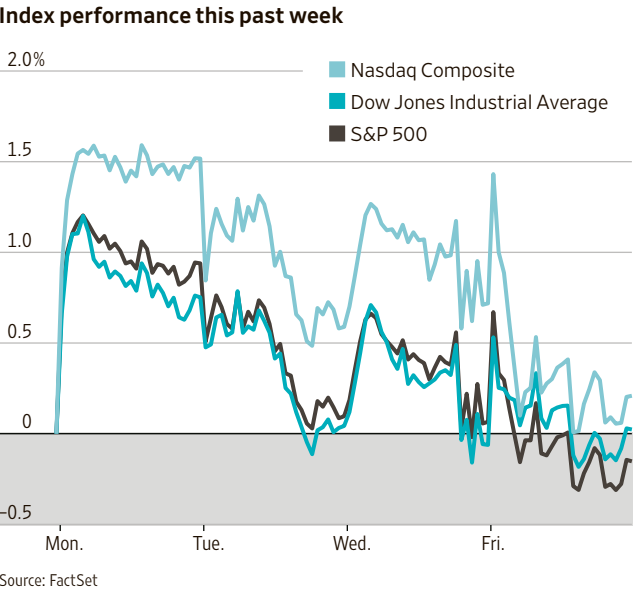
Traders feared a worst-case scenario in which Tehran could shock the global economy by cutting off ship traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, a choke-point for oil and gas supplies.

So far, those worries haven't materialized.

Oil prices cooled Friday after the White House said President Trump would make a decision on whether to strike Iran within two weeks—a duration he often cites when faced with difficult situations. Talks between European and Iranian officials in Geneva failed to break the impasse over Tehran's nuclear program.

While traders awaited clarity from the White House, the Federal Reserve held rates steady this past week, with Chairman Jerome Powell saying the central bank is monitoring energy prices. But he played down the potential for an extended inflationary shock.

The yield on 10-year Treasuries held roughly steady after Fed officials left interest rates unchanged and signaled that they were open to cutting rates in the second half of the year. The 10-year yield settled Friday at 4.374%, according to Tradeweb.



“When there’s turmoil in the Middle East, you may see a spike in energy prices, but [that] tends to come down,” Powell said at a news conference. “The U.S. economy is far

less dependent on foreign oil than it was back in the 1970s.”

On Friday, the Dow Jones Industrial Average ticked higher by 0.1%, or around 35 points. The S&P 500 declined 0.2%,

while the tech-heavy Nasdaq Composite lost 0.5%.

The weekly moves were similarly muted, with the Nasdaq up 0.2%, the Dow roughly flat and the S&P 500 down 0.2%. Energy stocks were the big gainers in the broad index, with the sector adding 1.1%.

Israeli strikes have disrupted Iran's domestic energy infrastructure in recent days. But exports from the country have continued flowing to oil-hungry buyers in China and elsewhere.

“Iran has been directing even more crude into its export facility, preparing to send as much as possible oil to the market while it can,” said DNB Markets analyst Helge André Martinsen. Rystad Energy estimates that Iranian shipments ferried abroad by skyscraper-size tankers appear to be as much as 30% to 40% higher than typical volumes this time of year.

Israel’s continuing strikes and Trump’s two-week window

for U.S. involvement promise to keep oil markets on edge in the coming days.

Elsewhere:

- ◆ **Chip stocks** TSMC, Nvidia and Intel fell Friday after a U.S. official told semiconductor firms he wanted to revoke waivers to access American technology in China.
- ◆ **Kroger shares** surged 10%. Despite mixed quarterly results, the grocery chain raised its same-stores sales outlook and said tariffs hadn't materially affected its business.
- ◆ **Bitcoin prices** tilted below \$104,000.
- ◆ **Gold prices** snapped a two-week streak of gains. Gold for June delivery lost \$63.10 a troy ounce, or 1.8% to \$3,368.10 this week.
- ◆ **Global stocks** were mixed. The Stoxx Europe 600 and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng Index gained Friday, while Japan’s Nikkei fell slightly.

Accenture Bookings Drop, Shares Sink

By DENNY JACOB

Accenture reported a drop in bookings in the latest quarter, prompting investor concern amid a more uncertain relationship with the federal government.

The 6% drop in bookings, a closely watched metric that measures future revenue based on contracts, came as the consulting firm on Friday posted higher sales and profit in the third quarter.

Shares fell nearly 7%, the largest percentage drop since March 2025. The stock, which touched a new 52-week low earlier in the session, was the S&P 500’s worst performer.

Some of the challenges stem

from the expectation that the Trump administration’s cost-cutting focus will hit consulting firms advising governments. Accenture and other firms have already offered billions in cuts in response to administration requests for price concessions.

Accenture executives said they expect a 2% headwind in its federal business in the current quarter, after seeing an immaterial impact in the latest quarter. Chief Executive Julie Sweet said that seven of Accenture’s 13 industries grew at a high single-digit rate or better in the third quarter.

Asked whether the headwind should be seen as the new norm, Sweet said it was

too early to make any assumptions.

Sweet said that executives at many companies it consults with are taking a different approach these days after earlier uncertainty brought on by the tariffs. “Our clients have moved from pause to focus and leapfrog,” Sweet said. “Tech, data and AI are really rewiring organizations working in new ways, being future ready so that no matter where they are on their curve, we’re helping them get to the point where they can use AI.”

To meet the growing changes and adoption of artificial intelligence, Accenture said it was combining several of its services into one business unit,

effective Sept. 1. The company will bring its strategy, consulting, song, technology and operations services into a unit called Reinvention Services. It will be led by Manish Sharma, the company’s current chief executive officer of the Americas.

John Walsh, Accenture’s current global chief operating officer, will become CEO of the Americas, succeeding Sharma. Kate Hogan, the current chief operating officer of the Americas, will become the global COO, succeeding Walsh.

Kate Clifford, currently CHRO of the Americas, will become the global chief leadership and human resources officer, succeeding Angela Beatty, who is leaving Accenture.

Aflac Says Cyberattack Breached Sensitive Files

By COLIN KELLAHER

Aflac has been hit with a cyberattack that may have resulted in the theft of personal data related to the insurer’s U.S. business.

Aflac on Friday said it identified suspicious activity on its U.S. network on June 12 and that it was able to stop the intrusion within hours.

The Columbus, Ga., company said files potentially affected by the cyberattack contain claims information, health information, social-security numbers, and/or other personal information, related to customers, beneficiaries, employees, agents and other individuals in its U.S. business.

Aflac said its review of the potentially affected files is in its early stages, and that it can’t yet determine the total number of affected individuals or the full scope and potential ultimate impact of the breach on the company.

Aflac added that it business

remains operational and that its systems weren’t affected by ransomware.

The company said the cyberattack, in which an unauthorized party used social-engineering tactics to gain access to its network, is the work of a sophisticated cybercrime group and is part of a campaign against the insurance industry.

Hackers stole sensitive information belonging to around 190 million people in a cyberattack on UnitedHealth Group’s Change Healthcare unit last year in a breach the has cost the company more than \$3 billion. Global cyberattacks rose 44% last year, marked by an increasing role of generative artificial intelligence, according to a January report from cyber-threat intelligence provider Check Point Research.

Aflac said it expects to notify regulators about the cyberattack, adding that it plans to offer free credit-monitoring and identity-theft-protection services to those affected.

ADVERTISEMENT

The Marketplace

To advertise: 800-366-3975 or WSJ.com/classifieds

BOATING

38' WAJER FOR SALE

Crafted for both speed and sophistication, the Wajer 38 is the The Ultimate Day Boat or Superyacht Tender. Priced to sell, Bring offers!

Call: (954) 519-3980
sales@moranyachts.com

MORAN YACHT & SHIP

COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

ISLAND FOR SALE

Bahamas Safe: NO TAXES - INCOME or ESTATE

42 Years of owning and enjoying paradise in Abaco Bahamas. Here is a list of what I have built during these 42 years.

PRIVATE Island in Abaco, Bahamas over 200 acres - no debt - same deed as USA

- 1. The complex has 17 bedrooms
- 2. 120 foot yacht like new - Big tenders
- 3. Water, Sewer, Electricity, Generators Can build 60 more houses if you desire
- 4. 6900 Foot airport plus AA, Delta, Others
- 5. No income tax - No estate tax
- 6. Your Private Security - Covid, Bird Flu, Crime, War are controlled by you not them
- 7. EVERYTHING GOES - Respond to email for brochure

No brokers Involved

8. Dock & House for yacht in Lauderdale and The Safe Island & No Tax

privatesafeisland@gmail.com

SECURED PARTY'S SALE AT PUBLIC AUCTION

Sale of Loan Secured by Former Marriott Courtyard Hotel

THURSDAY, JUNE 26, 2025 AT 11:00 AM EASTERN TIME at

Rierner & Braunstein LLP

Time Square Tower, Suite 2506 | Seven Times Square | New York, New York 10036

All right, title and interest of BC2 Beaumont LLC, a Delaware limited liability company, in and to a certain loan arrangement between BC2 Beaumont LLC, as lender, and Dave Raj Brothers LP, a Texas limited partnership, as borrower, in the original principal amount of \$7,250,000, including a Deed of Trust, Security Agreement and Financing Statement with respect to real property located at 2275 Interstate 10 South, Beaumont, Texas.

For Further Information Please Visit www.re-auctions.com

Terms of Sale: \$250,000.00 deposit in certified or bank cashier's check will be required at the time and place of the sale in order to qualify as a bidder. If you wish to bid remotely then the deposit must be wired to the auctioneer prior to bidding. The balance will be due within 30 days at the offices of the Attorney for the Mortgagee: Phillip J Block, Rierner & Braunstein LLP, 71 South Wacker Drive, Suite 3515 | Chicago, Illinois 60606.

Daniel P. McLaughlin & Co. AUCTIONEERS LLC

77 Fourth Avenue, 3rd fl., Waltham, MA 02451
PH: 781-208-0377

BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES

MORTGAGE REIT

8%-9% RETURN

TAX EFFICIENCY

REAL ESTATE SECURED GROWTH / INCOME

SEEKING RIA'S & ACCREDITED INVESTORS

866-700-0600

ALLIANCE MORTGAGE FUND

120 Vantis Dr., Ste. 515 • Aliso Viejo, CA 92655

www.AlliancePortfolio.com

RE Broker • CA DRE • 02064955 Broker License ID

COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

BANKRUPTCY SALE

Offers Being Considered Now

Portfolio of Hospital Properties in Philadelphia MSA

- Crozer Chester-Medical Center
- 283-bed hospital in Upland, PA
- Taylor Hospital
- 107-bed hospital in Ridley Park, PA
- Delaware County Memorial Hospital
- 168 bed hospital in Drexel Hill, PA
- Springfield Hospital
- 39-bed hospital in Springfield, PA

For more info, visit

Keen-ProspectMedicalRealEstate.com

KEEN-SUMMIT CAPITAL PARTNERS LLC

(646) 381-9222 • Keen-Summit.com

NOTICE OF SALE

NOTICE OF PUBLIC SALE OF COLLATERAL

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that in accordance with applicable provisions of the Uniform Commercial Code, as enacted in Illinois and all other applicable jurisdictions ("UCC"), ST. CLOUD CAPITAL PARTNERS III SBIC, LP, as agent ("Secured Party"), intends to offer for sale, at public auction, all right, title, and interest of Michael S. Butler, Michael S. Butler Beneficiary Grantor Trust Dated March 31, 2015, and Michael S. Butler Power of Appointment Trust Under Article III of the Michael S. Butler Beneficiary Grantor Trust Dated March 31, 2015 (collectively, "Debtors") in, under, and to all right, title and interest of the Debtors in and to (a) all capital stock and other equity interest in Life Spine, Inc., a Delaware corporation (the "Company"), representing approximately 50.7% of the common equity interests of the Company, and (b) certain related rights and property relating thereto (collectively, (a) and (b) are the "Collateral"). The public auction will be conducted on July 9, 2025, at 10:00 a.m. (PT), at the offices of Secured Party, 10866 Wilshire Boulevard, Suite 1450, Los Angeles, CA 90024, and by remote auction via telephonic and/or web-based video conferencing. Qualified bidders may attend and participate at the auction. Secured Party reserves the right to cancel the sale or adjourn the sale to a future date at any time at or prior to the sale. Secured Party further reserves the right, at its election, to designate one or more staking horse bidders. The Collateral (i) may be sold in one or more lots as Secured Party may determine, (ii) will be sold "as is, where is," "with all faults" and without any recourse, representation, guarantee, or warranty of any kind, all of which are expressly disclaimed, and (iii) will be sold subject to additional terms of sale. Parties interested in entering a bid must contact Cordell Gee, at 310 475 2700, Ext 108, to receive terms of sale, bidding procedures, and other information, which will be available after execution of a confidentiality agreement. Interested parties who do not contact Cordell Gee and qualify prior to the sale will not be permitted to participate in the auction.

COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

Notice of Disposition of Collateral

Public Auction - UCC Sale

Notice is hereby given that, in accordance with applicable provisions of the Uniform Commercial Code (the "UCC") as enacted in the State of New York, MFI Capital LLC ("Secured Party"), a Delaware limited liability company, will offer for sale (the "Sale"), at public auction, all right, title, and interest of DAJ 1500 Pine Manager LLC ("Pledgor"), a Delaware limited liability company, in and to 100% of the limited liability company membership interests, together with all economic rights and governance rights associated therewith, in and to DAJ 1500 Pine LLC (the "Collateral"). DAJ 1500 Pine LLC is a Delaware limited liability company and the owner of the real property, and improvements thereon, located at 1500 Pine Street, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania 19102 (the "Property"). The Sale shall occur on July 22, 2025 at 10:30 a.m. (ET) at the top of the front steps of the Courthouse of the New York County Supreme Court, located at 60 Centre Street, New York, New York 10007 with an option to participate virtually via the following Zoom meeting link: https://bit.ly/DAJ1500, Meeting ID: 845-1412-0695, Password: 047824, Call-in number: 1-646-931-3860 (US). The sale will be conducted by Matthew D. Mannion of Mannion Auctions, LLC. Parties interested in bidding on the Collateral must contact Secured Party's counsel, Jack Doherty, Esq. of Holland & Knight at (212) 751-3003 or jack.doherty@hklaw.com. Upon execution of a non-disclosure agreement, a copy of the Terms of Sale and additional documentation and information will be made available.

Secured Party, as lender, made a loan (the "Mezzanine Loan") to Pledgor, in the original principal amount of \$250,000.00. In connection with the Mezzanine Loan, Secured Party obtained a first-priority lien on the Collateral pursuant to a certain Pledge and Security Agreement. Secured Party is conducting the Sale as a result of Pledgor's default(s) under the applicable Mezzanine Loan documents. The Mezzanine Loan is subject to a senior loan (the "Senior Loan") and first-priority mortgage on the Property and the obligations and liabilities set forth in the Senior Loan documents. The Collateral is being offered as a single lot, "as-is, where-is", with no express or implied warranties, representations, statements or conditions of any kind made by Secured Party or any person acting for or on behalf of the Secured Party, without any recourse whatsoever to the Secured Party or any other person acting for or on behalf of the Secured Party and each bidder must make its own inquiry regarding the Collateral. The successful bidder shall be responsible for the payment of all transfer taxes, stamp duties and similar taxes incurred in connection with the purchase of the Collateral.

The Secured Party reserves the right to credit bid, set a minimum reserve price, reject all bids and terminate or adjourn the sale to another time, without further notice. All bids (other than credit bids of the Secured Party) must be for cash, and the successful bidder must be prepared to comply with the bidding and closing requirements in the Terms of Sale. None of the Collateral has been registered for sale under any federal or state securities laws, and as such may not be sold or otherwise transferred by Secured Party or a purchaser of any Collateral except in accordance with applicable law.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

THE MARKETPLACE

ADVERTISE TODAY

(800) 366-3975

For more information visit:

wsj.com/classifieds

© 2025 Dow Jones & Company, Inc. All Rights Reserved.

Goldman, BlackRock Provide New Pay Perk

By TED BUNKER

Goldman Sachs and BlackRock are among the first in providing top executives unconnected to alternative investments with a pay perk common in private-equity firms.

Cutting named executive officers into the profits generated by private-markets investments likely will spread to more bank leaders, according to compensation consulting company Johnson Associates and corporate pay analysts at proxy advisory firms.

Banks and other financial institutions are expected to start paying top executives partly with carry, as the portion of profits from fund investments is known, to show their interests are aligned with investors in their private-markets funds, said Bryan Liou, a Johnson Associates managing director. Bankers want investors to know they are “very serious about being players in this market,” Liou said.

Goldman led the industry in paying carry to top executives, Liou said. The Wall Street bank awarded more than \$9 million in carry to five named executive officers this year, including nearly \$2.8 million to David Solomon, its chairman and chief executive, and \$2.9 million to John Waldron, president and chief operating officer.

The payments marked the first time Goldman executives who don’t work in the bank’s alternative-assets operations have been compensated with carried interest.

Asset-management giant BlackRock laid out plans to

pay Larry Fink, its chairman and CEO, partly with carried interest from investments made through its private-markets funds, but didn’t make any performance payouts on that basis this year. BlackRock’s plan for paying Fink partly with carry is also a first, Liou said.

The New York asset manager makes clear in regulatory filings that any carry payout will be based on performance of the underlying funds and isn’t guaranteed.

Both firms cited the growing importance of private markets in their operations and financial results as reasons for paying top executives partly with a portion of profits from private-markets deals. But the move at Goldman also provided more incentives for the most senior executives to stay on board as private-equity firms increasingly seek to recruit bank talent.

Previously, Goldman’s top executives received carry from co-investments they made individually to firm-sponsored funds, according to regulatory filings.

Compensation analysts with ISS-Corporate, an affiliate of Institutional Shareholder Services, and Glass Lewis say such payments have yet to emerge at other major banks. But they say carry will be part of compensation more frequently in the future as more banks and other financial-services companies step up private-markets operations.

So far, such payments have gone to executives closely connected with alternative assets investments.

This form of compensation is expected to spread to more banks.

HEARD^{ON}_{THE} STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

Trying to Dethrone the Birkin? Make Fewer Bags

Chanel has taken a less effective approach to competing with Hermès than The Row

Chanel is discovering that it's hard going toe-to-toe with the **Hermès** Birkin bag. A much smaller American brand, The Row, is becoming a more convincing challenger.

Two of France's most famous luxury brands grew roughly in lockstep from 2018 until a change last year. Chanel is privately owned but recently published annual results showing sales fell 4% in 2024 and operating profit dropped almost a third. Meanwhile, Hermès grew sales 15% last year and operating profit rose 9%.

Chanel doesn't release as many financial details as its publicly traded peer, so it is difficult to know exactly what is going on. Demand for luxury goods has slowed globally. However, Chanel is underperforming its peers. One theory is that the company raised prices too fast on its handbags.

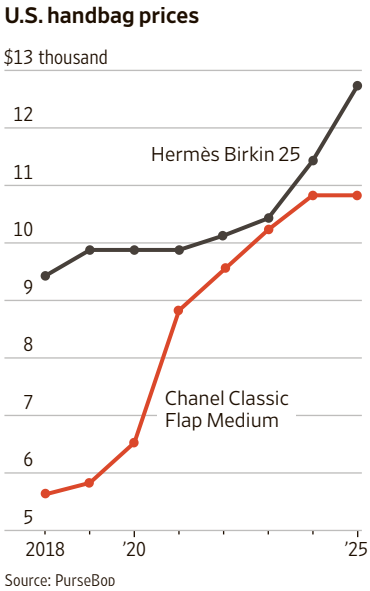
One of the brand's most recognizable products, the quilted classic flap purse, has become emblematic of the extraordinary price increases in luxury goods. American shoppers pay \$10,800 for the bag today, up from \$5,800 in 2019.

Chanel says it had to raise prices because raw materials have become more expensive. But the bag's 86% price increase far outstrips the overall rate of inflation for the period, as well as the average for the wider luxury industry. If Chanel's prices had risen in line with the overall inflation, the bag would cost around \$7,400 today.

Professionals in the luxury-goods industry think that Chanel may be trying to compete directly with Hermès's most popular handbag, the Birkin. Chanel's price



The Chanel quilted flap purse, left, has been trying to mimic the success of the Hermès Birkin bag.



bag recently joined the ranks of luxury products that cost more to buy secondhand than new, including the Birkin, and Rolex and Patek Philippe watches.

At 41% above its \$4,700 retail price, the Margaux's resale premium isn't as large as the Birkin's but shows high demand. Last year, the investment vehicle of the billionaire family behind Chanel took a stake in The Row.

The U.S. brand gave priority to scarcity over price increases to boost demand. The Margaux costs a fifth more today than in 2019, but The Row is making it harder for shoppers to get their hands on it. This looks like a strategy of manufactured scarcity—The Row could increase production, as the Margaux isn't hand-stitched like the Birkin. Instead, it removed an option to be added to a waiting list for the bag and may be restricting access to the bag to its biggest-spending customers.

This scarcity-style approach means sacrificing short-term profits in return for steady demand.

—Carol Ryan

FROM LEFT: EDWARD BERTHELOT/GETTY IMAGES, ERIC HELGAS FOR WSJ

No More Surprises
No More Emergencies
No More Disruptions

Factiva Sentiment Signals

POWERED BY OLIVER WYMAN

An unforeseen corporate credit event can leave your business exposed to risk. Utilizing Factiva's renowned news content collection and cutting edge, AI based models, Dow Jones and Oliver Wyman have partnered on a solution that offers early warning signals of potential corporate risk events that you can add to your own workflow via an API.

Get the critical insights you need, now.

For more information visit dowjones.com/fss or email fss@dowjones.com.

DOW JONES
FACTIVA



LEARN MORE

Hybrids from Hyundai.

The best of both worlds.



With America’s most exciting hybrid lineup, you don’t have to choose. Because with the reliability and efficiency of the Hyundai TUCSON Hybrid, and the style and capability of the SANTA FE Hybrid, you get the best of both worlds.



TUCSON Hybrid Limited AWD and SANTA FE Hybrid Calligraphy AWD models shown with optional features. See dealer for details and vehicle inventory availability. EPA-estimated fuel economy for 2025 TUCSON Hybrid Limited HTRAC AWD shown is 35 City/35 Highway/35 Combined miles per gallon. Fuel economy estimates for other trims and other vehicles vary. All figures are EPA estimates and for comparison purposes only. Actual mileage may vary with options, driving conditions, driving habits and vehicle's condition. Hyundai is a registered trademark of Hyundai Motor Company. All rights reserved. ©2025 Hyundai Motor America.



Family Fitness
Want a great way to bond with your teens? Exercise with them **C3**

REVIEW

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Saturday/Sunday, June 21 - 22, 2025 | **C1**

Lost Girls
When adoption became big business in China **Books C7**



FROM TOP: BRIAN CAHN; ZUMA PRESS; MIKESH GUPTA/AGENCE FRANCE PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

A Titan II ICBM in its silo at the Titan Missile Museum, formerly an operational missile complex in Sahuarita, Ariz.

The Nuclear-Weapons Club Could Get a Lot Bigger

Wars in Ukraine and Iran, and rising doubts about the reliability of the U.S., are making countries around the world wonder if having their own nukes is the key to survival.

By Yaroslav Trofimov

W

hen it came to nuclear weapons, the U.S. had two top priorities in the 1990s. One was to ensure that newly independent Ukraine handed over its vast arsenal to Russia. The other was to prevent North Korea from obtaining its own nukes. The first effort was a success, but today, many regard Ukraine's disarmament as a strategic blunder, leaving it vulnerable to a Russian invasion that has triggered the bloodiest European war in generations. The second attempt was a failure: Pyongyang deftly exploited American reluctance to use military force and became a nuclear-armed state that can challenge global security.

Now, as Israel unleashes its military seeking to prevent what it says could be a similar nuclear breakthrough by Iran, these examples are being carefully studied around the world. Is the lesson that countries facing existential threats need nuclear weapons to survive? Or that pursuing those weapons is too dangerous, encouraging enemies to strike while they still can?

In the past, it was mostly rogue states like Libya, Syria and Iraq that tried to obtain nukes. Today the option is being seriously contemplated by American allies such as South Korea, Japan, Poland, Germany and Turkey, who worry that they can no longer rely on Washington's protection. President Trump has fueled this existential dread by questioning the value of NATO, cutting off military aid to Ukraine and considering a pullback of American forces from South Korea.

Meanwhile, North Korea emerged from isolation to join a formal military alliance with Russia, sending troops to fight on European soil and testing its ballistic missiles on Ukrainian cities. It could do so with impunity because, unlike Tehran's theocracy, Pyongyang's totalitarian regime has a growing arsenal of nuclear



Indian soldiers in the Jammu and Kashmir region on May 20, 2025, during a military clash between Pakistan and India. Both countries possess nuclear weapons.

weapons and doesn't fear being challenged with military force.

"A lot of countries will now be thinking that nuclear weapons are the ticket to sovereignty," said Kurt Volker, a former U.S. ambassador to NATO who served as special envoy for Ukraine in the first Trump administration. "If we don't change our behavior—and I don't expect we will—the world we're going to live in 20 years from now will be a world with lots of nuclear-weapons states."

A Ruthless New World

Nuclear-weapons technology is some 80 years old, and it's within reach of any determined industrialized

nation. Yet the nuclear club has remained small. The five nuclear powers recognized by the 1968 Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)—the U.S., Russia, China, France and the U.K.—are all permanent members of the United Nations Security Council. The other four nuclear powers don't belong to the NPT. India and Pakistan tested nuclear weapons in 1998; North Korea tested its first bomb in 2006. Israel, whose program drew on French assistance in the 1960s, is believed to have at least 90 warheads, but maintains a formal policy of ambiguity about its nuclear status.

The U.S. has long encouraged allied nations to rely on the American nuclear umbrella for protection

Please turn to the next page

Inside

METEOROLOGY AND TECH

The future of weather forecasting is hyperlocal, as new technologies are making it possible to predict conditions on a single city block. **C4**



Back Roads

Traffic jams can be the best part of a road trip, if they make you get off the interstate and explore. **C3**

MY MONDAY MORNING

Cynthia Nixon on the wisdom and benefits of age and the lasting success of 'Sex and the City.' **C14**



WAR IN IRAN

Why calls for Iranians to move now to topple the clerics are misguided. **C5**



REVIEW

Do Countries Now Need Nukes to Survive?

Continued from the prior page

rather than building their own arsenals. Despite all the fears sparked by the Trump administration, American officials insist that security commitments to allies remain iron-clad. “We’re not going anywhere,” said Matthew Whitaker, the U.S. ambassador to NATO, at a conference in Brussels this month. “The United States cannot go alone into this very dangerous world, and so we need our allies. But we need allies that are capable, that are strong as well, and that can join the fight if a fight breaks out.”

Yet those promises sound less convincing in a ruthless global environment where interlocking conflicts continue to expand. “The international order, which we knew for 80 years after World War II, has fallen apart. That international order created a certain predictable environment, including nonproliferation treaties on so many types of weapons,” said Czech Foreign Minister Jan Lipavský. “Clearly, we now see a discussion on nuclear weapons—and Vladimir Putin is to blame for that because he opened this Pandora’s box. He’s challenging borders and so, logically, others are asking: how can we now protect our own borders?”

To France, the decision by President Charles de Gaulle to develop a fully independent nuclear capability in the 1960s, instead of relying on American promises, looks like a stroke of historic genius today. That decision went against American wishes at the time, noted French Defense Minister Sébastien Lecornu. “We have always believed that we cannot delegate our security to others,” he said.

Yet Lecornu noted that Russia’s invasion of Ukraine has also shown that nuclear weapons are no substitute for conventional military strength. “Nuclear deterrence doesn’t solve all your problems. Even though it is a nuclear power, Russia hasn’t been able to succeed in its conventional military operations in Ukraine where, three years later, the once great Russian army is stalled and has yet to conquer four oblasts,” or regions, he said. “This must be food for thought for our South Korean and Japanese friends when it comes to North Korea.”

Ukraine’s Choice

The contrast between Ukraine’s vulnerability and North Korea’s immunity looms large in the deliberations of governments worldwide. When Ukraine became independent in 1991, following the collapse of the Soviet Union, Russia swiftly removed tactical nuclear weapons from Ukrainian soil. But Kyiv retained sole physical custody over some 1,800 strategic warheads, the world’s third largest nuclear arsenal, as well as a fleet of strategic bombers and intercontinental missiles. Ukraine did not have the ability to launch these weapons independently, but officials familiar with the program say the country, where a large part of the Soviet Union’s military industries were located, had enough technical exper-



Above: Kim Jong Un inspects a nuclear material production site in a photo released by North Korea’s official news agency, Jan. 29, 2025. Left: The remains of an Iranian missile that struck northern Israel, June 18. Israel attacked Iran this month to prevent what it says could be a nuclear breakthrough.



civilian nuclear-energy program based on enriching uranium. Israel and the U.S. say that was a cover for its nuclear-weapons ambitions. The program has cost Iran an estimated \$1 trillion, between direct spending and the impact of sanctions. Yet it has turned out to be

Nuclear capability doesn’t come cheap. Obtaining weapons and the means to deliver them, such as missiles, would cost at least several billion dollars, and potentially much more if international sanctions are imposed.

“Everyone wants to be able to fight outside their weight class, which is what being a nuclear power allows,” said Rep. Brian Mast, a Florida Republican who is chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee. Yet many countries that considered going nuclear in the past “stepped back and said, we just simply can’t afford to do that because we would have to put all those other things aside, despite our desire.”

The U.S. and other existing nuclear powers long argued against proliferation on the grounds that a planet with dozens of nuclear-armed states would be inherently much more unstable, even threatening the survival of humanity as a whole. When India and Pakistan clashed in May following a terrorist attack in Indian-controlled Kashmir, “You had a world on edge in a way that would not have otherwise been because they were two nuclear powers that were in direct conflict directly next to one another,” noted Mast.

Yet some argue that the clash ended quickly, and didn’t turn into a full-scale war, precisely because both sides could exercise nuclear deterrence. That’s a lesson for South Korea, which sees its strategic position increasingly endangered by the growth of North Korean military strength.

The expanding range of North Korea’s missiles and the potency of its nuclear arsenal mean that it now has the ability to threaten the U.S. mainland, which could deter future U.S. military action to protect South Korea. That leaves South Korea facing the same dilemma that prompted France to go nuclear, after de Gaulle asked President John F. Kennedy whether the U.S. would risk having New York City destroyed to protect Paris—and failed to obtain a clear-cut answer.

Opinion polls now show that a majority of South Koreans view American promises of security as insufficient, and some three-quarters want the country to acquire its own nuclear weapons. Support for nukes now “is in the middle of the mainstream,” said Eric Ballbach, an expert on Korea at the German Institute for International and Security Affairs in Berlin, noting that backing for a nuclear option has expanded beyond its traditional conservative base to parts of the center-left led by newly elected President Lee Jae-myung.

“Trump is certainly not going to take nuclear risks for allies, that’s just painfully obvious,” said Robert E. Kelly, a professor at Pusan National University in South Korea. He has authored several papers arguing that Seoul should develop an independent nuclear deterrent.

“Nobody believes that South Korea is going to launch a nuclear weapon out of the blue, nobody thinks that if Poland builds a nuclear weapon, they’re going to drop it on Moscow,” Kelly said. “These are democracies, and if they build a nuclear weapon, that’s OK. It’s only the American hubris that convinces us that we are the only ones responsible enough to manage these weapons.”

tise to rewire the warheads and gain full control if it wanted.

“It shouldn’t surprise anybody that the United States wanted to eliminate those weapons, because they were designed, built and deployed to incinerate American cities,” said Steven Pifer, a former U.S. ambassador to Kyiv. Faced with economic collapse and fierce American pressure, Ukraine agreed to transfer its nuclear arsenal to Russia in accordance with the 1994 Budapest Memorandum. In exchange, the U.S., Russia and the U.K. gave “security assurances” to respect Ukraine’s independence and existing borders, commitments that ultimately turned out to be worthless.

A refusal to have put Ukraine on a very different geopolitical trajectory, Pifer noted: “If Ukraine had tried to keep nuclear weapons, it would not have been as ostracized as North Korea. But Ukraine would have had no relationship with NATO and the European Union, and Ukraine might have found out that if it did get to a crisis point with Russia, it was having no support from the West.”

Former President Clinton, in an Irish TV interview in 2023, said he felt “terrible” about having forced Kyiv to give up nukes, suggesting Russia wouldn’t have invaded otherwise.

Lithuania’s Defense Minister Dovilė Šakalienė agreed, saying the West’s reluctance to help Ukraine after the Russian annexation of Crimea in 2014, which violated the Budapest

Memorandum, shows that Kyiv should not have given up its arsenal.

“The message that this sends to other countries is: if you have weapons, don’t abandon them, if you have the ability to produce weapons, produce them. Weapons of all kinds,” she said. “As you see, countries that do have a nuclear weapon, somehow they do not get attacked fiercely...

Saying let’s disarm, let’s be peaceful pigeons—that’s suicidal. Now we understand.”

Now that Ukraine has lost a fifth of its territory to Russia, and faces Putin’s demands to essentially relinquish sovereignty over the rest, many Ukrainians agree that the country made a mistake in the 1990s. They point out that, after initially imposing sanctions, the U.S. eventually acquiesced to India and Pakistan going nuclear. Ukraine might have followed the same path if it had insisted on keeping its nukes.

Some Ukrainian officials have even hinted that the door to pursuing nuclear weapons could be reopened. Retired Gen. Valeriy Zaluzhnyi, Ukraine’s former military chief and current ambassador to London, raised eyebrows in March by saying that Ukraine has become the bulwark of European security even though “for now, it doesn’t possess its own nuclear weapons.” The Ukrainian government says it’s committed to the NPT.

While North Korea pursued a secret nuclear-weapons program primarily based on producing plutonium, Iran—which is a member of the NPT—developed an ostensibly

‘Saying let’s disarm, let’s be peaceful pigeons—that’s suicidal. Now we understand.’

DOVILĖ ŠAKALIENĖ
Lithuanian Defense Minister



Russian ICBM launchers on display in the Victory Day parade in Moscow, May 9, 2025.

FROM TOP: KCH/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES; GIL EUTAIH/REUTERS; MAXIM SHPENOV/SHUTTERSTOCK

The Future of Weather Forecasting Is Hyperlocal

Researchers and companies are tapping into new sources of data to predict conditions in an area as small as a backyard or a city block.



By THOMAS E. WEBER

On a sunny spring afternoon in Virginia Beach, Va., I’m waiting on a package delivery from a big-box retailer. But today, I’m not looking for a truck or the neighborhood postal carrier; I’m watching the sky. I see a small dark dot in the distance, and as it nears the object reveals itself clearly as a quadcopter-style drone. While it hovers nearby, a small box detaches from underneath and is lowered on a thin tether until it touches the ground, with surprising gentleness. The box sports an orange-and-white logo for DroneUp, the startup that’s sending these packages flying through the air.

The technology behind drone delivery has advanced significantly in just a few years, but its future depends in large part on using weather intelligence to ensure safe and efficient flights. Every flight takes off at the whims of the weather, particularly the winds. Gusting air can affect a drone’s stability. Strong headwinds force it to perform the aerial equivalent of swimming upstream, depleting its batteries at a faster clip.

“Weather has a huge impact,” says John Vernon, DroneUp’s chief technology officer. “I would say 25% of our current downtime is due to weather-related issues.”

To bring about a delivery revolution, Vernon and his competitors need a new kind of hyperlocal weather forecast. How hyper is hyperlocal? NOAA’s High-Resolution Rapid Refresh system (HRRR, usually pronounced “hurr”), can zero in on an area of 1.8 miles. Contrast that with the Comprehensive Bespoke Atmospheric Model, or CBAM, developed by Tomorrow.io, a hyperlocal weather startup. Tomorrow.io says the CBAM can be run at resolutions as small as tens of meters, effectively predicting how the weather will differ from one city block to another.

Researchers and companies working on hyperlocal forecasts hope to tap a number of sources beyond traditional satellite and radar data. One is the Internet of Things—the billions of internet-connected devices that gather data, from barometric pressure sensors built into cell phones to webcam video feeds. Across the country, states have been building networks of weather stations called mesonets that can supplement the National Weather Service monitors typically found at airports. LIDAR technology, which can measure wind speed by bouncing lasers off particles in the air, is able to gather information with a small box on the ground instead of a weather tower.

Nearly every kind of weather

forecasting relies on a mix of public and private data sources, but in the hyperlocal realm private companies are growing more prominent, in part because business customers have the most to gain from tailored forecasts. Microsoft, for instance, deploys its machine-learning technologies to refine weather predictions, which it then incorporates into broader cloud-computing products it markets to agriculture companies. Tomorrow.io provides hyperlocal forecasts to major airlines to help guide airport operations.

Personally, I don’t need to coordinate airport de-icing crews or worry about fertilizing crops, but I am interested in the weather in my own backyard. At our family home in upstate New York, the terrain varies from flat meadows and farmland to steep hills and narrow valleys. When you walk, hike, or drive in this area, you see microclimates in action as winds shift around the hills and rain falls in spotty patches. A one-size-fits-all forecast can’t always tell you what will happen when.

I brought hyperlocal forecasting to my backyard in the form of a foot-tall white plastic device that looks

like a cross between a flashlight and a back massager. It’s a Tempest weather station, which feeds its observations first to the Wi-Fi network in my home and then to the internet. A light sensor on top keeps track of sunlight and UV radiation, charting the variations between sunny and cloudy periods. Other sensors measure temperature, barometric pressure and humidity. When falling raindrops strike the domed top of the Tempest, it senses vibrations and estimates the amount of precipitation from the size and frequency of the tap-tap-tap. A miniature solar panel powers the whole thing.

The Tempest sells for \$339, while fancier stations can cost upward of \$1,000. A friend of mine operates a more elaborate station from Davis Instruments; he likes to tinker and connected the device to the internet by hooking it up to an inexpensive minicomputer called a Raspberry Pi. Ambient Weather also makes some popular stations suitable for home use.

After I got my Tempest up and running, I quickly found myself addicted to checking the conditions at our upstate home, even when we weren’t there. The data flows to an

More precise forecasts can help farmers, airports and drone delivery services.

app on my iPhone, and I can get a notification whenever rain begins. One feature I’ve found useful when I’m actually at the house is a lightning-detection alert. Because the Tempest can sense lightning strikes a few dozen miles away, these alerts warn you when thunderstorms are on the way and it’s time to wrap up grilling and get everyone inside.

“We’re focusing on short-term forecasting,” says Buck Lyons, the CEO and cofounder of WeatherFlow-Tempest. He says the business is focused on geographic scales between one and four kilometers, and in some areas even more fine-grained than that. “We’re trying to deliver information to people where there are differences in the weather at that scale, and where they will really benefit from knowing what it’s doing now, what it’s going to do later today, and what it’s going to do tomorrow.”

As hyperlocal forecasting evolves, the challenges of figuring out how to gather that data, apply it effectively, and ensure its quality will only grow. In hopes of gathering more information, the European Space Agency turned to crowdsourcing. Smartphone owners can install an app called CAMALIOT, which works by gathering atmospheric data from the phone’s GPS receiver.

“The water vapor in the air is actually what we can measure,” says Benedikt Soja, project manager for CAMALIOT and a professor at ETH Zurich. Moisture affects the GPS radio signal on its way through the atmosphere: “It slows it down to a certain extent. Also it bends, so there’s some refraction going on,” Soja explains. “This is quite interesting, because we can very precisely measure the water vapor between the satellite and the receiver.”

In less than a year, more than 11,000 CAMALIOT users in 142 countries contributed over 100 billion individual measurements. (If you’re interested and have an Android phone, you can download the app from the Google Play store; if you have an iPhone, you’re out of luck, since the Apple system doesn’t allow apps to access raw GPS signal data.) What Soja and his colleagues really want to figure out is how to turn these massive data sets into something usable. “Recently, with developments in AI and machine learning, this has actually become feasible,” he says.

When I get curious about rain headed to my precise location, I turn to the smartphone app called RadarScope, which uses raw data from the National Weather Service. Stormchasers use it to monitor the formation of thunderstorms and to look for patterns on the radar that can indicate a tornado. RadarScope also helpfully displays the map boundaries for all Weather Service-issued alerts.

My own usage has been more mundane: I was able to impress my family at a New York Mets game by noting the incoming rain on the app and suggesting we find indoor seats. A few minutes later, a heavy shower began and drove thousands of other Citi Field fans inside, dripping wet and searching for spots to wait out the rain delay. We relaxed in our seats, warm and dry.

This article is adapted from Thomas E. Weber’s new book, “Cloud Warriors: Deadly Storms, Climate Chaos—and the Pioneers Creating a Revolution in Weather Forecasting,” published by St. Martin’s Press.

GREG CLARKE

SCIENCE SHORTS

The Sun’s Fiery South Pole Revealed For the First Time

The new images are key to analyzing solar storms that can threaten astronauts.

By ERIC NILER

A SPACECRAFT has captured the first-ever images of the sun’s south pole, a key to understanding the solar magnetic storms that can threaten astronauts with radiation exposure, block communications on Earth and create vivid displays of northern lights.

The new images by the European Space Agency’s Solar Orbiter spacecraft are among several recent observations of the sun’s atmosphere and surface that are helping to improve predictions of how and when space weather will affect Earth, according to Daniel Müller, a physicist at the ESA.

Most of us experience the sun as an unwavering source of heat and light. However, the sun’s surface and surrounding atmosphere are roiled by turbulent forces that create solar winds of charged particles, powerful magnetic events known as coronal mass ejections and flares that erupt from the sun’s surface like tongues of fire.

In one of the strongest events in decades, the sun erupted in a series of solar flares and coronal mass ejections in May 2024 that dis-

turbed the Earth’s magnetic field, sent currents through power grids, overheated some transformers and temporarily thickened the Earth’s atmosphere. Several thousand satellites had to adjust their orbits to avoid the drag caused by the conditions.

The event also disrupted the accuracy of GPS-guided tractors used by U.S. farmers to plant and fertilize their

crops, according to Joseph Westlake, director of the heliophysics division at the National Aeronautics and Space Administration.

The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration issues space weather forecasts to warn power grid operators, satellite internet providers and others who might be affected. “That’s why we need this new data,” Müller said. “The funda-

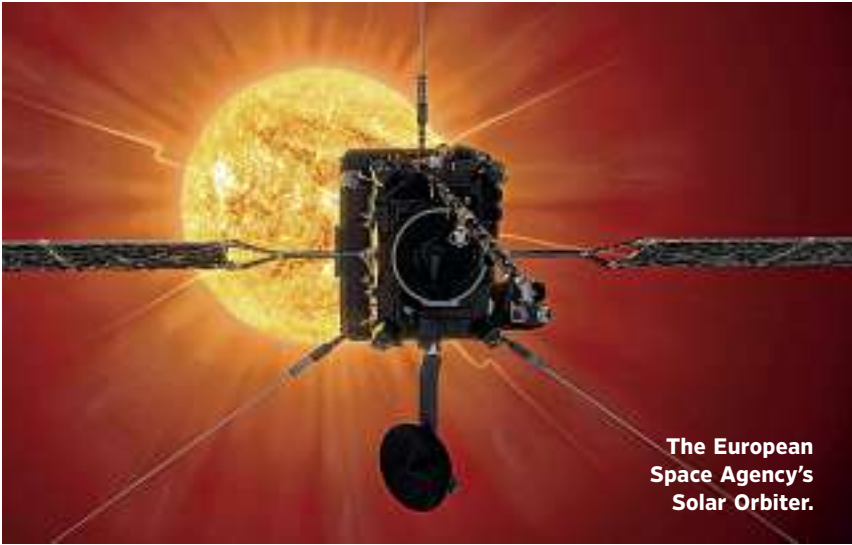
mental science has to be understood first before you can make a good forecast.”

Previous spacecraft have taken images of the sun’s midsection, or equatorial regions, but the Solar Orbiter used the gravitational pull of Venus to slingshot to a higher orbital angle and fly over the sun’s south pole in March.

It is one of three missions that have recently returned new data about the sun. NASA scientists watched a coronal mass ejection take place in June with a new Earth-orbiting observatory called Punch, while an instrument on the International Space Station called Codex captured temperature changes in the sun’s outer atmosphere for the first time.

“We’re in a brand new age of discovery in heliophysics with the multitude of missions that we have up and running,” said NASA’s Westlake. “We’re just in the early days, and it’s really going to be fantastic. These images are just amazing.”

ESA/JAG MEDIALAB



The European Space Agency's Solar Orbiter.

REVIEW



Black smoke billows from the headquarters of Iranian state television in Tehran on June 17.

By Christopher de Bellaigue

It is safe to assume that over the years many Iranians, when passing the Tehran headquarters of the Islamic Republic’s broadcasting company, Sound and Vision, have found themselves muttering, “someone should drop a bomb on this place.” Sound and Vision is notorious for airing the “confessions” of dissidents who are tortured and subsequently executed. Back in the early and mid-2000s, when I was living in Iran as a journalist, and on frequent later visits to the country to see my Iranian wife’s family, its squat silhouette would induce in me a feeling of revulsion.

On June 16 Sound and Vision was hit by an Israeli airstrike during a live broadcast and there were reports of casualties, but the reaction of many Iranians was hardly celebratory. “I feel for the young reporters,” said my mother-in-law, who heard the blast from her apartment 2 miles away, when we got through to her from London. “What did the poor tea-maker do to deserve being bombed?” another friend wondered. Such reactions fly in the face of those who argue that Israel’s war against the Islamic Republic, while primarily aimed at destroying its nuclear and military infrastructure, gives Iranians a golden opportunity to topple the clerics that have controlled the country ever since Shah Muhammad-Reza Pahlavi was ousted in 1979. On June 13 Benjamin Netanyahu urged the “noble people of Iran” to grasp their “freedom” from the “evil and repressive regime.” Four days later Reza Pahlavi, Muhammad-

Calls for Iranians to Rise Up Misunderstand Iran

Decades of meddling have left Iranians wary of foreign ambitions. Many are also too busy running for their lives to take to the streets.

Reza’s 63-year-old son, who lives in the U.S. and is considered by his supporters to be Iran’s rightful monarch, issued a call for a “nationwide rising...now is the time to reclaim Iran.” Yet, in the face of such appeals, and mounting evidence that this embarrassingly one-sided war can only end in defeat for the Islamic Republic, the people of Tehran haven’t rushed into the streets to rebel. Why? For all the detestation that millions of Iranians feel for the Islamic Republic, they have more pressing things to do than launch a revolution at the behest of people sitting comfortably thousands of miles away. While their cities burn, Iranians are on the move—provided they can get hold of gasoline—driving into the hills or toward the Caspian coast, filling summer houses or piling into the homes of generous-hearted strangers, where they hope they will be safe from an Israeli onslaught that has not spared residential buildings and other civilian infrastructure. The exodus from the capital was lent fresh impetus on June 17 when President Trump told “everyone” to “immediately evacuate Tehran,” leading to speculation—yet to be

borne out at this writing—that the U.S. was on the verge of entering the war. Among those who followed the president’s advice was my mother-in-law, who, having initially decided to stay in Tehran, was persuaded by her three children, all foreign residents, to drive with two other women to a summer house in the hills. Thousands more have made it across the country’s land borders with Armenia and Turkey. Those who cannot leave the cities, either because they are too old, too poor, or have nowhere to go, have been filling cans with drinking water and buying gas canisters in anticipation of the moment when basic utilities are taken out and the city goes from being dangerous to lethally uninhabitable. But there is a more fundamental reason for Iranians’ rejection of these calls to rebel. Revolutions that are orchestrated by foreigners are tarnished with dishonor and treachery. This is especially true in Iran—and for precise historical reasons. On

three occasions since the 1920s, the interference of foreign powers has had a detrimental effect on Iran’s politics, leaving behind a deep skepticism toward those foreigners that claim to have Iranians’ best interests at heart and, equally, those Iranians who ally with them. Back in 1921, in the chaotic aftermath of World War I, Britain engineered the rise to power of an ambitious army officer who four years later was crowned Shah Reza Pahlavi—grandfather of his namesake in the U.S. Try as he did, Reza Shah never managed to free himself from the taint of having been brought to power by foreigners. In World War II his pro-German sympathies provoked Britain and Russia to invade. The Russians threatened Tehran with destruction and Reza abdicated in favor of his son Muhammad-Reza. The foreigners didn’t stop there. In 1953, a coup devised by MI6 and carried out by the CIA led to the overthrow of Muhammad Mossa-

War has made Iranians less likely to rebel against their leaders, not more.

degh, the widely popular prime minister, who had nationalized Iran’s (British-run) oil industry and was trying to reduce the Shah’s power. Mossadegh spent the rest of his days under house arrest while Muhammad-Reza went on to become both a despot and a client of the U.S., a dependency that cost him his throne when the viscerally anti-American revolutionaries toppled him in 1979. I know about Iranians’ sensitivity to foreigners better than most. As a Brit living in Tehran, I constantly had to fend off allegations—mostly jocular, but sometimes deadly serious—that even now the British exercised, sometimes on behalf of their American paymasters, a nefarious influence over the country. I was one of two Western journalists to remain in Tehran for the duration of the Green Movement of 2009, when thousands took to the streets to protest a rigged election. At Friday prayers at the peak of the protests, the supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, excoriated the West for stoking the unrest. Turning toward me, a few yards away in the journalists’ tribune, he looked me straight in the eye and said, “and the most evil of them all are the British.” For all the nostalgia that some Iranians feel for the monarchy they rejected in 1979, the present-day Reza Pahlavi will have a credibility problem if he tries to return on the coattails of a foreign enemy that has trashed the country and killed his compatriots. The same is true for a second exiled opposition group, the People’s Mujahedin, whose Iran-based agents are suspected of passing intelligence to Israel that has enabled assassinations and other acts of sabotage against the Islamic Republic. All this is to say that this war has made Iranians less likely to rebel against their leaders, not more, at least in the short term. Just a few weeks ago the country seethed with political agitation, from a nationwide strike of truck drivers over the rising cost of fuel to protests over quotidian government failures such as water shortages, pollution and an odd dearth of natural gas. Millions of women expressed their dissatisfaction by not wearing the mandatory hijab. Given the devastating economic effects of sanctions and the long-expected demise of the 86-year-old Khamenei, many believed that freedom from the tyranny of the clerics was imminent. Now, however, change may come much sooner and more convulsively than expected, but not liberation. A wounded and possibly decapitated regime may still preside over a ruined country. If Khamenei is killed, his successor will likely struggle to unify the regime’s various factions, many of which are armed. It is a grim picture, for both Iranians and the world.

Christopher de Bellaigue is an author and journalist. His latest book is “The Lion House: The Coming of a King,” about Suleyman the Magnificent.

EXHIBIT

Uneasy States

PHOTOGRAPHER Mitch Epstein has described his work as “a celebration of the profound gift of nature...about its tragic destruction and loss, and about American hubris.” His new book “American Nature” (Gallerie d’Italia/Skira) puts that ambivalence on display, as in “Old Growth,” a series of portraits of ancient trees in forests across the country. Logging has shrunk their numbers, but some glories survive—such as a bigleaf maple from Washington’s

Olympic National Park, photographed with a crown of autumn’s yellow leaves, its lower branches draped by smaller plants like the tassels of a giant shawl. Epstein can set a scene of indistinct unease. In a 2004 picture (below right), high-school football players in West Virginia practice under a cloudless, brilliant sky, while white smoke pours from a coal-burning power plant nearby.

In a photo taken in Biloxi, Miss., several weeks after Hurricane Katrina hit (below left), a truck lies upside down next to a tree shorn of leaves but festooned with detritus, including a large mattress. The whole scene glows warmly as the sun begins to set. “It is the tree of life turned upside down,” Epstein said in a 2006 interview, creating “a tension between a kind of beauty and a kind of terror.” —Peter Saenger



Mitch Epstein’s photo ‘Biloxi, Miss.,’ taken after Hurricane Katrina in 2005.



‘Poca High School and Amos Coal Power Plant,’ West Virginia. 2004.

REVIEW

OBITUARIES

MARINA WHITMAN | 1935-2025



An Economist Who Advised Nixon and General Motors

The daughter of a renowned mathematician, she broke glass ceilings and defied stereotypes

By JAMES R. HAGERTY

Marina Whitman was thrilled when President Richard Nixon announced her appointment in January 1972 as one of three members of the Council of Economic Advisers, the first woman to serve in that role. He cited her “intellectual ability of the first magnitude.” Then she was annoyed when much of the reaction focused on her womanhood, not her intellect. The Wall Street Journal reported that Nixon was “trying another surprise weapon in his effort to enliven the economy—feminine charm.” The Journal also described her as comely and noted that she wore “an emerald-green, deeply slit skirt.” Alluding to her Hungarian ancestors, the syndicated columnist Nicholas von Hoffman dubbed her the “Zsa Zsa Gabor of economics.” Whitman, who died May 20 at the age of 90, resisted stereotypes. She dismissed a suggestion that she should accompany Nixon to a supermarket for a photo op capturing their anguish over the high cost of hamburger. At dinner parties, she refused to be herded into another room for lady talk while the men discussed politics and policy. Later, as a director of Procter & Gamble, she objected to ads in which a male authority figure enlightened grinning housewives. Women, she informed P&G executives, were perfectly capable of evaluating detergents and diapers on their own.

A Martian father

Marina von Neumann was born on March 6, 1935, in New York. Her father, John von Neumann,

a Hungarian-born immigrant, was a renowned mathematician who helped develop nuclear weapons during World War II and pioneered both game theory and computer design. In her 2012 memoir, “The Martian’s Daughter,” whose title refers to her father’s otherworldly genius, she recalls his insistence that she excel in all subjects—an A-minus would never do—and chart an ambitious career. Her mother, Mariette Kovesi, also a Hungarian immigrant, pursued an administrative career outside the home but warned young Marina that she would repel suitors if she seemed too brainy. Her parents divorced when she was an infant. Both remarried, leaving her to shuttle between households. In her memoir, Whitman depicts herself as “a plump, pigtailed, bespectacled little egg-head, always at the top of her class in school but notably lacking in social graces.” Eccentricity ran in the family. Her father wore a three-piece suit for almost any occasion, including a tour of the Grand Canyon by mule. Her father’s dinner guests included physicists Edward Teller and Eugene Wigner, the author Arthur Koestler and the economist Oskar Morgenstern. Her father enjoyed ribald limericks and had an “ability to down a remarkable number of martinis without any sign of impairment,” Whitman wrote. Her mother persuaded her to get surgery to reshape her nose before heading off to Radcliffe College, a women’s school affiliated with Harvard. She soon met a Harvard graduate student, Robert Whitman, an aspiring English professor. They married shortly after she graduated, at the top of her class, in 1956. Her father opposed the match, warn-

Alluding to her Hungarian ancestors, a syndicated columnist dubbed her the ‘Zsa Zsa Gabor of economics.’

ing that marrying young would stunt her career. In 68 years of marriage, however, Whitman found that her husband encouraged her career, even when it meant uprooting the family. Robert Whitman died in 2024. Their daughter, Laura M. Whitman, a physician who taught at the Yale School of Medicine, died in 2023. Marina Whitman is survived by her son, Malcolm, a professor of developmental biology at Harvard; two grandchildren; and a half brother, George Kuper.

A Rockefeller Republican

Though wary of mathematics, given her father’s reputation, she earned a master’s degree and a Ph.D. in economics at Columbia University. When her husband became a professor at the University of Pittsburgh, she joined the economics faculty. Her career took a detour to Washington in 1970 when she was hired as a senior staff economist for the Council of Economic Advisers. Whitman, who described herself as a “moderate Republican in the mold of Dwight Eisenhower and Nelson Rockefeller,” favored free trade as well as government support for U.S. companies hurt by surging imports. Despite her concerns about government caps on prices, she took a job on Nixon’s new Price Commission. These price controls ultimately failed to tame inflation: “I could take solace in the fact that my original skepticism about controls had been justified,” she wrote in her memoir. “But I couldn’t escape the reality that for nearly two years I had been the public face of a failed program.” In early 1972, when U.S. trade deficits were bloating and the end of the gold standard left the dollar vulnerable to market gyrations, she joined the Council of Economic Advisers. When she and other U.S. officials visited Tokyo for talks, their Japanese hosts arranged separate entertainment: “While my male colleagues were being plied with drink and entertained by beautiful young women, I was struggling to stay awake through interminable hours of Kabuki theater.” Troubled by revelations from the Watergate hearings, she resigned in 1973—though her resignation letter never mentioned the scandal.

A ‘pushy broad’

Her public profile led to directorships at P&G, Westinghouse Electric and a series of banks whose mergers created today’s JPMorgan Chase. She served on the Harvard board of overseers and the Princeton board of trustees. She was often the only woman on a board. In her memoir, she counseled



Whitman and her family with President Nixon.

female directors to “be a pushy broad and put some spine into whatever board you’re on.” At General Motors, where she arrived in 1979, Whitman found “an ingrown, self-satisfied and self-destructive corporate culture.” She was unsparing about herself, too: “I was a control freak, micromanaging people,” she wrote, adding that she “didn’t have the guts” to slash costs in the public affairs and marketing operations she led. Whitman grew frustrated, then depressed, when her calls to change strategy at GM, in part to counter the rise of Japanese rivals, were ignored. She retired early in 1992 and happily returned to teaching, this time at the University of Michigan. She saw her career as proof that a woman could combine motherhood with demanding work outside the home. She dared think that even her demanding dad, who died in 1957, would have been proud. “My father’s shadow has lifted at last; if we meet again, it will be in sunlight,” she wrote.

FROM TOP: SCOTT C. SODERBERG/MICHIGAN PHOTOGRAPHY; WHITMAN FAMILY

GARY ENGLAND | 1939-2025

A Meteorologist Who Calmed Viewers, Saved Lives

Part broadcaster, part first responder, he brought compassion and cutting-edge science to Tornado Alley.

By CHRIS KORNELIS

WHEN A TORNADO threatened, Gary England would stop to talk to kids. England, a meteorologist, would look straight into the camera with a special message for children who were home alone while their parents were at work. Turn the volume on the TV all the way up, he’d say in his calm, grandfatherly, unmistakably Oklahoma voice. Now, grab your helmet and get to the center of your house. If you’ve got a bathtub, climb inside. Cover yourself in blankets and pillows. You’re going to be all right. In Tornado Alley, a meteorologist is part broadcaster, part first responder. In the four decades that he was the top meteorologist at Oklahoma City’s KWTV, England—who died June 10 at the age of 85—also became a kind of folk hero, the person generations of Oklahomans turned to on some of the scariest days of their lives. A tornado isn’t like a snowstorm

that blankets regions. It picks homes, streets and schools. England knew all of them. When he reported on where a twister was headed, he didn’t just rattle off coordinates on a map or mile markers on a highway. He named the burger joint it was passing, the grocery store it was approaching, the school in its path. More than a calming presence, his coverage and technological innovations were credited with saving lives and changing the way storms are covered. In the early 1980s, he convinced his bosses to invest in a Doppler radar—reportedly the first time the technology was used to warn the public of weather—which increased warning times before storms hit. After a tornado devastated parts of the region in 1999, some survivors painted the sides of their destroyed homes with



Gary England in front of the ‘Big Board’ at KWTV.

messages like: “Thanks Gary England For Getting Us Out Alive.” Gary Alan England was born just outside of Seiling, Okla., on Oct. 3, 1939. Like many of his neighbors, he grew up poor. His father drove a bread truck and the family moved from rental to rental—one with an outhouse connected to a chicken coop. England was popular in school and punched above his height: 5 feet 8 with his cowboy boots on, he was still captain of the high-school football team. His wife, Mary England, said that he was a bit of an “ornery” child.

a disaster, and spent time between tornadoes helping people get ready for the next one. He’d sometimes visit three schools a week, preaching tornado safety while building an audience. Adults regularly approached him who met him as children and became viewers for life. “I can’t imagine how many lives Gary England saved,” said Tulsa-born country star Garth Brooks over email. “In my opinion, how he served the people of the great state of Oklahoma deserves the highest honor the state can bestow. We ALL loved him.”

OKLAHOMA HALL OF FAME



Sad Romance
The tragedy
of Stefan Zweig
C11

BOOKS

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Saturday/Sunday, June 21 - 22, 2025 | **C7**

The Art of Travel
Thirty artists who
went looking for
inspiration C12



BARBARA DEMICK

A MATTER OF POLICY
A child in an orphanage in
Guizhou, China, in 2009.

The Children Who Went Away

How China's restrictive birth policies and a Western demand for adoptions split up families

Daughters of the Bamboo Grove

By Barbara Demick
Random House, 352 pages, \$32

By MAURA ELIZABETH CUNNINGHAM

‘YOU'RE NOT allowed to keep this child," a Family Planning official informed Xiuhua. Another man held her wailing 21-month-old niece, Fangfang, the toddler reaching out for the only mother she had ever known. The group of men had caught Xiuhua off-guard moments earlier when they burst into the house and restrained her while they grabbed Fangfang. A group of neighbors heard the commotion and came running, attempting to assist Xiuhua as she pursued the departing officials, but they couldn't keep up with the car driving away from the village. On that steamy early spring day in 2002, Fangfang disappeared into China's indomitable child-welfare system.

Xiuhua had understood the risk of taking in her niece: Fangfang and her twin sister, Shuangjie, had been born in violation of China's family-planning policy, often called the one-child policy. Their parents, Zanhua and Youdong, were farmers who already had two daughters and couldn't afford the fine that another child—let alone two—would incur. Zanhua had given birth to the twins in secret, then placed Fangfang with her brother and his wife to raise as their own. Shuangjie moved with her parents to Chong-

qing, where they worked as migrant laborers to save money for the exorbitant fines they anticipated. One day, if they earned enough, Zanhua and Youdong hoped to pay the fines, register the girls' births and reunite their family. But before that day arrived, the local Family Planning office had discovered the ruse and seized Fangfang.

Family Planning cadres were not, officially, supposed to take children from their homes as punishment for policy violations. By the early 2000s, however, a thriving overseas adoption industry had become a byproduct of China's planned-birth regime, which the government had created in the late 1970s to help slow population growth while the country focused on economic development. A longstanding preference for sons over daughters led hundreds of thousands of families to abandon female children rather than risk fines or even violence at the hands of powerful Family Planning officials. Orphanages grew crowded, so in 1991 the government passed a new law permitting foreign adoption and watched the program take off.

Barbara Demick movingly traces this history of overseas Chinese adoptions and their ripple effects on both sides of the Pacific in "Daughters of the Bamboo Grove." Other authors have written about the one-child policy, or the experience of adopting a Chinese daughter; Ms. Demick's skill shines through in her synthesis of the two stories.

Throughout the 1990s, foreign parents flocked to China, handing over cash "donations" of \$3,000 to \$5,000 to the orphanages

that housed their new daughters. The money served as a powerful incentive to keep the number of adoptions high, Ms. Demick notes, "but just when it seemed the supply of abandoned baby girls was inexhaustible, it wasn't." Demographic changes and economic growth meant people were having fewer children and could more readily afford excess-birth fines.

Foreign parents flocked to China, giving cash 'donations' to the orphanages that housed their new daughters.

Both human-trafficking networks and Family Planning officials stepped in to ensure that the country could meet the foreign demand for Chinese daughters, kidnapping children and delivering them to orphanages.

"To make the babies legally adoptable," Ms. Demick explains, "they had to be transformed into orphans." Bureaucrats fabricated new backstories for the girls. They satisfied a legal requirement that the government search for the children's birth families by publishing tiny "Seeking Family" notices in obscure newspapers with small circulations. Parents such as Zanhua and Youdong, who had basic educations but few resources, had almost no chance of finding the babies taken from them.

Fangfang spent six months in an orphanage before a Christian couple from Texas arrived to adopt her. Renamed Esther, she flew to the U.S. with her new parents and older sister (also a Chinese adoptee) and started a new life, unaware of the couple from Hunan province that desperately hoped to get her back one day.

Rumors and scattered reports of government baby-trafficking circulated in Chinese media in the early 2000s, when Ms. Demick was the Beijing bureau chief for the Los Angeles Times. In pursuing one of these leads she met Zanhua and wrote an article about then 9-year-old Shuangjie's disappeared twin sister. The article attracted attention among communities of adoptive parents in the U.S. who were struggling with the implications of their own adoptions: "the possibility that their children had been kidnapped felt like a question mark over their moral right to custody." Although the vast majority—perhaps 90%—of the girls had been abandoned, articles such as Ms. Demick's forced adoptive parents to confront uncomfortable questions about the birth families left behind in China.

The story of Shuangjie's missing twin intrigued Ms. Demick, who knew enough details about Fangfang's kidnapping to embark on a search. She found an article written by Marsha, Esther's mother, and soon Ms. Demick faced her own moral quandary: Should she inform Zanhua and Youdong that she had located their long-lost Fangfang? Should she tell Marsha that Esther

Please turn to page C8

Eloquence Against Slavery

Charles Sumner

By Zaakir Tameez
Holt, 640 pages, \$38.99

By AMANDA BRICKELL BELLOWS

AMONG THE leaders of the Civil War era, figures such as Abraham Lincoln, Frederick Douglass and Harriet Tubman stand tall. Charles Sumner, the abolitionist and senator, was their contemporary—yet many Americans today associate his name with a single historical moment: when Preston Brooks, the representative from South Carolina, viciously beat him with a cane on the floor of the Senate Chamber in 1856.

Sumner deserves to be remembered for much more than being the victim of

Brooks's assault, argues Zaakir Tameez in his engrossing biography "Charles Sumner: The Conscience of a Nation." Mr. Tameez, a scholar of antitrust and constitutional law, has written an excellent book about the courageous Massachusetts senator, whom the author calls "the most famous civil rights leader of the nineteenth century." A physically and intellectually imposing figure whose heart "bled for abolition, racial justice, and constitutional democracy," Sumner pushed U.S. presidents and Senate colleagues alike to end slavery before the Civil War and to secure black rights during Reconstruction.

Mr. Tameez's monograph joins Stephen Puleo's "The Great Abolitionist" (2024) as the only two biographies of Sumner to have been published since David Herbert Donald's "Charles Sumner and the Rights of Man" (1970). The excision of some repetitious material could have reduced the protracted length of Mr. Tameez's book, but "Charles Sumner" is nonetheless an engaging account. Drawing from hundreds of letters, articles and speeches, Mr. Tameez has created a remarkable portrait of a complex man who faced

many personal challenges. Depression stalked Sumner throughout his life, but his desire for racial justice gave him a sense of purpose and a will to live. As a young man, he struggled with his sexuality, partaking in "romantic friendships" with married men—including Samuel Gridley Howe, the abolitionist and physician, and Henry Wadsworth

In the divided Senate of the 1850s, Sumner was among the most passionate abolitionists.

Longfellow, the poet—and failing to find happiness with Alice Hooper, who abandoned him after mere months of matrimony. Heart disease afflicted Sumner in his older age, causing painful episodes of angina that sapped his strength and impeded his ability to work.

Sumner's unwavering commitment to uplifting African-Americans was informed by his childhood on the North

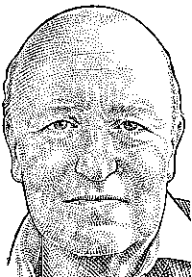
Please turn to page C8



'THANK GOD THAT I LIVE TO ENJOY THIS DAY' A lithograph depicting Charles Sumner speaking in Boston's Faneuil Hall in 1862.

BOOKS

‘He wanted to cry quietly but not for himself: for the words, so beautiful and sad, like music.’ —JAMES JOYCE



FIVE BEST ON CLASSICAL MUSIC IN FICTION

Tim Page

The author of the memoir ‘Parallel Play’



SCORE KEEPER Detail of a 1742 portrait of Jacopo Puccini by Giovanni Domenico Lombardi.

The Dead

By James Joyce (1914)

The books of James Joyce burst with music. There are Irish ballads, popular songs of his time, and tenor arias such as “M’appari” from Flotow’s opera “Martha,” which was once as familiar as the best-known melodies of Verdi and Puccini. Perhaps Joyce’s most immediately affecting writing about music is in “The Dead,” the last (and longest) tale in his book of stories, “Dubliners.” Inspired by warm memories of Epiphany celebrations with Joyce’s great aunts, it is a mingling of past and present, a meditation on aging and mortality, and the power of a simple song—“The Lass of Aughrim,” heard from another room. “The Dead” is a simple story—a gathering of people who have known each other for many years and suddenly realize that they have all grown old. Romantic secrets are shared, much too late to do anything about them, and the hapless hero, Gabriel Conroy, learns that his wife has spent much of their married life mourning an old love. It is the music of the language in “The Dead” that keeps us coming back to it. Joyce’s writing, as his countryman Samuel Beckett put it, “is not about something; it is that something itself.”

Swann’s Way

By Marcel Proust (1913)

“Music is feeling, then, not sound,” Wallace Stevens wrote in his early poem “Peter Quince at the Clavier,” published in 1915. It is unlikely that Marcel Proust knew of this work but it sums up much of the French author’s “In Search of Lost Time,” a set of seven autobiographical novels published between 1913 and 1927. A fragment of a violin sonata by Proust’s fictional composer Vinteuil is cherished by Charles Swann, a central character. Swann associates the music with the days of his early love for Odette, a former courtesan who

seduces and ultimately marries him. “It had immediately proposed to him particular sensual pleasures which he had never imagined before hearing it, which he felt could be introduced to him by nothing else, and he had experienced for it something like an unfamiliar love,” Proust’s narrator says in “Swann’s Way,” the first volume of the series. There has been much discussion of what real-life composition might have inspired Vinteuil’s fictional piece. But no matter: Proust is clearly interested in the feeling here, not the sound.

The Song of the Lark

By Willa Cather (1915)

While much of Willa Cather’s early journalism dealt with music and musicians, she had a particular love of opera. Thea Kronborg, the heroine of “The Song of the Lark,” is often described as a portrait of the Wagnerian soprano Olive Fremstad. Like Cather, Fremstad came of age in a sparsely populated Midwestern town and made herself one of the great figures of her day, simply because she would not have it otherwise. Cather interviewed Fremstad and remained fascinated by her. However, one senses that the real Thea is Cather herself, with her unsparing determination to master an art that nobody would have expected from her. “Artistic growth is, more than it is anything else, a refining of the sense of truthfulness,” the novel’s narrator reflects. “The stupid believe that to be truthful is easy; only the artist, the great artist, knows how difficult it is.”

Point Counter Point

By Aldous Huxley (1928)

The early novels of Aldous Huxley deserve rediscovery. At his best, in books such as “Crome Yellow” (1921) and “Antic Hay” (1923), he was as funny as Evelyn

Waugh and almost as mean-spirited. Huxley’s later works—including his most famous, the dystopian “Brave New World” (1932)—have merits but sardonic wit is not among them. Huxley conceived “Point Counter Point” as what he called “the musicalization of fiction.” His narrator commands: “Meditate on Beethoven” —and then reflects on the similarities between composing music and writing a book: “A novelist modulates by reduplicating situations and characters. He shows several people falling in love, or dying, or praying in different ways—dissimilars solving the same problem.” The book is also a send-up of London intellectual life in the 1920s, with characters based on D.H. Lawrence, Katherine Mansfield, Lady Ottoline Morrell and Nancy Cunard. You will never listen to Beethoven’s Quartet in A minor in quite the same way after reading “Point Counter Point.”

Jean-Christophe

By Romain Rolland (1904-12)

Romain Rolland’s “Jean-Christophe” is based very loosely on the life of Beethoven, from birth to death. This 1,000-page collection of 10 short novels, published over several years, may best be appreciated by relatively young readers. I found an old Modern Library edition in a second-hand bookstore during my last year of college and was enraptured by its swooning romanticism—its succession of passionate friendships, love affairs, triumphs and failures—and pushed it on all my friends. About 20 years later, bringing a copy along to read on a flight was a less happy affair. I jumped from page to page, chapter to chapter and finally from book to book. It was now simply too much. “Oh, the sweetness of that voice . . . the light of the enchanted world conjured up by the reading of the divine poets! Goethe, Schiller, Shakespeare, springs of strength, of sorrow, and of love!” Still, give this book to a young music lover at a susceptible age and it may be remembered for life.

Who Was Charles Sumner?

Continued from page C7

Slope of Boston’s Beacon Hill, where he was born, in 1811, in a predominantly black community. Mr. Tameez describes Sumner’s birthplace as “featuring gaslit lamps, steep cobblestone roads, and redbrick sidewalks”; these distinctive elements didn’t emerge until years later, but Beacon Hill at the turn of the 19th century was exceptional in other ways. Approximately 1,000 free African-Americans lived there and helped produce a “bubbling movement of Black abolitionism,” Mr. Tameez tells us, making the neighborhood “a beacon of hope” at a time when slavery was still legal in many states.

By the time Sumner reached adolescence, he displayed a powerful intellect. After graduating from the Boston Latin School, he matriculated at Harvard College, where he threw himself into debating, reading literature and memorizing long classical texts. At the age of 20, he entered Harvard’s law school and became, according to a peer, “the best scholar in the school.” Sumner opened his private practice in 1834 but discovered he was better suited to the study of law than the reading of contracts and arguing before juries. A trip to the nation’s capital that year opened his mind to the possibility of working in government; a jaunt to Europe in 1837 broadened his worldview. Over the years that followed, Sumner became active in Boston politics, aligned with abolitionists, and helped establish the Free Soil Party before his election to the U.S. Senate in 1851.

Sumner was at the height of his powers during the 1850s and ‘60s as a ferocious opponent of slavery. Mr. Tameez highlights the senator’s most influential speeches and actions, showing readers that Sumner was a leader in the fight to emancipate the nation’s four million enslaved African-Americans. What was notable in his approach, Mr. Tameez aptly observes, was Sumner’s belief that the Constitution was inclined “toward liberty.” Sumner “marshaled impressive evidence from the Constitution’s text, animating principles, and original understanding to illustrate its antislavery character,” Mr. Tameez contends. He tells us that Sumner argued in 1852 that the Slave Trade Clause was “a compromise, not a sanction, of the slave trade” and that although African-Americans were enslaved within individual states, they were “free nationally.” Sumner urged Americans to resist the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, decried the violence in Kansas in 1856 and condemned slaveholding senators in a powerful speech that infuriated Congressman Brooks, who assaulted Sumner with his cane in response.

When the Civil War broke out, Sumner quickly identified its cause. In a November 1861 speech at the Cooper Union in New York, he asserted that “all must see—and nobody can deny—that Slavery is the ruling idea of this rebellion.” To that end, he urged Lincoln to issue a proclamation liberating enslaved African-Americans but was initially rebuffed. By the fall of 1862, however, Lincoln had changed his mind. A delighted Sumner advised Lincoln on the text of the draft proclamation and later received his signing pen as a gift.

Even before the war ended, it was clear to Sumner that African-Americans’ fight for equal rights was only beginning. In the spring of 1864, he maintained that the phrase “equality before the law” ought to be included in the future 13th Amendment. During the early days of Reconstruction, Sumner advocated for the enfranchisement of freedmen so that there would be “no exclusion of any kind, civil or political, founded on color”; thus the promises of the Founding Fathers, he insisted, would be fulfilled. He voted to ratify the 14th Amendment but, surprisingly, abstained from voting on the 15th Amendment because, according to Mr. Tameez, Sumner thought that “Congress was implicitly acknowledging that political discrimination based on race had been constitutionally allowed beforehand,” which “offended his sensibilities about human rights constitutionalism.”

For Sumner, legislation was the most effective mechanism for achieving equal rights. He fought to pass the Civil Rights Act quite literally until his last breath, begging colleagues not to let it fail as he lay dying from a heart attack in 1874.

“Charles Sumner” is a moving portrayal of a courageous, long-overlooked American who, in the words of one contemporary, “stood in the vanguard of Freedom.”

Ms. Bellows is a historian and the author of “The Explorers: A New History of America in Ten Expeditions.”

China’s Missing Daughters

Continued from page C7

had been kidnapped, not abandoned? “I had heedlessly barreled ahead,” Ms. Demick admits, “without giving enough thought to the next step or the implications for very real people.” She attempted to make contact with Marsha and her family, who rebuffed Ms. Demick’s advances.

Years passed. Ms. Demick moved to New York, where she was living in early 2017 when a Facebook message arrived from Esther’s adoptive brother. Marsha was ready to talk, and Esther wanted to get in touch with the sister she had lost.



REUNITED Shuangjie and Esther in 2019 in Hunan, China.

Slowly, Ms. Demick became the go-between who connected Esther and Shuangjie as they hesitantly exchanged messages and then broached the possibility of meeting face-to-face. The second half of “Daughters of the Bamboo Grove” recounts the remarkable story of the twins’ reunion, made possible by the presence of an interpreter but awkward by the girls’ long separation. Ms. Demick accompanied Esther and her

American family to the village where she was born, watching as Esther navigated the complicated experience of meeting her birth family and considering the course her life might have taken if the kidnapping had not occurred.

In the face of a looming demographic crisis, the Chinese government ended its family-planning policies in January 2016, then closed the country to foreign

adoptions in 2024. During the three decades when adoptions were permitted, more than 160,000 children were taken overseas. For years, it seemed that their previous lives and families in China were completely shut off from them, with no original records of their births or verifiable accounts of how they came to the orphanages. “There was a finality to these adoptions unlike almost any others in the world,” Ms. Demick says. That is no longer the case. The availability of inexpensive commercial DNA services has enabled reunions of birth parents and their children and connected separated siblings. As Esther and Shuangjie, Marsha, Zanhua and Youdong know, these stories are anything but final.

Ms. Cunningham is a historian and writer in Ann Arbor, Mich., and a co-author of the third edition of “China in the 21st Century: What Everyone Needs to Know.”

BOOKS

‘It is best that you do not try to write a history, but only to look back upon your own experiences.’ —GAO XINGJIAN



UPRISING Tibetans surrender to Chinese troops in front of the Dalai Lama’s Potala Palace in Lhasa, in 1959.

Mountains of Cruelty



FICTION
SAM SACKS

CENSORED IN CHINA, Tsering Döndrup’s vivid and excoriating “**The Red Wind Howls**” (Columbia, 320 pages, \$25) recounts the decadeslong Communist clampdown in Amdo, a multiethnic region of north-eastern Tibet roughly the size of France. The story begins in the late 1950s, immediately after the civilian massacres perpetrated by the People’s Liberation Army during what

has come to be known as the Amdo uprising but which the characters in this novel call simply the Harrowing Day. It ends with the death of Mao Zedong in 1976, by which time Tibetan society has not been transformed so much as nearly eliminated.

Mr. Döndrup, who writes in Tibetan, divides the novel into two parts. The first follows the 10-year sentence being served by the lama Alak Drong at a brutal re-education camp alongside other so-called class enemies from the clans of nomadic Tibetan Buddhists. The second part chronicles the fate of the camp’s survivors during the Cultural Revolution (1966-1976), when all traditional customs are violently proscribed and the people are brought to starvation by the government requirement that they plant crops that cannot grow in Amdo’s mountainous altitude.

In an acid-etched translation by Christopher Peacock, the whole book is memorable, but it is the first section that makes “The Red Wind Howls” a contemporary world-literature classic. With the vigorous anger and precise detail that calls to mind Varlam Shalamov’s remembrances of life in the Siberian Gulag, Mr. Döndrup depicts the horrors of the Chinese prison

camp: the struggle sessions, the culture of “backstabbing and informing,” the ritualized torture and the many other daily punishments and deprivations that turn even the strongest prisoners into mindless “labor machines.”

As in all totalitarian regimes, the rules imposed by the party cadres are Kafkaesque in their absurdity. For instance, suicide is commonplace among the prisoners, but because it is outlawed in Buddhism the nomads succumb to it far less. This fact is marshaled as evidence of their lingering religious faith, and for the crime of not killing themselves they are re-educated even more harshly.

Lest the novel be taken for anti-Chinese propaganda, it should be said that the portrayal of the Tibetans is far from idealized. Mr. Döndrup’s “The Handsome Monk and Other Stories” (2019) satirized the corruption of the monastic order and here Alak Drong is a spoiled and callow religious ruler who earns our sympathy only due to the torments he endures.

But if the novel is undeluded about human frailty, it is respectful of Buddhist teachings, which hold that “death and impermanence are matters of a moment.” Karma is a bitter theme, at least as it applies to political power. Some Tibetans seize the main chance by embracing Communism. Zealous to prove their loyalty, they tend to be the cruellest party officials. But in time they are inevitably denounced and destroyed and replaced by some more eager collaborator. The wheel turns and no one escapes it.

The Chinese writer Yu Hua’s “**City of Fiction**” (Europa, 432 pages, \$28) is set during China’s Warlord Era, a chaotic period in the 1910s and ‘20s when the country was ruled by regional strongmen with private militias. In an unfussy translation by Todd Foley, the novel

centers on Lin Xiangfu, who appears with his infant daughter in the town of Xizhen in search of his runaway wife. Rescued by the villagers from a snowstorm, he decides to stay. There he plies his trade as a woodworker and becomes a respected figure in the community. But Xizhen is targeted by bandits led by a particularly wicked specimen called One-Ax Zhang. The

THIS WEEK

The Red Wind Howls

By Tsering Döndrup

City of Fiction

By Yu Hua

Hunter

By Shuang Xuetao

bulk of “City of Fiction” relates the desperate struggle Lin Xiangfu and his neighbors wage against the bloodthirsty gang.

Mr. Yu is a writer of melodramas par excellence. His most famous work is the historical saga “To Live” (1993), which recounts the downfall and gradual redemption of a landowner’s prodigal son from the Chinese Civil War in the 1930s and ‘40s through the upheavals of collectivization and the Cultural Revolution. The novel foregrounds its operatic personal tragedies over its political critiques, which helped it get past the Communist Party’s censors. (In contrast, Zhang Yimou’s gorgeous and perhaps less historically fuzzy 1994 film adaptation was banned.)

“City of Fiction,” though baggier, possesses many of the qualities of “To Live”: It features an errant but doggedly heroic protagonist, a lot of

admirably humble village folk, crude humor, natural disasters, heartbreak and hopeful consolations. With the addition of sword fights and gruesome violence, you have a book that reads like a 19th-century serial or *feuilleton*—a tale of adventure, romance and good versus evil.

The writer Shuang Xuetao is from the north-eastern Chinese city Shenyang, a onetime industrial hub that collapsed in the 1990s after the country shifted from a planned economy to one based on marketization, causing factories to move south. Mr. Shuang’s fiction about his hometown is credited with kick-starting a movement of rust-belt realism known as the Dongbei Renaissance. His story collection “**Hunter**” (Granta, 256 pages, \$18.99) still has plenty of gritty urban ennui, but it also now incorporates elements of magic realism and fantasy.

The fusion is at its uncanny best in “Heart,” in which a young man riding with his dying father in the back of an ambulance passes into a bizarre highway limbo between life and death. The Hitchcockian title story concerns an actor cast to play a sharpshooter in a film whose disciplined preparations transform his ordinary surroundings into someplace malign and dangerous. Such eerie artistic projections are frequent. A blocked science-fiction author in “Premonition” meets the sort of alien he might dream up; a sociopathic killer in “Up at Night” seems to materialize from the psyche of a crime writer.

Though there’s nothing new in the coupling of the mundane and the fantastic—see, for example, everything by Haruki Murakami—these stories feel fresh and invigorating, and Jeremy Tiang’s translation is noticeably good. At age 41—extremely young in writer years—Mr. Shuang is imaginative and versatile, someone who will be worth keeping up with.

Deception Takes No Holidays

Don’t Let Him In

By Lisa Jewell
Atria, 368 pages, \$29.99

Murder Takes a Vacation

By Laura Lippman
William Morrow, 272 pages, \$30

By ANNA MUNDOW

MIDWAY through Lisa Jewell’s “Don’t Let Him In,” two friends, Martha and Grace, meet for lunch. When Martha describes how attentive her previously errant boyfriend has become, Grace is relieved but still skeptical. “I thought it was going to end up that he was one of those blokes you read about,” she admits. “The ones who marry loads of women and lie to everyone and steal all their money.” That fairly sums up the deceptions at the core of this subtly layered British thriller, but it’s not the whole story. For the crimes perpetrated here, including murder, are part of a larger mosaic, one that depicts the intersecting lives of three female characters so vividly that we feel, at times, more like voyeurs than readers. Their intimate thoughts become as familiar to us as their occasionally messy households. The dishes piled in the sink, the morning scramble, the sudden silence of an emptied house: Ms. Jewell captures

these moments, as she does the doubts and fears of the residents.

One such is Ash (short for Aisling), a young woman who “feels the thud and canter of time running by as her early twenties bleed into her late twenties and thirty appears heavy on the horizon.” She’s still reeling from the death of her father—who was pushed under a train by an apparently deranged stranger—when her mother, Nina, welcomes handsome Nick Radcliffe into their seaside home. Nick claims to have known Ash’s father, but she is wary of the charmer with “neat cuticles and defined muscles and a brand-new haircut.” Ash wonders: “Why has this man never been married?” The reader knows that he is married (a fact revealed at the outset), and much more, because alternating chapters of the novel are narrated by this consummate liar. We see the world both as it is, therefore, and through his eyes. We see the world both as it is and through his eyes. “They are my puppets now in so many ways,” Nick gloats—with a touch of melodrama—when he begins spying on Nina’s family, “and I am their master.”

As Nick’s deceptions multiply, we fear for his victims—chief among them Tara, a successful businesswoman who almost outwits him, and Martha, the sweet-natured florist who might have been his salvation—and brace ourselves for the unmasking of a con artist who remains defiant to the last. “You all wanted me,” he silently protests when finally cornered. “You all had gaping voids in your lives. . . . I did not force one of you to choose me.” By then, Ash has uncovered the truth, if not the bodies, though Ms. Jewell shocks us with one final twist. Over the course of more than 20 novels, she has perfected such denouements. The

enduring appeal of her fiction, however, resides not in its cleverness, but in the atmosphere of intimate unease that Ms. Jewell—like her forebear Ruth Rendell—so expertly creates.

Laura Lippman’s “Murder Takes a Vacation” sets an unlikely sleuth afloat in unfamiliar luxury. “Mrs. Blossom



had never been upgraded in her life,” we learn of the lottery winner and Baltimore native who sets out for a river cruise through France. Her first name is Muriel but she has embraced the universal use of her surname, in part because every time she hears it, it is as if her dead husband “lived again for a nanosecond.” Many readers will have met Mrs. Blossom before, working alongside private detective Tess Monaghan in a series of Baltimore-set mysteries by Ms. Lippman, but this is Mrs. Blossom’s first solo adventure. It will take her into the sinister world of antiquities smuggling and jewel theft, but it begins with romance.

Elevated to business class on the flight to London, this ample widow (“Her grandchildren kept telling her that the word *fat* was okay now”) is cosseted by a charming, silver-haired seatmate named Allan. When Mrs. Blossom is delayed overnight in the British capital, Allan surprises her with

rous reveries. An oddly intense young man named Danny attaches himself to our heroine, arousing her suspicions. Is he perhaps a gigolo or a crook? Cruising down the Seine, Mrs. Blossom encounters him repeatedly. She also becomes intrigued by a rich brother and sister on board who appear to be hiding something. Or is Mrs. Blossom imagining things? “Not everyone had her talent for fantasy,” she admits, “a talent that had seen her through her often lonely childhood, comforted her in widowhood”—and that has some-

Alarm bells ring at the appearance of a charmer with ‘neat cuticles and defined muscles and a brand-new haircut.’

times been the cause of trouble. But she is soon diverted, not only by her traveling companion, Elinor, an aging flirt wonderfully drawn by Ms. Lippman, but also by an apparently random attempted theft and clumsy assault. Mrs. Blossom, however, knows better than to ignore her instincts.

“You’re nobody’s fool,” Mrs. Blossom recalls being told by her employer and friend Tess, “but you do tend to think the best of people.” After Mrs. Blossom’s lottery bonanza, Tess warns, it’s a mindset she may have to leave behind. In “Murder Takes a Vacation,” this resilient widow proves she has what it takes to confront both gold diggers and killers in a plot that has the charm of a summertime caper.

Ms. Mundow is a writer in Massachusetts.

BOOKS

‘I belong nowhere, and everywhere am a stranger, a guest at best.’ —STEFAN ZWEIG

Writing as the Shadows Fell

In the Future of Yesterday
By Rüdiger Görner
Haus, 480 pages, \$34.95

By DOMINIC GREEN

STEFAN ZWEIG was probably the world’s most famous living Austrian before the rise of Adolf Hitler. Among the most widely translated authors of the 1920s and ’30s, Zweig specialized in novels of doomed romance whose titles sound like prompts for a Freudian case study (“Fear,” “Compulsion,” “Confusion”) and biographies that insert the speculations of psychoanalysis into the shell of heroic lives (“Montaigne,” “Balzac,” “Amerigo”). In his 1934 biography of Erasmus, Zweig presents the Dutch humanist as a European without borders, a moderate in an age of fanatics. Erasmus, Zweig writes, is a “brilliant star” who was once widely read but whose works now sit “undisturbed upon the shelves of libraries.” The English title “Erasmus of Rotterdam” masks the German original’s admission that Zweig saw Erasmus as a study in failure: “Triumph und Tragik des Erasmus von Rotterdam.”

Hitler forced Zweig to flee to England in 1934. Six years later, despairing at the destruction of Europe and fearing that Britain would not hold out, he and his second wife, Lotte, went to the U.S., and then to Brazil. They died by suicide there in 1942, shortly after Zweig had mailed his publisher the manuscript of “The World of Yesterday,” his memoir of life in Habsburg Vienna before 1914. Zweig’s triumph is that he reclaimed the city he loved and had lost to Hitler. His tragedy is that he had to do so in the first place.

Rüdiger Görner’s “In the Future of Yesterday: A Life of Stefan Zweig” is an elegant and compassionate look at the contrasts, aspirations and disasters of its subject’s age. Its message resounds loudly in our own time, when, as Robert D. Kaplan observes in “Waste Land,” published this year, the breakdown of the American-led global system resembles the fate of the Weimar Republic.

Zweig was born in Vienna in 1881. His parents, a textile manufacturer and a banker’s daughter, were assimilated Jews. A child of what he called “the world of security,” Zweig felt no need to convert to Christianity. He viewed Jewishness much as his emperor preferred his polyglot subjects—exotic but useful, respectfully distant, necessarily apolitical. Zweig could afford to write poetry and novellas; visit Paris, London and Rome; and cultivate complex erotic entanglements while less wealthy contemporaries scraped by as freelancers. He traveled through life first-class, unaware that his “strong cosmopolitan feeling,” as he termed it, was a luxury.



DOOMED ROMANTIC Stefan Zweig in Ossining, N.Y., in 1941.

At the outbreak of World War I, Zweig caught the patriotic fever. He volunteered, failed the physical and was assigned to the military archives. In a 1918 essay he declared for “defeatism.” Mr. Görner, following Zweig’s biographical preference for “decisive moments,” identifies this statement as the emergence of Zweig’s public persona. More decisive moments ensued. The Habsburg Empire collapsed in defeat and a truncated Austrian state arose. In 1920 Zweig married his prewar lover, Friderike von Winternitz, who had two daughters from an earlier marriage. He moved his family into a splendid baroque villa in Salzburg, but he remained restless and remote.

In the decisive moments of Zweig’s fiction, fatal tragedy emerges when inexorable social forces thwart the

imperatives of desire. The “authenticity and immediacy” of these stories, Mr. Görner writes, tempt us to read Zweig autobiographically. So does their resemblance to his biographies, which analyze the need for heroism and the rush to disaster.

In “The Struggle With the Daemon,” his 1925 biographical survey of Friedrich Hölderlin, Heinrich von Kleist and Friedrich Nietzsche, Zweig defined the daemon as the inner ferment that drives an “otherwise quiet Being towards excessiveness, ecstasy, self-expression and self-destruction.” Hölderlin, Kleist and Nietzsche, according to Zweig, were “three demonic characters, the only ones in Germany who did not pact with society, the nation, and their period in history, and therefore were destroyed.”

There is something of Zweig in Hölderlin’s rhythmic drive and formal control; in Kleist’s emotional restlessness; and in Nietzsche’s ideal of life as art. In Friderike’s assessment, Zweig’s management of literary effects was the only consistent thing about him. He was, she told her husband in 1930, “closed as regards your own persona.” His written work represented “only a third” of his personality, she noted, and “nobody has figured out its essence for the interpretation of the other two thirds.” Mr. Görner detects hints of daemonic exhibitionism and bisexuality, and a promising diary entry from 1912 records that “the cards of the perversion were put more openly than ever on the table” before Friderike, but Zweig’s editing of messy lives included his own.

The 1920s were a blur of grand hotels, literary meetings and efforts to reconstruct a European identity. While Zweig’s diary recorded “critical and war-like” times, his political statements suggest naiveté and fear of conflict. As early as 1923, he had warned the French writer Romain Rolland that Germany was a “hotbed of war” and “political moronism.” Having striven to build transnational alliances against fascism, he played down the Nazis’ success in the 1930 elections as “perhaps unwise but, in principle, a natural and by all means welcome revolt of the young against high politics.” In a public letter, his protégé Klaus Mann indicted Zweig’s “normally delightful sympathy for anything youthful” as a denial of reality.

Zweig wrote for a cosmopolitan Europe and wore his Jewish identity lightly.

By 1931, Mr. Görner writes, Zweig was in the “crisis mode” that ended in suicide. The rise of fascism aside, he turned 50 that year. Pining for his youth, he was irritated by the “calious impertinence” of his stepdaughters, who were now in their 20s. Friderike called him “unmanly” and complained about his “inner discrepancies.” Zweig began an affair with his young secretary, Lotte Altmann. His life increasingly resembled a Zweig novel, perhaps to be called “Ideals,” perhaps “Vanity.”

“Do not deceive yourself,” Joseph Roth told Zweig after Hitler took power in 1933. “Hell reigns.” Roth was Zweig’s literary antipode. Born poor in present-day Ukraine, at the wrong end of the empire, Roth served in the army and then traveled third-class through Europe in the 1920s. He saw disaster coming and had the foresight to drink himself to death in 1939. “One day your conscience won’t be able to stand it any longer, and you will try and flee your own powerlessness,” Roth had predicted in 1936. Zweig took his own life six years later.

C.K. Scott Moncrieff found an English title for Marcel Proust’s novel of pre-1914 Paris in a Shakespearean sonnet: “Remembrance of Things Past.” The motif for Zweig’s life might be the lines from “Henry IV, Pt. 2” that he took as the motto of his Marie Antoinette biography: “There is a history in all men’s lives, / Figuring the nature of the times deceased.” Mr. Görner figures Zweig’s tragic times with the wisdom of historical hindsight and extracts the triumph of art from the shadow of its decease.

Mr. Green is a Journal contributor and a fellow of the Royal Historical Society.

They All Met Up Downtown

Everything Is Now
By J. Hoberman
Verso, 464 pages, \$34.95

IN THE ASTONISHING “Everything Is Now: The 1960s New York Avant-Garde—Primal Happenings, Underground Movies, Radical Pop,” J. Hoberman assumes the roles of Google Earth satellite, Leica Rangefinder and time machine. The subject is, admittedly, more modest than a planet, but more elusive than a comet: An eruption of art that occurred over the course of a decade within an area of 20 square blocks in downtown Manhattan. What Mr. Hoberman has rendered is a blueprint to an explosion, the schematic to a zeitgeist.

The characters wandering through the portraitist’s uber-Breughelian picture—sometimes drunkenly, often beatifically—include predictable personalities (Ornette Coleman, Bob Dylan, Allen Ginsberg, Yoko Ono, Andy Warhol); second-tier celebrities and first-class provocateurs (the mad visionary Barbara Rubin, the archivist Harry Smith, the musician LaMonte Young); and some whom Mr. Hoberman regularly cited as essentials during his 40-odd years as a film and culture

critic at the Village Voice, among them the filmmaker-academic Ken Jacobs, the filmmaker-impresario Jonas Mekas, the video artist Nam June Paik and the singular Jack Smith. (How does Mr. Hoberman know that Smith’s unhinged landmark 1963 film, “Flaming Creatures,” was shot on “the leaky, tar-paper roof of the Windsor Theater at 412 Grand Street”? He wrote a book on it. But still.)

While many film critics (and readers) of a certain age fetishized the New Yorker’s Pauline Kael, a younger contingent found their critical mentor in Mr. Hoberman, whose interest was (and is) not only film but the intersection of movies, politics, literature and social movements. This is less a work of criticism than history, journalism, detective work and interrogation. Many of the people described have died, but the more obscure among the living often provide the best stories.

Each chapter opens with a forecast (“In which strobe lights proliferate as, conquering St. Mark’s Place, Multi-Media goes Pop. Warhol and Dylan create their masterpieces. Jimi Hendrix wows MacDougal Street and Sun Ra settles in the East Village, where Timothy Leary puts on a show.”). The author then mischievously connects his stories about a future being born to literary legacies of an inescapable past. This is a unique book for a critic, the criticism being implicit in the chronicle. Mr. Hoberman describes it as “a memoir, although not mine.” Which might have been the title, it explains so much.

SHORTCUTS: ECCENTRICS
By JOHN ANDERSON



SKETCHY Robert Crumb, ca. 2010.

His Comics Were a Real Trip

Crumb
By Dan Nadel
Scribner, 480 pages, \$35

AS DAN NADEL tells us in the highly entertaining, affectionate and insightful “Crumb: A Cartoonist’s Life,” his misanthropic subject created work that seemed to be directly channeled—some would say drained—from an overflowing wellspring of sexual fixations, fatalistic worldviews and a contempt for both conformity and nonconformity. We learn of the many traumas that formed Robert Crumb as an artist: a tyrannical father, a weird childhood and the suicide of the brother who was his chief artistic inspiration and influence. It was artistic genius, and no small amount of chance, that lifted R. Crumb out of what seemed destined to be a purgatorial existence.

Mr. Nadel has—as Terry Zwigoff had in his landmark documentary “Crumb” (1994)—a cooperative subject. The author’s response to the unhinged quality of Mr. Crumb’s art (and life) is a straightforward, sober account that lacks nothing in wit but knows what separated the artist

from the rest of the world of ’60s underground comics. “He was doing things other guys had wanted to do all their lives,” Manuel “Spain” Rodriguez, a contemporary of Mr. Crumb, tells Mr. Nadel. This led a number of fellow artists to go through “a deep, personal crisis. Some thought about quitting cartooning forever. Others tried to commit suicide.”

Mr. Nadel also makes clear his subject’s various influences (including George Herriman’s “Krazy Kat,” Winsor McCay’s “Little Nemo in Slumberland” and Walt Disney’s “Donald Duck”); his tampering with the cartoon frame; his ability to tell a story within the traditional panels of a comic strip; his foregrounding of random figures; his respect for an art form he was violating at every turn. And seeing things that others might prefer to ignore: One of Mr. Crumb’s more notorious efforts, the x-rated “Joe Blow,” Mr. Nadel writes, “stands out for Robert’s commitment to telling the story with the same matter-of-fact beats as a ‘Little Lulu’ comic book” while, at the same time, transgressing wildly.

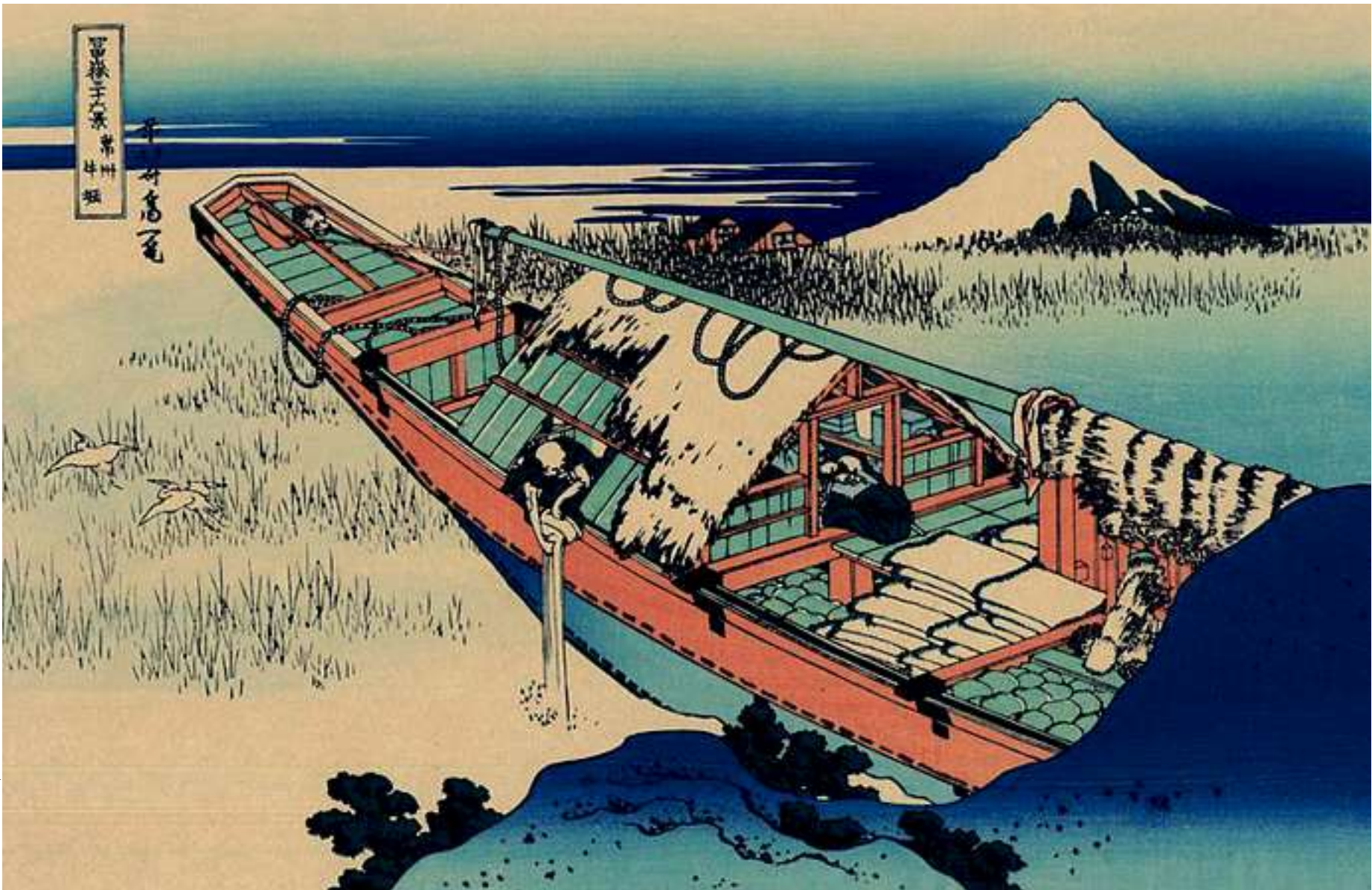
Little Lulu never saw anything like Joe Blow. Amid the generous sampling of photos and art included in “Crumb,” we don’t get the whole “Joe Blow” picture either, but some may find it reassuring that many of Mr. Crumb’s transgressions continue to be outrageous.

Mr. Anderson is the Journal’s television critic.

BOOKS

‘When I am 110, everything I do, be it a dot or a line, will be alive. I beg those who live as long as I to see if I do not keep my word.’ —HOKUSAI

The Art of Being Where You Are



PICTURES FROM HISTORY/GETTY IMAGES

SENECA, THAT CRABBY Roman Stoic, once chided a disciple for believing travel could dispel his gloom: “You ask why such flight does not help you? It is because you flee along with yourself.” The masters in Travis Elborough’s jaunty “**Artists’ Journeys That Shaped Our World**” (**White Lion**, 224 pages, \$18.99) prove otherwise. In his tidy book, Mr. Elborough, a visiting lecturer at the University of Westminster, includes 30 artists whose reasons for traveling are as varied as their destinations. Katsushika Hokusai (1760-1849) orbited Mount Fuji’s sacred summit for years, painting the peak and the people living beneath it from dozens of locales. In works such as “Ushibori in Hitachi Province” (ca. 1830-33, above), the mountain looms over its subjects like a watchful god. Hokusai was so moved by the sights he witnessed on his travels that he changed his name to Gakyō Rōjin Manji:

“The Old Man Crazy to Paint.” Equally mad about painting was Gustav Klimt (1862-1918), whose nocturnal wanderings around Austria’s Lake Attersee led locals to dub him the *Waldschrat* (“forest demon”). The destination inspired his most innovative landscapes, in which nature devours a castle, the Schloss Kammer. For the Flemish painter Alexander Keirincx (1600-52), British castles proved a muse after King Charles I commissioned him to paint the royal residences in Scotland and Yorkshire. Keirincx showed the countryside surrounding these stony manors bathed in a pastoral light—a vision that stoked the popular image of the British landscape as a mythic ideal and helped create the very British genre of house portraiture. This was the landscape, however, that David Hockney (1937-) sought to escape when he decamped for California in 1964, trading rainy York-

shire for eternal summer in Los Angeles, where he would discover the motif of shimmering swimming pools that became his trademark. Isamu Noguchi (1904-88) made a globe-trotting odyssey in pursuit of the lover who’d dumped him. Did he win her back? No. But he did see the ancient sculpture of four continents, whose influence greatly enlivened his work. Berthe Morisot’s (1841-95) travels brought happier romantic tidings: In Normandy, she cultivated her plein-air technique as well as a relationship with Eugène Manet. The two were engaged while painting side by side. They honeymooned on Britain’s Isle of Wight, which Morisot declared “the prettiest place for painting.” Mr. Elborough’s book makes a breezy companion to any summer wanderings.

—Luke Lyman

How Your Workout Works

Stronger
By Michael Joseph Gross
Dutton, 480 pages, \$35

On Muscle
By Bonnie Tsui
Algonquin, 256 pages, \$29

By MICHAEL P.H. STANLEY

WHEN doctors talk to patients about exercise, Michael Joseph Gross writes, “they rarely say much more than ‘take a walk’—though telling most patients to take a walk is as useless, and to frail older patients it can be as dangerous, as it would be to hand them prescriptions that said only, ‘take a drug.’” In “Stronger: The Untold Story of Muscle in Our Lives,” Mr. Gross writes on physical culture—“the multitude of practices by which people pursue health, strength, endurance, beauty, and athletic victory”—at the intersection of the biomedical and social sciences; he colorfully traces a historical tug-of-war between athletic trainers and bodybuilders, on the one end, and medical doctors, on the other. Mr. Gross, a former journalist and the author of “Starstruck: When a Fan Gets Close to Fame,” looks back to the classical philosophical debates—from ancient Olympic rituals to the Enlightenment’s mind-body problem—to show how, in many ways, a fledgling medical profession was slow to grasp the science behind “bodily knowledge,” lagging behind its older rival, athleticism, in competition for command over the public’s idea of a healthy physique. The mind-body problem, for instance, “is nonsense,” Mr. Gross claims, “because muscle stops working and fades out of existence without constant interaction with the neurological

system. Mind and muscle are not enemies. They’re the best of friends.” The author explains the push and pull of muscles, the tension and release that drives bodies forward and can hold us back if not effectively trained. He cites recent scientific discoveries that have identified the ways—long intuitively known by those who are physically active—that exercise produces neurological benefits: “The brain’s posterior cingulate cortex, the seat of empathy, grows larger when people do weightlifting exercise,” we are told, while “the hippocampus, the part of the brain responsible for memory, grows larger when people do aerobic exercise.” The book connects physiology not only to philosophy but also philology. We learn, for instance, that around 700 B.C. one of the earliest gatherings at Olympia sought to bridge the human and the divine by means of a footrace. Runners competed to offer a sacrifice to Zeus. “The distance between altars,” we are told—roughly 200 modern meters—

Weight-lifting makes parts of the brain, such as the posterior cingulate cortex, grow larger.

“was called a *stade*. The race across that distance was the *stadion*,” and the victor “won for everyone.” To push back against the notion “that femininity and muscular strength” are “somehow incompatible,” the author looks to the example of Jan Todd, the former female bodybuilder and “world’s strongest woman,” according to Sports Illustrated in 1977. “As a woman,” Ms. Todd has said, “if you feel physically stronger, you’re going to be less afraid, more willing to try new things, and have more of a sense—I think—of yourself as a whole person.” Pointing out that few women ever realize their full potential strength, Mr. Gross reminds us that, “considered in proportion to their body weight,” women can increase their leg strength “almost exactly as much as men.” But the author isn’t promoting any gender agenda other than longevity and vitality

for the longer-living sex. It’s not about having a perfect body and a perfect soul; it’s about having a sound body to support a sound mind. “Stronger” occasionally veers into overstatement and misconception, as when Mr. Gross suggests that there are no medical specialists that focus on muscles. (There are several, such as neuromuscular subspecialists, physiatrists and sports-medicine doctors.) But

duces “On Muscle” as a collection of “stories about the stuff that moves us and why it matters.” The book fits squarely into the physical culture of bodybuilding and seeks to redefine the superficial, commercially construed cosmetic paradigm of sculpted grotesques as a moderated model of sustainable, almost conservative, self-care: a finding in one’s firmness what reaffirms one’s character.

religious mores. Today muscular Christianity has been largely replaced by muscular intellectualism, which places on its pedestal a rugged individualism for the supposedly self-made person—in health and in wealth. “All man can do is to move things, and his muscular contraction is his sole means thereto,” said the Nobel Prize-winning neurophysiologist Charles Sherrington, referred to by



BETTMANN/GETTY IMAGES

for the most part the book succeeds in gently asserting the necessity of moderate weight training for all. Bonnie Tsui’s “On Muscle” contains a similar cast of personalities and experts, and covers a number of the same themes. But rather than proffering the wisdom of the ancients, she asks how her past experiences with strength training resonate with her present concern: “Am I fit or what?” This existential conundrum, originally asked by her father—at first cheekily, then seriously—has been internalized by Ms. Tsui, whose previous books include “Why We Swim.” She intro-

“I’ve been doing a lot of push-ups,” Ms. Tsui writes, “and thinking about what it means to do them. Lately, I’ve come to understand that what I learned from my father was not just to lift heavy things, but to lift myself.” It’s not about being fit, it’s about finding the right fit. Mr. Gross’s popular-science meditation and Ms. Tsui’s medicalized memoir are part of a new equilibrium in physical culture: muscular intellectualism. In the 19th century, muscular Christianity viewed the human body as something no longer to be forsaken for spiritual concerns but to be deployed as an engine of war in the service of

both Mr. Gross and Ms. Tsui. Both authors point out that as free agents, our decisions are accomplished through action. The gracefully formed stories in these two books wield enough explanatory heft to stretch readers’ minds about their bodies without becoming technical how-to-get-swole manuals. To exercise our will in this world for what’s good about “the good life,” we will need a new kind of strength grounded in an age-old approach found in these books.

Dr. Stanley is a neurologist at Tufts Medical Center.

PLAY

NEWS QUIZ DANIEL AKST

From this week's Wall Street Journal

1. Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem was taken to a hospital by ambulance—for what reason?

- A. Dehydration
- B. Influenza
- C. Appendicitis
- D. Allergic reaction

2. Israel and Iran remained at war. Which city is home to the world's largest Iranian diaspora, a group including many Jews?

- A. London
- B. Paris
- C. New York
- D. Los Angeles

3. The Supreme Court ruled that states could restrict gender-transition treatment for minors. Where did the case arise?

- A. Pennsylvania
- B. Tennessee
- C. Texas
- D. Wyoming

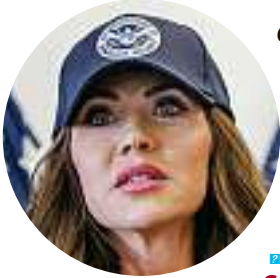
4. The date of Social Security's potential insolvency crept a year closer. What's the new due date for going broke?

- A. 2054
- B. 2044
- C. 2034
- D. 2026

5. Police arrested a suspect in the shootings of two state lawmakers and their spouses—in which state?

- A. Iowa
- B. Wisconsin
- C. Minnesota
- D. Illinois

Answers are listed below the crossword solutions at right.



6. Canada is gathering world leaders to a summit in a province considering a divorce from Canada. Which one is that?

- A. Alberta
- B. Manitoba
- C. British Columbia
- D. Saskatchewan

7. The Senate passed the Genius Act, aimed at regulating what?

- A. Individuals of high intelligence
- B. Genetic engineering
- C. Stablecoins
- D. Equine facility financing

8. What surprising treatment is gaining in popularity for autism?

- A. Cannabis
- B. Choline
- C. Creatine
- D. Chromium

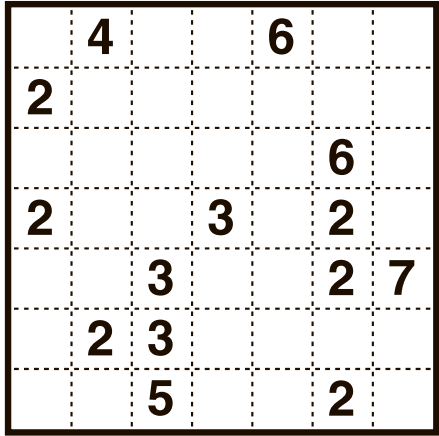
9. Jeanie Buss and her family will sell the Los Angeles Lakers for a record \$10 billion to Mark Walter, a part owner of what?

- A. The Los Angeles Clippers
- B. The Los Angeles Dodgers
- C. The Los Angeles Kings
- D. The Los Angeles Times



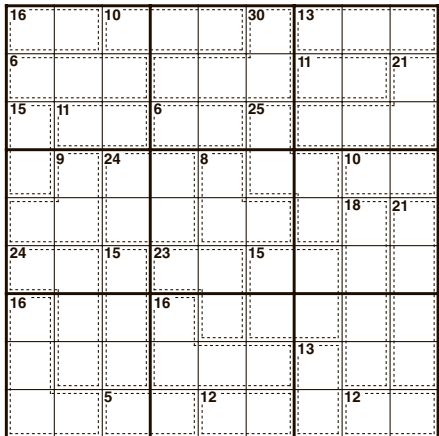
NUMBER PUZZLES

Cell Blocks



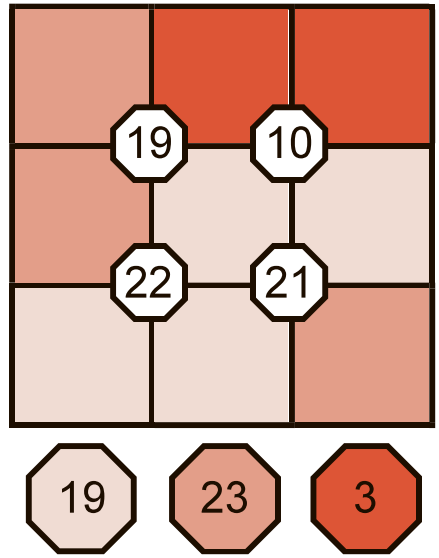
Divide the grid into square or rectangular blocks, each containing one digit only. Every block must contain the number of cells indicated by the digit inside it.

Killer Sudoku Level 3



As with standard Sudoku, fill the grid so that every column, every row and every 3x3 box contains the digits 1 to 9. Each set of cells joined by dotted lines must add up to the target number in its top-left corner. Within each set of cells joined by dotted lines, a digit cannot be repeated.

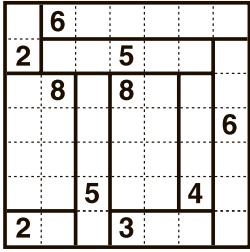
Suko



Place the numbers 1 to 9 in the spaces so that the number in each circle is equal to the sum of the four surrounding spaces, and each color total is correct.

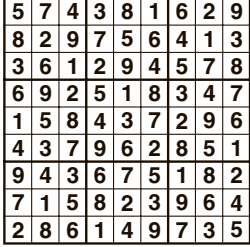
SOLUTIONS TO LAST WEEK'S PUZZLES

Cell Blocks

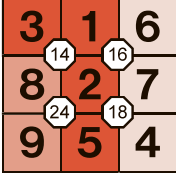


For previous weeks' puzzles, and to discuss strategies with other solvers, go to [WSJ.com/puzzles](https://www.wsj.com/puzzles).

Killer Sudoku Level 2



Suko



Hopeless House Hunt

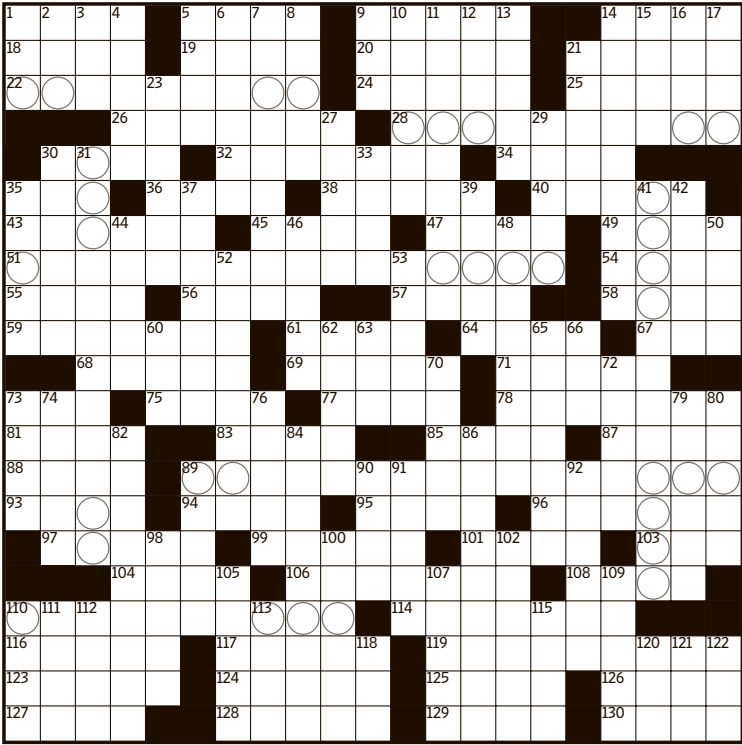


Acrostic

E.B. White, "Once More to the Lake"—"Summer-time, oh, summertime.... The cottages with their innocent and tranquil design, their tiny docks with...the American flag floating against the white clouds in the blue sky, the...paths...leading from camp to camp. This was the American family at play, escaping the city heat."

- A. Eclectic; B. Betsy Ross; C. Wheatland; D. High-and-mighty; E. Israel; F. "Twelfth Night"; G. Eye-catching; H. Off the chain; I. Numismatist; J. Chump change; K. En pointe; L. Malaise; M. Ottawa; N. Rusty nail; O. Emma Thompson; P. Turtles; Q. Operetta; R. "The Town"; S. Hit the dirt; T. Enigma; U. "Light My Fire"; V. Adriatic; W. Kiss-me-quick; X. Empanada

THE JOURNAL WEEKEND PUZZLES edited by MIKE SHENK

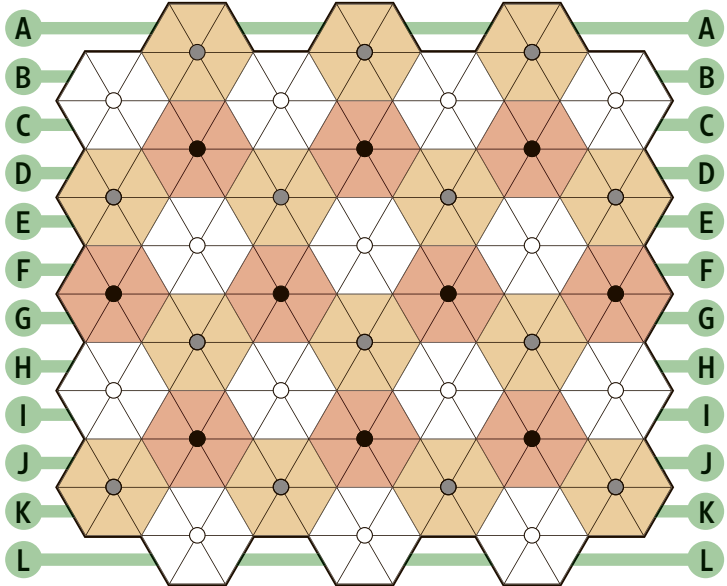


Trading Places | by Zhouqin Burnikel

- Across**
- 1 Ear piece?
 - 5 Octopus octet
 - 9 Hodge of "Black Adam"
 - 14 Hopper on a lily pad
 - 18 Latvia's largest city
 - 19 Water repellent?
 - 20 Attach with twine
 - 21 "Is this thing on?"
 - 22 Philosopher known as the father of liberalism
 - 24 Film character from Motunui
 - 25 Shout while banging a gavel
 - 26 Blue Devil's rival
 - 28 Utter disaster
 - 30 Exchange barbs
 - 32 Secures the help of
 - 34 Simpson with a sax
 - 35 Nintendo console
 - 36 ___ Beach, Florida
 - 38 LGBTQ+ advocacy group
 - 40 Code name?
 - 43 Grp. called in after a crash
 - 45 Innovative flash
 - 47 Cubs infielder Hoerner
 - 49 Right-leaning type: Abbr.
 - 51 Orbital lab for cosmic exploration
 - 54 Strongly suggest
 - 55 El ___, Texas
 - 56 Sweeties
 - 57 Tapered hairstyle
 - 58 Ram or rooster
 - 59 Verse clusters
 - 61 The Green Hornet's valet
 - 64 Peters of "X-Men: Days of Future Past"
 - 67 Tetris console
 - 68 High times?
 - 69 One-masted sailboat
 - 71 Must-have purse
 - 73 Hemp compound, familiarly
 - 75 Smell
 - 77 A fan of
 - 78 Shelters that provide cold comfort
 - 81 Takes a hatchet to
 - 83 Snoozefest
 - 85 German naval port
 - 87 "Ah, of course!"
 - 88 Notice with a short bio
 - 89 Peace Corps offering, e.g.
 - 93 Somewhat, in scores
 - 94 Fish in hitsumabushi
 - 95 About
 - 96 What tube riders are warned to "mind"
 - 97 Plant from the Greek for "flame"
 - 99 Boiling point?
 - 101 Blues guitarist Robert
 - 103 Abbr. in some town names
 - 104 Preludes to big days
 - 106 Item waxed for a run
 - 108 Close friend
 - 110 Letdown after optimistic expectations
 - 114 Sink item
 - 116 "Good Eats" host Brown
 - 117 Undermine
 - 119 Totally reversed, and a hint to this puzzle's circled letters
 - 123 Gets into a lather
 - 124 "Drop that at once!"
 - 125 Future J.D.'s exam
 - 126 Supernatural glow
 - 127 Went lightning-fast
 - 128 Gets trounced
 - 129 Chilliest temps
 - 130 Spill the beans
- Down**
- 1 The Sixers retired his #6
 - 2 Carnival city
 - 3 "That's disgusting!"
 - 4 Devilish ray
 - 5 "Te quiero" sentiment
 - 6 Ferrero ___ (chocolate brand)
 - 7 Cause a racket
 - 8 Girder material
 - 9 Bread machine?
 - 10 Ray of "Goodfellas"
 - 11 Start of a seasonal letter
 - 12 Burial site of early Scottish kings
 - 13 Garden slowpoke
 - 14 Glass house?
 - 15 Ye ___ Shoppe
 - 16 Phillies infielder Bohm
 - 17 Lovable goof
 - 21 "In what way?"
 - 23 Silkworms, e.g.
 - 27 Hybrid big cat
 - 29 Author of 1975's "I Am Not Spock" and 1995's "I Am Spock"
 - 30 Hold tight

- 31 Pocket full of meat
- 33 Pole, e.g.
- 35 Thin strands
- 37 Fall Out Boy, for one
- 39 Light emitter, perhaps
- 41 Scene that raises eyebrows
- 42 Two under par
- 44 ___ Lodge
- 46 Library lineup
- 48 Cracks
- 50 Vintner's sediment
- 52 Double reed with a haunting tone
- 53 Happening
- 60 Absolute madhouse
- 62 Disturbingly different
- 63 Great weight
- 65 Lululemon rival
- 66 Wizards' org.
- 70 Game involving drawing and folding
- 72 Full of energy
- 73 Take a hatchet to
- 74 Charlie Parker genre
- 76 Diner basketful
- 79 Dos Equis alternative
- 80 Percolates
- 82 Pulled off the ultimate diamond theft?
- 84 Auto blemishes caused by road salt
- 86 "Sounds about right"
- 89 Irritated
- 90 DVR debut of 1999
- 91 Celebrity gossip show
- 92 Paired surf and turf, say
- 98 Subway fixtures
- 100 High-strung
- 102 Lumber mill cutter
- 105 Taco part
- 107 Immobile
- 109 Parts of town
- 110 Foolish
- 111 Potato, in Indian cuisine
- 112 Great ball of fire?
- 113 Triple-tier snack
- 115 Olive discards
- 118 Aurora's counterpart
- 120 "Yes, monsieur"
- 121 Big tea dispenser
- 122 Rummage sale label

Answers to News Quiz: 1.D, 2.D, 3.B, 4.C, 5.C, 6.A, 7.C, 8.A, 9.B



Rows Garden | by Patrick Berry

Answers fit into this flower garden in two ways. Row answers read horizontally from the lettered markers; each Row contains two consecutive answers reading left to right (except Rows A and L, which contain one answer reading across the nine protruding spaces). Blooms are six-letter answers that fill the shaded and unshaded hexagons, reading either clockwise or counterclockwise. Bloom clues are divided into three lists: Light, Medium and Dark. Answers to Light clues should be placed in hexagons with white centers; Medium answers belong in hexagons with gray centers; and Dark answers belong in hexagons with black centers. All three Bloom lists are in random order, so you must use the Row answers to figure out where to plant each Bloom.

Rows

- A House area also known as a "flex space" (2 wds.)
- B Football strategy designed to prevent completed passes (2 wds.)
- Like beer that can't legally be sold in the U.S. (Hyph.)
- C Appliance company named for the Iowa town where it was founded
- Fliers who use both their hands and feet to control the aircraft (2 wds.)
- D Common inclusions in modern house listings (2 wds.)
- Ominous words on a wanted poster (3 wds.)
- E Embarrassing personal matters that a blackmailer might threaten to publicize (2 wds.)
- Fraction of the U.S. Senate that must vote "yes" to expel a senator (Hyph.)

- F Exactly what you'd expect (2 wds.)
- Purina product since 1926 (2 wds.)
- G Instruments heard in films when cutting to shots of beach resorts (2 wds.)
- 1968 Simon and Garfunkel song that name-checks Joe DiMaggio (2 wds.)
- H Emergency exit from a submarine (2 wds.)
- Skee-Ball or Whac-a-Mole, e.g. (2 wds.)
- I Document filled out before starting a repair job (2 wds.)
- Tweaked a product so no consumer could misuse it (Hyph.)
- J Enjoys as much as possible despite adverse circumstances (4 wds.)
- Rule in favor of (2 wds.)
- K Naturally-occurring air currents that facilitated the Age of Sail (2 wds.)
- Paid no attention to
- L Garish color for a pantsuit (2 wds.)
- Light Blooms**
- Architectural style featuring pointed arches
 - Account created by a mortgage company
 - Like panthers and pumas
 - Songs played at funerals
 - Tucked away
 - One taking prisoners
 - ___ disguised (not fooling anyone)
 - Fill with fury

- Cast aspersions on
 - River with the world's largest drainage basin
 - Shower curtain stain
 - Animosity
 - Refrigerant used in fog machines (2 wds.)
 - Item often lost in couch cushions
- Medium Blooms**
- Bracelet attachments
 - Gen Xer's parent, perhaps
 - Prepare for eating, as a fish
 - Bounded
 - Job seekers' successes
 - Overembellished
 - The National Railroad Passenger Corporation, familiarly
 - Uses a 1-wood
 - Not managing to keep up
 - "The Handmaid's Tale" author
 - Crossed, as a stream
 - Like most film festivals
 - Monkey used in medical research
 - Sped through every episode of
- Dark Blooms**
- ___ of salt (what Lot's wife was transformed into)
 - Wyoming mountain range
 - Located on the back, as a fish's fin
 - Swimming style
 - Oliver Twist or David Copperfield, e.g.
 - Curmudgeonly types
 - Eyeballed, with "out"
 - One whose "yes" RSVP was a lie (Hyph.)
 - Like rainy day pastimes
 - Straightens up

► Get the solutions to this week's Journal Weekend Puzzles in next Saturday's Wall Street Journal. Solve crosswords and acrostics online, get pointers on solving cryptic puzzles and discuss all of the puzzles online at [WSJ.com/Puzzles](https://www.wsj.com/puzzles).

This summer, Cynthia Nixon stars in two hit television shows as leading women confronting major life changes. She navigates sexuality in midlife as Miranda Hobbes in “And Just Like That.” Meanwhile, in the historical drama “The Gilded Age,” she returns as the newly widowed Ada Brook, who comes into an unexpected inheritance.

Nixon, 59, has lived through a few changes of her own, from becoming a director to watching her kids leave for college. She says young women have a lot to look forward to in middle age. “It’s a time when you can return to yourself,” she says. “In the same way adolescence [was] breaking away from your parents. This is a version of that, but hopefully with a little or a lot more wisdom.”

Season 3 of “And Just Like That” began last month, and season 3 of “The Gilded Age” returns on June 22. Nixon lives in New York with her wife, Christine, and 14-year-old son. She has two older children from a previous relationship. Here, she discusses “Sex and the City”’s new audience, her approach to political conversations and her Hamptons “harvest.”

What time do you get up on Mondays and what’s the first thing you do?

I get up at 7:30. I brush my teeth then make my son breakfast and lunch.

Do you have coffee or breakfast?

I am not a coffee drinker. I drink tea, and I usually have a piece of fruit, often an apple.

Do you have a morning skin care routine?

I have an infrared mask that I try and use most days, which I often fail at. You’re not supposed to have anything on your face when you put the infrared light on, so I very deliberately don’t put anything on my face to start the day.

It’s been just over a year since “Sex and the City” started streaming on Netflix and had a resurgence with a whole new audience. What has that been like for you?
Amazingly there’s so many young people that are watching it. My own children aren’t, but many of their friends and my friends’ teenage kids are watching it. You feel like everyone has seen it, but peo-



MY MONDAY MORNING | BY AVA MANSON

Cynthia Nixon on The Beauty of Middle Age

The actor on marriage, life changes and the remarkable longevity of ‘Sex and the City.’

ple just keep getting born.

Right now you play Miranda in “And Just Like That” and Ada in “The Gilded Age.” Do you take pieces of these characters home with you at the end of the day?
I think it’s more [that] you bring pieces of yourself to them when you come to work. People for decades now have identified me with Miranda. Of course I have a number of Miranda qualities, but I have at least as many Ada qualities, if not more.

Your characters showcase a phase of a woman’s life that we don’t see as much of in the media. What do you think young women have to look forward to as they get older?
There’s so much. There’s getting to know yourself better and not having your life as crowded as it was when you were younger. With Miranda, it’s a time in life where you’re finally reaping the rewards of all this hard work you’ve put into your career. It’s also a time when you can say, “This served me

for a certain amount of time, but now I want something different.”
You have more behind you than in front of you, so if you’re going to make a big change, what are you waiting for?
Did you feel like you had that big change or have one coming?
I started directing 10 [or] 15 years ago. That is an enormous change and something that I had been wanting to do for so long.
I still have a child at home. He’s entering high school next year, but

him going to college is not really that far away. I’ve been raising kids since I was 31, and I’m going to be 60 next year. That is another part of what I’m talking about, if you’ve been raising kids, [you’re] getting your life back in a way that it hasn’t been for, in my case, three decades.

Is there anything you and your wife want to do once he’s in college?

We have started to travel a lot more, but I think once we are no longer tied to a school schedule, the sky is the limit. I’m not a person that craves to be out of New York.

I hear you have a garden.

I have a garden in Montauk and I have a garden just to look at in the city, although I do have some herbs on the roof. I wouldn’t really say that I garden. I would say that I *harvest*.

Is there a secret to a happy marriage?

Finding the right person. I have endless love and lust for my wife, but I have an enormous amount of respect. She’s the person orchestrating for our whole family. Like my mother and my father’s marriage, my mother was really dazzled by my dad, and I am endlessly dazzled by Christine’s gut about what’s worthwhile.

You’re very outspoken online. How do you approach difficult conversations?

One of the main things I think is important to do, particularly if you’re talking about stuff that is very emotionally charged, is to do your best to speak carefully and with respect, and to assume that the person who has a different opinion than yours is also an intelligent, well-meaning person.

What are you reading and watching right now?

So much of our watching revolves around our 14-year-old, so we are watching “Parks and Recreation.” We just finished “Better Call Saul.” We’re not particularly timely, although we were huge “Severance” fans.
The last thing that I read that knocked my socks off was Naomi Klein’s “Doppelganger.”

What do you splurge on?
Restaurants, theater and travel.

This interview has been edited and condensed for clarity.

BETTMANN ARCHIVE

MASTERPIECE | ‘THE GOLD RUSH’ (1925), BY CHARLIE CHAPLIN

A Movie’s Mother Lode of Innovation

By CHRIS VOGNAR

CHARLIE CHAPLIN was already an international celebrity and king of silent cinema when he made “The Gold Rush,” his Klondike comedy adventure that had its premiere 100 years ago this month at Grauman’s Egyptian Theatre in Hollywood. But there was still a great deal riding on the production. His previous feature, “A Woman of Paris” (1923), had failed at the box office, in no small part because Chaplin sidelined his beloved “Little Tramp” (or “the little fellow,” as he liked to call his alter ego) and mostly remained behind the camera. Lesson learned: This time Chaplin would pit his bowler-wearing underdog against the fiercest elements, from blizzards and starvation to outlaws, cads and a very persistent bear.
The resulting film remains a towering monument in the medium’s history. “The Gold Rush” is a work of innovation notable not just for Chaplin’s mastery of extended comedic scenarios but also for the bold visual effects executed by Chaplin and his endlessly innovative director of photography, Roland Totheroh. Together they created a series of indelible illusions.
Through the magic of models and practical effects created during filming, they led millions to believe they

were seeing a cabin teetering off the edge of a snowy cliff as Chaplin’s Lone Prospector and his fellow gold digger, Big Jim McKay (Mack Swain), held on for dear life. They turned the ever-looming threat of extreme hunger into one of the movies’ great sight gags, in which the Prospector dissolves into a human-size chicken and Big Jim must refrain from shooting and eating his new friend. Such visual flourishes, achieved largely through inventive use of Totheroh’s hand-cranked Bell & Howell 2709 camera, were every bit as groundbreaking as the films that would dazzle down the final stretch of the silent era, including Fritz Lang’s “Metropolis” and F.W. Murnau’s “Sunrise” (both 1927). Already a first-rate comedian and exacting director, Chaplin reached new levels of filmmaking ingenuity with “The Gold Rush.”
That chicken gag marks one of several moments in the film that wring humor from the most serious and severe of subjects: starvation. As Lucy Sante writes in her es-

say for the 2012 Criterion Collection Blu-ray release, Chaplin was fascinated by the story of the Donner Party, the group of pioneers that resorted to cannibalism in an attempt to survive the winter of 1846-47 in the Sierra Nevada mountains. Nobody eats each other in “The Gold Rush,” although Big Jim briefly considers making a meal of his friend even after realizing he’s not a chicken. The two famously dine on a boiled shoe, Chaplin twirling and devouring the laces like a tasty bite of spaghetti (the actors are in fact



Charlie Chaplin as the Lone Prospector eating a boiled shoe.

munching on a candy prop). Later in the film, as Chaplin’s Prospector awaits a New Year’s dinner date who never arrives, he falls asleep and imagines himself whimsically using forks to make a pair of dinner rolls dance. Food, and its absence, are rarely far from mind in “The Gold Rush,” and hunger is a chief source of the movie’s considerable pathos.
Unlike most silent-film masters, Chaplin found a number of ways to make the transition to sound—even revisiting “The Gold Rush” in 1942. By then he had made his first full-sound feature, the 1940 anti-Nazi satire “The Great Dictator”; a few years earlier, in 1936, he directed the sound/silent hybrid “Modern Times.” He decided to tinker with “The Gold Rush” because he wanted to make it newly relevant to a modern audience that had grown accustomed to sound.
To this end he reissued his masterpiece with an orchestral score, sound effects, and narration delivered in Chaplin’s own stentorian tones. He

also tightened up the narrative by excising a storyline involving the dancehall girl for whom the Lone Prospector pines (Georgia Hale) and her caddish boyfriend (Malcolm Waite). The reissue earned Oscar nominations for sound recording and music, but purists may prefer the original intertitles to Chaplin’s shouty narration. The Criterion edition contains both versions, should you wish to judge for yourself.
Whichever variation you watch, “The Gold Rush” stands as a momentous hinge film for Chaplin. It brought the Little Tramp not merely his greatest adventure, but his fullest flowering as a character to date—downtrodden but plucky, earnest but a bit conniving (as when he feigns frozen unconsciousness to hustle a man for beans and coffee), always a surrogate for underdogs in the audience. It set the tone for future sublime Tramp outings, from “City Lights” (1931) to “Modern Times,” but as a work of filmmaking imagination it has no peer in Chaplin’s body of work.
With “The Gold Rush” Chaplin and Totheroh looked backward to the radical visual vocabulary of D.W. Griffith, and forward to the wizardry Orson Welles and his trailblazing cinematographer Gregg Toland would achieve 16 years later with “Citizen Kane.” “The Gold Rush” isn’t just the work of a great funny man. It provides the thrill of a top-flight filmmaker reaching a new level of artistry.

Mr. Vognar is a freelance culture writer.

BETTMANN ARCHIVE



**Cargo Shorts
That Are
Long on Style**
Our menswear
expert opines
D2

OFF DUTY

**Whole Lotta
Mozza
Going On**
Two impressive
cheese salads
D15



FASHION | FOOD | DESIGN | TRAVEL | GEAR

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Saturday/Sunday, June 21 - 22, 2025 | **D1**

ABOUT TO SNAP Last year, auto-related expenses cost the average owner more than \$12,000—a roughly 30% jump in a decade—led by higher car payments and financing.



MATT CHASE, GETTY IMAGES

DRIVEN *to* DESPAIR

Our love affair with automobiles is draining our wallets, with new vehicles increasingly out of reach and repair costs sending cars to the scrapper before their time. Can the relationship be saved? Dan Neil weighs the options.

By DAN NEIL

I **THINK OF MYSELF** not so much as a car reviewer as an intimacy coordinator. Four out of five American households depend on an automobile to get to work, to get the kids to school, to go wherever. The typical driver spends about an hour a day in the car, says the AAA—more face time than many of us spend with our families. A good relationship starts with a good match.

Lately, though, Americans have been losing that car-loving feeling. Actually, they're at the dish-throwing stage. Light-vehicle sales have fallen by about 1.7 million a year since

2016, reflecting the number of younger consumers declining the pleasures of ownership. Millions more remained trapped in toxic relationships with abusive elders. The average age of passenger cars on the road is currently 14.5 years, according to S&P Global's data.



Most of the yelling is about money. According to U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, the total cost to own and operate an automobile averaged a frightening \$12,296 in 2024, roughly 30% higher than a decade ago. Driving the numbers are new-vehicle prices, now averaging \$48,883, according to Cox Automotive's latest data.

With middle-income buyers priced out of new cars, de-

mand for used cars has strengthened, now averaging around \$25,500.

Go ahead, throw a dish. It'll make you feel better.

Among the major stressors: car insurance. Lexis-Nexis Risk Solutions' annual report found average insurance costs rose 10% in 2024, after soaring 15% in 2023. Full-coverage policies now average \$2,680 annually, up 12% from June 2024, says Bankrate.

And whatever you do, don't mention depreciation. In 2024, the AAA calculated the average new vehicle loses an eye-watering \$4,680 in value every year, over the first five years. Edmunds reported that in the last quarter 2024, one in four consumers were underwater on a car loan—meaning that they owed more than the vehicle's market value.

Please turn to page D16

Inside



THE NEW POWER PINK
It's not sweet. It's not Barbie. It's muted, dusty and means business. **D3**



FAR AWAY FROM YOUR REAL LIFE
Escape, emphatically, to this isolated Canadian island **D13**



AVOIDING SEED OILS?
As canola and sunflower come under scrutiny, consider these alternatives **D14**



THE FAMILY THAT INVESTED IN \$500,000 WORTH OF CABINETS
A laundry room and much, much more **D6**

MATT RUSSELL FOR WSJ FOOD STYLING BY REBECCA JURKEVICH PROP STYLING BY JULIA ROSE (PARTY TRIO)

STYLE & FASHION



DAVE LUBMAN

STYLE COACH Q&A / JAMIE WATERS



Advice for Finance Guys Seeking a Style Boost

I used to work in the big-bank world but now have my own small advisory practice. I'm looking for clothes—for the office and off-duty—that bridge the gap between formal business dressing and casual golf clothes. Also, do you have any favorite sources of style inspiration for finance guys?

—Jake Hamlin, 38, Chicago

When dressing smart-casual today, it's easy to wind up a modern corporate drone in clingy, stretchy polos and "tech" pants. So, first, some ground rules: 1) Avoid fabrics spiked with more than about 2% elastane; 2) If you're ever trying on a garment and find yourself wondering "Can I get away with something this tight?" promise me you will stop shopping and screw your head back on. Onto the essential items. A quality polo with a slightly relaxed fit is a finance guy's best friend. Grab ones in cotton piqué or merino; a cable-knit mixes things up. Think

navy, cream or shades you'd find on a tree. Alex Seo, a stylish 33-year-old with a New York investment management firm, calls the sub-\$200 knit polos from Beams Plus "awesome quality and value." He also likes King & Tuckfield's more-adventurous designs. For a steal, check out Kent Wang's \$75 piqué takes.

An easy tech-pants upgrade: five-pocket pants in textured cotton twill or cotton-linen. They typically retain the familiar cut of straight-leg jeans, but skew slightly dressier. And I'd step into slim-sole loafers or lug-sole derbies. Both read current and classy and, crucially, are not "hybrid" dress-shoes

with sneaker soles, which are harder to defend than an impulsive crypto trade. If you want to look like A Finance Guy, hit up brands that are reinvigorating trading-floor staples. Le Alfré's shirts—Oxfords with white contrast collars; chambrays with stripes nearly as fat as an '80s banker's tie—suggest



Finisterre Clipper 9-Inch Cotton Ripstop Cargo Shorts, \$115

Gordon Gekko's button-ups put through a "Casual Friday" filter. Jacques's precise quarter-zip sweaters and P. Johnson's shockingly handsome navy linen vests force anyone who has mocked finance-bro staples to eat their words (I'm gorging on mine). Alternatively, you could dress like a suave guy who just happens to work with money. Seo loves classic-but-not-corporate jackets from the Armoury, including the safari styles. Zach Garst, a trendy Houston tax consultant, 28, pairs cotton slacks with "something a little more spicy," like boxy shirts and cardigans from Auralee and Frizmworx. For style inspo, Le Alfré founder Brandon Snower recommends @schoonerscorer, an Instagram account popular with finance guys. It features videos of a charismatic Brit—Alex Hendy—rating beers at pubs. He's stylish but never mentions clothes. After bingeing clips, I can tell you that I won't be slurping the ho-hum porter at one central London pub, but I do need Hendy's cream cable-knit sweater and red Ralph Lauren shirt. I like that he's not a "fashion influencer"—outfit-dissecting accounts often come off cringe—just a cool guy doing his thing. One menswear account I do enjoy: @the_daily_mirror. Founder Manish Puri, who works in financial services and writes about menswear, radiates unprecious elegance with flowy trousers, suede chore coats—and a cartoon chicken head superimposed over his own. My best outfit ideas come from scrolling sites like Mr Porter, Drake's and Buck Mason to see how their models are dressed. A favorite corporate-cool look by P. Johnson (above) is inspiring me to do up just a few shirt buttons, buy a cowboy belt and a bro vest, and apply for an internship at JPMorgan.



A P. Johnson outfit

best-looking ones get a pass. **Five tips to avoid channeling a style-allergic dad:** ▶ Seek out shorts that boast a streamlined cut with empty pockets—and don't bulge like a packhorse when filled. ▶ Ensure they end above the knee: a 9-inch inseam max. Any longer lurches into Frumptown. ▶ Go for navy, black or olive. Approach khaki and camo with extreme caution. ▶ Bypass heavy cotton for fresher linen blends or sporty performance fabrics, said Michael Maccari, a super-stylish menswear designer and professor who admittedly sometimes wears cargos. ▶ Limit use to casual settings where you might reasonably need to haul a truckload of supplies on your thighs. Radio work and plane trips qualify. Dinner out does not.

P. Johnson's vests force anyone who has mocked finance-bro staples to eat their words (I'm gorging).

2 Any cargo-shorts rules? I say they're OK due to the extreme functionality. I carry lots of useful stuff in mine, like a Gerber multi-tool and amateur radio gear.

—Harry Bloomberg, 68, Pittsburgh

Anytime someone praises a clothing item's "extreme functionality," extreme anxiety stirs in my stomach. Like other wonderfully practical items such as caps with back flaps, the utility of cargo shorts often comes at a cost to others' eyeballs. Most cargos—long as Capri pants, wide as a bison—are terminally unattractive. But the

I tried a bunch of cargos to find the most palatable. I sought to mimic your haul by stuffing the pockets with items from my work bag. I replaced your radio gear with a bulky laptop charger, and swapped out your multi-tool for a pot of "Rough Rider" hairstyling clay for "a slick, matte look that lasts" (let's not dwell on it). Some shorts recommended online looked lousy IRL, though I didn't mind the belted, hiking-style takes by Uniqlo and Gramicci. The sleekest? A ripstop pair by surf brand Finisterre. Lean, subtly sporty and the color of an avocado's rind, they looked far too good to be accused of "extreme functionality."

CALL OF THE THINGS I JUST FOUND TOO HARD TO SAY

LAUREN JAUREGUI // TRACK 03

WHEN YOUR KID CAN'T FIND THE LANGUAGE, FIND THE LYRICS.

USE THEM TO START A CONVERSATION WITH YOUR KIDS ABOUT EMOTIONAL WELLBEING. LISTEN TO THE ALBUM, FIND TOOLS AND GET TIPS FROM PROFESSIONALS AT [SOUNDITOUTTOGETHER.ORG](https://sounditouttogether.org)

SOUND IT OUT

ad COUNCIL | pivotal

A Thin Line Between Love and Hate

Four of us tried 'all-day' eyeliner. Our findings after eight hours of wear.

LONG-WEARING, waterproof eyeliners have a tough gig. Their to-do list: Don't budge during the day; come off easily at night. Blend smoothly, yet never smear messily. In summer months when lids perspire, their job gets harder. "I'm always looking to trade up if a better product hits the market," said fashion assistant Haley Wells of her hunt for the perfect pencil. Here, Wells and three other staffers put two fan-favorite formulas—one \$5 drugstore go-to, one \$38 luxury splurge—to an all-day-wear test.

Kelly Peck Assistant Art Director Valentino Beauty Colorgraph Waterproof Gel Eyeliner (\$38) Application ease 8/10 Blendability 7/10 Staying power 8/10 Ease of removal 8/10 "Application was easy, as was blending with the attached brush. This didn't migrate onto my lids. The color had a little extra sparkle—always welcome in my makeup bag."	E.l.f. Cosmetics No Budge Retractable Eyeliner (\$5) Application ease 4/10 Blendability 4/10 Staying power 2/10 Ease of removal 8/10
--	---

"Blending was difficult and the application was uneven. I had to use the ancient hack of warming the pencil with a lighter." Haley Wells Fashion Assistant Valentino Beauty Eyeliner Application ease 4/10 Blendability 3/10 Staying power 6/10 Ease of removal 9/10 "The soft gel didn't shift once throughout the day. If someone prefers a lived-in, rocker look, this might be the liner for them." E.l.f. Cosmetics Eyeliner Application ease 3/10 Blendability 3/10 Staying power 7/10	Ease of removal 10/10 "The pencil is not soft enough to go on the waterline, but I was pleasantly surprised how long it stayed on. It fully came off with my regular CeraVe face cleanser." Maria Amador Art Director Valentino Beauty Eyeliner Application ease 9/10 Blendability 7/10 Staying power 8/10 Ease of removal 10/10 "The Valentino won out for me overall. It glided onto my lid much smoother and easier than the E.l.f." E.l.f. Cosmetics Eyeliner
--	---

Caitie Kelly Fashion Market Editor Valentino Beauty Eyeliner Application Ease 9/10 Blendability 8/10 Staying power 6/10 Ease of removal 6/10 "Between the soft pigment and the glitter, it felt more like an eye shadow." E.l.f. Cosmetics Eyeliner Application Ease 7/10 Blendability 8/10 Staying power 8/10 Ease of removal 9/10 "This experiment made me realize that I don't really need all the bells and whistles like the brush and the glitter. My makeup looks require just the basics, and E.l.f. was that for me." —Antonina Jedrzejczak	
--	--

STYLE & FASHION

Barbie Need Not Apply

A more muted, dusty pink is taking over corner offices as this season’s power color, letting women telegraph a softer strength.

By Freya Drohan

WHEN Palm Beach native McKenna Phillips moved to Manhattan in 2019, she seemed to develop “an allergic reaction” to wearing color, she said. Phillips, a 29-year-old hospitality manager, even earned Instagram clout for documenting her tough, all-black outfits. But lately, Phillips says she’s found similar strength in a particular shade of pink.

Meet the new power neutral—a muted, slightly dusty pale pink. It’s as if the quiet-luxury beiges of recent seasons have been washed in rosé. Gone are any associations with Barbie, Pepto-Bismol and frilly baby showers. “This pink emphasizes the power of sharp tailoring, without sacrificing any minimalism,” said Phillips, who credits the brands Khaite and Alaïa for turning her on to the shade.

Nishi Somaiya, the global

head of private banking, lending and deposits at Goldman Sachs, considers the shade an unconventional power color that’s elevated enough for the boardroom. “It makes me feel confident in an understated way. In dusty pink, I can totally own a situation,” said Somaiya, who especially favors a silk button-up blouse by Victoria Beckham.

Think of it as quiet-luxury beige washed in rosé.

Julia Sloan, the founder of the womenswear brand Sloan, says the shade captures the nuances of femininity in a way baby or hot pink don’t. “Pink has historically had a hard time holding that complexity.” This year’s breakout hue, Sloan believes, comes closest. “It doesn’t shout [like hot pink]. It feels elemental,” she said.

When incorporating the color into your wardrobe,

avoid any “fussy” textures like bouclé or tweed, advises Elizabeth Giardina, the creative director of womenswear brand Another Tomorrow.

For maximum impact, she suggests, wear it head-to-toe in a single easy fabric such as cotton. “Avoid anything that turns the knob into effort dressing—this pink should be just about the color, and not texture,” Giardina said.

Her label’s newest collection features a 1990s-esque slip dress, cropped trousers and simple crew-neck T-shirts, all in the shade she’s dubbed “quartz.” A trench

coat in the hue debuted last month and has already sold out. “Color gives language to a silhouette—especially when you’re talking about really minimal clothes,” Giardina said. “A desaturated pink like this reads like an optimistic neutral.”

Designer Daniella Kallmeyer, who similarly embraced the unique hue this year, admits that some tricky associations weaken pink. “There’s a challenge in using pink and maintaining a strength to it. It really comes down to the silhouettes and fabrication. You don’t want anything

dainty or exaggerated,” Kallmeyer said.

For her resort 2025 collection, Kallmeyer opted for the shade, which she says felt “grown up” and “non-gendered” in a modern, empowering way. The collection includes a mini skirt, a cashmere wool sweater and a tuxedo shirt with a detachable bow tie.

How to wear the color in a way that doesn’t lean too saccharine? Juxtapose it with sharp, angular lines and relaxed fits, says Kallmeyer. Look for loosefitting pieces and traditionally “masculine” cuts “to balance

the softness of the color,” she added.

Phillips likes to achieve that contrast by pairing the gentle pastel with black shoes or a leather jacket. “If you go too feminine,” she said, “it loses its edge.”

For those wary of a head-to-toe look, Kallmeyer suggests keeping the mood light and a bit unexpected by combining the color with chocolate brown and khaki. The pink, she said, also “mixes beautifully under a black suit.” Giardina’s tip? To “avoid looking like a Valentine, [don’t] wear this pink with reds.”

Meanwhile, for a party in Monaco next month, Phillips will be packing a swimsuit and skirt combo from Jacquemus—a look she ordered after seeing it on “The White Lotus.” Of the mood she said, “It’s such a cool way to welcome in femininity without sacrificing any of the strength I usually rely on.”

LOUISE & MARIA THORNFELDT (ANOTHER TOMORROW)



AT FIRST BLUSH
Menswear-inspired silhouettes anchor the murky pastel. Another Tomorrow Trench, \$1,990, and Dress, \$1,190



Toteme Shirt, \$264, Pants, \$312, and Scarf, \$252



Tried-and-true beige and black accessories feel newer in this pink.
Bottega Veneta Bag, \$8,900



GIORGIO ARMANI

STYLE & FASHION

Gifts for the 0.0001%

What presents do billionaires like Jeff Bezos want for their weddings? According to etiquette experts, this is an arena in which less is more.



By Ashley Wong

JEFF BEZOS, one of the wealthiest people in the world, is getting married this month. What could he and his bride, former TV journalist Lauren Sánchez, possibly want as a gift? “Well, I wouldn’t get them anything that I could buy on Amazon,” joked Jean Shafiroff, a philanthropist and socialite in New York City. Shafiroff said she does not know Bezos and Sánchez personally, but has attended and given gifts at many sumptuous parties.

Gift registries are standard for most weddings. However, the etiquette is a little different for some very wealthy

couples. When Ivanka Trump and Jared Kushner were married in 2009, their three publicly available online gift registries—featuring items like a \$300 KitchenAid stand mixer from Williams Sonoma and a Tiffany & Co. \$295 silver vegetable spoon—were closely scrutinized by the public and the media. Trump and Kushner did not respond to requests for comment. “Couples that are high net worth have to be very careful when it comes to setting up a registry,” said Elaine Swann, an etiquette expert who has worked with wealthy high-net-worth clients. “It should be something that’s private and not a public registry.” Including a registry link in the wedding invitation is also con-

sidered a faux pas. “It’s really easy to look at a registry as a greedy, gross thing from the couple, right?” said Lizzie Post, co-president of etiquette organization the Emily Post Institute. “But the registry is actually supposed to be a helpful tool for the guests.” Wedding etiquette experts said it’s up to the couple to set expectations about whether and what to give. Shafiroff, a well-known philanthropist in the New York social scene, said the most likely path Bezos and Sánchez would choose is to highlight a few charities they would like their guests to donate to. Jaime Xie, daughter of Fortinet billionaire Ken Xie, model and former star of

Netflix show “Bling Empire,” said her go-to wedding gifts are Hermès trays and blankets, or Tiffany & Co. home goods like teacups. For the upcoming weddings of friends this summer, she said, she has her eye on Smeg’s \$800 toasters made in collaboration with Dolce & Gabbana. Billionaires can afford to get creative with gifts. To celebrate his dating anniversary with wife Priscilla Chan, Mark Zuckerberg (with help from rapper T-Pain) recorded and

‘It’s really easy to look at a registry as a greedy, gross thing from the couple, right?’

released a slowed-down, acoustic cover of Lil Jon & the East Side Boyz’s “Get Low.” The Meta co-founder also commissioned a bright blue statue of Chan from sculptor Daniel Arsham—though Zuckerberg later revealed on Theo Von’s podcast “This Past Weekend” that Chan did not like it. In 2004, Oracle founder Larry Ellison gave his fourth wife, Melanie Craft, 911,744 shares of Oracle stock as a wedding present. Sánchez and Bezos have said little publicly about the gifts they have given or received. Neither responded to requests for comment. In early 2024, Sánchez posted a since-deleted Instagram photo praising a charm necklace her children had designed for her birthday. After she went up in a Blue Origin rocket in

April, Sánchez posted on social media a bag gifted to her by the Kardashians: a \$6,995 minaudière shaped like a UFO. Page Six reported that Bezos had a strict “no gifts” policy for his 60th birthday party last January. In 2004, Bezos told the radio program Marketplace that the most impactful gifts he ever received were the construction toys his grandfather gave him as a child, such as Legos, Erector Sets and Lincoln Logs. For the fifth wedding anniversary of Bezos and former wife MacKenzie Scott, Scott gifted Bezos a five-foot-tall Lego chest. In the absence of clear guidance, experts said, an engraved picture frame, or anything sentimental and personal to the couple’s interests, should always be welcome. A gift idea Swann has suggested in the past for luxury weddings is buying the rights to a meaningful photo of the couple, such as the kind taken at red carpets for black-tie galas and fundraisers with professional photographers, and placing it in a personalized frame. Rare collectors’ items, depending on the couple’s interests, can also work. The most important thing to remember, Swann said, is that guests shouldn’t stress over finding a gift that matches the couple’s financial means. “Anytime you’re attending a wedding that’s in a whole other tax bracket, go into it owning the space that you have been invited into,” Swann said. “Recognize that your presence is a present to the couple who has invited you.”



DON'T LOOK A GIFT HORSE Jaime Xie, the daughter of a billionaire, turns to Hermès for ideas.

SCAN FOR A CLOSER LOOK

Endless Blue

PAUL MORELLI

725 MADISON AVENUE (NYC)
510 WALNUT ST, STE 200 (PHL)
917.227.9039

LUCA FALONI

MILAN • PARIS • LONDON • NEW YORK
MIAMI • MUNICH • ZURICH

lucafaloni.com



SAPPHIRE RESERVE

SUMMER 2025

Member FDIC

DESIGN & DECORATING



HOUSE TOUR

THE BIGGEST BITE In the suburban-Philadelphia project designed by Miggy Mason, the combined kitchen and dining room storage ate up \$305K of the \$500K budget for millwork.

Enough Cabinets for the Costco

Old houses notoriously lack storage—irksome for this family of five in the age of bulk buying. Their solution? \$500K of built-ins.

By Michelle Slatalla

WHEN Gilded Age architect Addison Hutton designed a grand, circa-1870s mansion for the family of a prominent attorney in a bucolic town near Philadelphia, nobody was worried about where to put the extra rolls of paper towels.

Such things weren't invented yet. Neither were those wholesaler stores that sell bulk-packaged pallets of everything from canned tuna to Ziploc bags to meet the needs of families with, say, three young boys and a golden retriever.

After Patrick and Dava Murray moved their family into Hutton's lovely, 7,500-square-foot masterpiece of Second Empire style, they opened the doors of the tiny time-capsule closets and wondered: Where will all the Costco stuff go?

"Patrick really brought it up several times. At the time, they were storing everything down in the basement or in a small pantry cupboard in the mudroom," said Miggy Mason, the designer whom the couple hired to reconfigure the layout, to redo the kitchen, bedrooms, laundry and baths, and—most crucial—to add \$500,000 worth of new cabinetry.

Mason, the founder of West Chester, Penn., design firm Holley Alley, started on the job five years ago. By then, the Murrys had already made their affinity for their house's history clear: They'd painstakingly restored original win-

dows, repaired the slate roof and built a garage with a facade of green serpentine stone, matching that of the house.

"They loved the charm and all the quirks, and wanted to embrace the character of the house, so even the built-ins needed to feel very intentional and not like an afterthought," Mason said. "I wanted to make sure the house also felt fresh and approachable for a young family."

So how do you add nearly 160 linear feet of modern storage to a historic house in a way that doesn't look boring or overwhelming? You make it look as if all those new cabinets and wardrobes and closets had been there for 150 years.

Luckily, channeling the 19th century—and translating its architectural vernacular for the 21st—comes naturally to Mason, who lives in a nearby Queen Anne Victorian built in 1890.

It helped that she had a secret weapon: Bluebell Fine Cabinetry & Design, in Wayne, Penn. "They're the premier cabinet designer and builder in our area, and they built every cabinet in the house with solid wood, thicker-than-standard doors, and special wavy glass panels in the kitchen," she said.

While Shaker-style door panels visually link the storage units throughout the house, the team made tweaks here and there because "every room called for something a little different," said Mason.

For instance, the \$305,000 of cabinetry in the open-plan kitchen-dining room includes not



From left: A well-stocked kitchen pantry cupboard features shelving, dovetail drawer boxes and door racks. The laundry room, located upstairs, includes drying pegs and three clothes hampers, one for each boy.



only a wall of stately paneled-oak cabinets but the sort of rolling ladder that Victorians loved to scale in their bustles. (No one would ever guess that lurking behind the paneled cabinet doors are shelves stacked with facial tissue, aluminum foil and flavored carbonated water.)

To visually define the separate kitchen workspace, Mason painted

its cabinets a dusky green shade (Farrow & Ball's French Gray) and installed them against walls tiled floor-to-ceiling with subway tile in the same simple, running-bond pattern one might have seen at Philly's City Hall metro stop more than a century ago.

The 72 linear feet of kitchen millwork includes a custom stove hood; a pantry closet whose doors

custom built-in wardrobes (and a built-in window seat that invites you to curl up on it with a hardcover copy of "Little Women"). In all, the storage adds up to 40 linear feet of specially configured shelves and drawers to hold everything from luggage to shoes. The \$80,000 of carpentry adds "an architectural detail that elevates what had been sort of a nonde-



Oak cabinets, bin-pull hardware and a rolling ladder give the dining room the feel of a decades-old library.

No one would ever guess that lurking behind the paneled cabinet doors are shelves stacked with facial tissue, aluminum foil and flavored water.

accommodate shallow shelves like a refrigerator's; and paneled facings that hide a 36-inch Sub-Zero fridge and a 24-inch Sub-Zero freezer. Still, the kitchen manages to feel airy and open.

The reason? "Nearly 11-foot-high ceilings and very large windows," Mason said.

Upstairs, a conveniently situated laundry room has been wallpapered with the Morris & Co. pattern Bellflowers and painted Farrow & Ball's Light Blue. In addition to 11 linear feet of storage—hello, jumbo-sized jugs of detergent—the \$25,000 of millwork included a shelf with custom-size baskets to hide unmentionables, wooden pegs on which to hang clothes to dry and three Steele Canvas hampers (one for each boy's laundry).

In the primary bedroom, Mason wrapped three of the four walls in

script, plain room," Mason said. Painted in a serene shade—Farrow & Ball's Joa's White—the wardrobes are a neutral backdrop for a room dominated by the simple, architectural lines of a custom four-poster bed built in Pennsylvania.

Mason's clients helped brainstorm other ways to camouflage all that storage. When they asked for a coffee station in the kitchen, they suggested disguising it as an old-fashioned pantry behind glass doors. "Patrick drinks tea, Dava drinks coffee, and we planned where every item would go," Mason said.

In fact, said Mason, "Dava took my drawings and labeled every drawer and shelf on them with where she wanted everything to go, including a label where she wanted the dishes and dish towels, and even the tea bags."



Special Advertising Feature

EAT DRINK EXPLORE



What Are Cruisers Looking for Now?

Smaller, more luxurious ships plus great adventures

by Julie Bennett

Cruising is more popular than ever. According to Cruise Lines International Association’s *State of the Cruise Industry Report 2025*, 34.6 million people from around the world took ocean-going cruises in 2024. That number is expected to grow to 37.7 million this year.

While giant mega-ships carry most of these passengers, the fastest-growing segment of the cruise industry is luxury ships, tripling in number since 2010, when worldwide fleets had only 28 of these vessels. By 2024, that number had grown to 97 with several more currently under construction in shipyards around the world.

Cruisers are getting younger and more adventurous, too, according to the CLIA report. The average age is now 46.5 years. And while the Caribbean, the Bahamas and Bermuda are still the top destinations, cold-water expeditions are coming in hot. Think Antarctica, the Arctic, Greenland, Iceland and the North Cape of Norway: In just one year, the number of intrepid travelers on voyages to these icy destinations jumped 21.6%.

All of this is good news for Atlas Ocean Voyages.

Jason O’Keefe, director of guest experience and corporate communications, says, “We have three ships that carry a maximum of 198 guests each, with the layout and decor of private yachts. We quickly became known for year-round expeditions, the highlight being our polar expeditions to the Arctic and Antarctica, transporting guests off-ship in inflatables to get closer to icebergs and wild-life like penguins and whales.”

GUESTS OF HONOR

In the summer, instead of polar experts, the expedition leaders are culinary scene celebrities and winemakers who offer immersive gourmet experiences. “Voyages in the Mediterranean become

Luxury travelers today want immersive experiences that appeal to all their senses, choosing cruise lines that promise the height of food, drink and adventure. The Grand Dining Room on Oceania Vista serves gourmet meals often linked to the ports of call (top). Regent’s Seven Seas Prestige, launching at the end of 2026, includes two-story loft suites, perfect for multigenerational families traveling together (left). Atlas Ocean Voyages debuted in 2021 and has already introduced thousands of travelers to the Arctic and Antarctica (top right). Guests aboard Oceania Cruises can carry their favorite onboard and regional meals home, by learning to prepare them in select ship’s Culinary Arts Centers (bottom right).



COURTESY OF ATLAS OCEAN VOYAGES

An exotic cocktail provides the perfect ending to a day of exploring icebergs or local food markets on an Atlas Ocean Voyages ship.

Epicurean Expeditions led by our guest chefs, and shore excursions often have a focus on culinary tastings and culture,” O’Keefe explains. “A local vintner comes aboard to showcase regional wines.”

Typically, guest chefs conduct cooking demonstrations and provide recipes for the famous dishes they serve in the yacht’s dining room. They also host market tours in port, taking guests along to shop for local produce, meat and seafood. “Because our yachts are so small, with only 100 staterooms,” he adds, “our passengers can really get to know our chefs.”

“The main highlight of these expeditions,” O’Keefe relates, “is the yachtsman cook-off, where teams of guests are given simple ingredients and compete to produce the best version of a dish that’s connected to our itineraries, like pizza in Italy. Then the guest chef judges the winner.”

Continued on Page D12

INSIDE



COURTESY OF REGENT SEVEN SEAS CRUISES

EXCELLENT TASTE
How can you get on a ship in London and have dinner in Morocco?

PAGE D8



COURTESY OF OCEANIA CRUISES

SWEET SATISFACTION
What makes this man think of his grandmother when it's lunchtime on Oceania cruise ships?

PAGE D10

The Wall Street Journal news organization was not involved in the creation of this content.



Sitting on top of the sea, watching the world go by. The Regent Suite on Seven Seas Prestige, launching next year, features a Skyview Terrace.

ALL PHOTOS COURTESY OF REGENT SEVEN SEAS CRUISES

CHEF'S KISS

New elegance and new cuisine are on the horizon

by Julie Bennett

Luxury cruisers who love to be among the first to try out the amenities of the newest cruise ships, check out the brand-new cabins, and enjoy the cuisine of their debut restaurants will want to circle June 25 on their calendars. That's the day Regent Seven Seas Cruises® begins taking reservations for the maiden voyage of *Seven Seas Prestige* in December 2026.

Seven Seas Prestige, now under construction in the famous Fincantieri shipyard in Marghera, Italy, will share the sumptuous features of her six sister ships and incorporate new design features. Guests suites will be even larger, and the most splendid will span two stories and have their own elevators. *Seven Seas Prestige* will still contain the Regent array of a half dozen popular gourmet restaurants, but with updated decor and expanded menus.

A SURE THING

Seven Seas Prestige will also launch Azure, a specialty restaurant with Mediterranean flair and mezze-style communal dining. Mezze dining, in which diners share from a collection of small flavorful dishes, is popular in countries as varied as Greece, Turkey and Egypt. Azure meals will begin with an *amuse-bouche* and several shared appetizers. Main courses will include colorful salads and platters of regional vegetables, grilled meats, kebabs, pita and flatbreads.

"Cuisine has always been at the heart of the Regent experience, and with *Seven Seas Prestige*, we are taking our commitment to epicurean perfection to an entirely new level," says Jason Montague, chief luxury officer for the cruise line. "I'm especially excited to introduce Azure, an innovative and exciting new dining experience that will bring fresh flavors and a bold new concept for Regent guests to enjoy."

Azure's decor will imbue color and design from sunny Mediterranean countries like Morocco, Spain, Italy, Greece, Israel and Lebanon, says Yohandel Ruiz, a founding partner with boutique firm Studio DADO. "It will feel exotic, but also comfortable and welcoming." Special touches will include mosaics, rustic pottery, clay pots and dried flower arrangements.

RICH REWARDS

Upgrades will also enhance versions of the fleet's popular restaurants. Aboard *Seven Seas Prestige*, guests will enter the main restaurant, Compass Rose, through a sparkling tunnel, mimicking the stars and moonlight reflected on the surrounding water. And the ship's Pacific Rim Pan-Asian restaurant will feature an enhanced Zen-like atmosphere.

Seven Seas Prestige suites are even more dramatic. The new ship will carry a maximum of 822 passengers and contain 411 guest suites,



The breathtaking Starlight Atrium in Seven Seas Prestige was conceived by Studio DADO, an award-winning hospitality design studio in Miami.



Azure, a Mediterranean restaurant debuting on Seven Seas Prestige, will offer guests mezze-style dining within a colorful decor of mosaics and clay pots.



A dozen new Epicurean Explorer tours will take Regent guests foraging for seaweed and herbs in Ireland, sampling artisanal cider in Nova Scotia or touring local food markets in Japan and Korea. These immersive tours often include meals of special regional dishes.

all with balconies. Private elevators will transport guests between the two levels of Skyview Suites, on Decks 14 and 15. Each includes a rooftop terrace with its own jetted tub. Grand Loft Suites "evoke the feel of a refined Lower Manhattan residence," according to Regent, and each Horizon Penthouse Suite will include an oversized balcony.

Cruisers who want to sail before *Seven Seas Prestige* launches and begin enjoying all-inclusive fares and epicurean delights even sooner can choose from over 164 Regent itineraries scheduled between now and the end of 2026. Visiting over 500 ports with itineraries covering most of the world, sailings last from seven to 154 days.

FOOD FOR THOUGHT

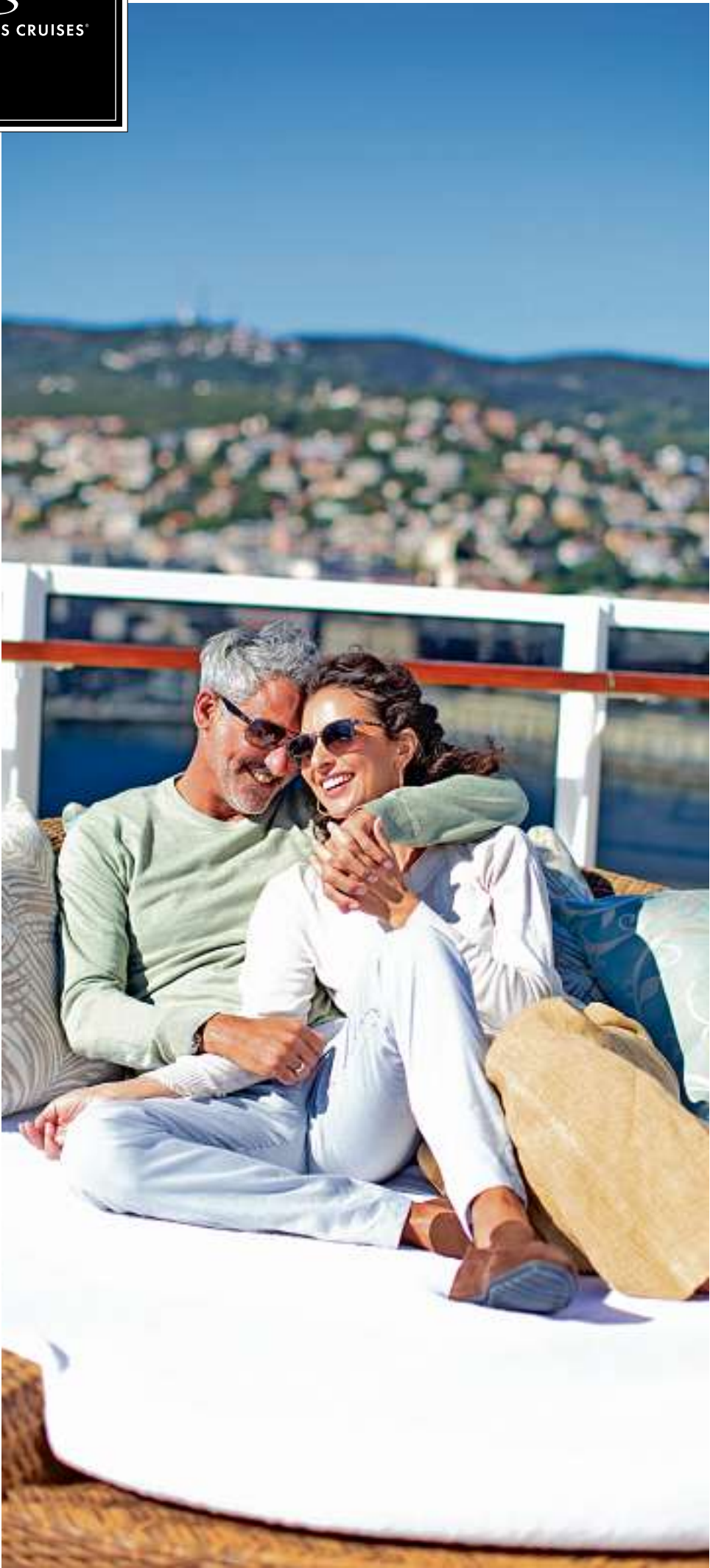
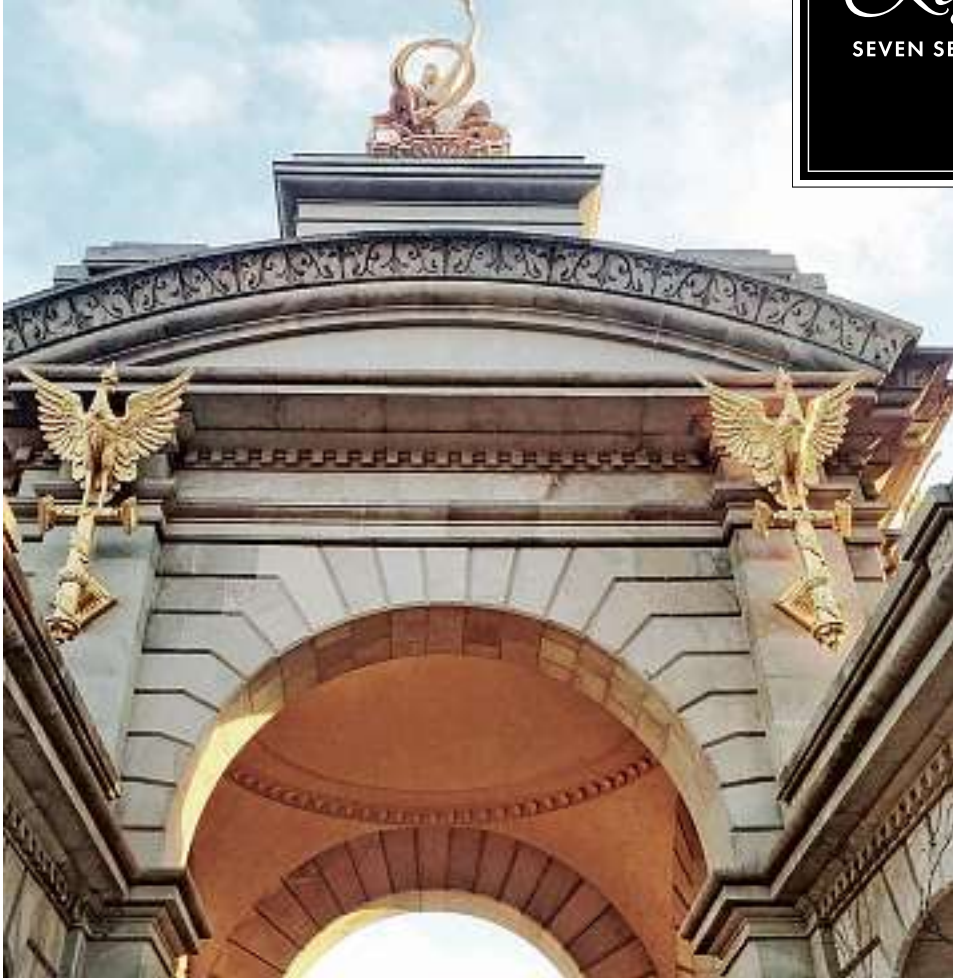
Several upcoming voyages are Spotlight on Cuisine cruises, hosted by well-known chefs. On August 28, a 12-night cruise on *Seven Seas Grandeur* from Amsterdam to Paris will feature Chef Christopher Gross, winner of James Beard awards and chef/director of Christopher's at Wrigley Mansion in Phoenix, Arizona. Gross, who is known for his French-inspired bistro food, will lead onboard cooking demonstrations.

When *Seven Seas Grandeur* stops at Invergordon, Scotland, food-inspired guests can opt for the Foraging & Onboard Scottish Cooking Class, one of Regent's 12 new Epicurean Explorer tours. A chef leads guests through local markets to sample local fare like haggis and to gather ingredients for Cullen Skink, a fish chowder made with smoked haddock they will learn to prepare back on the ship. Guests can also learn to make paella in Spain, bread in Malta and sushi in Japan on other new Epicurean Explorer excursions.

Wine lovers can still book a suite on *Seven Seas Mariner* for a Spotlight on Wine cruise from Trieste to Barcelona sailing on October 22. Steven Honig will share stories about his family's Napa Valley winery and host tastings of its top vintages. Or cruisers who enjoy wine and adventure can book an Alaskan Spotlight on Wines cruise next June on *Seven Seas Explorer* led by representatives from the Ken Brown Wines in California, known for its small production pinot noir.



The Regent Suite, the most luxurious quarters on Seven Seas Prestige, will be so elegant, guests will hate to leave it, even for meals. 24-hour room service comes in handy (left). Future cruisers can sit at Galileo's Bar on Seven Seas Prestige and watch fellow passengers as they stroll by or gaze at the ceiling with its hand-painted designs (right).



SALE
— INTO —
SUMMER
with up to
50% off
on select
2025-2026 voyages

Step into an all-inclusive ultra luxury experience that is *Unrivaled at Sea*™. Explore more than 550 destinations around the world while enjoying the unrivaled space, elegance, and comfort of *The World's Most Luxurious Fleet*®. We'll tend to every detail of your journey from start to finish, so you can be pampered by the warm, *Heartfelt Hospitality*™ delivered by our incredible crew who not only care for you, but about you.

Nobody Does It Better than *Regent Seven Seas Cruises*®.

For a limited time, enjoy up to **50% Savings*** on select 2025-2026 sailings to the Caribbean, Europe, Alaska, Asia, and beyond.

**OFFER ENDS JUNE 30, 2025.
RESERVE YOUR SUITE TODAY.**

THE MOST INCLUSIVE LUXURY EXPERIENCE®

*For applicable sailings and full Terms and Conditions, visit [RSSC.com/legal](https://www.regentcruises.com/legal)

CALL **1.844.861.9774** OR CONTACT
YOUR TRAVEL ADVISOR

SCAN THE QR CODE OR
VISIT **[RSSC.COM/SPECIALS](https://www.regentcruises.com/specials)** TO LEARN
MORE ABOUT OUR SPECIAL OFFERS



EAT DRINK EXPLORE

Special Advertising Feature



The best restaurant in Europe this summer may be sailing on the Mediterranean. This sumptuous lobster pasta is one of the dishes served in the Toscana dining room on Oceania Vista (left). Because Oceania's luxury ships are small, they can carry travelers to less visited locations. Oceania Vista is seen here in a picturesque port on the Croatian island of Hvar (top right). In addition to their Grand Dining Rooms, all Oceania ships have specialty restaurants, like the Asian-themed Red Ginger on Oceania Vista (bottom right).

EAT YOUR HEART OUT

Culinary superstar Jacques Pépin serving world-class cuisine

by Julie Bennett

To maintain Oceania Cruises' reputation for serving "The Finest Cuisine at Sea" requires an army of chefs, inspiration from a world-famous culinary giant and a pair of executive culinary directors trained at the best restaurants in Europe at the helm.

Renowned Chef Jacques Pépin was the line's first executive culinary director and worked with its founders to put food at the heart of Oceania Cruises. The philosophy of serving "The Finest Cuisine at Sea" is anchored in sourcing the best ingredients and working with talented chefs from across the globe.

Pépin, who turns 90 this year, still serves as a culinary advisor, working alongside the line's pair of executive culinary directors, who are both French master chefs: Eric Barale, in charge of sourcing all the ingredients to serve 7,580 guests a day across its fleet of eight luxurious ships, and Alexis Quaretti, who designs each dish on every menu.

"I normally develop 300 new recipes each year," says Quaretti from his home in Southern France, "but this is a big year for us as we are thrilled to be welcoming a new ship, *Oceania Allura*, in July, so I have created 500. We have 30 restaurants across our fleet — including specialty French, Italian and Asian restaurants — and it is important to keep the dishes authentic to each region."

Oceania's chic signature French restaurant, Jacques, is named after Pépin and is found aboard *Oceania Marina* and *Oceania Riviera*, serving many of his signature dishes and showcasing art and heirlooms from his personal collections. New addition *Oceania Allura* will have the popular venue aboard, and it is being added later this year to her sister ship, *Oceania Vista*, which launched to great global acclaim in 2023.

CREATED FOR FOODIES BY FOODIES

Recipes are thoughtfully crafted to appeal to the palates of Oceania Cruises' foodie guests. "South American cuisine and Japanese food are trendy now, and we are adding a lot more vegetarian and vegan dishes. What is falling out of favor are heavy foods rich in cream and butter," he says. "People today want more simplicity. I've turned back to a few dishes my family prepared when I was a kid, and today my grandmother's chocolate mousse is often served at lunch. I love that a dessert she used to cook at home is now out in the world."

Quaretti says the most challenging part of his job is consistency, ensuring that his grandmother's mousse or his roasted Chilean sea bass with green apple sauce and caviar always taste the same. "We have



The executive culinary directors of Oceania Cruises, Chef Eric Barale (left) and Chef Alexis Quaretti (right), worked in Michelin-starred restaurants in France before joining the cruise line. Chef Barale is responsible for sourcing the world's best produce, fish, meat and other ingredients to serve to Oceania guests, while Chef Quaretti develops 300 or more recipes a year for the line's 30 restaurants. Oceania chefs serve more than 7,500 passengers each day aboard its fleet.

"We have a chef for every 10 guests."

— ALEXIS QUARETTI



A table for two in Toscana, the Italian specialty restaurant on Oceania Vista, combines excellent food with nautical views.

a chef for every 10 guests," he reveals. "We are fortunate the galleys [kitchens] are spacious enough to hold everybody. They are the first thing designed for our new ships — then the rest of the ship is built around them. Restaurant kitchens require different designs according to the type of food prepared there. An Asian kitchen is very different from one created for an Italian restaurant. I spend a week to 10 days each month at sea, working with our chefs."

SAVOR THE JOURNEY

For a truly immersive food-centric cruise, take a look at the line's annual specialty sailings. In 2026, four voyages will have a cuisine-focused theme. On May 12, 2026, a 12-day cruise from Lisbon to Paris on *Oceania Marina* will set sail, featuring chef, cookbook author and television personality Sara Moulton. She will curate menu items, lead shore excursions and conduct special events.

On July 2, 2026, Jacques' daughter and cookbook author, Claudine Pépin, will host an Alaska roundtrip from Seattle on *Oceania Riviera*. A 10-day Culinary Luminaries Cruise from Belfast to Lisbon, departing on September 15, 2026, on *Oceania Marina*, will feature culinary directors Barale and Quaretti and special guest chefs, who will lead guests through famous vineyards and historic wine cellars.

Oceania Cruises' love of food extends beyond the exquisite cuisine served in its restaurants. Aboard many of their ships, guests can hone their culinary skills and techniques at The Culinary Center, where a faculty of chef instructors teach guests how to prepare a variety of dishes at their own hands-on workstation.

In addition, guests can join the chef instructors ashore on Culinary Discovery Tours to local markets or farms for cooking demonstrations and tastings of regional foods and wines. Chef-led tours of historic wine estates in France and Italy, food markets in Japan and family-run tavernas in the Greek Isles are so popular that the Oceania Cruises website allows future guests to choose culinary tours first, then find the cruises on which they are offered.

"Many people ask me why I would give up a career in the best restaurants in France to work for a cruise line," Quaretti says. "When guests go back home after a cruise, they remember what they ate, part of creating those memories. And when I oversee multiple restaurants across eight beautiful ships, each sailing in the most incredible destinations all over the world, every day is different. I never get bored."

ALL PHOTOS COURTESY OF OCEANIA CRUISES

FLEETWIDE SALE

All voyages departing through December 31, 2026

up to **40% OFF**

+ FREE Beverage Package
+ Shipboard Credit up to \$800
+ 50% Reduced Deposits

YOUR WORLD INCLUDED™

2 for 1 Cruise Fares
Gourmet Specialty Dining
Shipboard Gratuities
Unlimited Starlink® WiFi
And so much more

THE BEST VALUE *in* LUXURY CRUISING

Our Fleetwide Sale is the perfect time to turn your dream vacation into your next best adventure. Available on all voyages departing through December 31, 2026, you'll enjoy a Free Beverage Package *and* a Shipboard Credit up to \$800 *plus* up to 40% off select sailings *and* 50% Reduced Deposits. Combined with the always free amenities of Your World Included™, you'll discover small ship luxury for less.

Scan this QR code with your smartphone camera to view Special Offer.

THE FINEST CUISINE AT SEA®
AWARD-WINNING ITINERARIES
SMALL SHIP LUXURY™

BOOK NOW. OFFER EXPIRES JUNE 30, 2025.
CALL **844-837-1324** | VISIT **OCEANIACRUISES.COM/WJ** | CONTACT YOUR TRAVEL ADVISOR

Terms, conditions, restrictions, and capacity controls apply. Special Offer expires on 6/30/25 and is available for select categories on select voyages, subject to change and capacity controlled. Savings amounts vary per sailing and are per person. Mention Code: DSC. Promotion may be withdrawn at any time without prior notice. Please visit www.OceaniaCruises.com for complete Terms & Conditions. JUN252134

EAT DRINK EXPLORE

Special Advertising Feature

Continued from Page D7

WHAT BECOMES A LEGENDARY CRUISE MOST?

A Legends of Antiquity tour on Atlas’ *World Navigator*, which begins in Lisbon on September 27 and docks 10 nights later in Barcelona, will provide guests with an immersion into local wines. Shore excursions in Spain include a winemaking class in a village in Ibiza, a sampling of the wines of Cadiz and a visit to El Bosque, famous for its cheese, made from the milk of sheep and goats.

The guest chefs will be Texas restaurateur Stephen Pyles, known as the father of Southwestern Cuisine, who has cooked for six U.S. presidents and Queen Elizabeth, and Chef Paula Lambert, an artisanal cheesemaker. A local vintner from Portimão, Portugal, will also come on board to share tastings of his wines. As a bonus, when the ship is docked in Ibiza, a modern dance company will entertain with a colorful, immersive performance.

Another trend is the rising popularity of back-to-back cruises, where travelers stay on board for a second journey. On the Legends of Antiquity expedition you can do just that, because when *World Navigator* makes its return trip from Barcelona to Lisbon on October 7, it starts another voyage, called Passion of Spain, that features Scandinavian Chef Christian Ørner. Its immersive experience in Seville includes a tapas dinner and flamenco dancing.

When the ship stops in Tangier, guests can opt for a shore excursion that will provide an immersion into the history and culture of Moroccan cuisine, and learn to prepare, and then eat, a variety of entrees, desserts and breads in the cooking classroom of Blue Door Cuisine.

MUSIC TO THE EARS

Travelers seeking even more unusual experiences and cuisines can book the Morocco & Canaries Explorer voyage on *World Navigator* that leaves Casablanca on October 22 and visits Safi, Arrecife and Puerto Del Rosario before docking in Las Palmas on Gran Canaria. The onboard culinary leader will be Chef Plum, known for his television and radio food shows, and the local vintner is from Portimão, Portugal. The astounding immersive experience of this itinerary is a one-of-a-kind concert in Cueva de Los Verdes, a volcanic cave in Lanzarote, one of the Canary Islands.

Most luxury cruises do not include music in caves, but several market reports state that luxury travelers want personalized experiences. Many people today prefer to invest in immersive experiences rather than material goods.

The expert Shoreside Experience team at Atlas can arrange for their guests to meet the locals, whether by visiting their farms or vine-



ALL PHOTOS COURTESY OF ATLAS OCEAN VOYAGES

Today’s luxury cruisers are seeking extraordinary experiences, like those they can find on Atlas Ocean Voyages. The cruise line’s three ships hold a maximum of 198 passengers each and have the look and feel of private yachts.



There is still time to explore exotic locations and cuisine this fall on an Atlas Ocean Voyages cruise to Morocco and the Canary Islands. Guests can enjoy the sights in Casablanca, the wines of Portugal and the music of the Canary Islands.



Expedition and exploration cruises to cold water countries near the North and South Poles are growing in popularity among luxury cruisers. Atlas Ocean Voyages deploys inflatables and other small vessels to take guests close to sea lions and penguins in Antarctica.

yards, sailing on their fishing boats and even eating in their homes. Because of their size, Atlas ships can access smaller, less-visited ports and stay there longer, allowing travelers to enjoy dinner in the restaurants ashore.

TRENDS ALERTS

Luxury cruise lines are attracting an increasing number of first-time cruisers, according to the CLIA report. “Guests tell us they avoided cruising before because they were intimidated by the long lines and crowds in touristy destinations,” O’Keefe says.

They also might fear hidden charges. The luxury cruise industry is moving toward fares that are more comprehensive. Aboard Atlas, “it’s an all-inclusive experience with drinks and gratuities covered in the fare and you only pay extra for select shore excursions, spa services and the items you purchase from the gift shop,” O’Keefe reveals.

Another trend revolves around who is traveling. The CLIA study finds more people are traveling alone and, on the flip side, more multi-generational groups are taking trips together. On traditional cruises, fares are calculated on two guests per room; a solo traveler gets a discount on the double-room rate. Many luxury lines are designing new ships with a selection of rooms specifically designed for solo adventurers.

With the advent of more grandparents traveling with their adult children and grandchildren, luxury lines are also expanding programming for younger travelers — and setting rules around them. Some luxury cruise lines advertise “No children!” At Atlas, “It’s not unusual to have family groups of 10 to 15 members,” O’Keefe says. “We welcome anyone down to age one for warm water destinations but insist a child must be at least eight years old before going on a polar expedition for safety reasons.”

As for the future of cruising, there seem to be two disparate trends. Since Wi-Fi connections have gotten so much better on the high seas, more travelers will take work along with them and use their cabin’s desk as a (very) remote office. Conversely, forecasters predict “digital detox cruises,” in which passengers surrender their phones and other devices when their ship disembarks to spend their vacations looking at the scenery and each other.

Whether you plan to work in your luxury suite or cruise without distraction, with a growing cohort of like-minded vacationers, you will be in good company.

Julie Bennett is a freelance writer specializing in luxury travel, real estate and lifestyle issues.



INTIMATE YACHTING EXPEDITIONS™

EXPLORER’S CHOICE

CHOOSE YOUR
COMPLIMENTARY
AMENITY

AIR CREDIT
SAVINGS
UP TO \$2000

HOTEL
AND/OR
LAND PACKAGE

ENHANCED
UNLIMITED
WIFI PACKAGE



BOOK BY JUNE 30 | FARES INCREASE JULY 1

EXCLUSIVE OFFER FOR
THE WALL STREET JOURNAL SUBSCRIBERS

\$200 ONBOARD CREDIT
MENTION PROMO CODE WS12024

ALWAYS INCLUDED BY ATLAS

Expedition Guides + Enriching Experiences,
L’OCCITANE Amenities,
Unlimited Wines + Spirits, Gratuities, and More



CONTACT YOUR TRAVEL ADVISOR OR
OUR VOYAGE SPECIALISTS AT 844.346.1438

ATLASOCEANVOYAGES.COM



ANTARCTICA / SOUTH AMERICA / CARIBBEAN & BERMUDA
MEDITERRANEAN / NORTHERN EUROPE / ARCTIC



GET
YOUR
EXCLUSIVE
OFFER

All fares, special offers and inclusions are subject to change at any time without notice. Mention WS12024 at time of booking for \$200 onboard credit per stateroom (\$100 per guest). Other restrictions may apply. Visas may be required for travel. ©2025 Atlas Ocean Voyages. Ships’ Registry: Portugal 4343_06.09.25

ADVENTURE & TRAVEL



AN ISLAND FAR, FAR AWAY Battle Harbour, where old fishing lodges have been restored into bookable cabins, is hard to get to—but that’s the point.

On a Quest for Rest

True peace and quiet is hard to find. In a remote corner of Canada, one island provides plenty of both.

By **MADELINE WEINFELD**

ON A RECENT trip to Battle Harbour, an island in Canada’s Labrador Sea, I heard the Northern Lights. Or at least I think I did. Scientists still debate whether the aurora actually makes any sounds, but as I gazed at the chartreuse display, I thought I could make out a faint whispered whistle in the night’s otherwise profound silence. A true separation from the din of daily life eludes most of us, even on vacation—but in that moment, I was sure I’d found it.

For most of the year, the remote island of Battle Harbour in the province of Newfoundland and Labrador lies empty, pummeled by relentless snowstorms. Icebergs regularly float by in the bay. But for the three months of summer, the island opens briefly, like a portal to another quieter world. I had traveled to the island from New York City with my new husband as part of our honeymoon.

True solitude and silence, it turns out, requires a small odyssey. To get to Battle Harbour, we flew from New York to Toronto; and then to Deer Lake, Newfound-

land. From there, we drove three hours up Newfoundland’s west coast, hopped on a ferry to Quebec and then continued our road trip on the Trans-Labrador Highway, a road only fully paved in 2022. Finally, an hour-long ferry from Mary’s Harbour on Labrador’s mainland brought us to Battle Harbour.

Stepping off the boat, I spotted a few dozen saltbox-style buildings near shore. The sea and the sky seemed endless. A few hundred years ago, the scene on the dock would have been very different. Despite its remove, Battle Harbour

was once a thriving hub of Canada’s cod fishing industry at a time when specimens pulled from the Labrador Sea could rival small children in size. But after a major fire devastated the settlement at Battle Harbour and decades of overfishing diminished cod stocks, Battle Harbour’s boom days dwindled.

In the 1960s, after Canada’s controversial campaign to resettle some of the country’s most remote communities, the island was left even more isolated.

Today Battle Harbour is a National Historic District run by the Battle Harbour Historic Trust, which has painstakingly restored the 19th-century fishing cottages and outbuildings, and transformed them into guest accommodations and mini museums. Between 20 and 30 people can stay overnight at a time on the one-kilometer-long island in the rustic but comfortable cottages or at the small inn by the

harbor. My husband and I stayed in the most remote of the island’s restored houses, a whitewashed cottage at the northern edge of the island with a wood-burning stove and a lofted bedroom.

Guests can book cod-fishing lessons and cooking classes. A general store that once catered to survivalists and fishermen now sells snacks and souvenirs. Should you grow tired of Battle Harbour’s footpaths and views, the crew will take you across “the tickle” to nearby Great Caribou Island, arm you with a packed lunch, a map of the hiking trails and walkie-talkies for emergency use, and pick you up a few hours later.

But we had come to Battle Harbour to sit back and feel the days stretch out and time slow down, so we booked very little. Instead, we watched the shore for humpback

For the three months of summer, the island of Battle Harbour opens briefly, like a portal to another quieter world.

whales and the skies for bald eagles. We read books and went for slow, mindful walks around the island. We met other guests over dinner in the communal dining hall every night, and had occasional conversations with the island’s caretakers. Many of them are Labrador locals who spent their childhoods on the island, and relish any opportunity to come back.

If You Go...

Plan and book your visit at BattleHarbour.com. The nightly price (from around \$215 a night) includes the ferry transfer between Mary’s Harbour and Battle Harbour, accommodation and all meals while on island. Additional activities such as boat rides, fishing excursions and bar drinks are extra. Battle Harbour is open this summer until Sept. 2.

► For more quiet island getaways head to **WSJ.com/Travel**.

DRU KENNEDY PHOTOGRAPHY/NEWFOUNDLAND AND LABRADOR TOURISM

BAGGAGE CLAIM

A Shipshape Stuffable Duffel

These one-of-a-kind bags just scream summer vacation. Made of recycled sails, they’re sturdy too.

TIM LAMORIELLO wasn’t looking for a weekend bag when he wandered into a Sea Bags shop in a Massachusetts mall some 10 years ago. Lamoriello needed to buy a gift, and the store’s colorful mix of carryalls caught his eye. Some sported bold graphic numbers and letters, others bore summery imagery—a lobster, rolling waves, an anchor.

Lamoriello, who is in his early 40s and a general counsel for a New York sports and entertainment company, soon learned that the maritime motifs weren’t contrived: Each bag was handcrafted out of a recycled sail cut and assembled in Portland, Maine.

He liked the company’s ethos of sustainability and the fact that its products are made in the U.S. Plus, the tightly woven sail cloth yielded light, yet durable, bags. “Sails take on large gusts of wind and are meant to get wet, so they’ve weathered a storm or two,” said Lamoriello. Of the many bags he’s bought through the years—from his go-to weekend duffel from

Sea Bags’ Vintage collection (similar shown below) to the smaller totes he’s gifted to family and friends—he’s never encountered one with “a point of failure.”

Distinguishing Features

Sea Bags upcycles around 8,000 sails a year and, since its 1999 launch, has kept more than 800 tons of used sails out of landfills. People can mail an old sail in or drop them off at a Sea Bags store and receive a free tote bag in return. “We take in old canvas schooner sails that are very heavy, but also 5- or 6-ounce Dacron nylon and high-performance fabric sails,” said president and CEO Beth Greenlaw who joined the company in 2006.

Old sails often feature unique topstitching, grom-

metts or other hints to their former lives. Sometimes these might include logos of companies that sponsor regattas such as Prada, Rolex and Mount Gay Rum. These one-off markings show up on Sea Bags’ Vintage line of bags. Another desirable twist: Sea Bags stitches vintage maritime signal flags into certain pieces to add a splash of color.

In private online auctions, collectors like Lamoriello vie for the most coveted bags. He says he just scored a bag bearing stars and stripes for his mother, who “is very patriotic.” He’s always on the lookout for a bag emblazoned with the number 14 (his daughter was born in 2014) and one sporting a Rolex logo, for a watch-collector friend.

Packing tip

You can pack a lot into the carry-on-friendly large travel duffel, which has sturdy rope handles and a shoulder strap. Filled to the brim, it might still be lighter than a similarly stuffed tote made from conventional cotton canvas.

—Donna Bulseco



TOUGH AS SAILS Vintage duffel, \$240, Sea Bags

LUCY HAN



Summer Sale! A Hot Exclusive. Suits of Summer 2 for \$499

Pure Linen Suits
100% pure linen suits in navy, khaki & natural.

Cool Seersucker Suits
Warm weather comfort in blue & white stripes or navy & blue stripes.

Prime Poplin Suits
Our timeless, cotton-rich “Prime Poplin” suits in khaki, olive, oyster & navy.

Reg. \$395, **Buy 1 Suit \$295**

Sale: 2 Suits for \$499



Tropical Wool Suits 2 for \$999

Our finely tailored, lightweight tropical suits are made from a luxurious blend of 96% wool and 4% stretch fabric allowing for greater movement, all while maintaining that classic fit.

Now offered at the sale price of **2 Suits for \$999!**

In your choice of navy, grey, charcoal, black or blue.

Buy 1 Suit \$695
Sale: 2 Suits for \$999



Please visit us online:
www.frankstellanyc.com



Find Us on Facebook.com/frankstellanyc

Find Us on Instagram.com/frankstellanyc

Phone Orders Accepted

NYC LOCATION
440 Columbus Ave. (cor. 81 st.)
Mon.-Sat. 10-7, Sun. 12-6 (212) 877-5566

EATING & DRINKING

By Jane Black

AMERICA LOVES a dietary villain: saturated fat, salt, carbs, sugar and now, seed oils. That's right: The seemingly innocuous vegetable, canola, sunflower, safflower and grapeseed oils that have long stocked our pantries are moving up the list of public-health enemies. According to consumer insight firm Tastewise, 62% of consumers say they are avoiding canola and vegetable oils. Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has called seed oils "one of the worst things you can eat." Many nutritionists disagree, but that has not stopped restaurants and food companies from offering alternatives. The salad chain Sweet-

'Algae oil' doesn't exactly sound appealing.

green has replaced seed oils across most of its menu. Steak 'n Shake boasts that its fries are now cooked in beef tallow—once a dietary villain itself. Meanwhile, startups Algae Cooking Club and Zero Acre have launched "clean" oils produced with algae for restaurants and home cooks. The furious debate and new high-tech options prompted me to put algae and other seed-oil alternatives to the test and figure out if, and when, to use them. **The New Guard** "Algae oil" doesn't exactly sound appealing. This is perhaps why Zero Acre calls its product "cultured oil" instead.



POUR CHOICES
We tested the new algae oils alongside avocado and extra-light olive oils. Find our top picks below.

heated to very high temperatures (over 500 degrees). Refined olive oil also is widely available but often overlooked thanks to years of proselytizing about the flavor and health properties of extra-virgin olive oil. Sometimes labeled "light" or "extra-light," refined olive oils offer the same high level of mono-unsaturated fats as extra-virgin olive oils but are far less expensive. Their smoke point is relatively high, around 410 degrees. Neither olive nor avocado oil is made using chemical extraction.

Testing, Testing
With little difference in flavor, the best way to put seed-oil alternatives to the test was ultra-high-heat cooking. I bought some thick, marbled rib-eye steaks, seasoned them with salt and rosemary, and set to work searing them in avocado, extra-light olive oil and the two fermented oils. All worked beautifully, with no notable differences or lingering flavors. The same went for basic salad dressings and baking. I used Zero Acre to make my birthday strawberry layer cake, and I can assure you no one complained.

Giving Seed Oils the Slip

From canola to sunflower, cooking oils we've long relied on are now considered unhealthy by some. But how do the alternatives perform in the kitchen? We put them to the test.

Either way, the production process is the same. Single-cell microalgae contain oil. Inside a fermenter, microalgae are fed sugar, causing the cells to multiply and the oil to accumulate. The oil is then pressed and refined without the chemical solvents that are commonly used—and considered by many to be unhealthy—in seed oils. The result: a versatile oil that is extremely high in healthy monounsaturated fat. Both Algae Cooking Club and Zero Acre oils contain 93% monounsaturated fat compared to somewhere between 70 and 75% for avocado and olive oils. The fermented oils are very low in polyunsaturated fats, which helps prevent the oils from going rancid. This is also a benefit for seed-oil skeptics,

who worry that polyunsaturated fats can transform into dangerous compounds when oils are used at high heat. Zero Acre boasts that its oil tastes "nutty." Algae Cooking Club, which counts three-Michelin-star chef Daniel Humm as a founding partner and culinary director, calls its product "buttery." In truth, I didn't detect nutty or buttery flavors in either one. Both oils offered

a clean, neutral flavor—precisely what you want in an oil that might be used in a range of applications, from baking a cake to searing a steak. **The Old Guard** While these high-tech oils are intriguing, alternatives to seed oils have long existed. Avocado oil, one popular substitute, is also refined for a neutral flavor and can be

The Upshot
If you are intrigued by fermented oils, for their high-tech production or environmental claims, go for it. Algae Cooking Club even offers chile- and mushroom-infused versions for pops of flavor. But those oils can come at a price: Zero Acre's is \$30 per 16-ounce bottle. Compare that to \$13 for extra-light olive oil. For me, the big reveal of my tests was less-expensive extra-light olive oil. It makes a healthy, affordable swap for the seed oils I've long used for searing, frying and baking.

SWITCH YOUR SIZZLE / 4 ALTERNATIVES TO SEED OIL AT DIFFERENT PRICES



Zero Acre Cultured Oil, \$30 for 16 ounces (discount on purchase of 2 or 4 bottles)



Algae Cooking Club Algae Cooking Oil, \$19 for 16 ounces



Primal Kitchen Organic Avocado Oil, \$19 for 16.9 ounces



Bertolli Olive Oil Extra Light Taste, \$13 for 16.9 ounces

ELIZABETH COETZEE/WSJ; STYLING BY JULIA ROSE

SLOW FOOD FAST / SATISFYING AND SEASONAL FOOD IN ABOUT 30 MINUTES



The Chef
Dean Neff

His Restaurants
Seabird and Zora's Market and Kitchen, both in Wilmington, N.C.

What he's known for
Co-owning a locally focused fine-dining seafood restaurant with his wife, Lydia Clopton. Inventing fresh, playful dishes that celebrate the abundance of North Carolina's waters.

Crab Cakes With Stone Fruit Salad and Green Goddess Sauce

A HANDFUL of ingredients is all it takes to make Dean Neff's crab cakes a winner. "If you have excellent crab, you don't need fillers," the chef said. He learned this lesson early, as a teenage cook in a seafood shack near Savannah, Ga. Neff and his wife, Lydia Clopton, opened their first restaurant in Wilmington, N.C., a decade ago. "We get local blue crabs delivered from friends we've worked with from the beginning," he said. "I'm obsessed. This seafood brings me back to my childhood."

Total Time 30 minutes
Serves 4
1½ cups roughly chopped basil leaves
1½ cups roughly chopped parsley leaves
¼ cup cold water
1¼ cups mayonnaise
5 tablespoons fresh lemon juice, plus more to season
Kosher salt
1 sleeve saltine crackers
1 pound jumbo lump crab meat
2 teaspoons Old Bay seasoning
1 cup olive oil, plus extra
5 small peaches, plums or a mix, cut in ½-inch wedges

1. Make the sauce: In a

blender or food processor, blend 1 cup basil, 1 cup parsley and water, 30 seconds. Scrape down sides and pulse until smooth. Pulse in ¾ cup mayonnaise, 3 tablespoons lemon juice and salt to taste. **2.** Make the crab cakes: Keeping saltines in their sleeve, smash into coarse crumbs. Some pieces should be fine and others about ¼ inch across. Transfer crumbs to a large bowl along with crab, ½ cup mayonnaise, 2 tablespoons lemon juice, Old Bay and 1 teaspoon salt. Use your hands to gently mix until mixture just comes together. Divide into 4 equal portions and pat into discs.

Smashed saltines lend his crab mixture a toothsome texture. Forming the patties, take care not to overmix, he warns: "You want some pieces [of crab] to remain whole." To round out the plate, Neff adds two more summery elements: a creamy green goddess sauce flecked with basil and parsley, and a stone fruit salad jazzed up with even more herbs. The peaches' natural acidity cuts through the dish's richness. Together, the trio pays testament to Neff's commitment to fresh Southern flavors—from land and from sea. —*Kitty Greenwald*

3. Set a large heavy skillet over medium-high heat and add ½ inch oil. Once oil reaches 335 degrees, add crab cakes. (To gauge oil temperature without a thermometer, drop in a saltine: It should puff and turn golden within 30 seconds.) Fry crab cakes until browned, about 3 minutes per side, working in batches if needed. Transfer to a paper towel-lined platter. **4.** In a bowl, combine fruit with remaining basil and parsley. Toss with lemon juice, olive oil and salt to taste. To serve, dollop dressing onto each plate. Place crab cake on top and mound salad alongside.



PIECE OF CAKE Minimal handling and a simple recipe ensure that sweet, fresh crab meat is the star of this decadent summer dish.

ELIZABETH COETZEE/WSJ; FOOD STYLING BY THU BUSER; PROP STYLING BY VANESSA VASQUEZ; MICHAEL WOEHLER (PORTRAIT)

EATING & DRINKING

PARTY TRICK

Mozz Appeal

In two sensational salads, mozzarella flexes its casual cool, showing off summer’s bounty to its best advantage

By ODETTE WILLIAMS



THE OTHER NIGHT I attended an aperitivo hour, creative and colorful all around, but one detail stood out. It wasn’t the spritzes or the rhubarb focaccia, the Marimekko tablecloths or the Sophie Lou Jacobsen glassware—all were upstaged by the hand-braided fresh mozzarella. Each antipasto plate had one mini braid, a casual charmer. Delighted to learn that the mozzarella came from Caputo’s Fine Foods, an Italian grocer in my Brooklyn neighborhood, I marched over and convinced Franco and Joseph Caputo to teach me to braid.

In a pot of extremely hot water, solid curds are melted and stirred into a glossy mass. Reaching in to grab handfuls and then braiding the cheese before it cools requires skill and speed. “We are lucky to have this in our lives,” said Franco. I implored him to broadcast this service, and I hope you’ll ask your own local Italian grocer for braided mozz.

Whatever form you find, as we ease into the first tastes of summer I offer two simple salads to showcase mozzarella’s sculptural quality. The first, a no-cook classic, barely needs a recipe. Melon, mozzarella, San Daniele prosciutto and basil is a perfect plate when you’re confident in your ingredients. Here, you could use bocconcini, the bite-size mozzarella balls. Salty, sweet, cured and fresh, this salad is a natural with a spritz or a glass of Mortellito Cala Iancu, a briny white from the southeastern coast of Sicily.

The other salad balances creamy mozzarella with grilled zucchini. The result of a need to clean out my fridge, it’s versatile, vegetarian and, now, a grill season go-to.

So, welcome back wide-brimmed hats, colorful stripes and salty skin. Let’s begin.



ENDLESS SUMMER
Melon, mozzarella, prosciutto and basil is a classic for a reason.

Melon, Mozzarella, Basil and Prosciutto

You can serve this on a platter as one big hero salad, but it’s especially nice antipasto style, on individual plates.

Total Time 15 minutes

Serves 4

3 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
2 tablespoons

balsamic or white balsamic vinegar
1 tablespoon lemon juice
1 tablespoon honey
Flaky salt and freshly ground black pepper
3 cups seeded, peeled honeydew melon cut into chunky cubes
8 thin slices (2 ounces) San

Daniele prosciutto
½ pound fresh mozzarella, cut into bite-size pieces
Handful small, tender basil leaves

1. In a mixing bowl, whisk together oil, balsamic vinegar, lemon juice and honey. Season with salt and pepper.

2. Add melon to bowl with dressing, and toss to coat.
3. On individual plates or a platter, arrange sheets of prosciutto like loosely curled ribbons. Add dressed melon and mozzarella. Drizzle any leftover dressing otop. Top with basil leaves, as if they’ve blown in on a summer breeze.

Grilled Zucchini, Mozzarella, Olive and Pistachio

Slicing zucchini on a mandoline produces even, delicate ribbons. If you’re not up for grilling, use a grill pan over medium-high heat.

Total Time 25 minutes

Serves 4

2 large zucchini (about 1½ pounds), sliced lengthwise into ¼- to ½-inch-thick ribbons
¼ cup extra-virgin olive oil
Kosher salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 clove garlic, minced
2 tablespoons Sherry vinegar
Juice from ½ lemon
½ pound fresh mozzarella, torn into small pieces
½ cup pitted Castelvetrano olives, halved
¼ cup salted pistachios, roughly chopped
½ cup roughly chopped basil leaves
½ cup roughly chopped flat-leaf parsley leaves
Parmigiano-Reggiano, to serve

1. Heat a grill.
2. Toss zucchini in 2 tablespoons oil and season with salt and pepper. Grill zucchini until tender with distinct grill marks, 2-3 minutes per side. Transfer to a serving platter.
3. In a small bowl, whisk together 2 tablespoons oil, garlic, vinegar and lemon juice. Season with salt and pepper.
4. Scatter mozzarella, olives, pistachios, basil and parsley over zucchini. Drizzle dressing on top. Finish with Parmigiano shavings.



MATT RUSSELL FOR WSJ; FOOD STYLING BY REBECCA JURJEVICH; PROP STYLING BY JULIA ROSE

Are You Missing Out On WSJ Digital Content?

Your WSJ subscription goes far beyond the news at your door each day. From audio articles to curated newsletters, explore more with your WSJ digital benefits.

Here’s a quick look at additional ways to access WSJ.



Newsletters

Keep up with your interests with our curated newsletters—including with your subscription and sent directly to your inbox.

[WSJ.com/printnl](https://www.wsj.com/printnl)



Audio

Give your eyes a break and instead press play. Listen to the latest audio articles or dig into the topics you care about with our WSJ podcasts.

[WSJ.com/print_audio](https://www.wsj.com/print_audio)



The Print Edition App

On the go? Page through the digital version instead. Access the subscriber-only app to click through the day’s print articles—and never miss a story.

[WSJ.com/print_app](https://www.wsj.com/print_app)

Email Sharing

Grant access to the biggest headlines. Share WSJ stories with your friends and family. Simply click on the share icon above the article to message or copy the link.

Look for this

Not sure how to access WSJ.com with your current print subscription? **Visit [WSJ.com/digitalaccess](https://www.wsj.com/digitalaccess)**

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

© 2025 Dow Jones & Co., Inc. All rights reserved. 6DJ0174

Create Where *You* Belong™



©2025 California Closet Company, Inc. Each California Closets® franchised location is independently owned and operated. C-11116 #0507206.

CALL, VISIT A SHOWROOM, OR GO ONLINE TO SCHEDULE YOUR COMPLIMENTARY DESIGN CONSULTATION 844.295.1402

New York City 26 Varick St | 1629 York Ave
Nassau 25 Northern Blvd, Greenvale
Westchester 16 Saw Mill River Rd, Hawthorne
Rockland 83 S Main St, New City
Connecticut 48 W Putnam Ave, Greenwich – coming soon
Miami 900 Park Centre Blvd, Miami Gardens

[CALIFORNIACLOSETS.COM](https://www.californiaclosets.com)

CALIFORNIA CLOSETS®



GEAR & GADGETS

Continued from page D1

The spike in personal transportation is a budget buster. Many thousands of families face being forced out of their cars and into what is effectively a second-class citizenship. What are we supposed to tell a generational workforce that is going broke just getting to work? Take one of America's fine new trains?

It's not just about money, honey. It's about trust. Doubts start with the mounting complexity of new cars: turbocharged hybrid and plug-in hybrid powertrains; screen-based displays and controls; and advanced safety systems. Anyone who has ever owned a laptop has reason to question the shelf-life of the technology.

"How long will manufacturers offer replacement modules and software for older cars?" wonders Tom Wilkinson, a former GM employee living in Michigan. In the future, cars might come with a fixed lifespan, perhaps "10 years or 150,000 miles,"

pays. In 2021 BMW settled a class-action suit over engine failures related to so-called plastic embrittlement of timing chain components. In 2022 Volkswagen Group settled a similar suit involving the use of plastic water pumps.

Among the more widely loathed current practices is the use of wet timing belts. These toothed, reinforced-rubber belts synchronize an engine's cam timing with the crankshaft. Commonly, the belt winds around the crank sprocket, partially submerged in hot engine oil.

A wet belt's typical lifespan is roughly equivalent to a chain belt's, but before wet belts break, they erode, spreading a rubbery contamination into the oiling system. If this gunk blocks the oil pickup, it can kill an engine.

Making matters worse—as in more expensive—is the practice of burying such term-limited components deep in the machinery, which often add hours of labor to the bill.

Right-to-repair legislation would oblige automakers to make the necessary tools, codes and parts available to owners and independent garages.

Wilkinson said. "After that, the [automaker] would brick them, if for no other reason than to avoid the decades-long liability...."

The acres of plastic under the hoods of new cars isn't very reassuring. In the early 2000s, automakers stepped up the use of injection molded thermoplastic components, which have the advantage of being lighter, more recyclable and cheaper than metal.

In the past two decades automakers have filled their engine bays with plasticized water pumps, oil filter housings, radiators and hoses. Between 2012 to 2021, the average amount of plastic in automobiles increased by 16%, to 411 pounds, according to the American Chemistry Council.

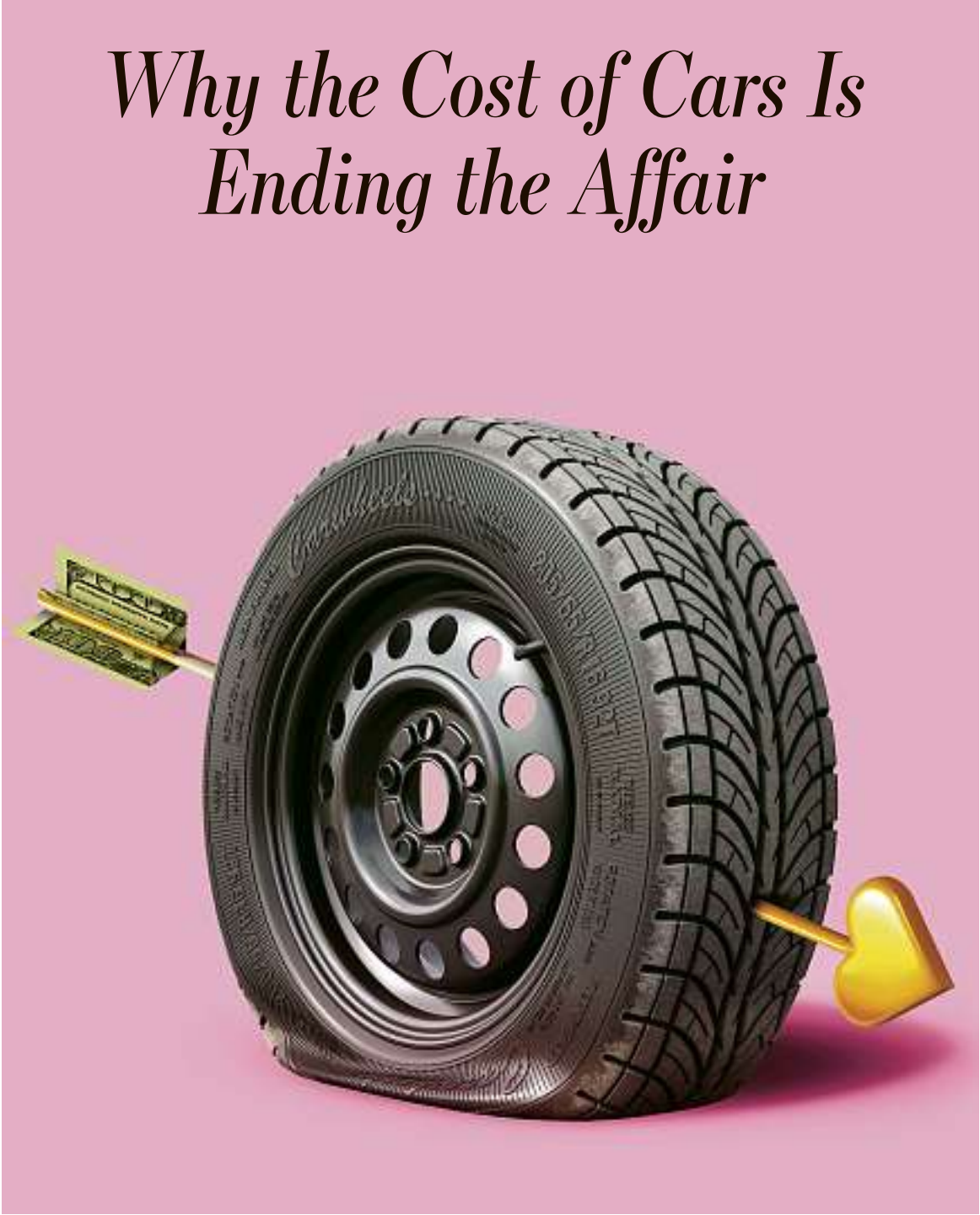
Unfortunately, even the strongest plastics degrade in the daily extremes of heat cycling under the hood. It is only a matter of who

In the terse wisdom of the garage: Engineers hate mechanics.

The "gizmo that failed in my Ford Escape that pivots to direct either hot or cold air in the HVAC is plastic," said David Francis Kiley, a producer and publisher in Michigan. "The cost to replace it was over 2,000 bucks because the geniuses at Ford buried it with no access unless the whole dash was pulled out."

Delivering value to customers, said Ford spokesperson Mike Levine, "requires a balance in engineering and manufacturing processes. We optimize between efficient assembly—which directly influences the customer's initial purchase price—and repairability, to minimize a customer's total cost of ownership over time."

With garage repair costs up over 43% in six years, according to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, the not-worth-fixing threshold is shock-



MATT CHASE

ingly easy to reach. The average single repair across all types of vehicles was \$838 in 2024, according to Cox Automotive.

"Cars have become disposable because automakers want them to be," said Eric Evarts, a high-school English teacher from Danbury,

Conn. Evarts noted automakers' ongoing fight against right-to-repair legislation. Among other things, right-to-repair would oblige automakers to make the necessary tools, codes and parts available to owners and independent garages.

It's surprising how many of the

current discontents are the consequences of good intentions. Take, for example, collision repair.

The cost of fixing damaged cars has skyrocketed 28% since 2021, according to data from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. The collision-re-

Please turn to the next page

Empowering your journey to leadership

Insights for the next
generation of advisors



Scan to learn more

BARRON'S
ADVISOR
NEXT GENERATION



Sponsored by



GEAR & GADGETS



A North Carolina owner’s BMW X5 (similar shown) rear-ended another car. The damage appeared minor, but repair costs meant the car had to be scrapped.

Continued from the prior page
pair industry blames the rising cost of replacement parts; a shortage of trained technicians; and the increasing complexity of new cars, with special scorn directed at Advanced Driver-Assist Systems, or ADAS.

Designed to reduce accidents and improve safety, ADAS technology—including functions such as automatic lane-keeping, dynamic cruise control and emergency braking—relies on cameras, sensors and transceivers integrated into the bumper trim, grille or windshield. Ultrasonic parking sensors are especially vulnerable.

In the era of ADAS, there is no such thing as a minor fender bender.

“My 2013 BMW X5 rear ended a small car and the damage to my car looked minor,” said Tom Walken, a psychologist in Raleigh, N.C. “But the electronics in the front bumper area pushed the repair cost to more than 75% of the car’s value so North Carolina law required that it be totaled.” (When contacted, BMW had no comment).

Millions of mindful consumers paid premium prices to drive electric cars. And they are still paying. Insurance companies are wary of covering collision repairs that involve battery packs or related systems. The diecast aluminum structural elements that undergird Teslas—“gigacastings”—are light-

weight, compact and robust. But when damaged they often can’t be repaired, only replaced, and with great difficulty.

Last year Edmunds had a spot of trouble with the Tesla Cybertruck in its one-year test fleet. While parked on a street in West Hollywood, the huge, steel-paneled truck was struck in the left rear by a small sedan. The Tesla was totaled. The estimate for repairs—including \$4,280 for a new rear casting and \$16,584 for labor—came to \$57,879.89. Edmunds sold its Cybertruck to a salvage company for \$8,000. (When contacted,



The estimate to fix a Cybertruck that had been struck by a small sedan came to nearly \$58,000. It was sold to a salvage yard for \$8,000.

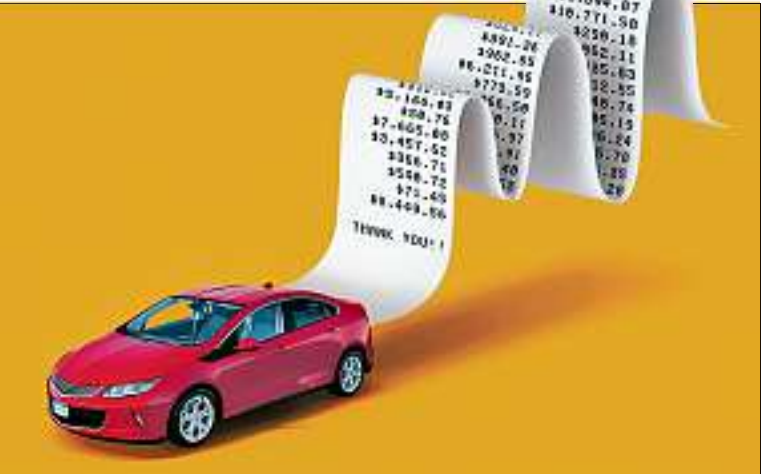
Tesla did not reply.)
The cost of making modern cars whole again, combined with steep depreciation, sends thousands of lightly damaged, otherwise functional cars and trucks to salvage yards every month. In 2018, adjusters totaled 19% of all vehicles they inspected, one of every five claims (LexisNexis Risk Solutions). By 2023, the ratio had jumped to one of four claims (27%).

No wonder people are having abandonment issues.
My take: If automobility is to remain a defining feature in American society, something has to give. And that’s gasoline. The mounting costs of the automobile enumerated are all associated with a greater disruption: vehicle electrification.

Despite Tesla’s best efforts, EV sales rose globally again in 2024. The global industry has reached the place where it is now nominally cheaper to build an EV than an equivalent ICE vehicle. As the cost of energy storage (batteries) continues to fall, EV’s advantages will accelerate. There is no rollback of rule or regulation that will allow ICE vehicles to again be cost-competitive.

EV technology is not perfect, not yet. But ICE technology is as good as it’s ever going to get.

So I say lean in and move on, America. Let go of the past. You have nothing to lose but your timing chains.



The Cost of Keeping the Lights On

The obscene price of replacing a high-tech headlamp

FOR DECADES, the U.S. Department of Transportation approved only round, sealed-beam headlights. Despite many limitations, such headlights were cheap, easy to replace and widely available. Today’s high-tech headlamps are anything but—and, when one gets damaged, can cost a small fortune to replace. Some sample part fees:

 Ram 1500 \$300	 Chevy Silverado 1500 \$589.99
 Ford F-150 \$1,667.67	 BMW M850i xDrive \$7,317.50
 Porsche 911 \$8,341.59	 Audi RS7 \$8,647.82

Sources: ebay.com; americantrucks.com; getoemparts.com; getbmwparts.com; parts.porschehandler.com; parts.audiusa.com

MATT CHASE (ILLUSTRATION), TESLA, BMW

THE JOURNAL
COLLECTION

Your Destination For Exclusive
Subscriber Offers

Introducing The Journal Collection, curated just for subscribers of The Wall Street Journal, Barron’s, MarketWatch, Financial News and Private Equity News. The Journal Collection is your destination for subscriber savings on insider deals that save you time and money.

Enjoy exclusive perks on travel, tech, wine and more.

The best way to find out about new exclusive offers?

Sign up for our complimentary newsletter rounding up your subscriber-only savings.

SIGN UP

wsj.com/journalcollection-signup



The Journal Collection is a marketing product, which is separate from The Wall Street Journal news staff.



MYSTERY AT THE GROOMS'

JUNE 19 – 29, 2025



BECOME AN HERMÈS DETECTIVE
PIER 36, 299 SOUTH ST, NEW YORK CITY
FREE ENTRY BOOK YOUR TICKETS

